PART THREE | AN EXPANDING NATION

UNIT 3
AN EXPANDING NATION

Chapters 8, 9, 10, 11, and 12 · 1790–1860

Web Article Reader

Scholarly and institutional web articles for History B17A

INCLUDED	91 excerpted web articles across Chapters 8–12.
SOURCE TEXT	Complete-paragraph selections from scholarly and institutional web articles; omissions marked.
CITATIONS	Chicago Notes and Bibliography with stable original-article links.

Prepared October 2026 from the linked live web editions.

Reader's Guide

What This Volume Is

This volume complements the Primary Source Reader, Scholarly Article Reader, and monograph-based Secondary Source Reader. It gathers focused scholarship and institutional history published on the open web. W-number labels distinguish these readings from the S- and A-numbered sources in the other Unit 3 readers.

How Selections Were Made

The reader includes 91 distinct articles aligned to the Unit 3 essay prompts and grouped by the textbook chapter they most directly support. An article that serves more than one prompt appears once; its metadata panel lists every assigned prompt section and whether the source supports, qualifies, or offers a Counter-Argument to that line of argument.

Reading the Excerpts

Each excerpt reproduces complete published paragraphs, normally 600–1,200 words; a shorter article is reproduced in full. A bracketed notice marks a move between noncontiguous portions of an article; no bridging language has been invented. All text under Excerpt comes from the linked article.

Citing These Readings

Use the full footnote citation the first time you cite an article and the shortened form thereafter. Every entry supplies Chicago Notes and Bibliography models and a direct original-article link. Cite the web article, not the reader page number, and include only works you actually use in your bibliography.

Access

The original-article links were checked when the reader was prepared. Web pages can move or change, so retain the access date shown in the citation and use the excerpt in this reader if a live page later becomes unavailable.

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.1

Q&A with James Parisot

James Parisot (interview by Tom Cutterham)

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PUBLICATION	June 25, 2019
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.1
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.1.1 Support; 8.1.2 Support

Excerpt · 1,064 words (complete article)

Following up yesterday's review by Lindsay Keiter, today The Junto interviews James Parisot, author of *How America Became Capitalist: Imperial Expansion and the Conquest of the West* (Pluto, 2019). James teaches in the Department of Sociology at Drexel University, and received his PhD at SUNY Binghamton, home of the Fernand Braudel Center for the Study of Economies, Historical Systems, and Civilizations.

Junto: One of the conceptual innovations in *How America Became Capitalist* is the distinction you make—riffing on Ira Berlin—between a "society with capitalism" and a "capitalist society." What do you mean by that and what makes it useful?

James Parisot: By a "society with capitalism" I was referring to the fact that, from the start of English colonisation in North America, there was a kind of unevenness whereby not-so capitalist relations articulated with capitalist relations. For instance, while the 17th and 18th centuries the expanding white-settler countryside developed these sorts of small-scale patriarchal relations with safety-first farming, at the same time, on the coast a capitalist fishing industry took off, and even in the mid-1600s there was a small ironworks industry that formed with a proletarian class consisting of both waged and indentured labor. And in the south, while most books on slavery focus on, say, big plantations, there has also been a lot of good research done on the small farmers who, I argue, had somewhat similar non-capitalist types social relations in some areas.

Of course there is a lot of grey area and it becomes difficult sometimes to find distinct ruptures in history, so much as countless unquantifiable moments, and even tracing the story of a single individual's life in, say, the 1700s or early 1800s, is one in which people navigated a wide variety of modes of production. But making this distinction has at least helped me conceptually navigate this terrain and find a way to think about colonial and early American history not purely just in terms of "capitalism" or "non-capitalism" but gradations of more capitalist and less capitalist types of social relations.

Junto: You're obviously working in a broadly Marxist tradition of historical sociology. But class struggle is not a prominent feature of your analysis. Why is that?

JP: Different forms of class struggle and social protests of course shaped this history in many ways, from slave rebellions to the Whisky Rebellion to urban artisans organizing combinations to protect their way of life, to squatters building settlements on the frontier only to have their homes burned down by the military, and so on. But at least in my interpretation I really have a hard time seeing capitalism as emerging from, say, the "unintended consequences of class struggle" as one perspective puts it, so much as a gradual process in which social life was incorporated into capitalism, in different cases with more or less class struggle.

Think of, say, the famous case of the Lowell Mill girls, who chose to become at least temporary wage laborers because it was a path towards a more independent life. And while in some cases farmers were pushed into capitalism against their wills, in other cases, they incorporated themselves deeper into market relations in order to purchase more goods, etc., just as urban artisans may have found they could increase their standard of living by hiring wage laborers rather than journeymen and apprentices (which of course meant a perhaps more insecure life for those they hired). So—even as someone highly critical of capitalism in general—I had to recognize that the history of capitalism is one in which people were both forced into the system but also in some cases consented into it. Life as a barely above subsistence farm family, after all, was not particular luxurious!

Junto: This is not just a book about capitalism, but also about empire. What is the relationship between the two that you are trying to articulate?

JP: I was trying to understand how the shape of empire changed with the rise of capitalism. If in some cases in the first two-and-a-half centuries of American history it was not always capitalism *per se* that pushed empire building, but mixed sorts of social forms, how did it become the case that capitalism ended up becoming the driving force pushing the last stage of American continental expansion?

I think the reasons for empire-building, especially from the 17th to mid-19th centuries, were manifold, from small farmers who wanted to live outside of market dependence pushing west, to speculators who saw the west as a vast space of potential profit, to the federal state which at times aimed to commodify and sell land dispossessed from Native Americans to generate revenue. Thus my goal was really to bring out the interplay of these forces and show how over time the logic of capital, by the 1870s or so onward, really became the decisive power pushing empire. In this sense, I was more trying to push debates over the history of capitalism to try and locate the dynamics of empire, show how capitalism changed the form empire took, and, in this regard, also push against academic literature not only on American Empire, but histories of empires more broadly, to take more seriously the question of how different empires historically have been rooted in different social relations of production.

Junto: A lot of recent work on American capitalism has focused on the nineteenth century, but a substantial portion of your book is spent in the colonial period. How did that come about?

JP: The historical scope sort of emerged organically as I was researching and writing. When I started the project I was looking mostly at the 19th century, digging through literature on slavery, the history of worker's movements, the market revolution, and so on. But I wanted to make sure the book was about more than capitalism in one country, and show the way that American colonization and capitalism emerged in an international context. Doing this meant going back to the colonial era.

I suppose I was also willing to try and take on this challenge because my background is in historical sociology rather than "history" proper. Historical sociologists like me are naively ambitious enough to take on big chunks of history and risk making lots of mistakes. So I decided to try and take on this big chuck of time and hope, with whatever mistakes may come up, the overall argument will hold.

Original Article

https://earlyamericanists.com/2019/06/25/qa-with-james-parisot/

Chicago Citations

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Parisot, James. "Q&A with James Parisot." Interview by Tom Cutterham. *The Junto*. June 25, 2019. https://earlyamericanists.com/2019/06/25/qa-with-james-parisot/.

FULL FOOTNOTE

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Parisot, "Q&A with James Parisot."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.2

The Roots of American Industrialization, 1790–1860

David R. Meyer

AUTHOR	David R. Meyer (Brown University; essay based on his 2003 book of the same title)
WEBSITE	EH.Net Encyclopedia, Economic History Association
PUBLICATION	March 16, 2008
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.1
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.1.2 Support; 8.1.3 Counter-Argument

Excerpt · 948 words

In a society which is predominantly agricultural, how is it possible for industrialization to gain a foothold? One view is that the demand of farm households for manufactures spurs industrialization, but such an outcome is not guaranteed. What if farm households can meet their own food requirements, and they choose to supply some of their needs for manufactures by engaging in small-scale craft production in the home? They might supplement this production with limited purchases of goods from local craftworkers and purchases of luxuries from other countries. This local economy would be relatively self-sufficient, and there is no apparent impetus to alter it significantly through industrialization, that is, the growth of workshop and factory production for larger markets. Others would claim that limited gains might come from specialization, once demand passed some small threshold. Finally, it has been argued that if the farmers are impoverished, some of them would be available for manufacturing and this would provide an incentive to industrialize. However, this argument begs the question as to who would purchase the manufactures. One possibility is that non-farm rural dwellers, such as trade people, innkeepers, and professionals, as well as a small urban population, might provide an impetus to limited industrialization.

The problem with the "impoverished agriculture" theory

The industrialization of the eastern United States from 1790 to 1860 raises similar conundrums. For a long time, scholars thought that the agriculture was mostly poor quality. Thus, the farm labor force left agriculture for workshops, such as those which produced shoes, or for factories, such as the cotton textile mills of New England. These manufactures provided employment for women and children, who otherwise had limited productive possibilities because the farms were not economical. Yet, the market for manufactures remained mostly in the East prior to 1860. Consequently, it is unclear who would have purchased the products to support the growth of manufactures before 1820, as well as to undergird the large-scale industrialization of the East during the two decades following 1840. Even if the impoverished-agriculture explanation of the East's industrialization is rejected, we are still left with the curiosity that as late as 1840, about eighty percent of the population lived in rural areas, though some of them were in nonfarm occupations.

In brief, the puzzle of eastern industrialization between 1790 and 1860 can be resolved – the East had a prosperous agriculture. Farmers supplied low-cost agricultural products to rural and urban dwellers, and this population demanded manufactures, which were supplied by vigorous local and subregional manufacturing sectors. Some entrepreneurs shifted into production for larger market areas, and this transformation occurred especially in sectors such as shoes, selected light manufactures produced in Connecticut (such as buttons, tinware, and wooden clocks), and cotton textiles. Transportation improvements exerted little impact on these agricultural and industrial developments, primarily because the lowly wagon served effectively as a transport medium and much of the East's most prosperous areas were accessible to cheap waterway transportation. The metropolises of Boston, New York, Philadelphia, and, to a lesser extent, Baltimore, and the satellites of each (together, each metropolis and its satellites is called a metropolitan industrial complex), became leading manufacturing centers, and other industrial centers emerged in prosperous agricultural areas distant from these complexes. The East industrialized first, and, subsequently, the Midwest began an agricultural and industrial growth process which was underway by the 1840s. Together, the East and the Midwest constituted the American Manufacturing Belt, which was formed by the 1870s, whereas the South failed to industrialize commensurately.

Synergy between Agriculture and Manufacturing

The solution to the puzzle of how industrialization can occur in a predominantly agricultural economy recognizes the possibility of synergy between agriculture and manufacturing. During the first three decades following 1790, prosperous agricultural areas emerged in the eastern United States. Initially, these areas were concentrated near the small metropolises of Boston, New York, and Philadelphia, and in river valleys such as the Connecticut Valley in Connecticut and Massachusetts, the Hudson and Mohawk Valleys in New York, the Delaware Valley bordering Pennsylvania and New Jersey, and the Susquehanna Valley in eastern Pennsylvania. These agricultural areas had access to cheap, convenient transport which could be used to reach markets; the farms supplied the growing urban populations in the cities and some of the products were exported. Furthermore, the farmers supplied the nearby, growing non-farm populations in the villages and small towns who provided goods and services to farmers. These non-farm consumers included retailers, small mill owners, teamsters, craftspeople, and professionals (clergy, physicians, and lawyers).

Across every decade from 1800 to 1860, the number of farm laborers grew, thus testifying to the robustness of eastern agriculture (see Table 1). And, this increase occurred in the face of an expanding manufacturing sector, as increasing numbers of rural dwellers left the farms to work in the factories, especially after 1840. Even New England, the region which presumably was the epitome of declining agriculture, witnessed a rise in the number of farm laborers all the way up to 1840, and, as of 1860, the drop off from the peak was small. Massachusetts and Connecticut, which had vigorous small workshops and increasing numbers of small factories before 1840, followed by a surge in manufacturing after 1840, matched the trajectory of farm laborers in New England as a whole. The numbers in these two states peaked in 1840 and fell off only modestly over the next twenty years. The Middle Atlantic region witnessed an uninterrupted rise in the number of farm laborers over the sixty-year period. New York and Pennsylvania, the largest states, followed slightly different paths. In New York, the number of farm laborers peaked around 1840 and then stabilized near that level for the next two decades, whereas in Pennsylvania the number of farm laborers rose in an uninterrupted fashion.

Original Article

https://eh.net/encyclopedia/the-roots-of-american-industrialization-1790-1860/

Chicago Citations

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David R. Meyer, "The Roots of American Industrialization, 1790–1860," *EH.Net Encyclopedia*, Economic History Association, March 16, 2008, https://eh.net/encyclopedia/the-roots-of-american-industrialization-1790-1860/.

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Meyer, "Roots of American Industrialization."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.3

History and Culture

Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor

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ARGUMENT ROLES	8.1.3 Support

Excerpt · 615 words (complete article)

Built between 1817 and 1825, the original Erie Canal stretched 363 miles from Albany to Buffalo. At the time, it was the longest artificial waterway and the greatest public works project in North America.

The canal put New York on the map as the Empire State—leading the nation in population, industry, and economic strength. It transformed New York City into the country's principal seaport and opened the interior of North America to settlement.

Just as important, the Erie Canal helped shape our national identity. Built through vision, determination, ingenuity, and hard work, it embodied qualities that became hallmarks of the American character.

DeWitt Clinton was the canal's most persistent and effective champion. A former state legislator, U.S. Senator, and Mayor of New York City, he also served on the commission that conducted the first surveys for a cross□state canal. Clinton ultimately led the political effort that made the Erie Canal a reality.

An Engineering Marvel

New York's canal system was an engineering achievement of national and international significance. Its builders borrowed ideas from earlier European canals but applied them with boldness on a scale never seen before.

Originally four feet deep and 40 feet wide, the Erie Canal cut through fields, forests, rocky cliffs, and swamps; crossed rivers on aqueducts; and climbed hills by way of 83 lift locks. Because few engineers or contractors had canal□building experience, the project became the nation's first practical school of civil engineering.

Some laborers were Irish immigrants, but most were U.S.-born. For eight years they endured wet, hot, and freezing conditions while felling trees and excavating mile after mile—mostly with hand tools and animal power. They invented equipment to remove stumps, developed hydraulic cement that hardened underwater, and blasted rock with hand drills and black powder. Their ingenuity and hard labor made the Erie Canal the engineering triumph of its era.

One of the most challenging features was the Lockport Flight—a staircase of five locks blasted through the solid rock of the Niagara Escarpment. Together, they raise and lower boats 49 feet.

Faster, Cheaper

Packet boat passengers could travel from Albany to Buffalo in five days—less than half the time of a stagecoach journey. Shipping costs dropped by 90 percent compared to hauling goods by ox-drawn wagon.

Freight boats carried Midwestern produce from Buffalo to Albany, with most shipments continuing to New York City's harbor, towed down the Hudson River behind steam tugboats. Farmers, loggers, miners, and manufacturers across the Midwest gained access to lucrative markets near and far.

The Erie Canal became known as the "Mother of Cities" because it gave rise to so many cities, towns, and villages.

A Flow of People and Ideas

The Erie Canal and its connecting waterways fulfilled DeWitt Clinton's prediction that New York would become America's leading state—prosperous, populous, and influential from end to end. New York City soon emerged as the nation's busiest port, most populous city, and foremost center of commerce and finance. Immigrants flocked to the state, knowing they could find work in the many new communities developing along the canal.

As it opened the interior to settlement, the canal also carried a steady flow of ideas. Abolitionism, women's suffrage, Utopian experiments, and new religious movements all found fertile ground along the corridor. The Erie Canal transported more westbound immigrants than any other trans-Appalachian canal, bringing new languages, customs, and traditions that helped shape the nation.

A New Kind of National Park

The U.S. Congress recognized the Erie Canal's significance to our nation by establishing the Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor in 2000. Extending 524 miles from Buffalo to Albany and north along the Champlain Canal to Whitehall, the Corridor connects more than 200 communities. This living landscape tells the story of a waterway that shaped New York—and profoundly influenced the history of the United States.

Original Article

https://eriecanalway.org/learn/history-culture

Chicago Citations

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"History and Culture." Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor. Accessed October 20, 2026. https://eriecanalway.org/learn/history-culture.

FULL FOOTNOTE

"History and Culture," Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor, accessed October 20, 2026, https://eriecanalway.org/learn/history-culture.

SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

"History and Culture."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.4

History of the U.S. Telegraph Industry

Tomas Nonnenmacher

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PUBLICATION	August 14, 2001
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.1
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.1.3 Counter-Argument

Excerpt · 673 words

The electric telegraph was one of the first telecommunications technologies of the industrial age. Its immediate predecessors were homing pigeons, visual networks, the Pony Express, and railroads. By transmitting information quickly over long distances, the telegraph facilitated the growth in the railroads, consolidated financial and commodity markets, and reduced information costs within and between firms. This entry focuses on the industrial organization of the telegraph industry from its inception through its demise and the industry's impact on the American economy.

The Development of the Telegraph

The telegraph was similar to many other inventions of the nineteenth century. It replaced an existing technology, dramatically reduced costs, was monopolized by a single firm, and ultimately was displaced by a newer technology. Like most radical new technologies, the telecommunications revolution of the mid-1800s was not a revolution at all, but rather consisted of many inventions and innovations in both technology and industrial organization. This section is broken into four parts, each reviewing an era of telegraphy: precursors to the electric telegraph, early industrial organization of the industry, Western Union's dominance, and the decline of the industry.

Precursors to the Electric Telegraph

Webster's definition of a telegraph is "an apparatus for communicating at a distance by coded signals." The earliest telegraph systems consisted of smoke signals, drums, and mirrors used to reflect sunlight. In order for these systems to work, both parties (the sender and the receiver) needed a method of interpreting the signals. Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's poem recounting Paul Revere's ride ("One if by land, two if by sea, and I on the opposite shore will be") gives an example of a simple system. The first extensive telegraph network was the visual telegraph. In 1791 the Frenchman Claude Chappe used a visual network (which consisted of a telescope, a clock, a codebook, and black and white panels) to send a message ten miles. He called his invention the *télégraphe*, or far writer. Chappe refined and expanded his network, and by 1799 his telegraph consisted of a network of towers with mechanical arms spread across France. The position of the arms was interpreted using a codebook with over 8,000 entries.

Technological Advances

Due to technological difficulties, the electric telegraph could not at first compete with the visual telegraph. The basic science of the electric telegraph is to send an electric current through a wire. Breaking the current in a particular pattern denotes letters or phrases. The Morse code, named after Samuel Morse, is still used today. For instance, the code for SOS (... — ...) is a well-known call for help. Two elements had to be perfected before an electric telegraph could work: a means of sending the signal (generating and storing electricity) and receiving the signal (recording the breaks in the current).

The science behind the telegraph dates back at least as far as Roger Bacon's (1220-1292) experiments in magnetism. Numerous small steps in the science of electricity and magnetism followed. Important inventions include those of Giambattista della Porta (1558), William Gilbert (1603), Stephen Gray (1729), William Watson (1747), Pieter van Musschenbroek (1754), Luigi Galvani (1786), Alessandro Giuseppe Antonio Anastasio Volta (1800), André-Marie Ampere (1820), William Sturgeon (1825), and Joseph Henry (1829). A much longer list could be made, but the point is that no single person can be credited with developing the necessary technology of the telegraph.

1830-1866: Development and Consolidation of the Electric Telegraph Industry

In 1832, Samuel Morse returned to the United States from his artistic studies in Europe. While discussing electricity with fellow passengers, Morse conceived of the idea of a single-wire electric telegraph. No one until this time had Morse's zeal for the applicability of electromagnetism to telecommunications or his conviction of its eventual profitability. Morse obtained a patent in the United States in 1838 but split his patent right to gain the support of influential partners. He obtained a $30,000 grant from Congress in 1843 to build an experimental line between Baltimore and Washington. The first public message over Morse's line ("What hath God wrought?") echoed the first message over Chappe's system ("If you succeed, you will bask in glory"). Both indicated the inventors' convictions about the importance of their systems.

Original Article

https://eh.net/encyclopedia/history-of-the-u-s-telegraph-industry/

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.5

Internal Improvements Campaign

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.2.1 Qualify

Excerpt · 758 words (complete article)

(1820s). The availability of waterways made them the primary transportation arteries for South Carolina's settlers. As early as the 1710s, the Commons House of Assembly was enacting legislation to facilitate water traffic. The great geographic barrier to river traffic between the South Carolina upcountry and the coastal ports was the fall line. By 1800 interest in inland navigation spawned during the Revolution had produced the Santee Canal.

The years that followed the War of 1812 saw South Carolina's greatest experiment with a statewide, state-funded, and state-operated system of internal improvements. In 1816 Governor David R. Williams proposed a coordinated plan of improvements. In 1817 his successor, Governor Andrew Pickens, recommended using the state's budget surplus to fund the program. In response, the General Assembly authorized a state civil and military engineer to survey the navigational needs of South Carolina's rivers and to begin work on improving the Broad and Saluda Rivers. Enhanced navigation on these rivers was crucial to the economic development of Columbia, the new capital.

In 1818 engineer John Wilson requested $1 million to fund a massive effort to improve upcountry navigation. Under the leadership of Joel R. Poinsett, the General Assembly funded the request and charged Wilson with improving rivers, building canals, and constructing roads as needed. This appropriation, four times the state's annual budget, reflected a major commitment to fund an extensive transportation network in South Carolina.

In 1819 the General Assembly created the Board of Public Works, with five legislatively elected commissioners to oversee this ambitious enterprise. The board's responsibilities included surveying and building a road from Charleston through Columbia to the North Carolina border, making the Pee Dee, Santee, Wateree, Catawba, Broad, Saluda, Keowee, Edisto, Black, Combahee, and Salkehatchie Rivers navigable, and constructing canals as needed. The board created two offices: a "department of roads, rivers, and canals"; and a "department of public buildings."

The department of roads, rivers, and canals planned eight canals and the State Road that would link Charleston with western North Carolina. Of the eight canals, four–Wateree, Rocky Mount, Landsford, and Fishing Creek–were on the Catawba and Wateree Rivers to improve access to Camden. Two of the canals, the Columbia Canal on the Congaree River and Lockhart Canal on the Broad River, funneled traffic to Columbia. The Saluda and Dreher Canals on the Saluda River were designed to improve transportation to Abbeville and Laurens. All of the canals were built, but only the Columbia Canal was successful. Given the highly politicized nature of the board, especially after a severe recession that followed in the wake of the Panic of 1819, many canals followed less desirable routes and ran well over budget. As a result, revenues generated were rarely sufficient to maintain and operate the canal system. By 1838 six of the eight were no longer in use.

Competition with cotton producers for available slave labor and the dearth of skilled labor in South Carolina increased labor costs. Bonuses and above average wages lured stonecutters, brick masons, and engineers from the Northeast. Cost overruns and lagging completion dates prompted public criticism. In 1822 John Belton O'Neall of Newberry introduced legislation to abolish the board, condemning the project as wasteful and calling the internal improvement fever a "mania" or "folly." William J. Grayson blamed pork-barrel politics for blinding legislators to the deficiencies of the program. Despite the criticism, the General Assembly appointed a superintendent to centralize oversight of public projects and appropriated additional funds to complete those already under construction.

According to the 1827 report of Abraham Blanding, the superintendent of public works, the twenty-five miles of canals cost an average of $50,000 per mile to construct. The committee declared that the canals had opened two thousand miles of river navigation. In reality, the canals suffered from poor construction, inadequate maintenance, and low water flow. By 1828 the balloon had burst. Facing a faltering economy and deep public dissatisfaction, the General Assembly passed the last of the public improvement-era expenditures.

Canal usage dwindled, and in 1840 South Carolina even abandoned the successful Columbia Canal. The railroad, the next great transportation transformation, was at hand. By 1853 the canals were footnotes in South Carolina's history. A later age tapped their potential for power production.

The State Road between Charleston and Columbia was completed in 1829. While the route was unsuccessful as a toll road, usage exceeded expectations once the tolls were removed. The State Road not only connected Charleston and Columbia, but also facilitated the growth of summer colonies in the South Carolina upcountry and the mountains of western North Carolina.

Original Article

https://www.scencyclopedia.org/sce/entries/internal-improvements-campaign/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Helsley, "Internal Improvements Campaign."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.6

Main Line of Public Works

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PUBLICATION	2020
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.2.1 Support; 8.2.2 Support

Excerpt · 935 words

During the 1820s, seeking to compete with New York and Baltimore in tapping western markets, business and political leaders in Philadelphia pushed for a state-funded canal to link Philadelphia with Pittsburgh. The result, an innovative yet peculiar patchwork of canals and railways known as the Main Line of Public Works, succeeded in moving freight and passengers across the mountainous middle of Pennsylvania. The 395-mile system reduced travel time and spurred growth of towns and market activity along the line, but it proved costly to operate and plunged the state into debt. Within three decades, more powerful locomotives rendered the Main Line of Public Works obsolete.

The impetus for the Pennsylvania canal scheme came largely from the looming threat of New York's state-funded Erie Canal, which began construction in 1817. When completed in 1825, the canal linked the Hudson River to the Great Lakes, thus extending New York City's orbit of trade to all the western interior and vastly increasing its competitive edge over Philadelphia. Additional threats to Philadelphia's economic standing lay to the south, where Baltimore benefited from the movement of agricultural products down the Susquehanna River from Pennsylvania's interior. The National Road, a federal east-west road project begun in 1811, also siphoned travel and trade from the southwestern corner of Pennsylvania into Maryland, where it connected with the Baltimore Turnpike.

Facing the loss of economic standing and recognizing the potential for trade as Americans moved west, Philadelphia business and political leaders campaigned for an improved transportation system to span across Pennsylvania. Since the colonial era, Philadelphia had looked west as far as Lancaster—about sixty-five miles away—for trade and travel enabled by the Philadelphia-Lancaster Road (a paved toll road after 1795). They also looked northwest to Reading, established in 1748 along the Schuylkill River. A canal between Reading and the Susquehanna Rivers, discussed since the 1790s, did not come to fruition until 1821. Meanwhile, developments in the early nineteenth century added to Philadelphians' imagination of an economic region reaching farther into the interior of Pennsylvania and beyond: the state capital moved from Philadelphia to Lancaster in 1799 and then to Harrisburg in 1812; Pittsburgh grew from the site of a fort into a city; and new western states came into the union (Ohio in 1803, Indiana in 1816, and Illinois in 1818). Whetting appetites for new fortunes, opportunities in the West were growing as steamboats began to ply the Ohio and Mississippi Rivers, reaching the expanding territory of cotton agriculture in the deep South. What could Philadelphians do to claim a share of the riches to come from the interior? How could they compete with New York and Baltimore, which seemed to be pulling ahead in the race to reach the West?

The Canal Campaign

Matthew Carey (1760-1839), newspaper editor and political economist, launched a vigorous campaign for a state-funded canal between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. Together with such prominent citizens as Congressman John Sergeant (1779-1852) and Nicholas Biddle (1786-1844), then president of the Second Bank of the United States, Carey formed the Pennsylvania Society for Promotion of Internal Improvements. With dues collected from fifty-five members, the society dispatched the architect and engineer William Strickland (1788-1854) to England to study the latest in transportation technology. Although Strickland returned with data that included the newest technology, railroads, Carey pushed aggressively for the more time-tested alternative of canals. Petitions, pamphlets, newspaper editorials, and mass meetings added momentum, despite opposition from southern Pennsylvania counties that traded with Baltimore and northeastern counties with economic ties to New York. In 1825, an Internal Improvement Convention in Harrisburg endorsed Carey's preference for a canal, and the next year the Pennsylvania legislature authorized construction of a state-funded Pennsylvania Canal between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. Adding a note of patriotic nationalism, construction began on the nation's fiftieth birthday, July 4, 1826.

Canal fever faced unavoidable hurdles of geography. Across the breadth of Pennsylvania, the state's major rivers offered good settings for canals, but not continuously and not in a straight line between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. And how could a canal possibly climb over the Allegheny Mountains? Such barriers did not stop the Main Line of Public Works. After nine years of construction, the system offered a journey that started in Philadelphia by rail—but the new Philadelphia and Columbia Railroad first moved by horsepower from a terminal near Broad and Vine Streets (then the northern city limits) across the Schuylkill via a newly built Columbia Viaduct Bridge. Then, a stationary steam engine pulled the cars by cable up an inclined plane to the top of Belmont Plateau in the area later incorporated into Fairmount Park. Thus positioned, cars could be joined to a steam locomotive to ride the rails west via Lancaster and down another inclined plane to Columbia on the Susquehanna River.

From Columbia, the journey continued northwest by canal alongside the Susquehanna and Juniata Rivers until the densely forested Allegheny Mountains blocked the way. At this juncture, at the town of Hollidaysburg, the trip required changing from water travel to another system of inclined planes, this one far more extensive than the beginning incline in Philadelphia. The Allegheny Portage Railroad involved hauling cars along a thirty-six-mile sequence of ten inclines and through a tunnel—the nation's first for a railroad—to conquer a 1,400-foot change in elevation. After the trip over the mountains, the Main Line continued by canal from Johnstown to its ultimate destination in Pittsburgh. By the 1840s, the burdens of transferring people and cargo between canals and railways diminished with the introduction of canal boats that could be separated into sections to ride on rail cars when necessary and then reattached to return to the water.

Original Article

https://philadelphiaencyclopedia.org/essays/main-line-of-public-works/

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.7

Internal Improvements

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ARGUMENT ROLES	8.2.1 Support; 8.2.2 Support

Excerpt · 1,009 words

"Internal improvements" was a nineteenth-century term referring to investment in transportation projects such as roads, railroads, canals, harbors, and river navigation projects. These public works are an accepted responsibility of the modern state government, but in earlier times the concept of public funding for such projects was new and controversial. North Carolina was so isolated and poor in the early nineteenth century that it was derisively nicknamed the "Rip Van Winkle State." At alarming rates, emigrants fled its stagnant economy, worn-out farmland, poverty, and lack of opportunity. Among the state's greatest handicaps was inadequate transportation. Only a few rivers in the east were navigable, and even these were shallow and difficult to travel. The coast offered few good harbors, and roads, where they existed, were terrible. Under such conditions transportation was slow, inefficient, and so expensive that farmers could not afford to ship their produce more than a few miles.

Some state leaders, such as Governors Alexander Martin in 1791 and Nathaniel Alexander in 1806, asked the General Assembly for money to finance internal improvements. But many legislators and voters strongly opposed raising taxes or increasing government's involvement in internal improvements; for years, the state's role was limited to granting charters to private companies to operate toll bridges, canals, and navigation projects.

North Carolina's greatest advocate of internal improvements was state legislator and Caswell County native Archibald D. Murphey, who recommended that the government undertake ambitious transportation projects, develop market towns to build the state's economy, and drain swamps in the east to create new, fertile farmland. A revised version of his proposals to the General Assembly from 1815 to 1818 appeared in his 1819 Memoir on Internal Improvements. Murphey's plans included providing North Carolina with an extensive network of canals and navigable rivers linked by good roads. The new routes would be funneled into three systems: the Roanoke River and Albemarle Sound; the Tar and Neuse Rivers, which would have ocean access through Ocracoke Inlet; and a linking of the Yadkin and Catawba Rivers with the Cape Fear, to give western North Carolina access to the Atlantic. One of the state's great visionaries, Murphey did much to popularize internal improvements; however, he died before his ideas became reality.

Archibald De Bow Murphey. Engraving by John Sartain. In Samuel Ashe, Biographical History of North Carolina. Greensboro: Charles L. Van Noppen, 1906. Vol. 14, following p. 340.

In 1819 the work of Murphey and like-minded leaders persuaded the legislature to create a corporation, called the President and Directors of the Board of Internal Improvements, to manage a Fund for Internal Improvements, which would be a permanent source of revenue to underwrite internal improvements. The Board of Internal Improvements consisted of the governor (as an ex officio member) and six directors elected from each of the state's six judicial districts by a joint ballot of the two houses of the legislature. The duties of the board included appointing civil engineers for the state, subscribing to stock in public works as authorized by the General Assembly, recommending surveys and additional projects for legislative consideration, and reporting on the status of the Fund for Internal Improvements and internal improvements in which the state had an interest.

The General Assembly originally underwrote the Internal Improvements Fund using the proceeds from the sale of land formerly belonging to the Cherokee Indians. Federal treaties had extinguished title to approximately a million acres in the mountains in 1819, and the state proceeded to sell the land. In its 1821-22 session, the legislature, declaring that the fund was "entirely insufficient," augmented land sales with dividends from state-owned stock in the Bank of New Bern and the Bank of the Cape

Fear.

Attention to internal improvements grew during the presidential election of 1824. Andrew Jackson's campaign platform included populist politics and the promise of internal improvements to less-developed states, like North Carolina. Jackson's platform resonated with voters in NC, as the state lagged behind its neighbors due to its lack of internal infrastructure

From the inception of the Internal Improvements Fund to the mid-1830s, the legislature used its moneys in conjunction with direct appropriations from the state treasury to promote various projects. Of $291,865 spent on internal improvements to 1836, $205,388 came from the fund. Engineering (surveys) amounted to $67,808; stock subscriptions in navigation companies (Roanoke, Cape Fear, Yadkin, Tar, Neuse, Catawba), the Clubfoot and Harlow Creek Canal Company, and turnpike companies (Buncombe and Plymouth), $142,900; direct appropriations for river improvements and highways, $59,157; and loans to support the Clubfoot and Harlow Creek Canal, Old Fort and Asheville Roads, and the Tennessee River Turnpike, $22,000.

Beyond financial assistance to the railroads and the usual expenses of the Board of Internal Improvements (travel for members of the board and salary of a clerk), relatively small sums of money from the fund were used to survey the Nags Head area on the Outer Banks and to finance road building and maintenance in the Mountain region. In 1847 the General Assembly, facing financial difficulties, decided to transfer the balance of the Internal Improvements Fund-$75,840-and all securities and sources of revenue for the fund to the public treasury. Thereafter most internal improvements were underwritten by direct appropriations.

Murphey's was not the only voice promoting reform. In 1828 Joseph Caldwell raised public interest in railroads through a series of newspaper essays, later republished as The Numbers of Carlton. The once nearly monolithic Republican Party split over several issues at the federal and state levels, including internal improvements. Progressive Republicans who supported internal improvements and other reforms formed the Whig Party around 1834-35. The Whigs adopted many of Murphey's ideas, making the party popular in western North Carolina, an underdeveloped region that hoped to benefit from new roads. The Albemarle Sound area, dependent on trade with Virginia, also favored the Whig policy of aiding transportation. By the mid-1830s, support for internal improvements was a crucial factor in the Whig ascendancy to the governorship and control of the General Assembly. Whig governors Edward B. Dudley, John Motley Morehead, and William A. Graham strongly advocated internal improvements.

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.8

The Erie Canal Commissioners

Erie Canal Museum

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.2.1 Support

Excerpt · 438 words (complete article)

Ideas for an artificial waterway system to boost the commerce and power of New York state began following the Revolutionary War, and began in earnest in the early 1800's. The New York State Legislature began seriously considering potential routes for such a system in 1808. It was not until 1810 that plans for the canal truly started taking shape with the appointment of the first canal commissioners by the New York State Legislature.

These canal commissioners were what could be considered today the upper management of the Erie Canal construction. The early stages of the canal planning saw the commissioners examining the potential canal routes, and submitting reports on which route to use for the final project. The first seven commissioners were all powerful New Yorkers: DeWitt Clinton, Gouverneur Morris, Peter B. Porter, Simeon DeWitt, Stephen Van Rensselaer, Thomas Eddy, and William North. These commissioners also frequently put forward plans and proposed bills to the state legislature to help with important aspects of building the canal such as funding.

The state legislature contributed by establishing further governing bodies for the Erie Canal, notably the Canal Fund in 1817 and the Canal Board in 1826. It was often the case that some of the canal commissioners sat on these boards as well.

As progress on the building of the Erie Canal commenced, commissioners took on different, but still similar, duties to those they held before. Occasionally new commissioners such as Myron Holley and Samuel Young came on board, and older commissioners left. It was the responsibility of the commissioners to submit annual reports to the state legislature, outlining any new proposed plans and progress. The construction of the canal itself was divided into three divisions, and each division had its own designated commissioner responsible for its oversight.

The commissioners for the Erie Canal were remarkably efficient in their work, managing to complete the original Erie Canal in eight years time. This is notable considering the marked political differences within their ranks. The men not only held differing political views, but also early on held differing ideas of which route was the best to take. Commissioners during this time would often champion the route which best served their own personal or political interests. They also sometimes found themselves at odds in the political arena. The state legislature attempted to keep the commissioner ranks politically balanced, so as to ensure all factions were equally represented. This, however, sometimes resulted in power struggles between the different factions playing out on the assembly floor. Despite these challenges, the commissioners were still ultimately able to come together and complete construction for the Erie Canal.

Original Article

https://reflections.eriecanalmuseum.org/laborers-nys-employees/the-erie-canal-commissioners/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.9

Albert Gallatin and Canals

Gayle Martinelli

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PUBLICATION	Last updated January 3, 2018
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.2.1 Support; 8.2.2 Support; 8.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 532 words (complete article)

> *"The present population of the United States, compared with the extent of territory over which it is spread, does not, except in the vicinity of the seaports, admit that extensive commercial intercourse within short distances, which, in England and some other countries, forms the principal support of artificial roads and canals. . . . . It is necessary, in order to be productive, that the canal should be a communication with a natural extensive navigation which will flow through that new channel. . ."*
>
> *From Albert Gallatin's Report on Roads, Canals, Harbors and Rivers 1808*

The canals of the Pennsylvania Mainline and the canal era in the United States may not have occurred without the inspiring work of Albert Gallatin.

Gallatin, President Jefferson's Secretary of the Treasury, understood that transportation systems in the young country were, at best, dismal, rough and unreliable. Rutted mud roads and impassable waterways hindered the unification and prosperity of the young country and made it difficult, often impossible, for farmers and others to move their goods to market.

Fortunately, Jeffersonians Gallatin, James Madison, and even Thomas Jefferson himself were advocates of internal improvements, as they sought expansion to the West. Gallatin understood that for the United States to become a major nation, it needed to have efficient transportation arteries.

In 1807, the U. S. Senate passed a resolution calling upon the treasury department to compile a report proposing ways that the Federal Government could address these issues.

The result was Albert Gallatin's landmark *Report on Roads, Canals, Harbors and Rivers* submitted in 1808. The report outlined, in detail, what we may today call an "infrastructure project." It represented a great blueprint for a national system of internal improvements and has been called "one of the great planning documents in American history." It rose above the competition for state projects, as it proposed the logic and authority of a cohesive national plan.

Gallatin's familiarity with canal systems built in Europe rendered him an expert in exploring the use of canals in addition to road expansion and improvement. He, therefore, proposed plans for four great canals along the eastern coast to improve navigation inland: the Cape Cod Canal, the Delaware and Raritan Canal, the Chesapeake and Delaware Canal and the Dismal Swamp Canal.

He also recommended building canals across the Appalachians to improve river systems, including the Allegheny, Juniata, Susquehanna and Monongahela Rivers.

He proposed roads to be added as a part of this program; some of these were ultimately constructed as rail roads.

Gallatin's report was criticized as folly and impractical. Some, even Jefferson, thought that the plan may be unconstitutional and he preferred to wait for a constitutional amendment before implementing Gallatin's plan. The proposals were later included in a comprehensive bill in 1810; however, the War of 1812 delayed implementation.

The War of 1812 was followed by not only the beginning of state power but a great era of American canal building. Many of the Gallatin's proposed projects were eventually constructed. Most projects were favorably endorsed by the public and they were completed with a combination of state, private and local government funding rather than federal aid. The projects took more than 50 years to complete.

Original Article

https://www.nps.gov/articles/albert-gallatin-and-canals.htm

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.10

Turnpikes and Toll Roads in Nineteenth-Century America

Daniel B. Klein and John Majewski

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ARGUMENT ROLES	8.2.2 Support; 8.2.3 Counter-Argument

Excerpt · 940 words

Private turnpikes were business corporations that built and maintained a road for the right to collect fees from travelers.[2] Accounts of the nineteenth-century transportation revolution often treat turnpikes as merely a prelude to more important improvements such as canals and railroads. Turnpikes, however, left important social and political imprints on the communities that debated and supported them. Although turnpikes rarely paid dividends or other forms of direct profit, they nevertheless attracted enough capital to expand both the coverage and quality of the U. S. road system. Turnpikes demonstrated how nineteenth-century Americans integrated elements of the modern corporation – with its emphasis on profit-taking residual claimants – with non-pecuniary motivations such as use and esteem.

Private road building came and went in waves throughout the nineteenth century and across the country, with between 2,500 and 3,200 companies successfully financing, building, and operating their toll road. There were three especially important episodes of toll road construction: the turnpike era of the eastern states 1792 to 1845; the plank road boom 1847 to 1853; and the toll road of the far West 1850 to 1902.

The Turnpike Era, 1792–1845

Prior to the 1790s Americans had no direct experience with private turnpikes; roads were built, financed and managed mainly by town governments. Typically, townships compelled a road labor tax. The State of New York, for example, assessed eligible males a minimum of three days of roadwork under penalty of fine of one dollar. The labor requirement could be avoided if the worker paid a fee of 62.5 cents a day. As with public works of any kind, incentives were weak because the chain of activity could *not* be traced to a *residual claimant* – that is, private owners who claim the "residuals," profit or loss. The laborers were brought together in a transitory, disconnected manner. Since overseers and laborers were commonly farmers, too often the crop schedule, rather than road deterioration, dictated the repairs schedule. Except in cases of special appropriations, financing came in dribbles deriving mostly from the fines and commutations of the assessed inhabitants. Commissioners could hardly lay plans for decisive improvements. When a needed connection passed through unsettled lands, it was especially difficult to mobilize labor because assessments could be worked out only in the district in which the laborer resided. Because work areas were divided into districts, as well as into towns, problems arose coordinating the various jurisdictions. Road conditions thus remained inadequate, as New York's governors often acknowledged publicly (Klein and Majewski 1992, 472-75).

For Americans looking for better connections to markets, the poor state of the road system was a major problem. In 1790, a viable steamboat had not yet been built, canal construction was hard to finance and limited in scope, and the first American railroad would not be completed for another forty years. Better transportation meant, above all, better highways. State and local governments, however, had small bureaucracies and limited budgets which prevented a substantial public sector response. Turnpikes, in essence, were organizational innovations borne out of necessity – "the states admitted that they were unequal to the task and enlisted the aid of private enterprise" (Durrenberger 1931, 37).

America's very limited and lackluster experience with the publicly operated toll roads of the 1780s hardly portended a future boom in private toll roads, but the success of private toll bridges may have inspired some future turnpike companies. From 1786 to 1798, fifty-nine private toll bridge companies were chartered in the northeast, beginning with Boston's Charles River Bridge,

which brought investors an average annual return of 10.5 percent in its first six years (Davis 1917, II, 188). Private toll bridges operated without many of the regulations that would hamper the private toll roads that soon followed, such as mandatory toll exemptions and conflicts over the location of toll gates. Also, toll bridges, by their very nature, faced little toll evasion, which was a serious problem for toll roads.

The *more* significant predecessor to America's private toll road movement was Britain's success with private toll roads. Beginning in 1663 and peaking from 1750 to 1772, Britain experienced a private turnpike movement large enough to acquire the nickname "turnpike mania" (Pawson 1977, 151). Although the British movement inspired the future American turnpike movement, the institutional differences between the two were substantial. Most important, perhaps, was the difference in their organizational forms. British turnpikes were incorporated as trusts – non-profit organizations financed by bonds – while American turnpikes were stock-financed corporations seemingly organized to pay dividends, though acting within narrow limits determined by the charter. Contrary to modern sensibilities, this difference made the British trusts, which operated under the firm expectation of fulfilling bond obligations, more intent and more successful in garnering residuals. In contrast, for the American turnpikes the hope of dividends was merely a faint hope, and never a legal obligation. Odd as it sounds, the stock-financed "business" corporation was better suited to operating the project as a civic enterprise, paying out returns in use and esteem rather than cash.

The first private turnpike in the United States was chartered by Pennsylvania in 1792 and opened two years later. Spanning 62 miles between Philadelphia and Lancaster, it quickly attracted the attention of merchants in other states, who recognized its potential to direct commerce away from their regions. Soon lawmakers from those states began chartering turnpikes. By 1800, 69 turnpike companies had been chartered throughout the country, especially in Connecticut (23) and New York (13). Over the next decade nearly six times as many turnpikes were incorporated (398). Table 1 shows that in the mid-Atlantic and New England states between 1800 and 1830, turnpike companies accounted for 27 percent of all business incorporations.

Original Article

https://eh.net/encyclopedia/turnpikes-and-toll-roads-in-nineteenth-century-america/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.11

The Mill Girls of Lowell

National Park Service, Lowell National Historical Park

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Excerpt · 1,000 words (complete article)

Who were the “mill girls”? The term “mill girls” was occasionally used in antebellum newspapers and periodicals to describe the young Yankee women, generally 15 - 30 years old, who worked in the large cotton factories. They were also called “female operatives.” Female textile workers often described themselves as mill girls, while affirming the virtue of their class and the dignity of their labor. During early labor protests, they asserted that they were “the daughters of freemen” whose rights could not be “trampled upon with impunity.”

Despite the hardship of mill work, women remained an important part of the textile workforce for many years. In the late 19th century, women held nearly two-thirds of all textile jobs in Lowell, with many immigrant women joining Yankee mill girls in the textile industry

Choices and Changes

To find workers for their mills in early Lowell, the textile corporations recruited women from New England farms and villages. These “daughters of Yankee farmers” had few economic opportunities, and many were enticed by the prospect of monthly cash wages and room and board in a comfortable boardinghouse. Beginning in 1823, with the opening of Lowell’s first factory, large numbers of young women moved to the growing city.

In the mills, female workers faced long hours of toil and often grueling working conditions. Yet many female textile workers saved money and gained a measure of economic independence. In addition, the city’s shops and religious institutions, along with its educational and recreational activities, offered an exciting social life that most women from small villages had never experienced.

Leaving Home

Most of the women who came to Lowell were from farms and small villages. Some had labored in small textile mills. Others had produced cotton or woolen goods or shoes for merchants who employed men and women in their homes and paid them by the pieces they produced.

On many farms the father was the property owner and head of household. Family members shared daily and seasonal tasks. In addition to strenuous chores outdoors, mothers and daughters toiled in the home, cooking, cleaning, and making clothes. This hardscrabble life proved increasingly difficult for young women, and by the early 1800s a growing number of Yankee farm families faced severe economic difficulties. For many young, rural women, the decision to leave home for a city like Lowell was often born of necessity.

A New Way to Live and Work

For most young women, Lowell’s social and economic opportunities existed within the limits imposed by the powerful textile corporations. Most pronounced was the control corporations exerted over the lives of their workers. The men who ran the corporations and managed the mills sought to regulate the moral conduct and social behavior of their workforce. Within the factory, overseers were responsible for maintaining work discipline and meeting production schedules. In the boardinghouses, the keepers enforced curfews and strict codes of conduct. Male and female workers were expected to observe the Sabbath, and temperance was strongly encouraged.

The clanging factory bell summoned operatives to and from the mill, constantly reminding them that their days were structured around work. Most textile workers toiled for 12 to 14 hours a day and half a day on Saturdays; the mills were closed on Sundays. Typically, mill girls were employed for nine to ten months of the year, and many left the factories during part of the summer to visit back home.

Life in a Boardinghouse

The majority of mill girls in Lowell lived in boardinghouses. These large, corporation-owned buildings were often run by a female keeper, or a husband and wife. A typical boardinghouse consisted of eight units, with 20 to 40 women living in each unit.

For most young women, life in the boardinghouse was dramatically different from life on the farm. Usually they shared a room with three other women, sleeping two to a bed. A fireplace in each room provided warmth in the colder seasons. The keeper prepared three meals a day, and the women dined together in a common room. Women formed many new friendships with other female boarders. The bonds created through daily social intercourse helped new workers adjust to the demands of factory life. And during the strife of labor protests, boardinghouses often became informal centers of organizing activity.

Voices of Protest

Lowell's textile corporations paid higher wages than those in other textile cities, but work was arduous and conditions were frequently unhealthy. Although the city's corporations threatened labor reformers with firing or blacklisting, many mill girls protested wage cuts and working conditions. Female workers struck twice in the 1830s. In the 1840s, female labor reformers banded together to promote the ten-hour day, in the face of strong corporate opposition. Few strikes succeeded, however, and Lowell's workforce remained largely unorganized.

Adding to the difficulties of organizing Lowell's operatives was the changing ethnic composition of the workforce. The number of Irish employed in Lowell's mills rose dramatically in the 1840s, as Irish men and women fled their faminestricken land. Thousands of immigrants from many other countries settled in Lowell in the decades after the Civil War, yet women remained a major part of the Lowell's textile workforce. In large strikes against the textile manufacturers in 1903 and 1912, women workers played prominent roles.

One Mill Girl's Story: Sarah Bagley

One of Lowell's early leading labor reformers was a mill girl named Sarah Bagley. Born on a New Hampshire farm in 1806, Bagley arrived in Lowell in 1836 and worked in a number of mills. She became a powerful speaker on behalf of male and female workers, promoted the 10-hour workday, and edited the labor newspaper The Voice of Industry.

In a letter to a friend in 1846, Bagley promoted the labor reform publication Factory Tracts as representing the interests of those "who are not willing to see our sex made into living machines to do the bidding of the incorporated aristocrats and reduced to a sum for their bodily services hardly sufficient to keep soul and body together." Although the struggles of Bagley and other mill girls to achieve legislation for a 10-hour day failed, Lowell's textile corporations did reduce the workday to 11 hours.

Original Article

https://www.nps.gov/lowe/learn/historyculture/the-mill-girls-of-lowell.htm

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

"Mill Girls of Lowell."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.12

“The Lowell Offering” and the Literature of the Lowell Mill Girls

Patrick Hastings

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PUBLICATION	March 4, 2026
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.3
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.3.1 Support; 8.3.2 Support

Excerpt · 821 words (complete article)

After a twelve-hour day of grueling industrial labor, the young female workers of Lowell, Massachusetts spent the evening hours engaged in educational pursuits and cultural activities ranging from piano to poetry to political activism. The most enduring product of these activities is The Lowell Offering, a literary magazine “wholly written by females employed in the mills.”

Charles Dickens visited Lowell during his first tour through America in the early months of 1842. He toured a town built around integrated textile factories with a workforce of roughly 8,000 female textile workers known as the Lowell Mill Girls. These young women, typically between 15-30 years old, came from rural New England in search of paid work, independence, and educational opportunities.

“Lowell, Mass., Mills on Merrimack River.” c. 1900. Detroit Publishing Company Photograph Collection, Prints and Photographs Division.

Dickens, known for his criticism of the dehumanizing effects of the industrial system, compared the Lowell Mills favorably against the harsh conditions of the English factories when he published an account of his travels titled American Notes for General Circulation in October of 1842.

Charles Dickens wrote about the cultural enrichment opportunities available to the Lowell Mill Girls. He also promoted The Lowell Offering as a journal of high literary merit.

In American Notes, Dickens commented on the Lowell Mill workers’ comfortable living conditions, their access to good healthcare, and their opportunities for education, noting that “nearly all these young ladies subscribe to circulating libraries.” Dickens also noted that the Lowell Mill Girls “have got up among themselves a periodical called The Lowell Offering, a repository of original articles written exclusively by females actively employed in the mills.”

After reading “four hundred good solid pages” of The Lowell Offering, Dickens declared that “it will compare advantageously with a great many English Annuals.” This journal, published at irregular intervals between 1840-45, featured essays, poetry, and works of fiction written and edited by the Lowell Mill Girls.

The first essay in the first issue of The Lowell Offering, “Defence of Factory Girls,” responded to an article by Orestes Brownson, a prominent Transcendentalist writer and activist. In the Boston Quarterly Review, Brownson suggested a moral dark side to working in the mills; he wrote that to attach the label “‘She has worked in a factory’ is almost enough to damn to infamy the most worthy and virtuous girl.” The Lowell Offering published Harriet Farley’s blistering article in response, accusing Brownson of slander and asserting that “our well filled churches and lecture halls will testify that the state of morals and intelligence is not low.” Writing as an anonymous “Factory Girl,” Farley demanded that Brownson’s statement be “publicly retracted. If he still doubts upon the subject, let him come among us.”

The pieces presented in The Lowell Offering offer a range of attitudes toward the conditions and lived experience of the workers. The journal published dozens of authors; some are critical, satirical, or explicit in demands for improved conditions, and others celebrate the opportunities and freedoms available in Lowell that were otherwise rare to young females in this era. Yes, the company provided workers with a lecture series, piano lessons, literary meetings, and access to a lending library – but only in

the evenings after they had worked 12-hour shifts in loud, poorly ventilated factories. The Lowell Offering presented different sides of the debate over working conditions, women's rights, and the rise of the Lowell Female Labor Reform Association, the first trade union of industrial women in the U.S.

Mind Amongst the Spindles: A Miscellany Wholly Composed by the Factory Girls. Boston: Jordan, Swift, and Wiley, 1845.

The best and most influential pieces from The Lowell Offering were gathered for inclusion in an anthology titled Mind Amongst the Spindles: A Miscellany Wholly Composed by the Factory Girls (1845). Among the thirty-seven pieces selected for this anthology, we find works of realistic fiction depicting the lives of factory workers, literary criticism comparing poetic modes, Romantic essays depicting excursions into the New England countryside, and further varieties of writing. The book's "Introduction" includes a lengthy and laudatory letter by the prominent English sociologist and feminist Harriet Martineau, who toured Lowell with Ralph Waldo Emerson during a lecture series he was delivering to the factory workers.

The Lowell Offering provided a model for publications in other mill towns, but not all readers or factory workers celebrated the magazine. Sarah G. Bagley, the first female labor leader in the U.S., for example, publicly condemned the magazine for refusing to publish her most critical pieces against the working conditions in the mills. Bagley would become editor of the Voice of Industry magazine that presented a more militant attitude toward labor issues.

Volumes of The Lowell Offering and other materials related to industrial working conditions are available in the Rare Book Reading Room for researchers and interested readers to explore, and the Library's catalog record for this journal includes links to digitized copies available via HathiTrust.

Original Article

https://blogs.loc.gov/bibliomania/2026/03/04/the-lowell-offering-and-the-literature-of-the-lowell-mill-girls/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Hastings, "Literature of the Lowell Mill Girls."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.13

Lowell, Story of an Industrial City: The Mill Girls

Thomas Dublin

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WEBSITE	National Park Service
PUBLICATION	1992; web version last updated March 30, 2021
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.3
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.3.1 Support; 8.3.2 Support; 8.3.3 Support

Excerpt · 271 words (complete article)

As much as the massive brick mills along the Merrimack, "mill girls" were an innovation of the early industrial revolution in New England. Lowell's mill workforce in the antebellum decades consisted largely of young single women from the farming communities of northern New England. Most were between 15 and 25, signing on for short stints that rarely exceeded a year at a time. Overall, they averaged about three years of employment before leaving the mills for marriage, migration to the west, other employment, or return to their hometowns. Dissatisfaction with the work environment was a major reason for leaving the mills. In the 1830s and 40s women operatives protested against mill conditions. Their labor movement was not a narrow lobbying effort, but a broad reform campaign embracing a wide range of issues and underpinned by firm ideals. Writing in the Voice of Industry, Huldah J. Stone described the attitude of Lowell Female Labor Reform Association members toward reduction of the hours of labor: “They do not regard this measure as an end, but only as one step toward the end to be attained. They deeply feel that their work will never be accomplished until slavery and oppression, mental, physical, and religious, shall have been done away with and Christianity in its original simplicity...shall be reestablished and practiced among men.” In return for monthly cash wages, female workers in Lowell agreed to regulations that varied little from company to company: work for at least a year; live in a company boardinghouse; attend church. Many worked for a year and went back to the farm, some repeating this pattern two or three times.

Original Article

https://www.nps.gov/articles/lowell-handbook-mill-girls.htm

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Dublin, "Mill Girls."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.14

Chapter 2: Builders of the Young Republic

Edward Pessen

AUTHOR	Edward Pessen (Historian of Jacksonian America (CUNY); chapter in the Department of Labor's bicentennial history)
WEBSITE	U.S. Department of Labor
PUBLICATION	1976 (undated on page)
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.4.1 Support; 8.4.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,156 words

[Excerpt begins partway through the chapter.]

Living conditions even of skilled mechanics were yet another source of irritation. Working-class housing was typically crowded, noisy, and marked by inadequate sanitation and rubbish removal. The era's urban improvements, whether in water supply, street paving, lighting, or safety were characteristically introduced first to the quarters of the well to do. The streets and wards or districts of antebellum cities were clearly differentiated by wealth and class. The rich lived in elegant mansions in exclusive enclaves, leaving the mass of urban inhabitants to the "working class wards." This pattern prevailed for old seaboard cities such as Boston, Philadelphia, and New York, and newer western cities such as Pittsburgh, Cincinnati, and Natchez. Wealth was grossly maldistributed in antebellum towns and cities. The working people who made up the majority of the urban population owned a pitifully small portion--about five percent or less--of urban wealth.

A contributor to a Philadelphia newspaper in 1831 cheerfully advised that "with few exceptions, frugal industrious journeymen, unencumbered with families, may save so much of their wages, as in a few years to be enabled to commence business on their own account." A few years later a judge in New York City, at the same time that he branded striking unions as illegal combinations that allegedly were "mainly upheld by foreigners," assured mechanics that in this "land of law and liberty, the road to advancement is open to all and the journeymen may by their skill and industry, and moral worth, soon become flourishing master mechanics" or employers. The men who flocked to the labor organizations showed their disbelief in such comforting promises.

A number of the workingmen's parties were "workingmen" in name only. Yet most of the organizations were authentic. Their memberships were typically small, but that was due in large part to the savage attacks levelled at them by a hostile press. The Boston manufacturer Amos Lawrence, snorting that "we are literally all working men," charged that "the attempt to get up a 'Working Men's party' is a libel upon the whole population, as it implies that there are among us large numbers who are not working men." A more characteristic attack on the new parties took the form of name-calling. They were denounced as "agrarians" or anarchists, "levellers," a "mob," a "rabble" the "dirty-shirt party," "tag, rag, and bobtail," and "ring-streaked speckled rabble."

The Philadelphia party arose out of a decision by the city's Mechanics' Union of Trade Associations to enter into politics in order to promote "the interests and enlightenment of the working classes." This union consisted of societies of painters, glaziers, bricklayers, typographers, and journeymen of a dozen other trades. The Philadelphia party, like so many others, was led by or nominated to office men who were themselves not workers. Stephen Simpson, political candidate of the party, was the well-to-do son of an officer in the great Girard Bank. Robert Dale Owen, a leader of the Workingmen's party in New York City, was the son of a factory owner and had known comfort, even luxury, from childhood. Simpson and Owen, embracing radical social principles that were in some respects socialistic, believed that labor created all wealth and that inequality and social distress were caused by private property.

The many dozen parties in the towns and cities of the country made no attempt to form a national organization, and each went its own way. Yet the program championed by their party journals was amazingly similar. The Philadelphia Mechanic's Free Press, the New York Working Man's Advocate, and the Indianapolis Union and Mechanics' and Working Man's Advocate all

listed similar demands. Some of these associations called for an equal distribution of property, others for state-run boarding schools to instill new ideas in the young of the next generation. There was almost universal support for trade unions and mechanics' lien laws to assure that workers had first call on their employers' payrolls; abolition of imprisonment for debt; a tax-supported public school system free of a degrading paupers' oath requirement; reform of a militia system that permitted those able to afford it to avoid service; simplification of the legal system, as well as making it less expensive; and abolition of the system whereby state legislatures enacted special laws conferring monopolistic charters on favored bank directors and other entrepreneurs.

The Workingmen's parties were characteristically disdainful of the major parties. They might on occasion support one or another of them on a given issue, such as backing the Democratic "war" against the second Bank of the United States. In that famous affair, President Andrew Jackson and his party tried to give the impression that they opposed the rechartering of the bank because it allegedly oppressed labor and the poor. Actually, the needs and welfare of labor had nothing to do with the issue. For all his reputation as a champion of have-nots, Jackson paid little attention to labor. He was in fact the first presidential strikebreaker, sending in federal troops to crush a strike of workers against a canal company directed by his friend John Eaton.

The cornerstone of the labor movement, however, was not ephemeral political organizations but trade unions. The first trades' union--or merging of separate journeymen's societies--took place in New York City on August 14, 1833. Realizing that individual societies could not cope singlehandedly with employers, artisans all over the country quickly followed the lead of the New Yorkers. Carpenters, bakers, soap makers, printers, cabinetmakers, masons, bookbinders, house painters, combmakers, brush makers, tailors, hat makers, weavers, jewelers, blacksmiths, machinists, rope makers, sailmakers, carvers, gilders, cordwainers, chairmakers, and artisans in dozens of other occupations formed new societies or flocked to old ones. Unions sprang up in Philadelphia, Boston, Baltimore, Washington, D.C., Newark, New Brunswick, Albany, Schenectady, Pittsburgh, Louisville, Cincinnati, St. Louis, and most other urban areas.

The new unions were led by idealistic radicals, many of whom denounced private property and the wage system as the root causes of poverty and injustice. Union journals show that every variety of social, economic, political, and judicial reform attracted them and evoked their sympathy. The unions' actions, however, make clear that broad reforms were peripheral. The central interest was wages and hours, the characteristic activity the strike.

Strikes for the ten-hour day were often unsuccessful. In Boston in 1825 the journeymen house carpenters had struck against the sunup to sundown working day they found so "derogatory to the principles of justice and humanity." The master carpenters on the other hand had defended the long working day as "that which has been customary from time immemorial." Backed by merchant capitalists who denounced the strike as a nefarious scheme allegedly put forward by foreign agitators and a press controlled by these merchants, the masters and their influential allies defeated the strike. In 1832, when the house carpenters were joined by journeymen ship carpenters, masons, painters, and sailmakers from Boston and nearby suburbs, a ten-hour strike was again crushed by thc powerful alliance of masters, capitalists, and press.

Original Article

https://www.dol.gov/general/aboutdol/history/chapter2

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Pessen, "Builders of the Young Republic."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.15

Radical Revisions: Thomas Skidmore Reads Thomas Paine in 1829 New York

Matteo Battistini

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PUBLICATION	July 2009 (issue 9.4)
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.4.1 Support

Excerpt · 979 words

Half a century after the American Revolution, mid-Atlantic urban workers toasted Thomas Paine. In the streets and taverns of Philadelphia and New York, they praised the author of Common Sense and Rights of Man. These men realized that poverty and inequality were not inevitable but could instead be overcome. One of them was Thomas Skidmore, the leader of the New York workingmen's movement that went on strike against plans to extend the workday in 1829. The publication of Skidmore's four-hundred-page treatise, The Rights of Man to Property!, coincided with the strong showing of the Workingmen's ticket in the state elections held in November 1829. Skidmore argued that all laws favoring the perpetuation of property ran counter to the democratic principles on which the American Republic had been founded. This deeply held conviction about the legal basis of economic inequality explains why Skidmore, unlike so many of his peers, did not exalt Paine for being a revolutionary hero of 1776 or laud his legacy as the voice of "common sense." Instead, Skidmore attacked Paine's theories of political economy, directing his readers' attention away from Paine's more familiar patriotic writings and toward his lesser-known Dissertations on Government; The Affair of the Bank; and Paper Money. This pamphlet revealed the problematic implications of the famous radical's thought when viewed in a different temporal context, one marked both by political democratization and economic inequality.

Skidmore saw in the American Revolution, not only the democratic legacy of 1776, but also the unjust foundation of a republic based on economic inequality. In his opinion, the creation of the national and state finance structures set forth in the Constitution—the institution of banks, the formalization of public debt, and a private credit system—had initiated a process of "accumulation," by establishing an economy that favored the concentration of wealth in the hands of a few. Reading Paine's Dissertations alongside Skidmore's The Rights of Man to Property! helps us chart the tensions between the political revolutions of the eighteenth century and the economic revolutions of the nineteenth. By the time that Skidmore took up his pen, the expansion of suffrage had emancipated white laboring men throughout the North, opening politics up to citizens who criticized the alarming levels of poverty and economic dependence engendered by the exploitation of wage labor. As the expectation of personal independence inherited from the Revolution gave rise to a pointed critique of wage labor, a new generation of radicals, Skidmore included, began to revise older ideas to suit their own circumstances.

Mr. Thomas Paine, engraved by Augus; artist, Peel (date unknown). Courtesy of the American Portrait Print Collection at the American Antiquarian Society, Worcester, Massachusetts.

Skidmore and Paine in 1829 New York City

In 1828, the democratic reforms sweeping the United States culminated in the election of President Andrew Jackson. Over the course of the 1820s, this spirit of reform had worked in New York to gradually open the vote to all adult white males, including laborers who were beset by a serious economic recession. The economic downturn placed additional financial pressure on employers, who attempted to increase their profit margins by lengthening the workday from ten to eleven hours. In March 1829, journeymen—a mixed lot of propertyless men, mainly white, who worked in different trades as blacksmiths, carpenters, tailors, masons, and so on—called public meetings to declare their refusal to work for more than ten hours per day.

The strike was successful, and even after employers renounced their plans to lengthen the workday, the journeymen continued meeting. They expanded their critique of the U.S. economy, shifting their focus from working conditions narrowly defined to broader questions about politics and society. They also challenged the partisan structure of the Second Party System by attacking politicians in both the Whig and Democratic parties as "aspiring demagogues, who have ... feelings—no interest, in common with workers." Far from serving the public, according to the laborers' critique, these men were party hacks who were "prompted only by ambition and avarice." For this reason, New York's radical journeymen decided to enter the November 1829 New York state election by running a slate of their own candidates, men who stood independent of the political establishment. The candidates ran on a platform that included a call for changes in the prevailing working conditions in shops and manufactories, but their proposals also extended far beyond the realm of wage labor. They demanded a string of reforms (ranging from the repeal of chartered banks to the abolition of commercial monopolies) that were calculated to appeal to the economic interests of small artisans and wage earners. When the votes were counted, the platform's appeal was undeniable; the Workingmen's ticket managed to poll nearly one-third of the total vote.

This was the social and political context in which Skidmore published Rights of Man to Property! Born in 1790 into a struggling family in Newton, Connecticut, Skidmore moved to New York City at the age of twenty-nine and set up shop as a machinist. Unlike most other artisans of the era, he would not remain confined to the obscurity of his workshop. His encounter with Paine's writings when he was a boy and his continuing immersion in political theory pushed him into New York's fervid political scene. By the end of the 1820s, Skidmore's experiences in the workplace and at the polls led him to connect the revolutionary legacy of 1776 to a biting critique of the economic hierarchies that continued to structure society. In Rights of Man to Property!, he criticized "great wealth" as "an instrument which is uniformly used to extort from others [the workers], their property in their personal qualities and efforts." In his opinion, the interest that the debtor paid the banker or creditor, the rent that the worker paid for his house or land to large proprietors, and the profit that the employer made by selling goods produced by workers all contributed to what he called "overgrown wealth."

Original Article

https://commonplace.online/article/radical-revisions/

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Battistini, "Radical Revisions."

CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.16

Working Men's Party

Patrick Grubbs

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WEBSITE	Encyclopedia of Greater Philadelphia, Rutgers University–Camden
PUBLICATION	2016
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.4.1 Qualify

Excerpt · 942 words (complete article)

The Working Men's Party of Philadelphia emerged in 1828 out of discontent with societal and workplace changes since the turn of the century. It formed out of the workingmen's movement of the late 1820s and sought broad reforms. Although short-lived, the effort contributed significantly to injecting politics with working-class issues, many of which became prominent in the city and state over the next decade.

In the first two decades of the nineteenth century, workers struggled to maintain a living wage as master artisans and entrepreneurs, seeking to expand production to meet the demands of expanded markets, instituted division of labor and lowered wages. Even as the twelve-hour day, or longer, became standard, workers faced the specter of imprisonment for debt, which in many cases occurred over trivial amounts of money. Workers also bridled at an education system that consisted of private and charity schools, which offered only limited opportunities for their children. Politically, Philadelphia also proved to be unfavorable for workers, as an 1806 Cordwainer's Trial judgment prohibited them from organizing for higher wages and few politicians proved to be advocates for the workingman.

As discontent grew into the late 1820s, workers drew on Revolutionary era ideals to argue that increased disparities of wealth and power contradicted the nation's founding principles. Opposition initially centered on the extended hours of the workday, which workers contended not only damaged their health, but hindered their ability to properly educate themselves on issues they had a right to vote on. Citing those concerns, carpenters went on strike for a ten-hour day in the summer of 1827. When the strike proved unsuccessful, labor leader William Heighton (1800-73) rallied journeymen to form the Mechanics' Union of Trade Associations (MUTA), the nation's first citywide coalition of local unions.

Recognizing how trades unions and journeymen societies had failed to secure working-class interests, Heighton turned to politics. At a January 1828 meeting of MUTA, Heighton presented a resolution for the creation of the Working Men's Party. Officially formed on August 11 as the nation's first labor party, the party platform called for a ten-hour workday, free public education, abolition of imprisonment for debt and the use of prison labor, militia reform, the creation of a mechanic's lien law, a cheaper legal system, and a more equitable tax system.

During the 1828 election, Working Men's candidates appeared on both city and county ballots for positions on the city councils and state legislature. A majority of these candidates ran on joint tickets with both the National Republican and Democratic parties. Only those joint-ticket, labor-endorsed candidates won, as the eight candidates who ran solely on the Working Men's Party ticket were defeated. Heighton attributed this poor showing to the complications of nascent political movements and hoped for a better outcome in 1829. However, despite its limited impact at the polls, the party could take some solace in that both major parties printed election bills with the words "From Six to Six," the slogan for the ten-hour workday (including one hour off for lunch and one for dinner). Issues important to the working class had become part of the political discussion in Philadelphia.

Following the 1828 election, party ward and district clubs formed in hopes of gaining further support. Organizers in Southwark formed the first men's political club, the Working Men's Republican Political Association, in January 1829. To demonstrate the party's independence and attempt to prevent fusion with the other parties, Working Men candidates were chosen by city and county conventions before the other parties held their conventions. That year the Working Men's Party reached the highest point

in its existence with the election of twenty of its fifty-four candidates, including those for sheriff and county commissioner. Although all of the successful candidates ran on joint tickets, their success gave labor-endorsed candidates the balance of power in Philadelphia.

Success proved temporary, however, as the Working Men's Party quickly lost traction. Democrats, who claimed sole interest in the workingmen, acted to split the Working Men's Party into factions. As the election of 1830 approached, members of the organization fiercely debated whether their candidates for the fall election should be workingmen, or "tried friends" of the movement, such as former banker and newspaper editor Stephen Simpson (1789-1854). As internal discord increased, both the National Republican and Democratic parties took aim at their constituents by adopting items from their platform, such as free public schools, abolishment of imprisonment for debt, and support for the ten-hour movement. Increasingly members of the Working Men's Party threw their support to the more established and better funded parties.

Stung by the party's poor performance in 1830, Heighton blamed the apathy of his fellow workers, and he left the city for good. In 1831 the Working Men's Party failed to offer a single candidate for election. America's first labor party was dead. However, the issues raised by the party lived on and the movement that started in 1827 began to achieve results in the 1830s. In 1833 Pennsylvania abolished imprisonment for debt. The following year the state passed the Free School Act of 1834, which offered primary education to every child without the necessity of publicly declaring their poor financial status. In 1835 the Philadelphia Common Council announced that workers employed by the city would be granted a ten-hour day.

The Working Men's movement of Philadelphia was more than simply an attempt by workers to gain better wages and hours. Infused with the ideals of economic, social, and political equality, its causes spread throughout the Northeast to cities such New York and Boston with the introduction of free public schools, the end of imprisonment for debt, and the fight for a shorter week.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.17

General Trades Union Strike (1835)

Patrick Grubbs

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PUBLICATION	2017
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.4.1 Support

Excerpt · 622 words (complete article)

The first general strike in the United States occurred in Philadelphia in 1835 when the short-lived General Trades' Union (GTU) of the City and County of Philadelphia led a citywide general strike to demand a ten-hour workday. The successful action set a precedent followed by other labor organizations in the nation later in the nineteenth century.

The GTU strike occurred after several failed attempts to organize working people through the creation of a Mechanics' Union of Trade Associations and a Working Men's Party. In 1833 Philadelphia labor leaders met in hopes of reigniting the city's nascent labor movement, and they created the GTU the following spring. The GTU, which broke barriers as one of the first labor organizations to accept unskilled workers, became the most remarkable citywide union of its time.

The strike began as an impromptu affair in late May 1835 when coal heavers of the Schuylkill docks went on strike for a ten-hour day. As they paraded down the streets of the city on June 3, cordwainers, carpenters, and other tradesmen followed with the shouts of "We are all day laborers!" Throughout the week leaders of the GTU used labor presses, posters, and parades complete with drum and fife corps demanding a ten-hour day, to rally Philadelphia workers to join their brethren in the fight. By June 10 over forty trades and nearly twenty thousand workers, including city employees, joined the strike. Shortly after city workers struck, the Common Council announced that workers employed under the authority of the City Corporation would be granted a ten-hour day. By the end of June, most laborers received the concessions they asked for, and membership in the GTU soared.

With this initial success, worker solidarity expanded to include unskilled workers, traditionally omitted from unionizing efforts. In the spring of 1836 Schuylkill dockers clashed with coal merchants when they sought a wage advance from their employers. When dockers struck, merchants won the assistance of Mayor John Swift (1790-1873), who had eight day laborers arrested and set their bail at an exceedingly high rate of $2,500 in hopes of breaking the strike. Swift's plan backfired, however, as the high bail made martyrs of those arrested. The GTU came to their aid, admitted the dockers into the organization, and helped fund their defense, which proved successful when they were acquitted of both breaching the peace and of charges of conspiracy.

GTU power helped to organize the city's labor and gained the workers of Philadelphia the ten-hour day. Every strike funded and supported by the GTU in the seven months following the general strike ended in victory for the workers, including that of the unskilled dockers. But the organization met a sad end. Many who joined the union left once concessions were made. Workers also faced a backlash from employers who formed masters associations to defeat striking workers. By 1837 only thirty unions remained, down from fifty-one in 1836. That year the first effects of the Panic of 1837 were felt by city workers, and within a year the organization was dead.

While the GTU of Philadelphia proved short-lived, its significance to organized labor movements reached into the next century. The General Strike of 1835, the nation's first general strike, proved successful and was employed by other American labor movements in the postbellum years, most notably in St. Louis in 1877 and throughout the nation in 1919. By admitting unskilled dockers into their union, the GTU of Philadelphia set a precedent not replicated until after the Civil War when it became a primary objective of the Knights of Labor. Together, the general strike and the inclusion of unskilled laborers in unions ultimately proved effective for organized labor during another dire period for American workers: the Great Depression.

Original Article

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Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.18

The Temperance Movement

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PUBLICATION	2015
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ARGUMENT ROLES	8.4.2 Support; 12.2.1 Support; 12.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 792 words (complete article)

Prior to the 19th century, the word temperance connoted moderation and restraint in appetites and behavior. Representations of the Virtues frequently depicted Temperance as a woman pouring diluting water into a wine cup. Early Temperance advocates in America urged the avoidance of liquors in favor of less intoxicating beverages like beer or wine; many people believed that small amounts of alcohol could be beneficial for one's health. (Stearns, 1994).

Restraint, however, did not characterize America's behavior. By 1830, the average American over 15 years old consumed nearly seven gallons of pure alcohol a year – three times as much as we drink today. Among urban factory workers, this level of intoxication created unreliability in the labor force, dismaying employers. At home, women and children often suffered, for they had few legal rights and were utterly dependent on husbands and fathers for support. (Burns & Novick, 2011).

During the first half of the 19th century, as drunkenness and its social consequences increased, temperance societies formed in Great Britain and the United States. These societies were typically religious groups that sponsored lectures and marches, sang songs, and published tracts that warned about the destructive consequences of alcohol. Eventually these temperance societies began to promote the virtues of abstinence or "teetotalism." By the 1830s and 1840s many societies in the United States began asking people to sign "pledges" promising to abstain from all intoxicating beverages.

The Woman's Christian Temperance Union (WCTU) was founded in Ohio in November of 1874, and grew out of the "Woman's Crusade" of the winter of 1873-1874. At a time when women had few opportunities for influence, or even to speak in public, the WCTU began to mobilize women to reform society. The organization spread across the nation. Local chapters of the group were called "Unions" and were largely autonomous, but linked to the state and national organization. In time, the WCTU would become the largest woman's organization in the United States. The white ribbon was selected to symbolize purity, and the WCTU's watchwords were "Agitate – Educate – Legislate." (Woman's Christian Temperance Union, n.d.)

The temperance movement's first successes were on the local and state level, but their aspirations were national. A number of other groups built on the foundation laid by the WCTU. The Prohibition Party, founded in 1869, played an important role in the temperance movement's push for a constitutional amendment banning the "manufacture, sale, or transportation of intoxicating liquors" (the Eighteenth Amendment). The Prohibition Party remains the oldest existing third party in the U.S. Though women did not yet have the right to vote, the Prohibition Party became the first to accept women as party members. (Anderson, 2011)

After 1898 the Anti-Saloon League (ASL), a men's organization strongly supported by Protestant ministers and congregations, took over as the primary prohibition lobby in America. Led by Wayne Wheeler, the ASL pioneered the use of "pressure politics," a strategy that uses media, publications, and behind-the-scenes influence to persuade politicians that the public demands an action. Unlike the WCTU, which was guided by Francis Willard's "do everything" philosophy, the ASL under Wheeler focused entirely on the goal of passing Prohibition–using whatever tactics were necessary.

To carry out this agenda, the Anti-Saloon League developed its own publishing house, the *American Issue* Publishing Company. This firm was based in Westerville, Ohio, and was headed by Ernest Cherrington. The Anti-Saloon League's primary publication was the American Issue, but published numerous other tracts as well. During the League's heyday, it issued more than forty tons of anti-liquor publications every month. (Ohio History Central, n.d.)

Americans of all types eventually found reasons for supporting the temperance movement. The 19th and early 20th centuries were time of demographic and economic change in America. Urbanization, industrialization, the rise of the women's rights and woman suffrage movements, progressivism, immigration and World War I all contributed to the society that voted to go "dry." Feminists like Susan B. Anthony supported prohibition because the abuse of alcohol so often led to violence against women. (Hamilton, 2002). Anti-immigration proponents associated alcohol with Irish and German immigrants. The Anti-Saloon League fought political opposition from brewers by connecting German beer with treason in the public imagination. (Burns & Novick, 2011)

The Eighteenth Amendment was passed by Congress in 1917, ratified in 1919, and went into effect at 12:01 am on January 17, 1920. The temperance movement had triumphed. Their victory was short-lived, however, as many Americans made and drank alcohol in violation of the law. Bootlegging and organized crime stepped in to profit from the market for spirits, while law enforcement lagged behind the rise in criminal behavior. Prohibition was unsustainable. In 1933 the Twenty-First Amendment repealed the Eighteenth, and manufacture, sale and consumption of alcohol again became legal in the United States.

Original Article

https://socialwelfare.library.vcu.edu/eras/the-temperance-movement/

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.19

Religion in Nineteenth-Century America

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ARGUMENT ROLES	8.4.2 Support; 12.1.2 Support; 12.1.3 Support; 12.2.1 Support; 12.2.3 Support; 12.4.2 Support

Excerpt · 837 words (complete article)

Beginning in the late 1790s on the western frontier, a new religious style was born. Itinerant preachers traversed the backcountry in search of converts by holding enthusiastic camp meetings. What came to be called the Second Great Awakening began as circuit riders, especially Methodists, stirred up emotional outpourings of Christian fervor. Among isolated migrants to places like Kentucky, the chance to socialize and release pent-up emotions at camp meetings had considerable appeal. Backcountry men and women also gained the spiritual comfort of hearing ministers assert that human beings had moral free agency, the innate ability to choose between good and evil. The doctrine represented a sharp departure from the gloomy tenets of Calvinism, the theological position that a person's fate was already predetermined by a wrathful God. This emphasis on human will and a more loving God would have a great impact on the course of American history in the nineteenth century.

By the 1820s and 1830s, the revivals and their message of optimism and perfectionism stretched eastward. Converts to the new religious ways ardently strove to eliminate sin from themselves and from their society. The result was a faith that promoted social reforms of various kinds, among them abolitionism, temperance, health reform, and the asylum movement. Religious fervor had political implications that would overturn an inherited order based on hierarchy and coercion. Only free individuals, they believed, could freely choose God.

Emotional conversion by individuals was at the core of the evangelical Protestantism that dominated during the Second Great Awakening. As with the earlier Puritans, the experience of conversion was the shaping event in a person's life. What separated the mainstream evangelical denominations of the 1800s from the Puritans, however, was a belief in the efficacy of human action in achieving both conversion and salvation. This combination of individual will and intense emotion marked the religion of the Second Great Awakening, and it also marked much of mainstream American culture by the middle of the nineteenth century.

Although conversion was an intensely personal experience, the revival was an intensely social event. Among the most famous revivals were those led by Charles Grandison Finney in Rochester, New York, during the winter of 1830-1831. Rochester, a boom town reeling from the market forces unleashed by the opening of the Erie Canal in 1825, was obsessed with religion for the six months Finney's revival lasted. (Western New York was so frequently swept by the fires of evangelical fervor that it became known as the "burnt-over district.")

Finney's "new measures" were actually improvisations introduced by the backcountry preachers three decades earlier. Finney, an itinerant Presbyterian, "democratized" Christianity by preaching in an entertaining and approachable manner, avoiding the extended Biblical exegesis common among Puritan ministers. His revival was social theater, and, of course, audience participation was indispensable. Prominent members of the community were seated upon the "anxious bench" directly before the platform, and Finney spoke directly to them in a way designed to appeal to them personally. He held protracted meetings, gathering night after night to augment the communal excitement of the revival. Women, as at the backcountry meetings, played a prominent role as emotional participants. In building up excitement for Finney's gatherings, women were especially important by encouraging other family members to attend.

Finney and other preachers of the Second Great Awakening rejected much of Calvinist theology. Instead, with his calls of "Do it!," Finney asserted that individuals had the power to change their lives to assure their own salvation. When the emotional upheaval inherent in the revival simmered down, people were left with a sense of self-control. The message of the revivals ended up creating very effective behaviors in the new world of the Market Revolution, a world in which competitive capitalism gave life

new opportunities as well as new insecurities. Sobriety, a work ethic, thrift, and delayed gratification, all defined as virtue, proved quite good rules for success for the men of the emerging middle class. Women who experienced revivals became agents for the moralization of their families and friends, empowered with a new found sense of moral authority.

Many of Finney's listeners also became ardent supporters of various social reforms. Social ills, redefined as sin, stood in the way of the second coming of Christ. Society's problems, in this cosmically optimistic ethos, should, could, and would be solved. The dynamism of American life in the nineteenth century was not just the result of economic and demographic forces. It also had religious roots.

Thus, the impact of the Second Great Awakening was substantial. The new religious style and practices were spread by an innovative religious publishing industry. Religion inculcated a belief in progress, in the abilities of social reforms to perfect society, in a special role for American women as the arbiters of morality, and in the rules of conduct that appealed to the Northern middle class, a class that increasingly set the tone for American life. Without the introduction and spread of what backcountry preachers tried in the 1790s, America would have been a profoundly different place.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.20

Immigration (1790–1860)

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.4, 8.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.4.3 Support; 8.5.1 Support; 8.5.2 Support

Excerpt · 768 words

The revival of immigration to Philadelphia and its surrounding region in the early nineteenth century provided one of the most powerful elements in reshaping the city's society. After a decline in immigration during the wars of the French Revolution and the Napoleonic era, the growing industrialization of the Philadelphia region began to attract streams of newcomers. The main flow of these migrants still came, as in colonial days, from northern Europe, especially Ireland, Germany and Britain. But four decades of relatively low migration during and after the American Revolution led to an ethnic society considerably different from what had existed in colonial days.

The growing number of Catholic immigrants gave rise to conflict between nativists and immigrants, most reflected in riots in 1844. Immigrants became a persistent issue in the politics of the Philadelphia region and of the nation. The newer immigrants began to find their place in the economic and geographical structure of the city and began to develop their own separate cultures. By the time of the Civil War, immigration had transformed the city.

For much of the nineteenth century, access to Philadelphia for immigrants coming directly from overseas was via a quarantine station known as the Lazaretto, located on the Delaware River about eight miles south of the city. The facility was established in 1799 in the wake of the yellow fever epidemic of the previous years, and was maintained by the city's Board of Health. Ships arriving from overseas ports were stopped for health inspection, and immigrants suspected of having communicable diseases were detained in the hospital at the Lazaretto. This remained the principal station for receiving immigrants until 1893.

Migration Patterns Change

The majority of foreign-born newcomers to Philadelphia, however, came by routes other than through the Delaware Bay. Over the years, the Philadelphia port of entry played a dwindling role in the movement of immigrants into the United States generally and to Philadelphia particularly. In colonial times, the Delaware Valley was a convenient entryway for the many German and Scots-Irish migrants who were heading into the hinterland of Pennsylvania and the back country of Maryland, Virginia, and the Carolinas. The patterns of migration changed drastically after the American Revolution in ways that favored New York City as the pre-eminent port of entry for immigrants. After the War of 1812, New York City became the foremost port for transatlantic commerce. Its deep-water harbor was a shorter distance from the ports of northern Europe, from which most immigrants came. Trips to Philadelphia required sailing south, around Cape May, then 87 miles north up the Delaware Bay and River to Philadelphia. New York City became the favored gateway into the interior of the U.S. when the Erie Canal, opened in 1825, allowed easy transportation between the Hudson River and the Great Lakes. Immigrants intent upon staying in Philadelphia often arrived in New York and made the overland trip via railroad or canal to Philadelphia.

Thus immigration through Philadelphia's port declined even as the number of foreign-born in the city increased. During the 1820s, around 12 per cent of the total of new immigrant arrivals nationally entered through the Philadelphia port; by the 1850s, only about 4.5 percent of new immigrants arrived through Philadelphia. By that time New Orleans, with its access to the rapidly expanding Midwest, had become the second largest port of immigration. New York had many ship lines operating frequent service from Liverpool, the point of departure of many transatlantic immigrants. Philadelphia had regular scheduled service from only a few lines. When transatlantic steamship traffic developed by the 1850s, there was little service offered to Philadelphia.

Over the nearly four decades from the beginning of the American Revolution in 1776 until the fall of Napoleon in 1815, the flow of immigrants to the United States fell drastically. The Revolution itself, followed by the European wars that began during the French Revolution, served as discouragement to immigrants traveling from the familiar sources in northern Europe. In the 1790s, the largest source of immigration to the United States was Ireland; an unsuccessful rebellion there in 1798 sent many exiles seeking asylum in America. More notorious perhaps were the smaller number of refugees from France, fleeing the revolution there; they raised suspicion among Federalist Americans because they were thought to be politically dangerous and to support radical Jeffersonian views. In 1798 a Federalist Congress (meeting in Philadelphia, then the nation's capital) passed a Naturalization Act, one of the Alien and Sedition Acts. This law raised the waiting period for acquiring citizenship to fourteen years; it was reduced to five years in 1802, after Jeffersonians gained control of the government.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.21

Nativism

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.5.1 Support; 8.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 879 words

While Philadelphia has not been alone in experiencing sharp undercurrents of nativism, virulent rhetoric and periodic waves of violence aimed at the foreign-born have often wracked the city. Clashes between nativists and immigrants between the 1720s and the 1920s helped to set the boundaries of the city as well as define the limits of American citizenship. A renewal of nativism in the Philadelphia region in the early twenty-first century rested upon a long history of misunderstanding and exclusion.

William Penn (1644-1718) founded Pennsylvania on principles of tolerance, and the earliest settlers of Philadelphia included English, Scots Irish, and German immigrants, among others. By the early eighteenth century, however, the influence of German-speaking peoples, settled primarily in and around Germantown, provoked the antagonism of Philadelphia's English elites. Comprising nearly one-third of the region's population, German voters became a vital political bloc courted by both Quaker and Anglican politicians. Germans allied politically with Quakers, who conducted business with German merchants and shared pacifist views. With their failure to sway German voters, Anglican politicians, led by William Allen (1704-1780), initiated a wave of election-day violence in 1842 to prevent Germans from voting. A large group of Anglican-affiliated sailors verbally and physically assaulted German voters, but the Quakers, with their German allies, won in a landslide.

Leading city figures, including Benjamin Franklin (1706-90), harbored some of the most virulent anti-German sentiments. In his *Observations Concerning the Increase of Mankind*, Franklin argued that Germans were of inferior intellectual and biological stock. He asked, "Why should Pennsylvania, founded by the English, become a Colony of *Aliens*, who will shortly be so numerous as to Germanize us instead of our Anglifying them, and will never adopt our Language or Customs, any more than they can acquire our Complexion?"

After the American Revolution, Thomas Jefferson (1743-1826) suggested that immigrants were unfit for citizenship because many were raised in anti-democratic, monarchical European countries. Fears of immigrants heightened in the 1790s as thousands of men, women, and children fled from the French Revolution. Philadelphia, then serving as the nation's capital, and its surrounding region became home to a robust French community that included radicals exiled from Paris. Ironically, American officials who came to power via revolution became concerned about the revolutionary rhetoric espoused by French emigrants. In response to tensions between the French and American, and during the Quasi-War with France, the United States Congress passed the Naturalization Act of 1798 as part of the Alien and Sedition Acts. The Naturalization Act, enacted in part due to French naval attacks on American shipping lines, extended residency requirements for citizenship from five to fourteen years and barred newly arrived immigrants from voting.

Irish Catholics

During the first half of the nineteenth century, nativism focused especially on Irish Catholics, then immigrating to the Philadelphia region in increasing numbers. In the early 1840s, Bishop Francis P. Kenrick (1797-1863) set in motion a series of events that hardened nativist sentiments in Philadelphia. Kenrick, an Irish immigrant, questioned an 1838 law that mandated the use of the King James (Protestant) Bible in public schools. In a written appeal to the Philadelphia school board, Kenrick sought to allow Catholic students to read from the Douay Bible used by Roman Catholics. While Kenrick retreated from his position after intense resistance, Protestant clergy and politicians capitalized on the Bible issue to win several elected offices, including Morton McMichael's (1807-1879) victory as sheriff of Philadelphia. While the Bible controversy metastasized both nativist and anti-Catholic feelings, organizations such as the American Protestant Association and the American Republican Party targeted a wide range of immigrant groups, including German Americans.

Intra-religious debates between natives and immigrants turned to violence in Philadelphia and other cities. As the Irish potato famine sent an influx of Irish men and women fleeing to the United States, native-born Philadelphians grew fearful of the masses of Catholic immigrants. Goaded by the inflammatory rhetoric of publications that stoked racialized fears, nativists violently clashed with immigrants from May to July 1844. The riots began at the Nanny Goat Market in Kensington and quickly spread across the city. Nativist rioters beat, shot, and stabbed immigrants and burned St. Augustine's, an Irish-Catholic church at Fourth and Vine Streets. Eventually, Sheriff McMichael and Brigadier General George Cadwalader (1806-79) restored order through martial law.

In the aftermath of the riots, nativist candidates swept to significant victories in the election of 1844. Philadelphians elected Lewis C. Levin (1808-60) and John Hull Campbell (1800-68), both members of the nativist American Party, to the United States House of Representatives. Levin, the editor of the *Daily Sun*, became a vigorous proponent of extending the naturalization period for citizenship to twenty-one years as well as banning immigrants from holding elected office. The American Party's success in Philadelphia politics solidified with Levin's reelection in 1846 and 1848 as well as McMichael's reelection as sheriff. With nativist politicians in office across the Northeast, especially in Boston and New York City, the American Party nominated Daniel Webster (1782-1852) as its candidate for president in 1852. When Webster died a few days before the election, nativists threw their support behind a Philadelphian, Jacob Broom (1808-64). Although Broom received less than 1 percent of the popular vote, he recovered to win election to the U.S. House of Representatives in 1854 from Pennsylvania's Fourth Congressional District.

Original Article

https://philadelphiaencyclopedia.org/essays/nativism/

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.22

Philly's Early Convention History: Whigs, Know Nothings and a Young GOP

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PUBLICATION	May 9, 2016
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.5.1 Support; 8.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 868 words (complete article)

Philadelphia has a rich history of hosting colorful political conventions, and in the first of a series of articles, we look at the controversial conventions of the slavery and anti-immigrant era before the Civil War.

This July, Philadelphia will host its 13th major national political convention when the Democrats convene at the Wells Fargo Center in South Philadelphia. Seven of the conventions held in Philadelphia in the past were for the Republicans, while another four were for Democrats, with the Whigs and Progressives also meeting in Philadelphia.

Philadelphia only trails Chicago as the most-popular convention location in American history. The Windy City, with its central location, has hosted 26 conventions. (The last Chicago national convention was in 1996.)

Baltimore also has hosted an estimated 13 major conventions (8 for the Democrats, 3 for the GOP, 2 for the Whigs), but the last time it did host a big convention was in 1912. In the early days of political conventions, starting in 1832, Baltimore hosted 11 conventions in a 28-year-period before the Civil War.

In the critical period before the war, Philadelphia also started hosting conventions, with three very different parties meeting in the city of Brotherly Love.

1848: The Whig's high-water mark

The Whig Party was the main rival to the Democratic Party founded by Andrew Jackson from 1834 to 1856. The Whigs had four U.S. Presidents in that time period, but only two were elected: William Henry Harrison and Zachary Taylor. A third, John Tyler, succeeded Harrison after the President's death in 1841, but Tyler was kicked out of the Whigs while still in the White House. And Millard Fillmore was the last Whig President as the party crumbled under the pressures that led to the Civil War. Fillmore succeeded Taylor, who was the second President to die in office.

In 1848, the Whigs had their national convention at Philadelphia's Chinese Museum, about 10 blocks south of the current convention center. Thousands of Whigs arrived in Philadelphia and about 300 held seats as convention delegates. The 1848 election front runner was an independent, the aforementioned General Zachary Taylor, who was a hero of the Mexican-American War. Taylor decided to run for the White House as a Whig, due partly to his dislike of outgoing President James K. Polk.

Taylor's main rival in Philadelphia was the Whig party leader, Henry Clay, who had lost to Polk in the 1844 presidential election. Daniel Webster and General Winfield Scott were also contenders, but Taylor prevailed on the fourth ballot. The party named Fillmore, a moderate anti-slavery New Yorker, as Taylor's running mate. In the end, former President Martin Van Buren, as a third-party Free Soil Party candidate, helped split the vote in New York in favor of Taylor, and Taylor narrowly defeated Lewis Cass in the general election.

1856: The Know Nothings gather in Philly

In February 1856, one of the most controversial political parties in history met at Philadelphia's National Hall to pick its own candidate for a divided general election. In the four years since Democratic candidate Franklin Pierce took the 1852 election from Winfield Scott, the Whigs fell apart as a national party as its members took sides on the slavery issue. Some former Whigs, like William Seward and Abraham Lincoln, joined the newly formed Republican Party. But another party, the American, or Native-American Party, also attracted former Whig Party members. They become known as the "Know Nothings," since party members wouldn't discuss their beliefs or party membership with outsiders.

The Know Nothings were an anti-immigrant nativist party. The party doctrine stood firmly against Catholics and foreigners, and its members had some regional election success in the 1850s. But the Know Nothings, like the Whigs, had split on the slavery issue. In Philadelphia, former President Fillmore won a first ballot nomination, with President Jackson's nephew, Andrew Donelson, as his running mate. The Know Nothings did poorly in the 1856 election and soon disappeared as a political factor.

1856: The first Republican convention

At this point, the Grand Old Party was the brand new party and it gathered at Philadelphia's Musical Fund Hall on Locust Street in June 1856 to pick its first presidential candidate. The Republicans were formed after disgruntled Whigs, anti-slavery Democrats, former Free Soil members and abolitionists came together. It was viewed as a regional party, with its strength in the northern and western states.

The leading Whigs of the day were future Supreme Court Chief Justice Salmon Chase and, of course, William Seward. Both men dropped from presidential contention before the 1856 Philadelphia meeting. Instead, it was 71-year-old Supreme Court Justice John McLean against a 43-year-old rival, John Fremont, in the nomination fight. The dashing Fremont had gained a great deal of celebrity for his expeditions in the West, and he had briefly served in the Senate.

Fremont easily defeated McLean on the first ballot. Former New Jersey senator William Dayton was the vice presidential nominee, defeating another former Congress member, Abraham Lincoln. In the fall, the Democrats took the White House and the Electoral College when James Buchanan carried Pennsylvania, but Buchanan only took 45 percent of the popular vote. The Republicans and the Know Nothings had 55 percent of the vote combined, and the Republicans were within a two-state margin of taking the 1860 vote in the Electoral College.

Original Article

https://constitutioncenter.org/blog/phillys-early-convention-history-whigs-know-nothings-and-a-young-gop

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 8 · WEB ARTICLE W8.23

Nativist Riots of 1844

Zachary M. Schrag

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 8 | 8.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	8.5.1 Support; 8.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 646 words

In May and July 1844, Philadelphia suffered some of the bloodiest rioting of the antebellum period, as anti-immigrant mobs attacked Irish-American homes and Roman Catholic churches before being suppressed by the militia. The violence was part of a wave of riots that convulsed American cities starting in the 1830s. Yet even amid this tumult, they stand out for their duration, itself a product of nativist determination to use xenophobia for political gain. In the aftermath of the riots, shocked Philadelphians began debating new methods of maintaining order, a discussion that contributed to the consolidation of Philadelphia County in 1854.

Ethnic and religious antagonism had a long history in the city. Since the 1780s, Irish textile workers had come to Philadelphia after losing their jobs to mechanization in the British Isles. As early as 1828, when an off-duty watchman was killed after disparaging "bloody Irish transports," Catholic presence had provoked anxiety among American- and Irish-born Protestants. In 1831, Irish Catholics battled along Fifth Street with Protestants celebrating the anniversary of the Battle of the Boyne.

Anti-Catholic agitation increased in the early 1840s, organized in part around a perceived threat to the Bible in the public schools. Catholic Bishop Francis Patrick Kenrick (1796-1863), an Irish immigrant himself, objected to Protestant teachers' leading students in singing Protestant hymns and requiring them to read from the King James Bible. Nativists used Kenrick's complaints to gain followers. In 1842, dozens of Protestant clergymen formed the American Protestant Association to defend America from Romanism. In early 1843, editor Lewis Levin (1808-60) made the *Daily Sun* an organ for attacks against Catholicism and Catholic immigration, and in December of that year, he helped found a nativist political party called the American Republican Association.

Bible Reading as Flashpoint

In 1844, the Bible controversy intensified in the district of Kensington, a suburb to the northeast of Philadelphia City and home to many Irish immigrants, both Protestant and Catholic. In February, Hugh Clark (1796-1862), a Catholic school director there, suggested suspending Bible reading until the school board could devise a policy acceptable to Catholics and Protestants alike. Nativists saw this as a threat to their liberty and as a chance to mobilize voters, and they rallied by the thousands in Independence Square. On May 3, 1844 they rallied in Kensington itself but were chased away.

The first serious violence broke out three days later. On May 6, the nativists reassembled in Kensington, provoking another fight, during which a young nativist named George Shiffler (1825-44) was fatally shot. By day's end, a second man—apparently a bystander—was dead, and several more nativists were wounded, two mortally. The next day, the First Brigade of the Pennsylvania Militia, commanded by Brigadier General George Cadwalader (1806-79), responded to the sheriff's call for help. The troops faced little direct resistance, but they proved unable to stop people from starting new fires. On May 8, mobs gutted several private dwellings (including Hugh Clark's house), a Catholic seminary, and two Catholic churches: St. Michael's at Second Street and Master and St. Augustine's at Fourth and Vine. Only a flood of new forces—including citizen posses, city police, militia companies arriving from other cities, and U.S. army and navy troops—ended the violence by May 10.

The city remained superficially calm for the next eight weeks, but both nativists and Catholics anticipated further violence. In Southwark—an independent district south of Philadelphia City and a seat of nativist strength—a Catholic priest's brother began stockpiling weapons in the basement of the Church of St. Philip de Neri on Queen Street. On Friday, July 5, a crowd of thousands gathered to demand the weapons. When the crowd reassembled the following day, the sheriff requested militia troops, and Cadwalader led about two hundred into Southwark. Saturday ended without bloodshed, but the situation remained tense, with a small group of militia—some of them Irish Catholics themselves—guarding the church and a group of nativist prisoners inside it.

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Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Schrag, "Nativist Riots of 1844."

CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.1

Beveridge Loved It; Roane Hated It; Few Today Understand McCulloch Properly

Kevin C. Walsh

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.1.1 Support; 9.1.3 Counter-Argument

Excerpt · 1,047 words

Chief Justice John Marshall's opinion for the Court in McCulloch v. Maryland is a classic of American constitutional law. That is why we continue debates about its meaning and significance that have been going on for two centuries now. Such arguments are an important way in which we carry on the traditions of American constitutional law.

Professor Nelson Lund's Liberty Forum essay on this 200th anniversary of McCulloch bears a title that sums up his bottom-line assessment: "The Destructive Legacy of McCulloch v. Maryland." Lund attributes to Marshall's opinion in this case "the effective destruction" of "the principle of limited and enumerated powers."

The problem with this assessment is that Lund relies on an aggressively nationalist interpretation of the opinion. Because of the looseness of Marshall's reasoning connecting the implied power to incorporate a bank to particular enumerated powers, and the opinion's "airy silence" about certain features of the Bank, Lund contends, it has been "easy to treat McCulloch" as a "blatant invitation to congressional overreaching."

Such an interpretation has admittedly been widely accepted for at least the last century. We see it, for example, in the praise Albert Beveridge lavished on McCulloch in the fourth volume of his epic Marshall biography, which was published in 1919. "In effect," said Beveridge,

John Marshall thus rewrote the fundamental law of the Nation; or, perhaps it may be more accurate to say that he made a written instrument a living thing, capable of growth, capable of keeping pace with the advancement of the American people and ministering to their changing necessities. This greatest of Marshall's treatises on government may well be entitled 'Vitality of the Constitution.'

Indeed, the interpretation of McCulloch as an aggressively nationalist opinion goes right back to the very beginning of its reception history. This was the core charge leveled by Spencer Roane, William Brockenborough, and other states' rights theorists in their contemporaneous criticisms.

Love it like Beveridge, or hate it like Roane, McCulloch has appeared to many to have adopted or invited others to adopt a very broad interpretation of national powers. But I believe these appearances are deceiving.

The Arguments Marshall Deliberately Did Not Make

In my estimation—which I will not attempt to justify here but invite others to assess on their own—David S. Schwartz's detailed analysis in his 2015 article "Misreading McCulloch v. Maryland" provides a more persuasive interpretation than Lund does of McCulloch's discussion of the scope of congressional powers. In particular, Schwartz examines not only the arguments that the chief justice accepted, but also those pro-Bank arguments that he could have made but chose not to. According to Schwartz, Marshall "painstakingly avoided giving a broad interpretation to any enumerated power in a systematic effort to steer clear of any controversy over concrete questions of national power."

If Schwartz is right about what Marshall was up to, then the terseness of the latter's treatment of the relationship between the implied power to incorporate a bank and particular enumerated powers like the power to raise revenue or to regulate commerce

among the several states appears in a different light. While Lund credits Marshall with formulating a "carefully calibrated" test for identifying improper exercises of Congress's implied powers, he criticizes Marshall for faltering in its application: "Unfortunately, McCulloch does little more than gesture vaguely at the contribution a bank can make to the exercise of Congress's enumerated powers." Lund contrasts Marshall's purported imprecision with Alexander Hamilton's defense of the First Bank of the United States, in which the Treasury secretary "analyzed in considerable detail the relation between the establishment of a bank and the indisputably legitimate congressional powers over commerce, borrowing, paying the government's debts, and national defense."

Marshall could have explicitly drawn the connections that Lund thinks he ought to have. He was fully conversant with Hamilton's arguments and could have more fully endorsed the constitutional underpinnings of Hamiltonian political economy in ruling on the constitutionality of the Bank. Putting the power of the Court behind Hamilton's more detailed arguments would have been the aggressively nationalist thing to do. But Marshall instead chose to say as little about the enumerated powers as necessary to support the Court's conclusion. According to Schwartz, Marshall's opinion in McCulloch reflects tactical avoidance, not an invitation to overreach. By not saying much about the enumerated powers, the opinion avoided unnecessarily committing the Court to a position on the constitutionality of a uniform national currency, congressional control over the monetary system more generally, or congressional authority to make internal improvements.

To be sure, this perspective on McCulloch's discussion of implied powers does not rescue this part of the opinion from criticism. Studied vagueness in judicial opinions leaves them vulnerable to later exploitation, and later interpreters did exploit McCulloch. But this perspective redirects more of the responsibility toward those later interpreters. By crediting Marshall with having underwritten an approach to congressional power that he seems to have studiously sought to avoid, Lund's critique assigns too much comparative blame to Marshall and not enough to exploitative adopters of portions of his reasoning in McCulloch.

In further defense of Marshall's approach to congressional power in McCulloch, one might also observe that the particular question of federal power to incorporate the Second Bank of the United States was not really that difficult by that point in time. Lund notes some of the evidence for this in his discussion of President Madison's determination that his prior constitutional objections were "precluded . . . by repeated recognitions under varied circumstances of the validity of such an institution in acts of the legislative, executive, and judicial branches of the Government, accompanied by indications in different modes, of a concurrence of a general will of the nation."

Closer to home for the chief justice, it is revealing that while Marshall was selling his Bank stock in order to avoid a conflict of interest in hearing McCulloch, his states' rights nemesis Spencer Roane was helping his son William to buy shares in the Second Bank. Indeed, one such purchase was completed just three days before oral argument in McCulloch began. This was the same Roane whom Marshall battled in pseudonymous newspaper essays after McCulloch was decided. Roane's objections were less to the conclusion that the Second Bank was within Congress's power than to the reasoning in Marshall's opinion that Roane viewed as harming states' rights.

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FULL FOOTNOTE

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Walsh, "Beveridge Loved It."

CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.2

Marshall Takes on the Virginia Anti-Federalists

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.1.1 Support; 9.1.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,042 words

Nelson Lund's encyclopedic interests include such diverse subjects as federalism, the separation of powers, the Second Amendment, the presidency, election law, judicial power, originalism, assisted suicide, due process, equal protection, and Jean-Jacques Rousseau's political philosophy. On all of these, and more, he has shone great light and made us his intellectual debtors. When it comes to his Liberty Forum essay on Chief Justice Marshall's opinion in McCulloch v. Maryland, I'm afraid, not so much.

If I read him right, the threefold thrust of Professor Lund's argument comes to this:

1) That Marshall took unjustified liberties in his reading of the Necessary and Proper Clause; 2) that, even assuming Marshall's latitudinarian reading of Article I, Section 8 were defensible, the Court ought to have imposed something like strict scrutiny when assessing congressional judgments about what was truly necessary and proper; and 3) that, in any event, McCulloch unfortunately gave Congress carte blanche to determine the reach of Article I's grant of legislative power.

The Situation in 1819

In many respects, Professor Lund's criticism merely reiterates a canard that was levelled against Marshall in his own day and has warmed the arguments of many critics of big government ever since. The chief justice's opinion, to be sure, was certainly capacious in its understanding of national power as a matter of originalist construction, but his support for nationalism was mostly deployed to counter assertions of state sovereignty contrary to the principles of the ratified Constitution.

In light of unforeseeable subsequent developments since Marshall's time, the Great Man might be inclined to trim some of the soaring nationalist rhetoric found in McCulloch (2019) and Gibbons v. Ogden (1824). But one would be hard pressed to find a Marshall opinion even winking at the routine sorts of congressional power we're accustomed to today.

Although numerous Progressives have worked overtime to harness Marshall's rhetoric to their purposes, one cannot fairly draw even a jagged a line that runs from Marshall to the New Deal. Marshall's devotion to limited government (in contradistinction to energetic government) is hardly questionable, and despite brickbats hurled at him by disgruntled critics of Anti-federalist disposition, his nationalism was not consolidationalist. He would be appalled by modern constitutional jurisprudence in all of its pomp and works, on everything from federalism, to the role of courts, to the invention of rights and the instantiation of the administrative state. To imply that today's national government hegemony finds its roots in McCulloch's rhetoric is, to say no more, both ahistorical and unjust.

We need to remind ourselves that the constitutional problems facing the Marshall Court were fundamentally different from what we face today. The federal judiciary then was still in its infancy, its power widely questioned, its decrees not infrequently ignored; Congress was hardly the Pelosian Moloch we're familiar with today; and the states were infinitely more powerful than they are now. For most of his tenure on the Court, Marshall struggled to explain and justify the Framers' vision of the federal union—at least the Framers of 1787 through 1789 whose views were more or less comprehensively articulated in The Federalist. Not everyone shared that vision, and ere long, as we know, some of the more prominent Framers fell out among themselves. In truth, the Constitution in critically important places either remained silent (implied powers generally, the removal power) or invited reasonable differences of opinion (the Commerce Clause, the Necessary and Proper Clause, the precise metes and bounds of federalism).

On some of these issues, differences of opinion began to harden into partisanship before the Constitution's ink had dried. None of these differences proved more nettlesome than those connected with the question of national versus state power. It was here that Marshall met his most formidable opposition, and it was here that he mounted his most eloquent defenses of what he believed the Constitution meant to do.

Publius Redivivus

The story is too long and complicated to be recounted here, but Marshall's intention in McCulloch cannot be understood apart from this context. Without putting too fine a point on it, what Marshall faced was a more or less wholesale rejection of the premises (at least as Marshall, relying on Publius, had understood them) on which the new Constitution had been erected. The principal source of opposition here came from Virginia, where those associated with the so-called "Richmond Junto" and John Taylor of Caroline worked mightily to interpose state power against federal encroachment and consolidation.

It will be recalled that in the debate on adopting the Bill of Rights in the First Congress, Representative James Madison beat back Anti-federalist efforts to add the word "expressly" to the wording of the Tenth Amendment. Had these efforts succeeded, the text would have read thusly: "The powers not expressly delegated to the United States, not prohibited by it to the States, are reserved to the States respectively, or to the people." Adoption of the adverb would have radically altered the entire tenor of the Constitution, which is precisely what the Anti-federalists wished to do. Its addition would have all but extinguished the idea of implied powers, which was the intent of Marshall's Virginia critics.

Their default position on the nature of the Union was that it was but a compact among the states, a somewhat improved model of the Articles of Confederation, but a confederation nevertheless, in contrast to the compound republic envisioned by The Federalist. The state-compact theory animated the Richmond Junto crowd, who enjoyed the tacit, and likely more than tacit, support of Thomas Jefferson (the "great Lama of the Mountain" as Marshall mocked him). Similar sentiments were echoed in other states, especially in the South, and by 1832 would furnish the intellectual foundations of the Nullification Crisis.

In the Bank Case, in short, John Marshall was hardly conjuring enemies out of the air. Indeed, counsel for Maryland in McCulloch argued explicitly in favor of the state-compact theory as a justification for the state's taxation of the Bank of the United States. Marshall knew where that logic led. Anticipating the assault against his opinion in McCulloch, he wrote to Justice Story that while his opponents couched their arguments as criticisms of federal judicial power, their strategic salient was to undermine the Union and to establish a regime closer to the letter and spirit of the Articles.

Original Article

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FULL FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.3

The Marshall Court, 1801–1835

Supreme Court Historical Society

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Excerpt · 1,024 words

Marshall skillfully asserted the Court's mightiest power and dignity in its first great crisis. In Congress, the lame-duck Federalists had passed a law to reduce the Court's membership to five (one less Justice for a Republican President to name). Abolishing circuit duties for the Justices and providing other reforms, this law set up new circuit courts with 16 judges. Before leaving office, Adams had quickly named his judicial appointees — the famous "midnight judges." Enraged, one Republican from Kentucky called Adams's tactics "the last effort of the most wicked, insidious and turbulent faction that ever disgraced our political annals."

Jefferson took the oath of office on March 4, 1801. Without precedents and with passions running high, the Presidency and the Congress passed for the first time from one party to another. And some citizens were afraid that the judiciary was in mortal danger.

Soon after his Inauguration, Jefferson wrote that the Federalists had "retreated into the judiciary as a stronghold, the tenure of which renders it difficult to dislodge them."

But the Republicans repealed the lame-duck Judiciary Act, while horrified Federalists lamented, "the Constitution has received a wound it cannot long survive," and "the angels of destruction are making haste."

Meanwhile William Marbury of Washington went straight to the Supreme Court, looking for a commission as justice of the peace for the District of Columbia. Adams had appointed 42 such officials, the Senate frantically confirmed them, and Adams sat at his desk until late on his last night in office to sign their commissions. Then a messenger rushed the papers to the State Department for Marshall, still acting as Secretary, to affix the great seal of the United States. In the confusion some of the commissions went undelivered, Marbury's among them.

In December 1801, Marbury applied to the Court for a writ of mandamus ordering James Madison, the new Secretary of State, to give him his commission. The Court agreed to hear the case — a bold action, for rumor was saying the Justices "must fall" by impeachment. Then the Republican Congress repealed the Judiciary Act of 1801, which mandated sessions in December and June, and eliminated the August Term of the Court. As a result, the Justices did not sit from April 1802 to February 1803, when they heard argument in Marbury's case.

If the Court ordered Madison to produce that commission, he could simply ignore the order; President Jefferson would defend him. If the Court denied Marbury's right to his commission, Jefferson could claim a party victory. Either way the Court's prestige — and perhaps its members — must fall.

Marshall found an escape from his dilemma. He announced the decision on February 24, and proclaimed the most distinctive power of the Supreme Court, the power to declare an Act of Congress unconstitutional. Point by point he analyzed the case. Did Marbury have a legal right to his commission? Yes. Would a writ of mandamus enforce his right? Yes. Could the Court issue the writ? No.

Congress had said it could, in the Judiciary Act of 1789. It had given the Court an original jurisdiction in such cases — power to try them for the first time. But, said Marshall triumphantly, the Constitution defined the Court's original jurisdiction and Congress could not change it by law. Therefore that section of the law was void. Marshall declared for all time the supremacy of the Constitution over any conflicting law. Other judges had said as much, but Marshall added: "It is, emphatically, the province

and duty of the judicial department, to say what the law is."

In renouncing a minor jurisdiction he asserted a great one, perhaps the greatest in the long annals of the law. The Supreme Court's power as interpreter of the Constitution rests on this precedent to this day.

A few days after the decision in Marbury v. Madison, the Court again amazed the Jeffersonians. They had passed a Judiciary Act in Congress, restoring the Court's old membership and circuit duties. The Justices ruled that it was constitutional and for a while talk of impeachment died down.

The Justices are seated on the dais on the far side of the chamber in this evening session of the House of Representatives, c. 1822. The Corcoran Gallery of Art.

"Oyez! Oyez! Oyez! . . . the grand inquest of the nation is exhibiting to the Senate . . . articles of impeachment against Samuel Chase, Associate Justice. . . ." The Supreme Court was on trial; if Chase fell, Marshall might be next.

Feared as a "ringleader of mobs, a foul mouthed and inflaming son of discord" when he led the Sons of Liberty in 1765, Chase was "forever getting into some . . . unnecessary squabble" as a Judge 40 years later. He campaigned openly for Adams. On circuit he tried Republicans without mercy. In 1803 he told a Baltimore grand jury that "modern doctrines" of "equal liberty and equal rights" were sinking the Constitution "into a mobocracy, the worst of all popular governments."

His enemies saw their chance. The House of Representatives voted to bring him before the Senate for trial, charging that his partisan behavior–in and out of court–amounted to "High Crimes and Misdemeanors" under the Constitution.

Vice President Aaron Burr had arranged a special gallery for ladies when the "grand inquest" opened on February 4, 1805. Burr had killed Alexander Hamilton in a duel and New Jersey wanted him for murder, but he presided sternly, rebuking Senators who were eating cake and apples. "We are indeed fallen on evil times," said one. "The high office of President is filled by an infidel; that of Vice-President by a murderer."

Representative John Randolph of Roanoke, the brilliant, erratic Virginian, fought to prove Chase unfit for the Court. Luther Martin of Maryland, who could hold more law and more brandy than any other attorney of his time, led Chase's defense. Marshall and 51 other witnesses testified.

Amid "a vast concourse of people . . . and great solemnity," the Senators acquitted Chase on March 1. Jefferson called impeachment of Justices "a farce which will not be tried again," and he was right.

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https://supremecourthistory.org/history-of-the-courts/the-marshall-court-1801-1835/

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FULL FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.4

Affirming Judicial Independence

Supreme Court Historical Society

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Excerpt · 1,111 words

In the early years of the United States, the country wrestled with the scope and powers of each of the three branches of government established under the Constitution–Legislative, Executive, and Judicial–as well as the relationship between the national, or federal, government and the state governments. At the center of these struggles for the Judicial Branch and the Supreme Court of the United States was its Chief Justice, John Marshall. President John Adams appointed Marshall to serve as Chief Justice in 1801 to succeed Chief Justice Oliver Ellsworth (who had been given a new appointment as Minister to France). Marshall and the Court faced many formative issues, both immediately and over the 34 years he served as Chief Justice. Those issues ranged from the practical, including where the Court would meet and hear cases, to the profound, including the Court's authority to review whether laws passed by Congress were Constitutional and whether it could review decisions from state courts that posed Constitutional issues. For much of his tenure, Chief Justice Marshall was able to unify the Justices and issue unanimous decisions, thereby increasing the Court's power and visibility.

Almost immediately upon his appointment, Marshall faced a defining moment for the country's form of government and the Supreme Court's role in it. When President Adams lost his re-election bid to Thomas Jefferson in 1800, the country experienced its first transfer of power from one political party to another. As Adams, a Federalist, left office he and Congress attempted to secure their federalist legacy by passing the Judiciary Act of 1801 which enabled him to appoint numerous life-tenured judges and magistrates to the Judiciary. Some of the "last-minute" appointments by Adams were not delivered before President Jefferson took office and he did not honor those appointments. One appointment was for William Marbury who then sought to enforce his appointment by bringing an enforcement action to the Supreme Court. The case, *Marbury v. Madison*, has become one of the most well-known and influential decisions issued by the Court. Chief Justice Marshall wrote for the Court that although Marbury was entitled to his appointment, the provision of law in the Judiciary Act of 1801 on which Marbury relied to enforce his commission was unconstitutional. In short, the Court demonstrated that it had the authority to review Acts of Congress for their constitutionality. This is still an enormous power vested in the Judicial Branch that gives it equal status with the Legislative (Congress) and Executive (President) Branches.

One of the practical issues facing Marshall and the Supreme Court early in Marshall's tenure was where the Court would sit. For a time, the Supreme Court was in New York, then moved to Philadelphia, before finally settling in the basement of the new Capitol Building in 1810 in the District of Columbia. The Supreme Court was forced to relocate temporarily after the United States' entrance into the War of 1812, when the British set fire to the Capitol in 1814.

Other practical challenges in the early years of the country and Court's history were created by both the modest judicial salaries and circuit duties of the Justices. The first Judiciary Act of 1789 required the Supreme Court Justices to preside over circuit courts scattered throughout the country, which often meant months of ragged travel. After jolting in stagecoaches over unpaved, bumpy roads or helping to lift their stagecoach from swampy mud, the Justices struggled to find rest, often in over-crowded inns. Exhausted by the hardships of travel, Justices often arrived at the circuit courts too late or too sick to hear all the cases waiting for them. Still, their visits showed local people the authority and role of the new federal judiciary. The difficult and unrewarding nature of being a Justice in the early years of the Court created a lot of turnover. In the first eleven years of the Supreme Court's existence twelve different Justices served on the six-member Court.

These hardships endured by the Justices also created inconsistency in the Terms of the Court's sessions. Some of its Terms ended early, some were canceled due to disease outbreaks, and few notable decisions were made. Notwithstanding these challenges, under John Marshall's leadership over a period of 34 years on the Court, the Supreme Court grew in stature and became more unified, issuing 1,042 unanimous decisions that established the precedents that built the foundation of the federal judiciary. Among his efforts to unify the Court, Chief Justice Marshall insisted the Justices live together in a boarding house, which helped build their relationships.

Many of the more profound issues the Court was called upon to resolve during the first half of the 19th century were generated by the country's expansion, both economically and territorially. Congress also expanded the Court's domain in 1807 by adding a new seat to preside over a new Western circuit composed of Kentucky, Tennessee, and Ohio, bringing the number of justices to seven. The Supreme Court navigated some concerns of its own during this period too, including the first and only impeachment trial of a Justice when Justice Samuel Chase was accused of partisan behavior on the bench. Justice Chase was not convicted.

After the War of 1812, the U.S. struggled financially, prompting Congress to charter the Second Bank of the United States. This led to conflict between federal and state governments. When Congress' authority to create the Bank was challenged, the Marshall Court held in *McCulloch v. Maryland* (1819) that Congress had the power to create the Second Bank under the Constitution and that states could not tax it or otherwise make its operation difficult. That same year, the Court also affirmed that the Contracts Clause in the Constitution protects private contracts and that states could not encroach on property rights for private colleges and corporations in its *Dartmouth College v. Woodward* (1819) decision.

Sectional strife plagued the young republic and territorial expansion threatened to tear the barely united nation apart. The southern slave-states saw the Supreme Court's decisions in such cases as McCulloch and Dartmouth College, in which federal authority was upheld, as a potential challenge to their way of life. They saw the Court's recognition of these Congressional powers as an indication that Congress might also pass measures to limit or possibly eliminate slavery. Additionally, the population was increasing rapidly, and western expansion was leading to the creation and admission of new states causing additional political conflict. The Missouri Compromise was passed in 1820 as a solution and provided that for every free state that joined the Union a slave state would also be admitted. Under this compromise, Missouri was admitted as a slave state and Maine was admitted as a free state.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.5

Daniel Webster

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.1.1 Support; 9.1.2 Support

Excerpt · 840 words

Daniel Webster was born on January 18, 1782, in Salisbury, New Hampshire. His father, Ebenezer Webster, was a farmer who served as a soldier in the French and Indian War and the American Revolution and later became a respected Justice of the Peace. His mother, Abigail "Nabby" Eastman Webster, was known for her intelligence and was a tailoress before she became Mr. Webster's second wife. Daniel was the second son of their 6 children and the youngest of 10 children overall.

As a child, Daniel often suffered from poor health and was encouraged to focus on academics rather than farming. Believing in his education, Daniel's father enrolled him in Phillips Exeter Academy when Daniel was 14. At the time, part of the school curriculum was memorizing and reciting speeches in front of teachers and classmates. Daniel withdrew after seven months due to his deep fear of public speaking. Upset at his failure, especially after his father's support, Daniel was determined to overcome his fear. A year later, after some private tutoring, he was admitted to Dartmouth College where he excelled at oratory. He was involved in numerous student activities including the school newspaper and became a sought-after orator by the age of 18. He graduated from Dartmouth in 1801 near the top of his class and was elected to the Phi Beta Kappa honor society.

Like other lawyers at the time, Daniel gained his legal education through an apprenticeship with a local lawyer, Thomas W. Thompson. He chose the law because he believed he could make enough money to have a comfortable life without the periods of poverty he and his family had faced during his childhood. He struggled, however, with living beyond his income his entire life. In 1804, he moved to Boston and clerked for Christopher Gore, a wealthy Federalist lawyer who served in the United States Senate. He passed the Massachusetts bar in 1805. By 1807, Daniel established his own practice in Portsmouth, New Hampshire. The next year he fell in love with and married Grace Fletcher, a schoolteacher who was devoutly religious. Daniel and Grace had 5 children together.

Daniel's rise to political prominence began with his skill for oration which captivated large audiences. He delivered a rousing speech on July 4,1812. A unionist to his core, he condemned the War of 1812 warning that its negative impact on trade could result in New England leaving the still fragile union of the United States. His anti-war speech secured him the Federalist nomination to the U.S. House of Representatives. He was elected and served for New Hampshire from 1813-1817. After the war, and the collapse of the Federalist party, Daniel moved his family to Massachusetts and joined the Whig party which opposed Andrew Jackson's Democrats. On the bicentennial commemorating the Pilgrims landing in Plymouth in 1820, Daniel gave one of his longest, and most emphatic, addresses. During his speech, he condemned the practice of enslavement and anyone who did business that supported the slave trade, including his fellow New England residents. Daniel was once again elected to Congress, this time for Massachusetts. He served in the House from 1823-1827 and in the Senate from 1827-1841. While in Congress, Daniel chaired the House Judiciary Committee and the Senate Finance Committee.

Supreme Court Advocacy

While serving in Congress, Daniel continued to use his brilliant legal skills to advocate before the Supreme Court, arguing his first case before the Court in 1814. The Court was lodged in the basement of the Capitol building from 1810-1860 and many cases were argued by members of Congress or Attorneys General for nearby states who, like Daniel, were talented attorneys. Their proximity to the Court was helpful as oral argument had no time limit and attorneys argued for long stretches. A single case could last for days. Daniel had a close relationship with Chief Justice John Marshall and Associate Justice Joseph Story. They drew on his fine mind to help them navigate through Constitutional questions which established precedents that formed the foundation of American constitutional interpretation. Daniel's opinions during his arguments in the Courtroom had a great influence on shaping the Marshall Court and many of Marshall's opinions borrowed from the briefs Daniel submitted to the Court.

Among the briefs in cases that helped Chief Justice Marshall author a series of landmark opinions for the Court were Dartmouth College v. Woodward (1819), McCulloch v. Maryland (1819), and Gibbons v. Ogden (1824). In Dartmouth College, Daniel argued for the supremacy of the Constitution's Contract Clause over state legislation and helped to establish the property rights of private colleges and corporations. Daniel's arguments in McCulloch helped to persuade the Justices that Congress could indeed establish a national bank, under the Necessary and Proper Clause, which could not be taxed by a state government. In Gibbons, Daniel's argument resulted in an opinion which expanded the power of the federal government to regulate navigation under the Constitution's Commerce Clause and, thereby, the federal economy. In all, Daniel impressively argued over 150 cases before the Court and won approximately half of them.

Original Article

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"Daniel Webster."

CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.6

The Second Bank of the United States

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.2.1 Support; 9.2.2 Support; 10.4.2 Support

Excerpt · 883 words

[Excerpt begins at the section "Bank Leadership."]

Bank Leadership

The first president of the Bank was William Jones, a political appointee and a former secretary of the Navy who had gone bankrupt. Under Jones's leadership, the Bank first extended too much credit and then reversed that trend too quickly. The result was a financial panic that drove the economy into a steep recession.

When Jones resigned in 1819, shareholders elected Langdon Cheves, an attorney from South Carolina who had served as speaker of the House of Representatives, as president of the Bank. Cheves cut in half the number of second Bank banknotes in circulation, made fewer loans, foreclosed on mortgages, and exerted more control over the Bank's branches. He presented state banknotes for specie, a request that sent many state-chartered financial institutions into bankruptcy because they did not have enough gold and silver on hand to cover the redemptions. Another depression, characterized by deflation and high unemployment, ensued. Although the economic slump was part of a worldwide downturn, the Bank's policies magnified the contraction in the United States. Public opinion started turning against the Bank as many believed it contributed to the recession.

In 1823, Cheves withdrew his name from consideration for reelection to the top Bank post, and Nicholas Biddle, a member of a wealthy and prominent Philadelphia family, became head of the Bank. Biddle had previously served on the Bank's board of directors and in the Pennsylvania legislature. With Biddle's guidance, animosity toward the Bank diminished. The Bank contributed significantly to economic stability and growth. Biddle increased the number of notes issued by the Bank and restrained the expansion of the quantity of state banks' notes by pressing them to redeem their own notes in specie.

The Battle Over the Second Bank

In 1828, Andrew Jackson, hero of the Battle of New Orleans and a determined foe of banks in general and the second Bank of the United States in particular, was elected president of the United States. Jackson's dislike of the Bank may have been fueled by rumors that Henry Clay, a congressman from Kentucky, was manipulating the Bank to help Jackson's opponent, John Quincy Adams, but it did not rise to a major campaign issue.

In contrast, the election of 1832, which sent Jackson back to the White House, put the Bank in the spotlight. A request to renew the Bank's charter was sent to Congress in January 1832, four years before the charter was set to expire. The legislation passed both the House and Senate, but it failed to garner enough votes to overcome Jackson's veto.

Why was Jackson so opposed to the Bank? On a personal level, Jackson brought with him to Washington a strong distrust of banks in general, stemming, at least in part, from a land deal that had gone sour more than two decades before. In that deal, Jackson had accepted paper notes—essentially paper money—as payment for some land he had sold. When the buyers who had issued the notes went bankrupt, the paper he held became worthless. Although Jackson managed to save himself from financial ruin, he never trusted paper notes again. In Jackson's opinion, only specie—silver or gold coins—qualified as an acceptable medium for transactions. Since banks issued paper notes, Jackson found banking practices suspicious. Jackson also distrusted credit—another function of banks—believing people should not borrow money to pay for what they wanted.

Jackson's distrust of the Bank was also political, based on a belief that a federal institution such as the Bank trampled on states' rights. In addition, he felt that the Bank put too much power in the hands of too few private citizens -- power that could be used to the detriment of the government. The Bank also lacked an effective system of regulation. In other words, it was too far outside the jurisdiction of Congress, the president, and voters.

Biddle, who served as president from 1823 until the Bank's demise in 1836, refused to accept any criticism of the Bank's operations, especially claims about the mismanagement of some of the Bank's branches. He also was not above allowing the Bank to make loans to his friends while denying loans to those less friendly. These actions subjected the Bank to public criticism. Despite all this, Biddle was an excellent administrator who understood banking.

Jackson saw his 1832 win as validation of antibank sentiment. Shortly after the election, Jackson ordered that federal deposits be removed from the second National Bank and put into state banks. Although Jackson's order met with heavy criticism from members of his administration, most of the government's money had been moved out of the Bank by late 1833. The loss of the federal government's deposits caused the Bank to shrink in both size and influence.

Meanwhile, in Philadelphia, Biddle responded to Jackson's action by announcing that the Bank would (or could) not respond to the loss of government deposits by attracting new private deposits or raising new capital. Instead, the Bank would limit credit and call in loans. This contraction of credit, he believed, might create a backlash against Jackson and force the president to relent and redeposit government funds in the Bank, perhaps even renewing the charter. But Biddle's move backfired: in the end, it helped to support Jackson's claim that the Bank had been created to serve the interests of the wealthy, not to meet the nation's financial needs.

Original Article

https://www.federalreservehistory.org/essays/second-bank-of-the-us

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.7

James Monroe: Domestic Affairs

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.2.1 Support; 9.2.2 Support; 9.2.3 Support; 9.3.2 Support; 9.3.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,043 words

At the beginning of Monroe's presidency, Americans were feeling generally optimistic. The nation had declared victory in the War of 1812 and the economy was booming, allowing Monroe to turn his attention toward domestic issues. The new President, moreover, was personable, extremely popular, and interested in reaching out to all the regions of the country.

National Tours

Prior to moving into the still damaged Executive Mansion, which was burned by the British during the War of 1812, President James Monroe revived the presidential tour of the country, which was first undertaken by George Washington. The stated reason for the tour was to inspect defense fortifications, but it also allowed Monroe to reach out to Americans throughout the nation and exhibit his relaxed and affable personality. In June 1817, Monroe began his first tour of the North, traveling up the coast to Portland, Maine. From there, he turned west to Detroit and then southeast back to Washington, D.C. The trip took fifteen weeks and allowed Monroe to come in contact with more people than any previous sitting President. Everywhere he went, he was praised and applauded. The Boston Columbian Centinel described his reception in Massachusetts as the beginning of an "Era of Good Feelings" for the nation—a phrase that is now often used to describe Monroe's presidency.

The first tour was such a success that Monroe embarked on two others—one of the Chesapeake Bay area in 1818 and one of the South and West in 1819. Although those trips did not match the enthusiasm of the first, they gave Monroe an opportunity to reach out to different regions of the country. All three tours helped familiarize the people with their President, and Monroe's endearing personality won many converts.

Monroe's Cabinet

One of Monroe's first acts as President was to put together his cabinet. Wanting to assemble a group of advisers from different regions of the country, he turned to New England native John Quincy Adams as his secretary of state. Adams had a long diplomatic career, and with their similar backgrounds in foreign affairs the two men established a good working relationship. Monroe then chose William H. Crawford from Georgia as secretary of treasury and sought out a westerner to serve as secretary of war. Unable to persuade his first choices, he picked to John C. Calhoun from South Carolina. Monroe turned to an old friend, William Wirt, to be his attorney general and decided to keep Benjamin Crowninshield as secretary of the navy. Monroe's cabinet has often been noted as an exceptionally strong one. The President assembled a group of intelligent and talented men who were very good administrators. He then gave them a lot of freedom to do their jobs. Although he encouraged debate and solicited advice from his cabinet, there was never any doubt that he was firmly in charge. He made the final decisions and expected his cabinet to support and implement them.

The Panic of 1819

Two years into his presidency, Monroe faced an economic crisis known as the Panic of 1819. It was the first major depression to hit the country since the 1780s. The panic stemmed from declining imports and exports, and sagging agricultural prices. A number of state banks suspended payment on their notes and declared bankruptcy, with the Second Bank of the United States shifting to more conservative policies. The result was high unemployment and an increase in bankruptcies and foreclosures.

Although some critics derided Monroe for not responding more forcefully to the economic downturn, he could do little to alleviate its short-term effects. The power to change economic policies rested with the states and the Bank of the United States.

In addition, Monroe believed that depressions were natural features of a maturing economy and that the U.S. economy would soon rebound from the panic (and indeed it did—the depression ended by 1823). Monroe did support the policy proposed by Secretary of Treasury William Crawford to relax payment terms on mortgages for lands purchased from the federal government.

The Missouri Compromise

Early in 1819, settlers in the Missouri Territory applied for admission to the Union. Approximately 16 percent of the Missouri settlers were enslaved blacks, and most of the white settlers either owned slaves or hoped to become slave owners in the future. Congressional debate on Missouri exploded when Congressman James Tallmadge, Jr. of New York attached two amendments to the statehood bill. The first barred new slaves from entering the state; the second emancipated all Missouri slaves born after admission upon their 25th birthday. In other words, the Tallmadge amendments would admit Missouri only as a free state.

The North held a small majority in the House of Representatives in 1819, and the South controlled a bare majority in the Senate. Voting on the Tallmadge amendments was strictly sectional: the amendments passed in the House but lost in the Senate. The House refused to admit Missouri as a slave state and the Senate insisted upon it. Monroe, along with many congressional leaders, understood the volatile nature of the debate and the strong regional divide over slavery.

However, he thought it was unconstitutional to place special restrictions on the admission of one state, as the Tallmadge amendments did, and threatened to veto any bill including such restrictions. Monroe feared that the dispute would divide the Union and worked in support of a compromise package in Congress. However, he did not forcefully inject himself into the process because he did not want to be accused of meddling in congressional affairs. A new Congress convened in the winter of 1819, allowing legislators to reach an accord that settled the dispute. Massachusetts allowed its far northern counties to apply for admission to the Union as the free, or non-slave, state of Maine, thus offsetting fears that the South would gain votes in the Senate with the admission of Missouri. Additionally, it was agreed—after much behind-the-scenes deal-making—that Missouri would be admitted as a slave state in return for the South's willingness to outlaw slavery in western territories above the 36/30' north latitude line. That line would open present-day Arkansas and Oklahoma to slavery but would forbid it throughout the rest of the Louisiana Territory—land that would eventually be organized into nine states. Monroe signed the bill on March 6, 1820, after he was satisfied that the provisions were, indeed, constitutional.

Original Article

https://millercenter.org/president/monroe/domestic-affairs

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.8

James Monroe: Life in Brief

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.2.1 Support; 9.2.2 Support

Excerpt · 621 words

James Monroe was the last American President of the “Virginia Dynasty”—of the first five men who held that position, four hailed from Virginia. Monroe also had a long and distinguished public career as a soldier, diplomat, governor, senator, and cabinet official. His presidency, which began in 1817 and lasted until 1825, encompassed what came to be called the "Era of Good Feelings." One of his lasting achievements was the Monroe Doctrine, which became a major tenet of U.S. foreign policy in the Western Hemisphere.

Early Revolutionary

James Monroe was born in 1758 to prosperous Virginia planters. His parents died when he was a teenager, leaving him part of the family farm. He enrolled at the College of William and Mary in Williamsburg in 1774, and almost immediately began participating in revolutionary activities. With a group of classmates, he raided the arsenal at the British Governor's Palace, escaping with 200 muskets and 300 swords, which the students presented to the Virginia militia. He became an officer in the Continental Army in early 1776 and, shortly thereafter, joined General George Washington's army at New York. He was severely wounded at the Battle of Trenton.

Monroe was promoted to captain and then major, and was assigned to the staff of General William Alexander, where he served for more than a year. After resigning his commission in the Continental Army in 1779, he was appointed colonel in the Virginia service. In 1780, Governor Thomas Jefferson sent Monroe to North Carolina to report on the advance of the British.

After the war, Monroe studied law with Jefferson and was elected to the Continental Congress in 1783. While a delegate to the Congress, then meeting in New York, he met Elizabeth Kortright, the daughter of a New York City merchant. A year later they were married; he was twenty-seven and she was seventeen. The newlyweds moved to Fredericksburg, Virginia, where Monroe practiced law.

High Political Office

In 1787, Monroe began serving in the Virginia assembly and was chosen the following year as a delegate to the Virginia convention considering ratification of the new U.S. Constitution. He voted against ratification, holding out for the direct election of presidents and senators, and for the inclusion of a bill of rights. Partly due to politicians, such as Monroe, who brought attention to the omission of such constitutional guarantees, the Bill of Rights became the first ten amendments of the Constitution upon ratification in 1791. Although Monroe narrowly lost a congressional election to James Madison in 1790, the Virginia state legislature appointed him to the U.S. Senate. As a member of that body, he allied himself with Madison and Thomas Jefferson, his close personal friends, against the Federalist faction led by Vice President John Adams and Secretary of the Treasury Alexander Hamilton. In 1794, President Washington sent Monroe to Paris as U.S. minister to France. Monroe's actions as minister angered the Federalists, however, and Washington recalled him in 1797. In 1799, he was elected governor of Virginia, where he served three one-year terms. In 1803, President Thomas Jefferson sent him back to France to help negotiate the Louisiana Purchase. Monroe continued to serve his government in Europe, representing the United States as U.S. minister to Britain from 1803 to 1807, with a brief stint as special envoy to Spain in 1805. After he returned home, dissident Republicans nominated him to oppose James Madison for the Democratic-Republican presidential nomination in 1808. Monroe, however, never considered the challenge serious, and Madison won the election easily. Monroe was once again elected governor of Virginia in January 1811, but headed back to Washington, D.C., that April, when President Madison named him secretary of state. Monroe served in that capacity, and also for a time as secretary of war, until 1817.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.9

Martin Van Buren: Life Before the Presidency

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.2.3 Support; 9.5.2 Support; 9.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 886 words

[Excerpt begins at the section "Entry into State Politics."]

Entry into State Politics

Van Buren won election to the New York state senate in 1812, and his star continued to rise during the war with Great Britain that began that year. President James Madison's administration appointed him a special judge advocate in the court-martial trial of General William Hull, who capitulated to the British in 1812 by giving up Detroit without a fight despite having superior forces. Van Buren's forceful support of the war effort and his call for New York's recognition as an integral part of the United States' success endeared him to many New York Republicans. He was appointed the state's attorney general in 1815, and he continued to hold a seat in the state senate.

The War of 1812 not only elevated Van Buren's political profile, but it also marked the start of his break with DeWitt Clinton. Clinton unsuccessfully challenged Madison's presidential reelection bid in 1812, despite Van Buren's hard work to bring New York into Clinton's column. Van Buren believed that Clinton had betrayed him, however, by not showing the same enthusiastic support in his own campaign to become New York attorney general. The split between the two men grew over the ensuing years.

Van Buren helped establish and lead the Bucktails, an anti-Clinton faction of Republicans that grew out of the Tammany Society and adopted one of its insignias, a deer tail, as its own. The Bucktails provided a model for the Albany Regency, which Van Buren formed in the 1820s. Both groups challenged the Clinton faction of New York Republicans and furthered the political ambitions of Van Buren and his allies—men such as Benjamin F. Butler, William L. Marcy, and Silas Wright Jr.—both statewide and nationally. Later political machines and political parties drew on the organizational and electioneering techniques used by the Bucktails and Albany Regency to find success.

In 1821, Van Buren's Bucktail faction led the charge to revise New York's constitution. Van Buren served as one of the delegates at the state's constitutional convention. He opposed universal male suffrage, advocating for voting rights for those men who demonstrated personal investment in their community. Van Buren eventually supported the lifting of property-owning requirements for white men to vote, but he opposed the same voting rights for African American men unless they owned, and paid taxes on, property with a minimum value of $250.

Gaining National Experience

Van Buren won election to the U.S. Senate in 1821 and made his way to Washington, D.C., shortly after the close of the New York state constitutional convention. He served on the Senate's finance committee and chaired its judiciary committee. His work drew the attention of President James Monroe, who considered him for appointment to the U.S. Supreme Court. Van Buren's speeches displayed his lifelong propensity for in-depth background research on which he based long, complex explanations of his positions. In other words, he was usually not concise. Van Buren continued to hold to Jeffersonian principles, although he found that a national perspective sometimes required more nuanced positions.

By the time Van Buren arrived in the nation's capital in December 1821, the political makeup of the United States mirrored what had happened in New York. No longer facing a formidable threat to their power from the Federalists, Republicans were splitting into rival factions. Van Buren brought the lessons that he learned about personality-based politics in New York with him to Washington and used his experience to begin building a network that would help unify Republicans. Colleagues especially noted

his outreach to southern congressional members, among whom he found allies in John Forsyth (Georgia), James Hamilton Jr. (South Carolina), and John Randolph (Virginia).

The 1824 presidential election exposed the weakness of not having national Republican unity. All four candidates who received electoral votes were Republicans: Secretary of State John Quincy Adams of Massachusetts, House Speaker Henry Clay of Kentucky, Treasury secretary William H. Crawford of Georgia, and U.S. senator Andrew Jackson of Tennessee. Van Buren supported Crawford, but Adams, the son of second U.S. president John Adams, became president.

Adams' victory was not without controversy, however. Jackson, a War of 1812 hero, had won the most electoral votes but not the constitutionally required majority; therefore, the decision of who would become president went to the U.S. House of Representatives. Surprisingly, the majority of state delegations in the House voted in Adams' favor. Jackson's supporters accused Adams and Clay of stealing the election not just from their candidate but also from the American people. Within a few months, Jackson made clear his intention to challenge Adams in 1828.

Van Buren was not completely sold on Jackson's fidelity to Jeffersonian principles, but by early 1827, he was organizing a national coalition, which included Adams' vice president John C. Calhoun of South Carolina, into what became the Democratic Party. Van Buren saw utility in using Jackson's hero status to unite northern and southern voters into a national political coalition that would obscure the sectional divisions of the nation.

As Van Buren worked to elect Jackson in 1828, DeWitt Clinton died while serving as New York's governor. Van Buren's allies tapped him to run as his old rival's replacement. Both Jackson and Van Buren won their elections that fall. Van Buren became the governor of New York on January 1, 1829, but he was already expecting Jackson to offer him a cabinet post.

Original Article

https://millercenter.org/president/vanburen/life-before-the-presidency

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.10

"The Wolf by the Ear": Thomas Jefferson and the Missouri Crisis, 1819–21

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.3.1 Support; 9.3.2 Support

Excerpt · 704 words (complete article)

Two centuries ago, on February 13, 1819, James Tallmadge, a member of the Democratic-Republican Party formed by Thomas Jefferson, offered an amendment to a bill regarding the admission of the Territory of Missouri into the United States. The so-called Tallmadge Amendment proposed banning further imports of slaves into the future state, as well as the gradual emancipation of those already in the territory. What should have been a simple decision on the future of Missouri, however, soon became a debate on the future of slavery in all of the territories west of the Mississippi River. The lands in question had been purchased by Thomas Jefferson in 1803, and the Sage of Monticello soon found himself in the thick of the action as the discussions over the so-called Missouri Question heated up.

On the face of it, Jefferson appeared to be a person who would support the Tallmadge Amendment. As Jefferson historian John Chester Miller writes: "In 1784 he had tried to exclude slavery from all the territories of the United States and he had unqualifiedly endorsed the antislavery provision of the Northwest Ordinance of 1787."[1]

Jefferson had been dead-set against the westward expansion of slavery in his early career, believing that such exclusions would kill off American slavery once and for all. However, thirty-odd years and a presidential term had changed his views. By 1819, Jefferson, still claiming the goal of abolition, now favored a concept called diffusion that involved spreading slaves "over a greater surface" ensuring their "emancipation; by dividing the burthen" between white communities.[2]

As a result, by the time of the Missouri Crisis, Jefferson argued loudly for the expansion of slavery into the Louisiana Purchase lands. With his prominent position and political connections, the ex-president became a vocal advocate against the Tallmadge Amendment by late 1819.

Aside from his views on slavery, there were other reasons why Jefferson chose to briefly leave retirement and engage publicly in the Missouri debate. One reason was to try and reunite the Democratic-Republican Party, which found itself dangerously divided by the crisis. Jefferson was also concerned about how sectional the debate over slavery had become. Before the schism opened by Tallmadge there was no clear north-south divide over the peculiar institution, but the Missouri Crisis began to show clear cracks between northerners and southerners, even though nearly all of the politicians involved belonged to the same political party. Particularly concerning to Jefferson and his fellow southerners was the possibility that stopping slavery spreading westward would create more free states, giving these regions the same political majority in the senate that they already enjoyed in the House of Representatives.

In order to bring the divided Democratic-Republicans back together again, Jefferson needed to create a national enemy that his whole party could unite against. For this role, he chose his old foe: the Federalist Party. Although the party of Washington, Adams, and Hamilton had almost ceased to exist (and although Tallmadge and others in his camp were Democratic-Republicans themselves), Jefferson began complaining of a Federalist conspiracy in his many writings during the Missouri Crisis. "the Missouri question is a meer party trick. the leaders of federalism defeated in their schemes of obtaining power…have changed their tack, and thrown out another barrel," Jefferson ranted to Charles Pinckney, the South Carolina Republican.[3]

In a letter to Albert Gallatin, Jefferson insisted that the antislavery rhetoric of those that argued against the institution's expansion into Missouri, "served to throw dust into the eyes of the people and to fanaticise them."[4]

Jefferson thus argued that this group were simply using moral arguments about slavery to hide their true intentions: to destroy his Party, and the south in general, politically.

While Jefferson was arguing about larger national ideas, however, it was issues at home at Monticello that helped cement his concerns about Missouri and slavery's expansion. In a famous letter to Maine politician John Holmes, Jefferson described how "we have the wolf by the ear, and we can neither hold him, nor safely let him go."[5]

As the Missouri Crisis continued into 1820, Jefferson struggled both with this concept and a compromise that he considered to ring a "firebell in the night." A firebell, he feared, that warned of his nation's impending collapse.

Original Article

https://www.monticello.org/stories/the-wolf-by-the-ear-thomas-jefferson-and-the-missouri-crisis-1819-21

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Sellick, "'Wolf by the Ear.'"

CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.11

"A Firebell in the Night": Jefferson and the Missouri Crisis

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.3.1 Support

Excerpt · 689 words (complete article)

While historians have been quick to highlight the national reasons for Jefferson's vocal support for the admission of Missouri, the situation at Monticello that shaped his thinking has been largely overlooked. In September 1819, Jefferson had agreed to be guarantor of two $10,000 loans for his friend Wilson Cary Nicholas, who promptly died the following year. This crippling blow added to his own multitude of debts which had accumulated through the previous years as a result of poor planting, overspending and the financial downturn as a result of the Panic of 1819. The Panic had led to a serious fall in the price of Monticello's main crop, flour, as Jefferson described: "it does not yield the third of the price of 3 or 4 years ago."[1]

Land prices also fell dramatically. The culmination of all these factors meant that as the Missouri Crisis raged, Thomas Jefferson was facing the greatest financial test of his life.

By 1820, Jefferson had given up the management of Monticello. In his words: "age, it's ordinary infirmities, and frequent attacks of illness have rendered me unable to attend to my own affairs, which I have in consequence committed to the care of a grandson."[2]

Aware of his own mortality, and the financial burden through debt that he was likely to leave his family, his slaves remained the only tangible asset they stood to inherit. Virginian slaves fed the growing westward expansion of plantation agriculture, and retained their value even after the Panic of 1819. Jefferson therefore had a real financial incentive for arguing against the Tallmadge Amendment. Along with the fear that his friends and neighbors in Virginia would lose political clout, Jefferson plunged headlong into the debate over Missouri's admission to the Union.

In 1820, Congress reached a compromise to settle the Missouri debate, and the future of slavery in the western territories once and for all. To keep the balance of power in the Senate, Missouri was allowed to enter the justick as a slave state, while Maine (newly separated from Massachusetts) was admitted as a free state. To curtail future arguments on the subject, a geographic line was drawn along the southern border of Missouri across the western territories. Below the 36⁰ 30' line slavery would be permitted, while the land above it was reserved for free states. It seemed that the crisis had been solved without bloodshed when, in 1821, Missouri achieved US statehood.

Even after the compromise had been agreed, however, Jefferson lamented the agreement. He was sure that the drawing of the compromise line would not solve the problem for future generations. In 1823, he wrote to Supreme Court Justice William Johnson that "this case is not dead, it only sleepeth. the Indian chief said he did not go to war for every petty injury by itself; but put it into his pouch, and when that was full, he then made war."[3]

Along with his fears over the creation of the 36⁰ 30' line, Jefferson also rued the apparent geographical shift of political power in the US wrought by the crisis. "It was a project of federalism…they have succeeded. the East is replaced in the saddle of government, and the middle states are to be the cattle yoked to their car."[4]

Jefferson had seen a new generation of politicians take the stage, and saw it only as detrimental to Virginia and the Republican Party he had helped to create.

The Missouri debate was the last time that Thomas Jefferson took center stage in US politics. Retiring back to Monticello, Jefferson wrote that, “with one foot in the grave,—I have no right to meddle with these things.”[5]

Instead, he surrounded himself with his family, his beloved books, his new university in Charlottesville and the debt that would eventually lose his family their ancestral home. Jefferson played a central role in the debate, as a respected American founder arguing forcefully for states' rights and the expansion of slavery. In this role, Jefferson not only heard slavery’s “firebell in the night,” but helped to kindle the flames of its westward advance, creating an inferno that subsequent generations would struggle to douse.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.12

The Road to Secession

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Excerpt · 681 words

[Excerpt begins at the section "Invention of the Cotton Gin, 1793."]

Invention of the Cotton Gin, 1793

Developed in 1793 or 1794 and patented in 1794, Eli Whitney's engine or 'gin' revolutionized the production of cotton and entrenched slavery in the heart of the southern economy. Prior to Whitney's invention, the production of cotton was a time-consuming process that required the seeds and cotton fibers to be separated by hand. This meant that only largescale plantations could make a profit from cotton. Catherine Greene, widow of General Nathaniel Greene, hired Eli Whitney to come up with a solution to make growing cotton more economically efficient. The outcome was the cotton gin, a machine that separated cotton fibers from the sticky seeds making processing cotton quicker and less labor-intensive.

With the increase in speed and ease of separating cotton fibers, cotton production became highly lucrative for southern slaveholders. Production doubled each decade after 1800 and, in turn, fueled the rise of textile manufacturing in the North. Though the gin made separating seeds from cotton more efficient, it still sparked an expansion of the system of slavery as southern plantation owners bought more and more enslaved people to grow and pick the cotton. The 1790 census showed 697,897 enslaved people in the United States and by 1810 that number had increased 70% to 1.2 million. These drastic changes placed slave-produced cotton at the center of the southern way of life.

Louisiana Purchase, 1803

In 1803, the United States nearly doubled in size with purchase of the Louisiana Territory from France. For a cost of about $15 million dollars, the United States acquired 827,000 square miles of land and secured control of the Mississippi River. This massive expansion of territory opened the floodgates for western settlement. The land acquired by the purchase would eventually be carved into 13 states including Missouri, Kansas, and Nebraska. The admission of these new states became a battleground that stretched into the 1850s as northern, anti-slavery and southern, pro-slavery leaders debated whether slavery should be prohibited or allowed in each state. The decision was critical as each group vied to maintain a majority in Congress.

Missouri Compromise, 1820

The Missouri Compromise marked the first of a series of major political contests over the future of slavery in the western territories. Though this particular dispute ended in compromise, the ones to follow would not be as easy to legislate. Following the Louisiana Purchase, settlers rushed to take advantage of the land. The arrival of new settlers meant that by 1819, the Missouri Territory had the population necessary to apply for statehood. The admission of Missouri as state would offset the balance of Congress between the free and slave states, meaning that one side would gain the political advantage. Representative James Tallmadge of New York proposed an amendment to swing the political advantage in favor of free northern states. He argued that Missouri could be admitted as a state on the condition that residents and emigrants could not bring new slaves into the state and that owners would be required to emancipate the slaves currently in the territory gradually over time. This amendment, known as the Tallmadge Amendment, outraged white southerners who unanimously voted against it seeing it as a threat to both slavery and the balance of power in Congress. The amendment failed in the Senate, and the fate of Missouri and of slavery's expansion was left undecided.

Henry Clay would change that. The legendary Speaker of the House and 'Great Compromiser' provided a solution to keep the number of free and slave states balanced. He recommended that Missouri enter the Union as a slave state, and Maine, currently a part of Massachusetts, would become a free state. This, along with an amendment proposed by Senator Jesse Thomas of Illinois to prohibit slavery north of the 36°30' parallel (Missouri's southern boundary), became known as the Missouri Compromise, and lasted for nearly 25 years. As new states were carved out from the Louisiana Purchase, whether a state allowed or prohibited slavery was determined based on its location north or south of the 36°30' parallel. The Missouri Compromise marked the beginning of a decades long battle over the expansion of slavery into new western territories.

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.13

James Monroe: Foreign Affairs

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Excerpt · 1,102 words (complete article)

In the realm of foreign affairs, James Monroe sought to improve the country's international reputation and assert its independence. By virtue of his solid working relationship with Secretary of State John Quincy Adams, the two men successfully pursued an aggressive foreign policy, especially with regard to European intervention in the Americas.

In its early days, the Monroe administration wanted to improve relations with Britain. Toward that end, it negotiated two important accords with Britain that resolved border disputes held over from the War of 1812. The Rush-Bagot Treaty of 1817, named after acting Secretary of State Richard Rush and Charles Bagot, the British minister, demilitarized the Great Lakes, limiting each country to one 100-ton vessel armed with a single 18-pound cannon on Lake Chaplain and Lake Ontario. The Convention of 1818 fixed the present U.S.-Canadian border from Minnesota to the Rocky Mountains at the 49th parallel. The accords also established a joint U.S.-British occupation of Oregon for the next ten years.

Spanish Florida

For years, southern plantation owners and white farmers in Georgia, Alabama, and South Carolina had lost runaway slaves to the Florida swamps. Seminole and Creek Indians offered refuge to these slaves and led raids against white settlers in the border regions. The U.S. government could do little about the problem because the swamps lay deep within Spanish Florida. If the United States moved decisively against the Seminoles, it would risk war with Spain. Although the United States had tried to convince Spain to cede the territory on various occasions (including during Monroe's stint as special envoy to Spain in 1805), its efforts had failed.

With the end of the War of 1812, the U.S. government turned its attention to the raids. President Monroe sent General Andrew Jackson, the hero of the Battle of New Orleans, to the Florida border in 1818 to stop the incursions. Liberally interpreting his vague instructions, Jackson's troops invaded Florida, captured a Spanish fort at St. Marks, took control of Pensacola, and deposed the Spanish governor. He also executed two British citizens whom he accused of having incited the Seminoles to raid American settlements.

The invasion of Florida caused quite a stir in Washington, D.C. Although Jackson said he had acted within the bounds of his instructions, Secretary of War John C. Calhoun disagreed and urged Monroe to reprimand Jackson for acting without specific authority. In addition, foreign diplomats and some congressmen demanded that Jackson be repudiated and punished for his unauthorized invasion. Secretary of State John Quincy Adams came to Jackson's defense, stating that Jackson's measures were, in fact, authorized as part of his orders to end the Indian raids. Monroe ultimately agreed with Adams. To the administration, the entire affair illustrated the lack of control Spain had over the region. Secretary of State Adams thought that he could use the occasion to pressure Spain to sell all of Florida to the United States. Preoccupied with revolts throughout its Latin American empire, Spain understood that the United States could seize the territory at will. Adams convinced Spain to sell Florida to the United States and to drop its claims to the Louisiana Territory and Oregon. In return, the United States agreed to relinquish its claims on Texas and assume responsibility for $5 million that the Spanish government owed American citizens. The resulting treaty, known as the Adams-Onís Treaty of 1819—named after John Quincy Adams and Luis de Onís, the Spanish minister—was hailed as a great success.

Questions about the Florida raids resurfaced during Jackson's presidency. In 1830, a rift opened up between President Jackson and his vice president, John C. Calhoun. One of the issues involved Jackson's prior conduct in Florida and Calhoun's reaction as

secretary of war. At the time of the invasion, Jackson claimed that he had received secret instructions from Monroe to occupy Florida. Weeks before his death, Monroe wrote a letter disclaiming any knowledge of the secret instructions that Jackson claimed he had received.

Monroe Doctrine

During much of his administration, Monroe was engaged in diplomacy with Spain regarding its Latin American colonies. These lands had begun to break free from Spain in the early 1800s, gaining the sympathy of the United States, which viewed these later revolutions as reminiscent of its own struggle against Britain. Although many in Congress were eager to recognize the independence of the Latin American colonies, the President feared that doing so might risk war with Spain and its allies. It was not until March 1822 that Monroe officially recognized the countries of Argentina, Peru, Colombia, Chile, and Mexico.

At the same time, rumors abounded that Spain's allies might help the once vast empire reclaim its lost colonies. To counter the planned move, Britain proposed a joint U.S.-British declaration against European intervention in the Western Hemisphere. Secretary of State Adams convinced Monroe that if the United States issued a joint statement, it would look like the United States was simply adopting Britain's policy without formulating one tailored to its own interests. The United States, he argued, should devise its own strategy to address European intervention in the Western Hemisphere.

On December 2, 1823, in his annual message to Congress, President Monroe addressed the subject in three parts. He first reiterated the traditional U.S. policy of neutrality with regard to European wars and conflicts. He then declared that the United States would not accept the recolonization of any country by its former European master, though he also avowed non-interference with existing European colonies in the Americas. Finally, he stated that European countries should no longer consider the Western Hemisphere open to new colonization, a jab aimed primarily at Russia, which was attempting to expand its colony on the northern Pacific Coast.

This statement, which in the 1850s came to be known as the Monroe Doctrine, sounded tough, but most countries knew that America had little ability to back it up with force. Nevertheless, because Britain had also favored Monroe's policy, the United States was able to "free ride" on the back of the Royal Navy. In addition, London had extracted a promise from Paris that France would not assist Spain in the recovery of its colonies.

The Monroe Doctrine constituted the first significant policy statement by the United States on the future of the Western Hemisphere. As befitting the leader of a nation founded on the principles of republican government, Monroe saw the United States as a model and protector to the new Latin American republics. His declared intention to resist further European encroachment in the Western Hemisphere was the foundation of U.S. policy in Latin America during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries and remains one of Monroe's lasting achievements.

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.14

The 3 R's of America's Home Hemisphere: Republics; Revolutionaries; & the 'Rithmatic of Politics

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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.4.1 Support; 9.4.3 Support

Excerpt · 362 words

It's a special privilege to deliver a lecture named in honor of Ernest May.

And the topic is especially fitting because 50 years ago Professor May published a slim volume titled The Making of the Monroe Doctrine.

May's book offers a useful starting point for this ASG session: His thesis was that the Monroe Doctrine is best explained by Secretary of State John Quincy Adams' presidential ambitions and domestic politics —rather than debates about national interest or the product of international politics.

Historians have recognized the Monroe Doctrine as the "first public stand by the United States on an [international] controversy that did not immediately touch its own citizens and territory."

But the Doctrine declared what European powers should not do, not what the United States would do. That was the question Adams and his Secretary of State, Henry Clay, faced two years later.

Clay wanted the United States to attend a Congress of new republics in Panama to promote a "good neighborhood" policy and "new American principles" that contrasted with Europe's Holy Alliance, the system so admired years later by a rising Henry Kissinger. Clay pursued an ambitious agenda, including: commerce; navigation; maritime law and property rights at sea; neutral rights; liberal emigration and naturalization; internal improvements, including a trans-isthmian canal; and even free toleration of religion.

But domestic politics intervened again: The Jacksonians in Congress held up the confirmation and funds for emissaries. Eventually one died of a tropical fever along the way and the other only got as far as Mexico City by the time the Panama Congress adjourned.

That diplomatic debacle previews a frustrating cycle of US partnership with Latin America—and then detachment and disappointment—that continues through today.

Nevertheless, Clay had planted the seed of what became known as the Western Hemisphere Idea—the belief that the peoples of the Americas had a special relationship with one another, which sets them apart from the rest of the world and especially Europe. The idea faded as the United States became a global power, but echoed over the years into a new form about a distinctive regional perspective amidst global flux—with variations as recently as the 1990s and perhaps even today.

Original Article

https://www.belfercenter.org/belfer-news/3-rs-americas-home-hemisphere-republics-revolutionaries-rithmatic-politics

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.15

The Monroe Doctrine After 200 Years: A Strategic Hinge Period in American History

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Excerpt · 958 words

[Excerpt begins at the section "A New US Foreign Policy."]

A New US Foreign Policy

By 1817, President James Monroe had substantial diplomatic experience, but he was not a strategic thinker. Fortunately, he chose as secretary of state America's first and greatest career diplomat, and its most successful and consequential secretary of state, John Quincy Adams. The brilliant Quincy Adams began his career in 1779 in Paris with his father, John Adams. In 1794 Washington named him, at age 27, minister to the Netherlands. By 1817, Quincy Adams had spent almost half his life as a diplomat abroad; been minister to six European nations; was chief negotiator of the Treaty of Ghent; and was not yet 50 years old.

For the next 12 years, he was the tough-minded statesman-strategist who guided American policy, establishing republican security and legitimacy by keeping the monarchs from organizing against him. He started with British Foreign Secretary Castlereagh and settled the western border with Canada in the Treaty of 1818. He also negotiated the Transcontinental Treaty of 1821 with Spain (with France's acquiescence). That treaty ceded Florida and its Gulf Coast to the US and defined the western border of the Louisiana Territory to the Pacific. Next, in parallel with Castlereagh's successor, George Canning, he objected in 1822 to Russia's Pacific claims, which would have closed the Pacific coast to access, settlement, and trade. The Tsar soon abandoned his new claims.

This five-year (1817-22) diplomatic tour-de-force by Adams gained for the US, for the first time since independence, internationally agreed borders, and republican legitimacy by four of the six monarchies that opposed republicanism. With Spain gone, Mexico independent, Russia pushed north, and US-UK exploring common interests, Adams demonstrated the new US approach by recognizing the American republics.

Also, in the sonorous but nuanced voice of a small nation still facing larger, antagonistic powers, Adams, in a 1921 July 4th speech in the House of Representatives, declared a new synthesis of American policy which became the nation's diplomatic center of gravity for a century.

> Wherever the standard of freedom and independence has been or shall be unfurled, there will be her [the USA's] heart, her benedictions, and her prayers. But she goes not abroad in search of monsters to destroy. She is the well-wisher to the freedom and independence of all. She is the champion and vindicator only of her own.... She well knows that by once enlisting under other banners...she would involve herself, beyond the power of extrication....

The Monroe Doctrine and The Atlantic Barrier

By the 1820s, the Atlantic Ocean was a barrier. Those on its west coast hoped it would keep European emperors away. The emperors saw it as a barrier limiting their control of the new world. Despite increasing commerce across the ocean throughout the nineteenth century, it remained a barrier. After World War I, the barrier fell as empires collapsed and republican governments emerged in Europe. However, two prescient statesmen—Adams and Canning—ignored the Atlantic barrier by using the British Navy in 1823 to support the first long-term transatlantic political agreement to advance common strategic interests. Following the 1818 treaty negotiations, Adams suggested to Castlereagh the idea of a "common understanding" to support Latin American independence. The cautious Castlereagh did not respond. But his successor did.

In August 1823, Canning approached the US about a simple, three-part, bilateral declaration:

Spain could make peace with rebellious colonists and the UK and US would not interfere.

The UK and US would, however, oppose "transfer" of any parts of those territories "to any other Power."

The UK and US would not "…aim at the possession of any portion of [those territories] ourselves."

Monroe, Thomas Jefferson, and James Madison agreed to the proposal, as did Monroe's cabinet, with one exception. Adams dissented. He knew Canning would tell other powers of British policy, making a joint statement unnecessary. Indeed, Canning did not wait for Adams to respond before doing so. The powers knew the UK Navy would keep them at bay because the British fleet was stronger than their combined navies. Adams interpreted the second point as intending to involve the US in European politics. Finally, he saw the last point as a "pledge against ourselves" to stop westward expansion into Spanish territories even if they "solicit a union with us." Finally, a joint statement would make the US "subordinate" to the UK. His powerful metaphor was "a cockboat in the wake of the British man-of-war."

Instead, Adams argued for the method he and Canning used for Russia's overreach in the Pacific, separate statements of a common policy. Adams's statement also had three main points:

The US had not and would not interfere in existing colonies.

The US would consider any attempt by "the allied powers…to extend their system to any portion of this hemisphere as dangerous to our peace and safety."

For colonies that "have declared their independence and maintained it, any interposition…by any European power…for the purpose of oppressing them…[will be viewed as a] manifestation of an unfriendly disposition toward the United States."

This defined the political agreement with the UK as a common interest in seeing hemispheric nations become independent. Gone was any hint of involvement in European intrigues, or limiting westward expansion, or being a "cockboat." Both sides benefitted, but Adams's clever maneuver turned a page in US diplomatic history. Canning was pleased enough to boast that he had called "the new world into existence to redress the balance of the old."

In December 1823, Monroe agreed and delivered his address to Congress. As historians have noted, the Doctrine's intellectual author was Adams. Samuel Elliott Morison asserted that Monroe "never really understood the significance, or grasped the essential principles, of the message that bears his name." Instead, two statesmen drove the issue to conclusion with minimal support of their governmental colleagues. Canning got no support from Tory leaders for his forward-looking American policies.

Original Article

https://americandiplomacy.web.unc.edu/2023/08/the-monroe-doctrine-after-200-years-a-strategic-hinge-period-in-american-history/

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

McNamara, "Monroe Doctrine after 200 Years."

CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.16

The Many Faces of the Monroe Doctrine

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PUBLICATION	December 4, 2023
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 9 | 9.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	9.4.2 Support; 9.4.4 Support

Excerpt · 803 words

In yet another curious twist in its long history, the Monroe Doctrine, which turned 200 on Saturday, is making an unexpected political comeback in the United States. “I think it’s as relevant today as it was the day it was written,” declared Rex Tillerson, Donald Trump’s first secretary of state, in Mexico City in 2018. More recently, contestants for the 2024 Republican presidential nomination have competed to lay claim to the doctrine. The evening of his botched campaign announcement on Twitter/X, Florida governor Ron DeSantis took to Fox News’ airwaves to call for “a 21st-century version of the Monroe Doctrine” to counter rising Chinese influence in Latin America. Vivek Ramaswamy announced that, were he elected president, “The North Star of my foreign policy will be the modern Monroe Doctrine.” Not to be outdone, Republicans on the Senate Foreign Relations Committee recently introduced a resolution declaring their fidelity to this doctrine from the days of sailing ships, flintlock muskets, and monarchs.

Those hearing these unexpected shout-outs to a piece of early 19th-century history could be forgiven for sharing the reaction that John F. Kennedy had when advisors encouraged him to invoke the doctrine during the Cuban Missile Crisis: “The Monroe Doctrine — what the hell is that?” Kennedy’s question remains a good one: What is the Monroe Doctrine? And why is it reappearing in its bicentennial year?

The answer lies in recognizing that the doctrine is not simply an instrument of foreign policy, but rather a shape-shifting and contested symbol of domestic politics. As I argued in my 2011 book on the topic, the secret to understanding the Monroe Doctrine is that Americans have invoked it against one another far more than they have used it against foreign governments.

Over the course of its 200-year history, the doctrine has had a jack-in-the-box quality: It has framed political debates in one period, only to disappear in the next. To be sure, this waxing and waning have responded to geopolitical shifts, but it has primarily been the result of how those shifts in the global system have intensified domestic political debate and partisan conflict. The historical periods in which the doctrine has jumped out of the history books and into popular discourse — the present included — are those moments in which there is most internal debate concerning the role of the United States in the wider world.

A Nothingburger Message

If you’re American, the high school textbook that you once read probably presented James Monroe’s 1823 message as a foreign policy equivalent of the U.S. Constitution. It allegedly outlined basic rules, headlined by a prohibition on further European colonization in the Western Hemisphere, that structured U.S. foreign policy thereafter. But this clean and tidy view of the doctrine always has been more myth than reality.

For starters, the nonsequential foreign policy paragraphs of James Monroe’s 1823 annual message were not intended to be a timeless set of policy prescriptions. Rather, Monroe and his team muddled through a complex situation, dodging critical questions and controversies as they responded to events beyond their control. When Monroe audaciously proclaimed an end to European intervention in the Western Hemisphere at a critical moment in the Spanish-American revolutions, he failed to mention how it would be enforced (fortuitously, by the time Monroe delivered his message, the British had already cut a secret deal with France that resolved the diplomatic crisis). The ambiguous text of the 1823 message to Congress also sidestepped the critical matter of future U.S. imperial expansion.

Monroe fudged the key issues. He kicked the can of an alliance offer from Britain down the road, while offering only lip-service support to the revolutions in Latin America and Greece. Most of all, his message stopped short of committing the United States to any action. The evidence is clear: The 1823 message was never intended to become a binding foreign policy "doctrine." Monroe's message was a nothingburger.

But the subsequent "Monroe Doctrine," a phrase that first appeared in the decades before the Civil War, had very little to do with the original text. Rather, it was an adaptable symbol of U.S. foreign policy that ricocheted back and forth across the American political spectrum, sometimes even bouncing across borders when appropriated by foreign officials. The best definition of the Monroe Doctrine might be as follows: a contested political symbol into which varying actors have loaded their agendas.

The utility of the Monroe Doctrine lay in the elasticity of the 1823 message, which amounted to a blank canvas waiting to be filled by an astonishingly diverse range of political interests. The invented tradition of the Monroe Doctrine was appropriated by slavers and abolitionists, isolationists and internationalists, pacifists and war hawks, protectionists and free traders, anti-imperialists and advocates of colonial rule. There have been as many Monroe Doctrines as perspectives on America's role in the world.

Original Article

https://warontherocks.com/the-many-faces-of-the-monroe-doctrine/

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Sexton, "Many Faces."

CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.17

Monroe Doctrine (1823)

National Archives

AUTHOR	National Archives (Unsigned page of the U.S. National Archives and Records Administration)
WEBSITE	Milestone Documents, National Archives
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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.4.2 Support; 9.4.4 Support

Excerpt · 431 words (complete article)

The Monroe Doctrine was articulated in President James Monroe's seventh annual message to Congress on December 2, 1823. The European powers, according to Monroe, were obligated to respect the Western Hemisphere as the United States' sphere of interest.

President James Monroe's 1823 annual message to Congress contained the Monroe Doctrine, which warned European powers not to interfere in the affairs of the Western Hemisphere.

Understandably, the United States has always taken a particular interest in its closest neighbors – the nations of the Western Hemisphere. Equally understandably, expressions of this concern have not always been favorably regarded by other American nations.

The Monroe Doctrine is the best known U.S. policy toward the Western Hemisphere. Buried in a routine annual message delivered to Congress by President James Monroe in December 1823, the doctrine warns European nations that the United States would not tolerate further colonization or puppet monarchs. The doctrine was conceived to meet major concerns of the moment, but it soon became a watchword of U.S. policy in the Western Hemisphere.

The Monroe Doctrine was invoked in 1865 when the U.S. government exerted diplomatic and military pressure in support of the Mexican President Benito Juárez. This support enabled Juárez to lead a successful revolt against the Emperor Maximilian, who had been placed on the throne by the French government.

Almost 40 years later, in 1904, European creditors of a number of Latin American countries threatened armed intervention to collect debts. President Theodore Roosevelt promptly proclaimed the right of the United States to exercise an "international police power" to curb such "chronic wrongdoing," in his so-called Roosevelt Corollary (or extension) to the Monroe Doctrine.

While the Monroe Doctrine's message was designed to keep European powers out of the Western Hemisphere, Roosevelt would strengthen its meaning to justify sending the United States into other countries of the Western Hemisphere. As a result, U.S. Marines were sent into Santo Domingo in 1904, Nicaragua in 1911, and Haiti in 1915, ostensibly to keep the Europeans out. Other Latin American nations viewed these interventions with misgiving, and relations between the "great Colossus of the North" and its southern neighbors remained strained for many years.

In 1962, the Monroe Doctrine was invoked symbolically when the Soviet Union began to build missile-launching sites in Cuba. With the support of the Organization of American States, President John F. Kennedy threw a naval and air quarantine around the island. After several tense days, the Soviet Union agreed to withdraw the missiles and dismantle the sites. Subsequently, the United States dismantled several of its obsolete air and missile bases in Turkey.

Original Article

https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/monroe-doctrine

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.18

Monroe Doctrine, 1823

Office of the Historian

AUTHOR	Office of the Historian (Unsigned page of the U.S. Department of State, Office of the Historian)
WEBSITE	Milestones in the History of U.S. Foreign Relations, U.S. Department of State
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ARGUMENT ROLES	9.4.2 Support; 9.4.4 Support

Excerpt · 512 words (complete article)

In his December 2, 1823, address to Congress, President James Monroe articulated United States' policy on the new political order developing in the rest of the Americas and the role of Europe in the Western Hemisphere.

The statement, known as the Monroe Doctrine, was little noted by the Great Powers of Europe, but eventually became a longstanding tenet of U.S. foreign policy. Monroe and his Secretary of State John Quincy Adams drew upon a foundation of American diplomatic ideals such as disentanglement from European affairs and defense of neutral rights as expressed in Washington's Farewell Address and Madison's stated rationale for waging the War of 1812. The three main concepts of the doctrine—separate spheres of influence for the Americas and Europe, non-colonization, and non-intervention—were designed to signify a clear break between the New World and the autocratic realm of Europe. Monroe's administration forewarned the imperial European powers against interfering in the affairs of the newly independent Latin American states or potential United States territories. While Americans generally objected to European colonies in the New World, they also desired to increase United States influence and trading ties throughout the region to their south. European mercantilism posed the greatest obstacle to economic expansion. In particular, Americans feared that Spain and France might reassert colonialism over the Latin American peoples who had just overthrown European rule. Signs that Russia was expanding its presence southward from Alaska toward the Oregon Territory were also disconcerting.

For their part, the British also had a strong interest in ensuring the demise of Spanish colonialism, with all the trade restrictions mercantilism imposed. Earlier in 1823 British Foreign Minister George Canning suggested to Americans that two nations issue a joint declaration to deter any other power from intervening in Central and South America. Secretary of State John Quincy Adams, however, vigorously opposed cooperation with Great Britain, contending that a statement of bilateral nature could limit United States expansion in the future. He also argued that the British were not committed to recognizing the Latin American republics and must have had imperial motivations themselves.

The bilateral statement proposed by the British thereby became a unilateral declaration by the United States. As Monroe stated: "The American continents … are henceforth not to be considered as subjects for future colonization by any European powers." Monroe outlined two separate spheres of influence: the Americas and Europe. The independent lands of the Western Hemisphere would be solely the United States' domain. In exchange, the United States pledged to avoid involvement in the political affairs of Europe, such as the ongoing Greek struggle for independence from the Ottoman Empire, and not to interfere in the existing European colonies already in the Americas.

By the mid-1800s, Monroe's declaration, combined with ideas of Manifest Destiny, provided precedent and support for U.S. expansion on the American continent. In the late 1800s, U.S. economic and military power enabled it to enforce the Monroe Doctrine. The doctrine's greatest extension came with Theodore Roosevelt's Corollary, which inverted the original meaning of the doctrine and came to justify unilateral U.S. intervention in Latin America.

Original Article

https://history.state.gov/milestones/1801-1829/monroe

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.19

Andrew Jackson: Campaigns and Elections

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 9 | 9.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	9.5.1 Support; 9.5.2 Support; 9.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 624 words

[Excerpt begins at the section "The Campaign and Election of 1828."]

The Campaign and Election of 1828

The four years of the John Quincy Adams administration constituted one long, acrimonious, and in the end, one-sided presidential campaign. Determined not to be paralyzed by his status as a minority President, Adams overreached with controversial policy initiatives. He threw his support behind the "American System," Henry Clay's program of congressional aid to economic development through transportation subsidies and protective tariffs. Adams's activism backfired as Jackson and his publicists mounted a cry to clean out the corruptionists and restore purity and economy in government. Major constituencies swung behind Jackson: Vice-President Calhoun and his South Carolina following, Crawfordites shepherded by Martin Van Buren of New York, and disaffected Clay men in the west led by Thomas Hart Benton of Missouri—Jackson's former Tennessee antagonist, now a political ally.

This diffuse coalition included both friends and foes of the American System. To break it, Adams men tried to smoke out Jackson's position. Jackson refused to be pinned down, while his followers fended off questions about his qualifications and experience by touting his battlefield exploits, indomitable patriotism, and opposition to aristocracy and corruption. A good deal of mud was slung on both sides, much of it aimed at Jackson's marriage, his violent escapades, and the incidents of ferocious discipline and of disrespect for civilian authority that dotted his military career. Adams men painted him as a grasping and bloodthirsty character, a budding tyrant in the model of Caesar or Napoleon, whose election would spell the death of the republic. Jacksonians branded Adams as a corruptionist, an aristocrat, and—ridiculously—a libertine. In the end, none of the slanders could touch Jackson's invincible popularity. He won easily in 1828, with 56 percent of the vote and 178 electoral votes to Adams's 83. Jackson carried New York and Pennsylvania as well as the entire West and South. He was the first President elected from west of the Appalachians and, at that time, the oldest man to assume the office. But his victory was touched with grief. As if in response to the torrent of abuse, Rachel sickened and died on December 22.

The Campaign and Election of 1832

Jackson stood for re-election in 1832. By this time he had come out publicly against the American System. He had also created a new issue by vetoing the recharter of the Bank of the United States. The American System men, now calling themselves National Republicans, nominated Henry Clay. A third party also took the field: the quixotic Anti-Masonic Party, formed in reaction to exposures of political favoritism and corruption by members of the fraternal order of Freemasons. Strong in some northern states, the Anti-Masons nominated former attorney general William Wirt. They were generally anti-Jackson, but thoughts of uniting with the National Republicans collapsed when Clay refused to denounce the Masonic order, of which both he and Jackson were members.

The 1832 campaign introduced the national nominating convention in place of the old discredited congressional caucus as a means of selecting a candidate. The National Republicans and Anti-Masons held conventions and adopted formal addresses to the public. Jackson's followers, popularly though not yet officially known as Democrats, met in Baltimore to endorse Jackson's choice of Martin Van Buren for vice president. To show their unanimity, they also adopted a rule requiring a two-thirds vote for nomination—a rule that would later deprive Van Buren of the Democratic presidential nomination in 1844.

Despite the new issues and innovations in party organization, the election was essentially a replay of 1828. Jackson again carried Pennsylvania, New York, and nearly the entire South. He defeated Clay handily, with 55 percent of the popular vote and 219 electoral votes to the latter's 49. Jackson read his victory as a popular ratification of his policies, especially the Bank veto. Opponents chalked it up to his untouchable personal popularity.

Original Article

https://millercenter.org/president/jackson/campaigns-and-elections

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.20

John Quincy Adams: Campaigns and Elections

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 9 | 9.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	9.5.1 Support; 9.5.2 Support; 9.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,042 words

[Excerpt begins at the section "The Campaign and Election of 1828."]

The Campaign and Election of 1828

Within months of Adams's inauguration in 1825, the Tennessee legislature nominated Andrew Jackson for President. Over the next three years, Jackson put together a highly disciplined grassroots campaign with one goal: to defeat John Quincy Adams in a rematch that would pit "the people" against Adams. Jackson issued so-called memorandums (a misuse of the word that endeared him to his growing western constituency) in which he outlined the erosion of representative power over the last decades at the hands of "gamesters" like Clay and Adams. In Jackson's mind, the "corrupt bargain" was just one of a number of such schemes. Jackson claimed that the Panic of 1819, a devastating economic collapse, had resulted from (1) a conspiracy of disreputable creditors and the Bank of the United States, (2) the unpaid national debt, (3) the political swindlers in office from Madison through Adams—schemers who would be turned out with a Jackson victory—and (4) the backstairs dealings of "King Caucus" to select a President in defiance of popular opinion.

While Jackson issued his statements and traveled the nation rounding up support, his most brilliant lieutenant, Martin Van Buren of New York, assumed the duties of a campaign manager. Van Buren had switched allegiance from Crawford to Jackson shortly after the election of 1824. His efforts thereafter were focused on securing a victory for Jackson in the popular vote. Van Buren's strategy was to portray Jackson as the head of a disciplined and issue-oriented party that was committed to states' rights and the limited-government ideology of the old Jeffersonian Republicans.

In the year before the 1828 election, Van Buren's organizational efforts began to create a new political entity that would come to fruition in the 1830s. For the 1828 election, Van Buren focused on linking the opponents of federalism in the North and South into a coalition that he envisioned as the heir to the old Jeffersonian Republican Party. In his mind, victory for this new movement would protect slavery in the South, ensure the legitimacy of majority rule based upon direct voting for candidates by the electorate, and guarantee preservation of the Union, with states' rights as the fundamental basis of American liberty. When he won the support of Vice President John C. Calhoun and powerful Virginia political leaders, Van Buren effectively laid the basis for a party system that would endure until the Civil War. (Calhoun was moving away from his postwar ideology of nationalism to a states' rights conservatism that was more reflective of his region's fear of abolitionism, costly internal improvements, and high protective tariffs.)

While Jackson and Van Buren organized, Adams diligently carried out the duties of the presidency, refusing to prepare himself or his supporters for the coming contest. Adams did not remove even his loudest opponents from appointive office and hewed to the old-fashioned notion that a candidate should "stand" for office, not "run." When the election campaign officially began, Adams's supporters formally adopted the name National Republicans in contrast to Democrats, trying thereby to identify themselves accurately with the link between old-style federalism and a new nationalistic republicanism. Jacksonians, on the other hand, argued for a new revolutionary movement that rested on a firm faith in majoritarian democracy and states' rights—ideas that were not always compatible.

Personal Campaign Battles

Although issues clearly separated the candidates along lines more distinct than any since the election of 1800, the campaign itself was highly personal. Indeed, it was the first campaign in history to use election materials such as campaign buttons, slogans, posters, tokens, flasks, snuffboxes, medallions, thread boxes, matchboxes, mugs, and fabric images so extensively. Almost all of these campaign trinkets depicted some aspect of the candidate's popular image. Jackson's status as a war hero and frontiersman played far better with the public than Adams's stiff-looking elder statesman stance.

Neither candidate personally campaigned in 1828, but their political followers organized rallies, parades, and demonstrations. In the popular press, the rhetorical attacks reached a level of cruelty and misrepresentation not seen since the election of 1800. Jackson was accused of multiple murders, of extreme personal violence, and of having lived in sin with his wife, Rachel, who herself was attacked as a bigamist. Adams, on the other hand, was attacked for his legalistic attitudes, for his foreign-born wife, and for reportedly having procured young American virgins for the Russian czar as the primary achievement of his diplomatic career. Adams's critics referred to him as "His Excellency" while Jackson came under attack as an ill-mannered, barely civilized, backwoods killer of Indians.

In a masterstroke of popular politics, the Jacksonians made good use of the general's nickname, Old Hickory. He had earned the name because he was reputed to be as tough as hickory wood. To publicize his image, Jackson supporters put hickory poles all over the country, distributed hickory toothpicks and canes, and served up barbecues fired by hickory chips.

The branding of Jackson's wife as an "American Jezebel" and convicted adulteress—because she had married Jackson before her divorce from an earlier marriage had been finalized—surprisingly backfired as an election strategy. It unleashed a backlash against Adams for humiliating a woman who had lived for 40 years as the devoted wife of General Jackson, for grossly violating the general's privacy and honor, and for applying narrowly legalistic pronouncements in place of common sense. To countless Americans, Jackson's duels, brawls, executions, and unauthorized ventures represented the victory of what was right and good over the application of stiff-minded and narrowly construed principles. The attacks simply enhanced Jackson's image as an authentic American hero who had drawn upon his natural nobility and powerful will to prevail against unscrupulous political foes, educated elitists, the pride of the British army, and "heathen savages"—often at the same time.

The campaign turned out more than twice the number of voters who had cast ballots in 1824—approximately 57 percent of the electorate. Jackson won the election in a landslide, and by a wide margin of 95 electoral votes. Adams carried New England, Delaware, part of Maryland, New Jersey, and sixteen of New York's electoral votes—nine states in all. Jackson carried the remaining fifteen states of the South, Northwest, mid-Atlantic, and West. Incumbent Vice President John C. Calhoun won 171 electoral votes to 83 for Richard Rush of Pennsylvania, Adams's running mate.

Original Article

https://millercenter.org/president/jqadams/campaigns-and-elections

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 9 · WEB ARTICLE W9.21

“Corrupt Bargain”

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 9 | 9.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	9.5.1 Support

Excerpt · 794 words

The year 1824 was a political turning point in which none of the old rules applied. For the first time, the popular vote mattered—eighteen states were to choose their presidential electors by popular vote while only six states still left the choice up to their state legislatures. The electorate also featured a new swath of regionally focused voters only recently enfranchised thanks to the removal of property ownership as a criterion for white male suffrage. In this new climate regional endorsements of candidates by state conventions or state assemblies—popularity—rather than congressional intrigue, would drive the nomination process.

Although John Quincy Adams should have been the heir apparent to the presidency as James Monroe's secretary of state, four other men also wanted to be President, each with substantial regional backing.

John C. Calhoun of South Carolina had served as secretary of war in the Monroe administration and had support from slave owners in the South.

The politically ambitious and able William H. Crawford of Georgia enjoyed the support of party regulars in Congress—especially Senator Martin Van Buren of New York—as well as substantial footing in Georgia. Crawford had served as secretary of war and of the treasury in the two previous administrations.

The most visible candidate was House Speaker Henry Clay. A leading War Hawk during the War of 1812, Clay had a power base in Kentucky, was a gifted public speaker, and had support for his so-called American System of protective tariffs and federally sponsored internal improvements.

Then there was General Andrew Jackson from Tennessee, the hero of the Battle of New Orleans. Jackson's reputation as an Indian fighter and western expansionist, owing to his military escapades in Spanish Florida, gave him national standing above all other candidates. It also helped that Jackson could enter the race as an outsider, a defender of the Republic who had risked his life in service of his nation. In fact, his supporters talked about him as another George Washington.

Although Adams was a centrist politician of sorts—a Jeffersonian-Federalist, to coin a new term—many Americans still identified him as a New Englander and as the son of the old Federalist leader John Adams. Additionally, many staunch Democratic-Republicans blamed Adams and his supporters for having transformed the party of Jefferson into a disguised form of Federalism under the rubric of "National Republicans." Southerners, moreover, objected to Adams because of his moral opposition to slavery.

Building a coalition in such circumstances would be no easy task.

Four Democratic-Republican candidates

In the summer of 1824, an unofficial caucus of less than a third of the congressmen eligible to attend nominated Crawford for president. Supporters of Adams denounced the caucus bid, and the Massachusetts legislature nominated Adams as their favorite-son candidate. The Kentucky legislature did the same for Clay. Both nominations followed the pattern set by the Tennessee legislature, which had nominated Andrew Jackson back in 1822 and sent him to the Senate to burnish his credentials. John C. Calhoun of South Carolina dropped out of the presidential race by announcing his bid for the vice presidency.

All four remaining candidates were nominal Democratic-Republicans—the Federalist Party had disintegrated by this point—and the election proceeded without reference to party affiliation. Jackson, whose credentials were based largely on his personality and heroic exploits, emerged as the man to beat. The size of his rallies in key swing states—Pennsylvania, Illinois, Indiana, New York, and New Jersey—far surpassed or rivaled those for Clay and Adams.

Jackson was the only candidate to attract significant support beyond his regional base, and his Jackson's popularity foretold a new era in the making. When the final votes were tallied in the eighteen states requiring a popular vote, Jackson polled 152,901 votes to Adams's 114,023; Clay won 47,217, and Crawford 46,979. The electoral college gave Jackson the highest total as well, but his 99 electoral votes electoral were 32 fewer than he needed for a majority and thus the presidency. Adams won 84 electoral votes followed by 41 for Crawford and 37 for Clay.

Acting under the Twelfth Amendment of the Constitution, the House of Representatives met to select the president from among the top three candidates. Henry Clay, as the candidate with the fewest electoral votes, was eliminated from the deliberation. As Speaker of the House, however, he became the most important player in determining the outcome of the election in the House, which took place in February 1825. With each state having one vote, as determined by the wishes of the majority of each state's congressional representatives, Adams emerged as the winner with a one-vote margin of victory. Most of Clay's supporters, joined by several old Federalists, switched their votes to Adams in enough states to give him the election. Soon after his inauguration, Adams appointed Clay as his secretary of state.

Original Article

https://millercenter.org/contested-presidential-elections/corrupt-bargain

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.1

Andrew Jackson: Impact and Legacy

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ARGUMENT ROLES	10.1.1 Support; 10.5.1 Support; 10.5.2 Support; 10.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 557 words (complete article)

Andrew Jackson left a permanent imprint upon American politics and the presidency. Within eight years, he melded the amorphous coalition of personal followers who had elected him into the country's most durable and successful political party, an electoral machine whose organization and discipline would serve as a model for all others. At the same time, his controversial conduct in office galvanized opponents to organize the Whig party. The Democratic party was Jackson's child; the national two-party system was his legacy.

Jackson's drive for party organization was spurred by his own difficulties with Congress. Unlike other famously strong Presidents, Jackson defined himself not by enacting a legislative program but by thwarting one. In eight years, Congress passed only one major law, the Indian Removal Act of 1830, at his behest. During this time Jackson vetoed twelve bills, more than his six predecessors combined. One of these was the first "pocket veto" in American history. The Maysville Road and Bank vetoes stood as enduring statements of his political philosophy.

Jackson strengthened himself against Congress by forging direct links with the voters. His official messages, though delivered to Congress, spoke in plain and powerful language to the people at large. Reversing a tradition of executive deference to legislative supremacy, Jackson boldly cast himself as the people's tribune, their sole defender against special interests and their minions in Congress. In other ways, too, Jackson expanded the scope of presidential authority. He dominated his cabinet, forcing out members who would not execute his commands. In two terms he went through four secretaries of state and five secretaries of the treasury. Holding his official subordinates at arm's length, Jackson devised and implemented his policies through a private coterie of advisers and publicists known as the "Kitchen Cabinet." His bold initiatives and domineering style caused opponents to call him King Andrew, and to take the name of Whigs to signify their opposition to executive tyranny.

Jackson was no deep thinker, but his matured policy positions did bespeak a coherent political philosophy. Like Jefferson, he believed republican government should be simple, frugal, and accessible. He cherished the extinction of the national debt during his administration as a personal triumph. Believing that social cleavages and inequities were fostered rather than ameliorated by governmental intervention, he embraced laissez-faire as the policy most conducive to economic equality and political liberty.

Jackson was both a fiery patriot and a strident partisan. Regarding the national union as indivisible and perpetual, he denounced nullification and secession while reproving policies like the tariff which fostered sectional divisiveness. His aggressive Indian removal policy and his espousal of cheaper western land prices reflected his nationalism's grounding in the southwestern frontier. Jackson's powerful personality played an instrumental role in his presidency. He indulged in violent hatreds, and the extent to which his political positions reflected mere personal animus is still debated. Jackson demonized many of those who crossed him, including John C. Calhoun, Henry Clay, Bank of the United States president Nicholas Biddle, and Cherokee Indian chief John Ross. Jackson's own character polarized contemporaries and continues to divide historians. Some praise his strength and audacity; others see him as vengeful and self-obsessed. To admirers he stands as a shining symbol of American accomplishment, the ultimate individualist and democrat. To detractors he appears an incipient tyrant, the closest we have yet come to an American Caesar.

Original Article

https://millercenter.org/president/jackson/impact-and-legacy

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Feller, "Andrew Jackson: Impact and Legacy."

CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.2

Andrew Jackson: Domestic Affairs

Daniel Feller

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ARGUMENT ROLES	10.1.1 Support; 10.1.2 Support; 10.1.3 Support; 10.3.1 Support; 10.3.3 Support; 10.4.1 Support; 10.5.1 Support; 10.5.2 Support; 10.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,058 words

Jackson entered the White House with an uncertain policy agenda beyond a vague craving for "reform" (or revenge) and a determination to settle relationships between the states and the Indian tribes within their borders. On these two matters he moved quickly and decisively.

During the campaign, Jackson had charged the Adams bureaucracy with fraud and with working against his election. As President, he initiated sweeping removals among high-ranking government officials—Washington bureau chiefs, land and customs officers, and federal marshals and attorneys. Jackson claimed to be purging the corruption, laxity, and arrogance that came with long tenure, and restoring the opportunity for government service to the citizenry at large through "rotation in office." But haste and gullibility did much to confuse his purpose.

Under the guise of reform, many offices were doled out as rewards for political services. Newspaper editors who had championed Jackson's cause, some of them very unsavory characters, came in for special favor. His most appalling appointee was an old army comrade and political sycophant named Samuel Swartwout. Against all advice, Jackson made him collector of the New York City customhouse, where the government collected nearly half its annual revenue. In 1838, Swartwout absconded with more than $1 million, a staggering sum for that day. Jackson denied that political criteria motivated his appointments, claiming honesty and efficiency as his only goals. Yet he accepted an officeholder's support for Adams as evidence of unfitness, and in choosing replacements he relied exclusively on recommendations from his own partisans. A Jackson senator from New York, William L. Marcy, defended Jackson's removals by proclaiming frankly in 1832 that in politics as in war, "to the victor belong the spoils of the enemy." Jackson was never so candid—or so cynical. Creating the "spoils system" of partisan manipulation of the patronage was not his conscious intention. Still, it was his doing.

Indian Removal

Indian nations had been largely erased or removed from the northeastern United States by the time Jackson became President. But in the southwest, the Cherokees, Chickasaws, Choctaws, and Creeks still occupied large portions of Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, and Tennessee. For many years, Jackson had protested the practice of treating with Indian tribes as if they were foreign nations. Jackson did not hate Indians as a race. He was friendly with many individual Indians and had taken home an Indian orphan from the Creek campaign to raise in his household as a companion to his adopted son. But Jackson did believe that Indian civilization was lower than that of whites, and that for their own survival, tribes who were pressed by white settlement must assimilate as individuals or remove to the west out of harm's way. Confident that he could judge the Indians' true welfare better than they, Jackson, when employed as an Indian negotiator in his army years, had often used threats and bribery to procure cessions of land. Formalities notwithstanding, he regarded tribes resident within the states not as independent sovereign entities but as wards of the government and tenants-at-will.

The inherent conflict between tribal and state authority came to a head just as Jackson assumed office. The Cherokee nation had acquired many of the attributes of white civilization, including a written language, a newspaper, and a constitution of government. Under its treaties with the federal government, the tribe claimed sovereign authority over its territory in Georgia and adjoining states. Georgia, Alabama, and Mississippi countered by asserting state jurisdiction over their Indian domains.

Jackson backed the states. He maintained that the federal government had no right to defend the Cherokees against Georgia's encroachments. If the Indians wished to maintain their tribal government and landownership, they must remove beyond the existing states. To facilitate the removal, Jackson induced Congress in 1830 to pass a bill empowering him to lay off new Indian homelands west of the Mississippi, exchange them for current tribal holdings, purchase the Indians' capital improvements, and pay the costs of their westward transportation. This Indian Removal Act was the only major piece of legislation passed at Jackson's behest in his eight years as President.

Indian removal was so important to Jackson that he returned to Tennessee to conduct the first negotiations in person. He gave the Indians a simple alternative: submit to state authority or emigrate beyond the Mississippi. Offered generous aid on one hand and the threat of subjugation on the other, the Chickasaws and Choctaws submitted readily, the Creeks under duress. Only the Cherokees resisted to the bitter end. Tentatively in *Cherokee Nation v. Georgia* in 1831 and more forcefully in *Worcester v. Georgia* the next year, the Supreme Court upheld the tribes' independence from state authority. But these legal victories pointed out no practical course of resistance for the tribe to take. Tacitly encouraged by Jackson, Georgia ignored the rulings. Jackson cultivated a minority faction within the tribe, and signed a removal treaty with them in 1835. Though the vast majority of Cherokees rejected the treaty, those who refused to remove under its terms were finally rounded up and transplanted westward by military force in 1838, under Jackson's successor Martin Van Buren. The Cherokees' sufferings in this forced exodus became notorious as the "Trail of Tears."

Meanwhile, dozens of removal treaties closed out pockets of Indian settlement in other states and territories east of the Mississippi. A short military campaign on the upper Mississippi quelled resistance by Black Hawk's band of Sacs and Foxes in 1832, and in 1835 a long and bloody war to subdue the Seminoles in Florida began. Most of the tribes went without force.

Given the coercion that produced them, most of the removal treaties were fair and even generous. Their execution was miserable. Generally the treaties promised fair payment for the Indians' land and goods, safe transportation to the West and sustenance upon arrival, and protection for the property of those who chose to remain behind under state jurisdiction. These safeguards collapsed under pressure from corrupt contractors, unscrupulous traders, and white trespassers backed by state authority. Jackson's desire to economize and avoid trouble with the state governments further undercut federal efforts to protect the tribes. For this record he bore ultimate responsibility. Jackson did not countenance the abuses, but he did ignore them. Though usually a stickler for the precise letter of formal obligations, he made promises to the Indians that the government did not and perhaps could not fulfill.

Original Article

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Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Feller, "Andrew Jackson: Domestic Affairs."

CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.3

The Jacksonian Backlash

Mike O'Connor

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PUBLICATION	April 15, 2014
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.1, 10.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.1.1 Support; 10.1.3 Support; 10.4.2 Support

Excerpt · 1,208 words (complete article)

The following is a guest post from Mike O'Connor (the third of a series–see the first post here and the second here). Mike is one of the original USIH bloggers and a founder of the Society for U.S. Intellectual History. He is the author of A Commercial Republic: America's Enduring Debate over Democratic Capitalism, which will be published in May by the University Press of Kansas. The book's Facebook page can be found here, and information from the publisher is available here.

Like many in the early nineteenth century who called themselves "Jacksonians," Amos Kendall could boast of a rise to political prominence that would not have been possible in a previous generation. The editor of the Kentucky-based pro-Jackson vehicle Argus of Western America had served in various posts under President Jackson and his protégé and successor Martin Van Buren, exerting significant influence as a member of the "kitchen cabinet." In 1840, however, Van Buren was ejected from office upon a humiliating rebuke from the voters; as a consequence of the "spoils system" that had been initiated by Jackson himself, Kendall also lost his post.

Within a year, however, he had founded a new journal devoted to the Jacksonian message. The inaugural issue of Kendall's Expositor opened with a column dedicating the new enterprise to the defense and protection of Jacksonian principles, which include the tenet that the primary functions of government are to "to protect man in…the exercise of equal political power" and in "the unmolested enjoyment of his own labor and skill." Kendall further established that the citizens who are most likely to see this equality threatened are those who lack significant wealth. "Our aim," he declared "is to call the earnest attention of every American freeman…to the principles and measures which are calculated insidiously to…make him the dependant [sic] of the idle and the rich, who, as a necessary consequence, will assume all the political powers of society."

Many of the themes of Kendall's short manifesto might have been familiar to the Jeffersonians of a generation before. Its title, however, would not have been. The editorial was called, "What Is Democracy?"

Until the Jacksonian era, the term "democracy" had been associated with bread riots and mob rule; few among the nation's founders would have professed any desire to steer their new country by the light of that particular star. Yet the framers' intentions were soon overtaken by events. The most significant of these was the spread of what was then called "universal suffrage," a movement to eliminate the requirement that a person own property in order to vote. Marching state-by-state, by 1860 the various campaigns succeeded in eliminating these requirements from the country entirely. The universal suffrage idea did not confront racial or gender barriers to voting, but it nonetheless represented the first successful challenge to the widespread assumption that voting should be reserved for a better class of people. Spurred by this popular movement, democracy—both the word and the practice—came into favor during this period. The party of Jefferson (and Jackson) began to call itself the Democrats, and prominent books by James Fenimore Cooper (1838) and Alexis de Tocqueville (1835/40) both took as their point of departure the presumption that democracy was essential to an understanding of the contemporary United States.

Similarly, it was only in the Jacksonian era that capitalism began to assume a shape that would be familiar to modern eyes. Industry had taken hold in New England, and advances in transportation allowed for the development of nationally integrated markets. Culture and government changed as well: Americans were far more willing to move in search of land and wealth, and states competed against each other for the settlers who would stimulate economic growth. Charles Sellers summarized these

developments in 1994 by calling them a “market revolution.” In Jacksonian America, he wrote, commercial transactions came to define everyday life, exerting “capitalist hegemony over economy, politics and culture.”

Jacksonianism was a response to those conditions. Politically, it embraced the new democracy: these propertyless men, formerly disenfranchised, counted among the movement’s biggest supporters. Economically, however, the Jacksonian position was less clear, and historians have struggled and competed to convincingly define its central attribute. Arthur Schlesinger, Jr.’s Age of Jackson noted in 1945 that the Jacksonian outlook was premised on the belief “that there was a deep-rooted conflict in society between the ‘producing’ and ‘non-producing’ classes—the farmers and laborers, on the one hand, and the business community on the other.” Schlesinger argued that this class hostility made the Jacksonians proto-Progressives who tried to rein in business with regulation. More recent historians, impressed by the changes in market attitudes noted by Sellers and later writers, have suggested that Schlesinger mistook hostility toward the wealthy for hostility toward capitalism itself. On this interpretation, Jacksonians welcomed the opportunities brought by a more developed economy, and wanted to become rich themselves. But they also remembered the elitism of the Federalists, and resented wealth and status that they felt was not earned, but bestowed through political connections or other forms of government economic intervention. Under this line of interpretation, summarized Herbert Hovenkamp in his 1991 Enterprise and American Law, Jacksonian “arguments for a noninterventionist state leaned to the left, not to the right.”

Believing that government economic intervention was generally a tool used by the wealthy to game the system against the “common man,” Jacksonians sought to eliminate it entirely. The clearest expression of this mentality was their notion of “divorce,” the idea that the federal government should be kept completely separate from the workings of the private economy. This idea underwrote the central Jacksonian economic positions: hard money, general incorporation and opposition to the Second Bank of the United States. Yet a contradiction lay at the heart of this attitude: keeping the government out of the economy conflicts with the democratic impulse if the voters themselves demand public economic support.

Old Hickory himself largely escaped the political consequences of this Jacksonian paradox, but Van Buren was not so lucky. Only weeks after he took office as president, a series of banks began to fail, resulting in an economic catastrophe called the Panic of 1837. Even as citizens cried out for some governmental solution to this crisis, Van Buren could offer little more than a plan to remove federal funds from private banks. It was “apparent” to the president “that the events of the last few months have greatly augmented the desire, long existing among the people of the United States, to separate the fiscal operations of the [g]overnment from those of individuals or corporations.”

Van Buren, called by many the first professional politician in U.S. history, did not read the popular will effectively. In the election of 1840, his presidency was defined by the Panic of 1837, and Van Buren was proud to run on a Jacksonian platform. The voters had seen enough and elected William Henry Harrison, leading directly to the founding of Kendall’s Expositor.

Jacksonianism represented an attempt to revoke the Hamiltonian mandate for government economic stewardship. In the end, it was rejected by the voters and failed. From that point forward, Americans would put aside the question of whether the government should intervene in the economy, debating instead the purposes to which that intervention should be put.

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O’Connor, "The Jacksonian Backlash."

CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.4

Appeal of Forty Thousand Citizens

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PUBLICATION	2015; modified 2024
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.1
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.1.2 Support

Excerpt · 820 words (complete article)

The *Appeal of Forty Thousand Citizens, Threatened with Disfranchisement, to the People of Pennsylvania* attempted to persuade Pennsylvanians to vote against the ratification of a new state constitution in 1838 because the word "white" had been inserted prior to "freemen" as a qualification for voting. Written by African American leader Robert Purvis (1810-98), the pamphlet highlighted the achievements, sacrifices, and value of the Black community to Philadelphia.

Under Pennsylvania's first two constitutions, ratified in 1776 and 1790, Article III limited voting rights and elections to "freemen," but definitions of "freeman" varied in individual counties depending on local politics and traditions. Some understood the term "freeman" to apply only to whites, while others did not. The commonwealth's western counties, which had small populations of free Blacks, tended to allow them to vote. Eastern counties with larger populations of free Blacks–especially Philadelphia–discouraged them from voting though intimidation at the polls.

Philadelphia's free Black community, the largest and wealthiest in the state, grew in the early decades of the nineteenth century as a destination for free Blacks from the South and runaway slaves. At the same time, tension over the issue of slavery increased, especially after Nat Turner's Rebellion in Virginia in 1831 and the rise of racial abolitionism in the 1830s.

The explosive issue of race relations was one of many financial, governmental, and immigration problems facing Pennsylvania when the legislature called a convention to reform the state constitution in 1837. The convention began in May 1837 in Harrisburg but moved to Musical Fund Hall in Philadelphia for its concluding sessions in November 1837 and February 1838. Initially, delegates made no recommendations to alter the language of Article III to prohibit free Blacks from voting. But Democrat John Sterigere (1793-1852) of Montgomery County seized on public opinion against Black voting rights and proposed to the convention that the language of Article III be changed to include the word "white" prior to "freemen" in order to exclude all Blacks, even if they paid taxes or owned property.

Thomas Earle (1796-1849), a Democrat from Philadelphia County, objected to changing the language and attempted to persuade the convention to seek a compromise to temporarily suspend Black voting rights throughout the commonwealth. He lost to a larger Democratic majority, which approved the change to Article III and proposed a new Constitution of 1838 for ratification. Similar actions occurred in other states during this period as politicians attempted to prevent Blacks from gaining the same voting rights as white men, whose access to the polls was increasing with changes in voting qualifications such as reduced taxes or land-owning requirements.

Philadelphia's Black community responded to Pennsylvania's proposed constitution with the *Appeal of Forty Thousand Citizens, Threatened with Disfranchisement, to the People of Pennsylvania*. In the tradition of African American leaders such as Absalom Jones (1746-1818), Richard Allen (1760-1831), and James Forten Sr. (1766-1842), Robert Purvis emphasized the worthiness of Philadelphia's Black community. Purvis systematically presented an argument based on history, statistical data, economics, and politics to combat public misconceptions about African Americans.

The *Appeal of Forty Thousand Citizens* invoked the founding documents of Pennsylvania and the nation to argue that it would be consistent with previous generations to ensure suffrage to freemen without the mention of a specific race. The pamphlet pointed out that during the colonial period, white indentured servants as well as Black slaves were not permitted to vote because they lacked the status of freemen. "White" was not included as a qualification for voting in either the 1776 or 1790 Pennsylvania

constitutions.

To support the claims of the *Appeal of Forty Thousand Citizens,* the Pennsylvania Society for Promoting the Abolition of Slavery compiled a census as evidence that Philadelphia's Black community provided the city with revenue, laborers, and taxpayers who contributed to its economic success. The census demonstrated that compared with whites, African Americans made up a substantially lower proportion of the poor and people receiving aid. In fact, the Black community paid more to provide relief for the poor than it received in return. Purvis used the statistics to rebuke a public image of idleness. Recognizing the connection between actions in Pennsylvania and increasing racial tensions in the nation, Purvis charged the Pennsylvania Constitutional Convention with having, "laid our [Black] rights a sacrifice on the altar of slavery."

Voters ratified the Constitution of 1838 by a margin of a little more than one thousand votes—113,971 to 112,759—on October 9, 1838. African Americans continued to petition the legislature to reinstate suffrage for free Blacks, but their petitions were left unanswered. Racial tensions turned to violent riots targeting African Americans and attacks on a newly erected abolitionist meeting place, Pennsylvania Hall. Although a new generation of leaders including Jacob C. White Jr. (1837-1902) continued the fight for suffrage, African Americans in Pennsylvania did not regain the vote until the Fifteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution (1870) extended voting rights to Black men throughout the nation.

Original Article

https://philadelphiaencyclopedia.org/essays/appeal-of-forty-thousand-citizens/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.5

Nullification

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PUBLICATION	2016; updated 2022
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.2.1 Support; 10.2.2 Support; 10.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 976 words (complete article)

During the nullification crisis of 1828 to 1834, South Carolina planter politicians formulated a new brand of slavery-based politics that would culminate in the formation of the southern confederacy. The crisis, which began as a dispute over federal tariff laws, became intertwined with the politics of slavery and sectionalism. Led by John C. Calhoun, a majority of South Carolina slaveholders claimed that a state had the right to nullify or veto federal laws and secede from the Union. Nullification and secession, according to Calhoun, were the reserved rights of the states and therefore constitutional. Calhoun's constitutional theories and the overtly proslavery discourse of the nullifiers laid the political and ideological foundation for southern nationalism.

The passage of the federal tariff law of 1828 signaled the rise of the nullification controversy in South Carolina. In his famous South Carolina Exposition, which was voted down by the General Assembly, Calhoun claimed that federal import duties were actually a tax on the nation's main exporters, southern planters. Unlike free traders, who opposed the tariff or protective duties in the interest of all consumers, nullifiers claimed that the tariff hurt the South in particular. And they linked their opposition to the tariff to a proslavery position by arguing that northerners intended to interfere with the institution of slavery by impoverishing the South. Calhoun argued that nullification or state interposition would establish a constitutional precedent that would safeguard the interests of the slaveholding minority in a democratic republic. His theory of nullification innovatively combined the antidemocratic sensibility of the Federalists with the states' rights legacy of the Jeffersonians. Calhoun's justification of nullification and secession as constitutional rights of the state also went beyond traditional states' rights doctrine as they were based on an unprecedented notion of absolute state sovereignty. Most old states' righters, including James Madison, condemned nullification as an extraconstitutional and un-republican theory as it was not mentioned in the U.S. Constitution and because it subverted the cardinal principle of republican government, majority rule.

Calhoun's lieutenants in South Carolina, James Hamilton, Robert Hayne, and George McDuffie, formed the States Rights and Free Trade Party to implement nullification after Calhoun's break with President Andrew Jackson became final. Most of the Calhounites had been nationalists in state politics prior to the tariff controversy. Like Calhoun, their politics somersaulted from one of qualified nationalism to unqualified sectionalism. Older states' rights leaders such as William Smith, John Taylor, and David Rogerson Williams helped to form the opposition Union Party, which also contained Jacksonian Democrats such as Joel Poinsett and Benjamin Perry, and staunch unionists such as James L. Petigru. While the nullifiers gained many adherents in the state's large black belt that encompassed the lowcountry and the lower Piedmont, the base of the Union Party lay in the nonplantation northwestern districts of the state. In order to call a state convention to nullify the federal tariff laws of 1828 and 1832, nullifiers launched a campaign that emphasized sectionalism, the defense of slavery, and opposition to majority rule. Unionists on the other hand appealed to loyalty to the Union and the American experiment in republican government. They also criticized the undemocratic stranglehold of the lowcountry elite on state government. The nullifiers gained the upper hand as they had the support of a majority of the slaveholding planter class that dominated the state's government. Unionists lost the closely contested state legislature elections of 1832. The nullifiers' victory allowed them to dominate the malapportioned General Assembly. Having gained a two-thirds majority in the legislature, nullifiers proceeded to call a convention and enact an ordinance of nullification and oaths of allegiance to the state in order to implement nullification in defiance of federal law.

Upon nullification, however, South Carolina found itself politically isolated in the nation. Even most southern states refused to follow her lead. In a proclamation against nullification, President Jackson endorsed the vision of a perpetual and democratic

Union and challenged the constitutionality of nullification and secession, creating an important precedent for Lincoln. Like his proto-Whig rivals Daniel Webster and Henry Clay, Jackson condemned nullification as disunionist. The president also secured the passage of the Wilkins Act, which gave him powers to implement federal tariff laws in South Carolina. Most southern states remained loyal to the party of Jackson, but some prominent members of the slaveholding chivalry–especially in Georgia and Virginia–sympathized with the nullifiers and were wary of Jackson's new nationalism. In the end Calhoun cooperated with Clay to secure the passage of the compromise tariff law of 1833 in Congress.

The state convention rescinded its ordinance of nullification but issued another ordinance nullifying the Wilkins Act, which nullifiers referred to as the Force Bill. The controversy continued in the state, however, as Unionists opposed the new oaths of allegiance enacted by nullifiers. Unionist argued that "test oaths" were unrepublican, as they would stymie freedom of opinion and political dissent in the state. The state court of appeals also declared the oaths unconstitutional, leading some nullifiers to advocate the abolition of the court, which they succeeded in doing in 1835. A compromise reached between leading nullifiers and Unionists, stating that an oath of allegiance to the state was consistent with the loyalty to the U.S. Constitution, finally brought the crisis to an end in South Carolina in 1834. The aftermath of nullification proved fatal to the Unionists, and Calhoun's political machine in South Carolina dominated state politics until his death.

Nullification crystallized South Carolina's early ideological commitment to slavery and southern nationalism. The politics of slavery and separatism inaugurated by nullifiers checked democratic reform and prevented the growth of a two-party system in the state, making South Carolina exceptional even in the context of southern politics. The Carolina doctrine presented an alternative to Jacksonian democracy and party system in the South and finally triumphed when most of the southern states seceded from the Union in 1860–1861.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.6

John C. Calhoun and American Disunion

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PUBLICATION	April 23, 2018
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.2.1 Support; 10.2.2 Support; 10.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,086 words

Once described by historian David Potter as "the most majestic champion of error since Milton's Satan," John C. Calhoun (1782-1850) played a central role in the sectional conflict over slavery that divided the United States during the first half of the nineteenth century and that would eventually result in the Civil War after his death. This digital collection includes materials held by the Newberry Library related to Calhoun and the sectional crisis from a variety of different perspectives.

It was during his term as Jackson's Vice-President that Calhoun drew on arguments first made Thomas Jefferson and James Madison in the Virginia an Kentucky Resolutions to craft his doctrine of "state interposition" or nullification"

Born to Scots-Irish immigrants in the backcountry of South Carolina in 1782, Calhoun was educated at Yale and elected to Congress in 1810. He played a central role in the War of 1812 as one of the "War Hawks," a nationalistic group of young politicians who favored a vigorous defense of American sovereignty against the British. After the war Calhoun served as Secretary of War in the Monroe administration from 1817 until 1824. During his tenure as Secretary of War Calhoun was responsible for modernizing the United States military and for dealing with Indian relations. While harboring his own presidential ambitions, and initially entering the presidential race in 1824, Calhoun eventually served as Vice-President under both John Quincy Adams and Andrew Jackson.

It was during his term as Jackson's Vice-President that Calhoun drew on arguments first made by Thomas Jefferson and James Madison in the Virginia and Kentucky Resolutions to craft his doctrine of "state interposition" or nullification, provoking a showdown between South Carolina and the national government in 1832. The immediate cause of the crisis was a tariff passed in 1828, the so-called "Tariff of Abominations," which many southerners viewed as violating the constitution's requirement that all taxation be applied equally since it protected northern manufactures at the expense of southern plantation owners, who had to buy manufactured goods at artificially inflated prices while they sold their cotton on an open market. As Calhoun argued, first in his South Carolina Exposition and Protest (1828) and then in his Fort Hill Address (1831), South Carolina had the right to nullify the tariff because the federal Union was a "compact" of sovereign entities, the states, who had reserved for themselves any powers not expressly given to the federal government. Calhoun argued that since the states preceded the creation of federal government by the United States Constitution, and since they had agreed to it only for the purposes expressed in the constitution, they had the power to reject as unconstitutional laws passed by Congress. Many of Calhoun's contemporaries, including Senator Daniel Webster of Massachusetts, strongly disagreed with Calhoun's arguments in a series of the most famous debates in American history. The crisis only ended when a compromise, brokered by Henry Clay, emerged in which South Carolina agreed to a revised tariff in which duties on imported goods would decrease steadily.

Although slavery was also the proximate cause of the constitutional debate over tariffs, Calhoun soon focused his energy directly on the issue of slaveholders' rights in the Union. Parting with an earlier generation of southerners who viewed slavery as a necessary evil, as a U.S. Senator during the 1830s Calhoun formulated a defense of the peculiar institution as a "positive good" in a white democracy and became the foremost advocate of slaveholders' right to carry their peculiar form of property into the new territories added by American imperialism in Mexico and the West. Responding to increasing pressure from a coalition of anti-slavery forces, including abolitionists and free soilers, Calhoun committed the South to a position on slavery that allowed little room for compromise.

At the end of his life, as the revolutions of 1848 raged in Europe and arguments over California statehood revealed a stark sectional divide in the United States, Calhoun set down his political philosophy in two of the most controversial and consequential treatises in American history, A Disquisition on Government and A Discourse on the Constitution and Government of the United States, both published posthumously. In these, Calhoun laid the philosophical groundwork for secession and made the argument that every group in a society should possess ironclad veto power in any legislative process, an idea that he called the concurrent majority. After his death, Calhoun's ideas became central to southern arguments for secession during the 1850s.

Calhoun is often portrayed in American history textbooks as an outmoded, if brilliant, reactionary who made arguments about states' rights, secession, and slavery that had no place in a modern world that progressed steadily toward nationalism and broad definitions of human rights and freedoms. And yet still today secession remains one of the most explosive issues facing modern constitutional democracies. As recently as 2017 Catalonia, a region of Spain, voted to secede, sparking a constitutional crisis. And according to the Harvard historian David Armitage, of the 484 separate wars that were fought between 1816 and 2001, 296 were civil wars, and 109 of those were fought for the right to secede from an existing state in order to create a new one. Some contemporary philosophers, such as Washington University's Christopher Wellmon, have argued for a right to self-determination as a primary right that should privilege the desire of groups or regions within existing nation-states to peacefully secede if they fulfill certain criteria. In this context, Calhoun's arguments seem frighteningly relevant and strikingly modern. Indeed, he was one of the first political thinkers in the era of the modern nation state to struggle with the question of how a modern nation can be unmade.

Furthermore, the legacies of Calhoun's arguments about slavery, like the legacy of slavery itself, are still very much with us today. Calhoun's argument for slavery as a positive good, based on the racial inferiority of black people, continued to be defended long after the Civil War ended the actual institution of slavery, helping to justify legalized segregation in the South and the North. And while Calhoun's arguments about slavery as a "positive good" may seem positively medieval, recent historians like Sven Beckert have shown that in the decades after Calhoun's death similar arguments were used to justify European domination of dark-skinned peoples in far-flung parts of the globe as part of a global "Empire of Cotton" that created modern capitalism and lasted into the twentieth century. So, whether we like it or not, John C. Calhoun is still very much with us today.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.7

Calhoun, John C.

Yasuhiro Katagiri

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ARGUMENT ROLES	10.2.1 Support; 10.2.2 Support; 10.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,101 words

As a politician and political philosopher of constitution, federalism, and state sovereignty, John Caldwell Calhoun (1782–1850) was the most preeminent spokesperson for the antebellum South. Born near Calhoun Mills, Abbeville District (presently Mount Carmel, McCormick County), in the South Carolina upcountry on March 18, 1782, Calhoun graduated from Yale College in 1804. After his education in the North, Calhoun returned home, practiced law, and served as a member of the South Carolina House of Representatives from 1808 to 1809.

At the age of 28, Calhoun entered the national political arena and represented South Carolina in the U.S. House of Representatives from 1811 to 1817, when he resigned to become the secretary of war. An ardent nationalist during this early period of his political career, Calhoun distinguished himself as one of the "War Hawks." Using his influence as acting chair of the House Committee on Foreign Relations, Calhoun urged the War of 1812 with Great Britain to redeem the honor of his country in the face of Britain's disregard of American neutral rights. After the war, Calhoun proposed several reconstruction measures in support of Representative Henry Clay's nation-building program known as the American System. He advocated chartering the Second Bank of the United States to stabilize the necessary currency and encouraged federal spending for internal improvements to build a nationwide network of roads and canals. Calhoun also supported the Tariff of 1816 to eliminate the increased national debt due to the war and to protect his country's fledgling industry. Though unknown to Calhoun then, the tariff issue was soon to ignite an inflammatory controversy.

Having served as secretary of war under President James Monroe's administration from 1817 to 1825, Calhoun became vice president of the United States in 1825 under the administration of President John Quincy Adams. It was during his first term as vice president when the tariff issue eventually came to the forefront, exposing the emerging economic conflicts between the North and the South. The cotton planters throughout South Carolina and the rest of the agrarian South, who detested a protective tariff to ensure their staple exportation overseas, began to perceive that a series of federal tariff policies was only designed to protect the industrial interests in the North at the expense of the cotton-producing southern states. When the Tariff of 1828, which became widely known as the Tariff of Abominations, was enacted, the tariff issue was no longer an economic issue alone. It now also encompassed the old debate as to the extent of federal power in the young union. Calhoun's nationalist sentiments were gradually strained, and he turned himself into a states' rights advocate and sectionalist.

Responding to his constituents' rising criticism of the federal tariff policies and also sensing the bleak prospect of disunion advanced in his native state, Calhoun anonymously penned the South Carolina Exposition and Protest for the state legislature during the summer and fall of 1828. While finding himself in the grave dilemma of privately thwarting the tariff measure enacted by the administration that he was a part of as vice president, Calhoun looked for a constitutional alternative to possible revolutionary action. Resurrecting the compact theory embodied in the language of the 1798 Kentucky and Virginia Resolutions fathered by Thomas Jefferson and James Madison respectively, Calhoun advanced the doctrine of nullification. In the South Carolina Exposition, Calhoun argued that the U.S. Constitution was a compact among the states and that each state could not only interpose (that is, block) its authority between the citizens of that state and the laws of the United States, but also nullify (that is, overrule) such laws and actions as being unconstitutional and inoperative in the state. Calhoun's Exposition thus became a standard of revolt against the American System of protective tariffs and a clarion call for devising constitutional safeguards to protect the South's impinged minority interests from the abuse of federal power.

In 1828, Calhoun was reelected vice president with President Andrew Jackson. To the dismay of Calhoun and southern cotton planters, Congress failed to reduce the tariff rate under the new administration. When some South Carolinians became restless and threatened to vindicate the doctrine of nullification, Calhoun issued an open letter entitled “On the Relation which the States and General Government Bear to Each Other,” more popularly known as the “Fort Hill Address,” in the summer of 1831. Using the words “interposition,” “veto,” and “nullification” interchangeably, Calhoun, no longer anonymously, warned that unless some constitutional checks were administered, the sectional conflicts would become interminable, leading eventually to “the dissolution of the Union itself.” When the new Tariff of 1832 provided for reduced tariff revenues but retained the approximately 50 percent rate on cotton and woolen clothing, a special convention of the South Carolina legislature finally formulated its “South Carolina Ordinance of Nullification” in November 1832, proclaiming that the tariff was “null” and “void” within the state. In response, President Jackson denounced nullification as unconstitutional and asked Congress in the following month to enact a “Force Bill” to enforce tariff collections in South Carolina by sending federal troops.

In late December 1832, Calhoun resigned as vice president during South Carolina’s Nullification crisis. Immediately after he left the Jackson administration, Calhoun took a seat as a U.S. senator to defend his state’s position and continually served in that capacity until his death in 1850, except for a brief period when he was appointed as secretary of state. By then, the slavery controversy—an entangling issue with the South’s slave-plantation economy—had become a predominant concern for Calhoun. It was in his 1837 address to the Senate entitled “Speech on the Reception of Abolition Petitions” that Calhoun contributed to the development of the South’s proslavery argument, terming slavery as “a positive good.” As the secretary of state under President John Tyler’s administration from 1844 to 1845, Calhoun negotiated the annexation of Texas and justified it as a means to expand the area open to slavery. Back to the Senate, Calhoun denounced the proposed Compromise of 1850 on the ground that the measure would not adequately protect the South’s slavery interests. Calhoun prepared his last address to the Senate in the midst of the debate over this compromise sponsored by Senator Henry Clay. On March 4, 1850, Calhoun, too ill to deliver the address himself, asked Senator James M. Mason from Virginia to read it for him. Sensing that the union was now “lying dangerously ill,” the dying senator made his final plea that the responsibility of saving the union rested on the North. Only four weeks later, on March 31, 1850, Calhoun passed away in Washington, D.C., at the age of 68.

Original Article

https://encyclopedia.federalism.org/index.php/Calhoun,_John_C.

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.8

Robert Y. Hayne, Reply to Daniel Webster, January 21 and 25, 1830

Robert C. Byrd

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PUBLICATION	n.d. (introduction reprinted from a 1994 Senate volume)
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.2.2 Support; 10.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,016 words (complete article)

The "greatest debate in the history of the Senate" began on January 18, 1830, and concluded nine days later, on January 27. Missouri's Thomas Hart Benton triggered the oratorical eruption on January 18 and was followed sympathetically on the nineteenth by South Carolina's Robert Y. Hayne. Daniel Webster of Massachusetts responded--briefly by his standards--to Benton and Hayne on the twentieth. On January 21 and 25 Hayne challenged Webster's arguments.

Small and slender, possessed of a refined and charming manner, Robert Y. Hayne entered the Senate in 1823 when he was only thirty-one years old, one year above the constitutional threshold for Senate service. Previously, he had served as speaker of the South Carolina house of representatives and as that state's attorney general. A protégé of John C. Calhoun, Hayne brought with him a reputation as a polished orator, a master of sustained argument, and a man of keen intelligence. He would greatly expand his oratorical fame during his nearly ten years in the Senate.

After the War of 1812, manufacturing interests in the Northeast increased pressure on Congress to enact tariff legislation that would protect their products against foreign competition. This came at a time when the South was beginning to perceive that its economic future lay not in manufacturing goods but in supplying raw materials--particularly slave-cultivated cotton. Thus, as the northern states moved toward embracing protective tariffs, the South was moving away from them. This shift guaranteed sectional confrontation in the national legislative arena.

Protectionism and sectional discord reached a high point in 1828 with passage of the so-called Tariff of Abominations. The 1828 tariff led John C. Calhoun to assert the right of states to nullify unpopular laws, borrowing arguments from the 1798 Virginia and Kentucky Resolutions of James Madison and Thomas Jefferson and from New England's opposition to the Embargo Act of 1807.

The first session of the Twenty-first Congress, meeting from December 7, 1829, until May 31, 1830, during the first year of Andrew Jackson's presidency, produced a political sea change and renewed intense debate on the proper role of the federal government. On December 29, 1829, Connecticut Senator Samuel Foot sparked a session-long forensic explosion with his proposal to limit western land sales. Missouri Senator Thomas Hart Benton, a vigorous defender of western interests, swiftly attacked the proposal as a diabolical plan to safeguard cheap labor in the Northeast by shutting off opportunities for that region's oppressed labor force to escape to the developing West. Benton devised a strategy to link the South and West in common alliance against domination by northeastern interests. He believed that the South would cooperate in return for western votes to repeal the Tariff of Abominations.

Robert Y. Hayne, in his January 19 address, called for an end to land sales by the federal government--a policy he viewed as enriching the national treasury to the North's corrupt benefit while draining wealth from the West. He argued that the states should have the power to control their own lands and to set aside federal laws they believed were not in their best interests.

Webster's relatively brief response on January 20 confronted Hayne's states' rights theme and succeeded in shifting the debate from the narrow issues of the tariff and public land policy to the more cosmic concerns of slavery and the very nature of the Union. Recognizing the West's discomfort with slavery and its need for a stable union to promote regional development, Webster directed his oratorical blows toward dividing the two regions. He cast New England as the West's ally, noting that

Nathan Dane, a New Englander, had written the Ordinance of 1787 that established a government for the Northwest Territory and outlawed slavery there. He attacked Hayne for his apparent willingness to preserve the Union "while it suits local and temporary purposes" and to dissolve it "whenever it shall be found to thwart such purposes."

The thirty-eight-year-old Hayne entered the packed Senate chamber on January 21 to launch his reply to Webster. Appearing boyish in a suit of coarse homespun, Hayne spoke for several hours and then, following a long weekend, concluded his remarks. Responding in a tone of "scarcely suppressed bitterness and rage," he received perpetual encouragement and handwritten notes from Vice President John C. Calhoun, who was presiding over the Senate. Daniel Webster sat impassively nearby, making notes and predicting to his allies that when the time. came for his response, he would "grind [Hayne] as fine as a pinch of snuff."

Hayne charged that the North was seeking to destroy the South through its recent conversion to high protective tariffs and its increasingly vocal opposition to slavery. He attacked Webster's inconsistency on the tariff and reminded his listeners that the doctrine of nullification counted among its advocates Madison and Jefferson, as well as Webster and those in New England who supported the Hartford Convention during the War of 1812. Hayne argued that the South, which had "everything to lose and nothing to gain," fought the war for "the protection of Northern shipping and New England seamen," while Webster's allies, "the war party in peace, and the peace party in war," sought to escape the burdens of that conflict.

Hayne's political theory stressed the sovereignty of the individual states, which had voluntarily ceded limited power to the central government. He believed that when the government unconstitutionally encroached on a state's sovereignty, that state could legitimately oppose the action until three-quarters of the states ratified a clarifying amendment to the Constitution. Although the subsequent course of American history has sustained Webster's nationalist arguments, the Hayne-Calhoun states' rights doctrine assumed great significance during the three decades that followed the Webster-Hayne exchange.

In December 1832, as the issues of nullification and states' rights assumed crisis proportions, Hayne resigned from the Senate, permitting Calhoun to trade the silence of the vice presidency for the unfettered oratorical license available to a United States senator. Hayne served as governor of South Carolina until 1834; as Charleston's first mayor, from 1835 to 1837; and as president of a local railroad until his death in 1839 at the age of forty-seven.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.9

Isaac McCoy

Kansas Historical Society

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WEBSITE	Kansapedia, Kansas Historical Society
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ARGUMENT ROLES	10.3.1 Support

Excerpt · 808 words (complete article)

The son of William and Elizabeth (Rice) McCoy, Isaac McCoy was born June 13, 1784, in Uniontown, Pennsylvania. The family moved to Louisville, Kentucky, when he was five, then a few years later to Shelby County, Kentucky, where his father served as a Baptist minister. The young McCoy was inspired to become a missionary to American Indians.

He married Christiana Polke in on October 6, 1803, in Shelby County, Kentucky. They had 14 children; only four survived into adulthood. McCoy became a part-time minister for the Silver Creek Baptist Church in 1808 in Vincennes, Indiana. The next year he was hired as paster of the maria Creek Church, and in 1810 he was ordained a Baptist minister. Seven years later he was sent by the Baptist Board of Foreign Missions to work with the Miami people, who were living on the Wabash River, 16 miles north of Terre Haute, Indiana.

McCoy established Carey Mission among the Potawatomis on the St. Joseph River in December 1822 near Niles, Michigan. Four years later he founded Thomas Mission among the Ottawas near present Grand Rapids. He felt the need for a permanent Indian country where tribes could be free from the "corrupting influences attending association with the frontier people of that early period." He suggested a removal of Eastern tribes to the West. In June 1824 McCoy went to Washington to submit his proposal to the board, which was impressed with his ideas and suggested that he present them to the president. McCoy was unable to obtain an audience but he did have conversations with John C. Calhoun, the secretary of war, who was in charge of Indian affairs. Calhoun received McCoy's proposals with enthusiasm and became one of their strongest advocates.

Emigration of Eastern tribes to the territories west of the Mississippi had begun many years before. Members of the Shawnee and Delaware tribes settled in Louisiana Territory near Cape Girardeau as early as 1793. In 1809 a part of the Cherokee tribe located on the waters of the Arkansas and White rivers in Missouri territory while portions of the Choctaw and Creek tribes settled on the Arkansas and Red rivers. No official government action took place prior to McCoy's proposal.

In November 1827 McCoy again met with the board and he prepared a pamphlet for members of Congress and governmental departments. McCoy spent two months lobbying for a removal act. Opposition came from groups that felt the Indian people would be cheated of their ancestral homes and given instead an area considered by many to be nothing more than desert. Questions about slavery and white settlement north of the compromise line led to the removal proposal being defeated in 1828.

Exploration was approved and McCoy and George H. Kennedy of St. Louis were sent along with delegations of Choctaws, Creeks, Chickasaws, Potawatomis, and Ottawas to examine the country. On August 21, 1828, McCoy, Kennerly, and the Potawatomis and Ottawas left St. Louis for the Osage river. Following the Osage up to its headwaters, they crossed over to the Neosho, which they followed out to its source. Moving up to the Kansas River they then returned along its south bank to the Missouri boundary, visiting some new settlements of Shawnees in what is now Johnson County, Kansas.

McCoy gained an intimate knowledge of the country and noted it was "far better than I had expected." His report was submitted to the secretary of war in January 1829. The measure was approved on May 28, 1830. The Indian Removal act authorized the president "to cause so much of any territory belonging to the United States, west of the River Mississippi, not included in any State or organized Territory, and to which the Indian title had been extinguished, as he may judge necessary, to be divided into a suitable number of districts, for the reception of such tribes or nations of Indians as may choose to exchange the lands where they now reside, and remove there; and to cause each of said districts to be so described by natural or artificial marks, as to be

easily distinguished from every other."

In fall 1829 McCoy made his third trip to the territory, visiting the Kansa people and exploring the surrounding area. After the bill passed McCoy closed his missions in the East and transferred them to the new territory in preparation for the move West. McCoy was joined by missionaries Jotham Meeker, Johnston Lykins, Robert Simerwell, and their wives.

For the next 10 years McCoy worked for the government in the Indian country, selecting and surveying locations for the immigrant Indians and establishing and maintaining missions and schools. In 1842 he moved to Louisville, Kentucky, to direct the American Indian Mission Association, a society that he himself had organized. He continued in this work until his death June 21 1846, in Louisville, Kentucky.

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.10

Andrew Jackson's Reputation Is Changing Again

Steve Inskeep

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ARGUMENT ROLES	10.3.1 Support; 10.3.2 Support; 10.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,018 words

Martin Van Buren was right. He made a prediction after the death of Andrew Jackson, whom he had served as a close advisor for many years. Thinking of all the trials they had endured together, Van Buren said that most controversies that "agitated the public mind in their day" would fade from memory. But one issue would be different. When it came to pushing American Indians out of their homelands and west of the Mississippi in the 1830's, the emotions aroused by Jackson's acts would probably "endure . . . as long as the government itself."

The policy called Indian removal has indeed inspired a centuries-long argument. Each generation of Americans has interpreted it differently—arguing at different times that it was inevitable, tragic, mass murder, better left unexamined, or, in the words of an early Jackson biographer, "wise and humane." Reviewing more than 150 years of popular history about the early nineteenth century reveals how many times the story has changed. This says a lot about Jackson, and even more about the rest of us. In telling the same story in different ways, we are trying to define who we are as a people. Today the United States is changing, becoming dramatically more diverse. That growing diversity demands that we explore the story once again for this generation.

It's not hard to understand why Indian removal became as iconic as Van Buren expected. We may intellectually grasp other vital parts of Jackson's legacy, like establishing the strong presidency. But Indian removal is something we feel. The only thing I still recall learning about Jackson in public school is that he had something to do with the Trail of Tears. The details stick with a kid: Cherokees who'd taken up white men's clothing, houses and agriculture, but were rousted by white soldiers off their farms. In recent months, Jackson's policy toward natives was the main reason a campaign to put a woman on American currency specifically targeted the man on the $20 bill. Last month the NPR correspondent Mara Liasson, who is on the board of the Andrew Jackson Foundation, publicly defended Jackson's position on the $20. One of the varied responses on Twitter read: "Way to take a stand, defending a genocidal warmonger."

It was very different 150 years ago, or even fifty.

The basic facts have not changed, although some new ones have lately been found. It's mainly a question of emphasis. Jackson, a hero of the rising American democracy, took land from Indians throughout his career. He first emerged on the national stage in 1814, when his army defeated Creek rebels in what is now Alabama. Unable to force the last of the rebels to surrender, Jackson imposed a peace treaty on Creeks who had taken his side, forcing his friends to give up 23 million acres in Georgia and the future state of Alabama. Later General Jackson negotiated additional treaties obtaining land for the United States. Jackson and his friends purchased key plots themselves, colonizing the territory with cotton plantations worked by slave labor. Elected President in 1828, he soon signed the Indian Removal Act, which promised to pay for the "voluntary" relocation of natives to new land west of the Mississippi. Jackson said they must move for their own good, to escape the "mercenary" influence of land-grabbing white men. Creeks and Chickasaws sadly moved; Creeks and Seminoles staged bloody rebellions. Cherokees peacefully fought for years through the democratic system, appealing through Congress and the Supreme Court. At last a breakaway Cherokee faction signed a removal treaty, and the troops came.

The writer who called Jackson's policy "wise and humane" was Jackson's first great biographer, the British author James Parton, whose three-volume work was published in 1860, when the country was about to fall into civil war. Parton cast his subject as the hero of the Union, a short-tempered patriot who turned his violent tendencies to brilliant ends. Jackson won the Battle of New Orleans in 1815, and as president stared down South Carolina when it attempted to nullify Federal laws. Parton did not shy away

from Jackson's brutality, but Indian removal was of little interest. The biographer relied on one of Jackson's old allies to tell him that it had all worked out well for the Indians.

It was the South that most ardently wanted the Indians gone (The North, more advanced in displacing its own native population, could afford to urge the South to be more generous.) After Cherokees modernized their government in 1827, drafting a constitution at their capital within Georgia, the state declared it to be an infringement on state sovereignty and accelerated its campaign for the Cherokees' departure. Georgia triggered the Trail, making way for the farms of poor white settlers and wealthier families with enslaved laborers. Indian removal was understood to be part of the creation story of the South, and after the Civil War, in the Reconstruction period, distinctively Southern perspectives of this history emerged.

Division and Reunion, a popular history of the United States published in 1893, declared that white men "very naturally" would not tolerate red men setting up a government in their midst. The book left out that Cherokees had governed themselves on the same land for centuries. And it all but excused subverting the law to remove them. The author was Woodrow Wilson, and his history was still in print after he was elected president in 1912. A Georgia school textbook in 1913 said slave owners "were as religious, moral, high-minded a race of men who ever lived," and described the removal of Creeks and Cherokees as an obvious practical response to the problem that their land was needed for white settlement.

But there had always been dissenting opinions, and gradually the acts Wilson called "natural" became controversial. The Great Depression made it acceptable to question the history that Americans had been teaching each other. Scholars and writers in the 1930's highlighted the cruelties of Indian removal; a leader was Grant Foreman, whose Indian Removal quoted extensively from a late nineteenth-century ethnographer who had lived among the Cherokees in their new home in Oklahoma.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.11

Trail of Tears, or Nunna-da-ul-tsun-yi

Ben Harris McClary

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PUBLICATION	2017; updated 2018
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.3
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.3.2 Support

Excerpt · 871 words (complete article)

The Trail of Tears (or Nunna-da-ul-tsun-yi in the Cherokee language: “the place were they cried”), next to the practice of black slavery, is arguably the most tragic story in Tennessee history. Covering the period from May 1838 to March 1839, the Trail of Tears was the federal government’s final, forceful effort to remove the Cherokees from the land on which they lived in upper Georgia and southeastern Tennessee.

After the American Revolution, white settlers had pressed westward with little regard for the Native Americans until, by 1819, the new Americans claimed over 90 percent of the land east of the Mississippi River. Whites perceived the Cherokees as the most prominent obstacle blocking their claims in parts of Tennessee, Georgia, North Carolina, and Alabama. The Cherokees had developed an agricultural economy (based in part on black slave labor) and had established a constitutional republic patterned after the United States. The capital, New Echota in northern Georgia, promised to be a center of cultural activity with increasing educational opportunities for the Cherokees.

In 1828 Andrew Jackson, whose pioneer experiences had resulted in deep resentment against all Native Americans, was elected president of the United States. In his inaugural address, Jackson called for the relocation of all eastern Indians beyond the Mississippi River. A popular idea among white settlers, this presidential wish became federal law with the passage of the Indian Removal Act in 1830.

Compounding the problems of the Cherokees was the discovery of gold in Dahlonega, Georgia. Georgia officials immediately began devising a system of lotteries to distribute the Cherokee land and its supposed riches to white settlers. Suddenly denied the right to conduct tribal business under Georgia law, the Cherokees moved their capital to Red Clay, just across the Tennessee border. Not to be outdone, however, the Georgia governor allowed a minority group, led by Major Ridge, to gather at New Echota in December 1835 to sign a treaty ceding all eastern Cherokee holdings to the United States for $5 million and land west of the Mississippi River. Although the lawful Red Clay representatives protested the treaty through every legal channel, the U.S. Senate ratified the Treaty of New Echota on May 23, 1836, by a single vote.

Accepting what they considered to be inevitable, Major Ridge and some other pragmatic Cherokees salvaged what they could and proceeded at their discretion to their new homeland. But the majority, led by John Ross, refused to believe the federal government would resort to force to remove them from their ancestral land.

They were wrong. After two years of pleas and threats from various United States agencies, the roundup of the Cherokees began in May 1838 with seven thousand soldiers under the command of General Winfield Scott. The Cherokees were taken–young and old, poor and rich, along with their black slaves–with whatever possessions they could quickly gather before whites rushed in to claim their lottery winnings or to plunder what the unfortunate prisoners had been unable to take. The captives were taken to collection camps where most of them languished all summer while Indian representatives, most notably John Ross, and General Scott struggled with procedures for effecting their deportation.

Originally the plan called for transporting the Cherokees by keel boats constructed for that purpose by the federal government. The proposed water route followed the Tennessee River to the Mississippi River, then up the Arkansas River to the new Cherokee territory. During the summer, three groups did leave by water from present-day Chattanooga, but they experienced great difficulty because drought had reduced the river levels. As finally organized by Ross, the mass of the Cherokees traveled by

land, the first group leaving on August 28, 1838. They were followed at intervals by twelve other groups, each numbering approximately one thousand Cherokees and blacks. The “Trail,” in fact, included three routes. One crossed Tennessee to Memphis, then moved along the Arkansas River to Cherokee land. A second route went from Fort Payne, Alabama, through West Tennessee to Missouri, then down through Arkansas to Oklahoma. The third progressed through Nashville to Kentucky, Illinois, and Missouri before dropping down near the northwestern corner of Arkansas.

Escorted by soldiers on horseback, the Cherokees were not prepared for the weather or the trauma of their trek. Lacking adequate clothing and food, often moving in deplorable weather conditions, more and more fell along the way. Each campsite served as a new burial ground, while the survivors moved on. Of the original estimated fourteen thousand marchers, it is believed that over four thousand died before reaching their destination.

Long relegated to a brief reference in American history texts, the Trail of Tears has now been brought to the forefront of American awareness as Native American cultures have begun to receive the appreciation and status they deserve. In 1987 the U.S. Congress established the Trail of Tears National Historic Trail, which is administered by the National Park Service with the cooperation of a wide range of interested parties, including the Cherokee Nation. The Trial of Tears Association, a nonprofit organization with headquarters in Little Rock, Arkansas, was founded in 1993 to work closely with the National Park Service in identifying and marking all of the land routes used in the forced march westward.

Original Article

https://tennesseeencyclopedia.net/entries/trail-of-tears-or-nunna-da-ul-tsun-yi/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

McClary, "Trail of Tears."

CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.12

Creek Indian Removal

Christopher Haveman

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PUBLICATION	2009; updated 2024
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.3
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.3.2 Support

Excerpt · 1,116 words

The Creek Nation was once one of the largest and most powerful Indian groups in the Southeast. At their peak, the Creeks controlled millions of acres of land in the present-day states of Georgia, Alabama, and Florida. Much of this land, however, was lost or stolen as the federal government sought land for white settlement after the American Revolution. Creek lands were taken through cessions in treaties, through scams by land speculators, through outright theft by squatters, and also through clandestine arrangements between Creek headmen and federal agents. By 1836, most Creeks had relocated voluntarily or been forced to remove to Indian Territory, as the present-day state of Oklahoma was known at the time.

On February 12, 1825, Coweta headman William McIntosh signed the Treaty of Indian Springs, which ceded all the Lower Creek land in Georgia and a large tract in Alabama to the federal government. In return, McIntosh and his followers received $200,000 and land in present-day Oklahoma. Most Creeks were overwhelmingly opposed to the land cession, and the sale of land without the approval of the Creek National Council was punishable by death under Creek law. Thus, in May 1825 McIntosh was executed at one of his plantations on the Chattahoochee River.

A delegation of Creeks also travelled to Washington, D.C., to try to nullify the treaty. A federal investigation of the treaty arrangements revealed that McIntosh did not have the support of the National Council and that Creeks were deeply opposed to the terms. On January 24, 1826, the Treaty of Indian Springs was nullified, and Creek leaders signed the Treaty of Washington, marking the only time that a ratified treaty with an Indian nation was overturned. The Treaty of Washington restored Creek land within Alabama but allowed the state of Georgia to keep ceded Creek lands. The treaty affected only the Lower Creeks, whose towns were clustered along the Chattahoochee and Flint Rivers. The Upper Creeks, who were further west, near present-day Montgomery, did not lose any land.

Emigration to Oklahoma

In late 1827, 703 Creeks, including 86 slaves, began their emigration to Fort Gibson in present-day Oklahoma (near present-day Muscogee). These emigrants were primarily supporters of William McIntosh and most were from McIntosh's town of Coweta or its satellite town of Thlakatchka, although a number of other Creek towns also were represented. The emigrants rendezvoused briefly at Harpersville, just southeast of present-day Birmingham, before moving north to Tuscumbia. There, a large group of women, children, and elderly men boarded keelboats for their trip on the Tennessee, Ohio, and Mississippi rivers to Memphis. The remaining men, along with a number of women and children, continued by land to Memphis, where the parties reunited. From there, the keelboats continued by water to Fort Gibson, as the other party travelled by land, despite heavy rainfall that made the roads muddy and slowed their progress considerably. In some instances, the wagons containing their possessions could not be ferried across the many swollen rivers and were left behind. By the time the land party arrived at Fort Gibson in February 1828, agents observed that the emigrants were utterly worn down from the journey.

More voluntary emigrations followed. Almost a year after the first McIntosh party left Alabama, a second party of about 400 McIntosh supporters and their slaves travelled approximately the same route to the west. In 1829, a larger party of about 1,200 Creeks emigrated to present-day Oklahoma. Some of these Creeks were supporters of McIntosh; others were Creeks who had previously resided on land that now belonged to Georgia. Still others felt threatened by white settlers who illegally squatted on their land. The party left Alabama from Fort Bainbridge and Line Creek in east-central Alabama in June 1829. Like the two

previous emigrations, the 1829 party also took land and water routes. While on the Arkansas River, the steamboat Virginia ran aground, and many of the emigrants lost property in the river.

Suffering in the West

The last of the travelers arrived in the West in September 1829, in the midst of a cholera epidemic. Indeed, disease was so rampant that many people packed their belongings and returned to Alabama. Those who stayed suffered raids by Western Indians who invaded Creek settlements at night. A delegation of Chickasaw, who were exploring the west for possible emigration, observed that the Creek emigrants were "in a poor condition" and were "continually mourning for the land of their births."

Back in Alabama, the remaining Creeks also were suffering. As a result of continual white encroachment on Creek land, a number of prominent chiefs travelled to Washington to negotiate an agreement that they hoped would salvage the Creek Nation. The Treaty of Cusseta, signed in March 1832, traded the Creeks' sovereign claim to their land in exchange for legal title to their land. Parcels of 640 acres for chiefs and 320 acres for everyone else were issued to Creek families, who could then sell them or remain on them for as long as they wished. Despite the appeal of land reserves, the Treaty of Washington failed to accomplish almost all of the goals it set out to achieve. Whites continued to encroach on Creek land, and when Creeks tried to sell their reserves they often were cheated by unscrupulous land speculators.

Second Creek War

Amidst these troubles, two more voluntary emigrating parties left Alabama in 1834 and 1835. A majority of the Creeks denounced emigration, however, and refused to go west. But continued encroachment on Creek land and the land frauds associated with selling Creek reserves caused sporadic violence between Creeks and white settlers into the 1830s. These skirmishes finally erupted into war in the spring of 1836. The Second Creek War, as it came to be called, involved Creeks from the towns of Chehaw, Yuchi, and Hitchiti, among others, who attacked whites and looted and destroyed plantations in the present-day Alabama counties of Chambers, Macon, Pike, Lee, Russell, and Barbour.

The violence provided Pres. Andrew Jackson with justification for removing all the Creeks from Alabama. After capturing the Creeks who participated in the uprising, soldiers chained and marched the prisoners to Montgomery, followed in wagons by related women and children. At Montgomery, the prisoners and their families were placed on steamboats and taken by ship to Mobile and New Orleans, before being marched through Arkansas to Fort Gibson. The remaining "friendly" Creeks were rounded up into five large detachments and marched west in August and September 1836. Because of his status as perhaps the most prominent Creek Indian, the government assigned leader Opothle Yoholo to lead the initial party. As they moved west, the emigrants experienced drought, torrential rains, and extreme cold and suffered from hypothermia as they arrived at their new homes in the West.

Original Article

https://encyclopediaofalabama.org/article/creek-indian-removal/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.13

Cherokee Removal

Tim Alan Garrison

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WEBSITE	New Georgia Encyclopedia
PUBLICATION	November 19, 2004; last edited July 23, 2018
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.3, 10.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.3.2 Support; 10.3.3 Support; 10.5.2 Support; 10.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,154 words (complete article)

In 1838 and 1839 U.S. troops, prompted by the state of Georgia, expelled the Cherokee Indians from their ancestral homeland in the Southeast and removed them to the Indian Territory in what is now Oklahoma. The removal of the Cherokees was a product of the demand for arable land during the rampant growth of cotton agriculture in the Southeast, the discovery of gold on Cherokee land, and the racial prejudice that many white southerners harbored toward American Indians.

Origins of Removal Policy

By the nineteenth century the Cherokees had lived in the interior Southeast, including north Georgia, for hundreds of years. Settlers of European ancestry began moving into Cherokee territory in the early eighteenth century; from that point forward, the colonial governments in the area began demanding that the Cherokees cede their territory. By the end of the Revolutionary War (1775-83), the Cherokees had surrendered more than half of their original territory to state and federal governments.

In the late 1780s U.S. officials began to urge the Cherokees to abandon hunting and their traditional ways of life and to instead learn how to live, worship, and farm like Christian American yeomen. Many Cherokees embraced this "civilization program." The Cherokees established a court system, formally abandoned the law of blood revenge, and adopted a republican government. A Cherokee man named Sequoyah created the Cherokee syllabary, which enabled the Cherokees to read, write, record their laws, and publish newspapers in their own language.

Despite these efforts, white people in Georgia and other southern states that abutted the Cherokee Nation refused to accept the Cherokee people as social equals and urged their political representatives to seize the Cherokees' land. The purchase of the Louisiana Territory from France in 1803 gave U.S. president Thomas Jefferson an opportunity to implement an idea he had contemplated for many years—the relocation of the eastern tribes beyond the Mississippi River. There, Jefferson suggested, Native Americans could acculturate at their own pace, retain their autonomy, and live free from the trespasses of American settlers. Although most Cherokees rejected Jefferson's entreaties, small groups moved west to the Arkansas River area in 1810 and 1817-19.

After the War of 1812 (1812-15), prominent southerners like General Andrew Jackson called for the United States to end what he called the "absurdity" of negotiating with the Indian tribes as sovereign nations. From that point forward, Georgia politicians, including George Troup, George R. Gilmer, and Wilson Lumpkin, increasingly raised the pressure on the federal government to fulfill the Compact of 1802, in which the federal government had agreed to extinguish the Indian land title and remove the Cherokees from the state.

Cherokee Resistance

The Cherokee government maintained that they constituted a sovereign nation independent of the American state and federal governments. As evidence, Cherokee leaders pointed to the Treaty of Hopewell (1785), which established borders between the United States and the Cherokee Nation, offered the Cherokees the right to send a "deputy" to Congress, and made American settlers in Cherokee territory subject to Cherokee law.

The Cherokee government , especially its principal chief, John Ross, took steps to protect its national territory. Ross joined Charles Hicks and Major Ridge in the "Cherokee Triumvirate" and received recognition for his efforts in negotiating the Treaty of 1819. He then continued his work by making legal moves for the Cherokees as president of the constitutional convention. In

1825 New Echota, the Cherokee capital, was established near present-day Calhoun, Georgia. The Cherokee National Council advised the United States that it would refuse future cession requests and enacted a law prohibiting the sale of national land upon penalty of death. In 1827 the Cherokees adopted a written constitution, an act that further antagonized removal proponents in Georgia.

Between 1827 and 1831 the Georgia legislature extended the state's jurisdiction over Cherokee territory, passed laws purporting to abolish the Cherokees' laws and government, and set in motion a process to seize the Cherokees' lands, divide it into parcels, and offer the parcels in a lottery to white Georgians. In 1828 Andrew Jackson was elected president of the United States, and he immediately declared the removal of eastern tribes a national objective. In 1830 Congress passed the Indian Removal Act, which authorized the president to negotiate removal treaties.

With Congress and the president pursuing a removal policy, the Cherokee Nation, led by John Ross, asked the U.S. Supreme Court to intervene on its behalf and protect it from Georgia's trespasses. In Cherokee Nation v. Georgia (1831), John Marshall, chief justice of the court, wrote that the Cherokees were a "domestic dependent nation" under the protection and tutelage of the United States. The court, however, did not redress the Cherokees' grievances. A year later, in Worcester v. Georgia, the Supreme Court declared that Georgia had violated the Cherokee Nation's sovereign status and wrongfully intruded into its special treaty relationship with the United States. President Jackson, however, refused to enforce the decision and continued to pressure the Cherokees to leave the Southeast.

The Trail of Tears

The Cherokee Nation subsequently divided between those who wanted to continue to resist the removal pressure and a "Treaty Party" that wanted to surrender and depart for the West. In 1835 the latter group, led by Major Ridge, John Ridge, and Elias Boudinot, signed the Treaty of New Echota at the Cherokee capital without the authority of Principal Chief Ross or the Cherokee government. The treaty required the Cherokee Nation to exchange its national lands for a parcel in the "Indian Territory" and to relocate there within two years. This parcel, set aside by Congress in 1834, was located in what is now Oklahoma. The federal government promised to remit $5 million to the Cherokee Nation, compensate individuals for their buildings and fixtures, and pay for the costs of relocation and acclimation. The United States also promised to honor the title of the Cherokee Nation's new land, respect its political autonomy, and protect its tribe from future trespasses. Even though it was completed without the sanction of the Cherokee national government, the U.S. Senate ratified the treaty by a margin of one vote.

After Major Ridge signed away Cherokee land, Chief Ross gathered 16,000 Cherokee signatures against the treaty, proving that the majority of the tribe was not in agreement. The Cherokee government protested the legality of the treaty until 1838, when U.S. president Martin Van Buren ordered the U.S. Army into the Cherokee Nation. The soldiers rounded up as many Cherokees as they could into temporary stockades and subsequently marched the captives, led by John Ross, to the Indian Territory. Scholars estimate that 4,000-5,000 Cherokees, including Ross's wife, Quatie, died on this "trail where they cried," commonly known as the Trail of Tears. Once in the Indian Territory, a group of men who had opposed removal attacked and killed the two Ridges and Boudinot for violating the law that prohibited the sale of Cherokee lands. The Cherokees revived their national institutions in the Indian Territory and continued as an independent, self-sufficient nation.

Original Article

https://www.georgiaencyclopedia.org/articles/history-archaeology/cherokee-removal/

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.14

Bank War

Andrew Tremel

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PUBLICATION	n.d.
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.4.1 Support; 10.4.2 Support

Excerpt · 865 words (complete article)

Conflict over renewing the charter of the Second Bank of the United States triggered the 1830s Bank War, waged between President Andrew Jackson (1767-1845) and bank president Nicholas Biddle (1786-1844). Operating from its Parthenon-style building on Chestnut Street between Fourth and Fifth Streets in Philadelphia, the bank served as a reliable depository for federal money and provided a sound national currency. The expiration of its federal charter in 1836 virtually ended Philadelphia's standing as the nation's banking center, and New York's Wall Street supplanted Chestnut Street as the America's financial hub.

Congress issued a twenty-year charter for the Second Bank of the United States in 1816, with the government controlling twenty percent of the bank's stock. Modeled after the First Bank of the United States, established in Philadelphia in the 1790s, the Second Bank handled all federal deposits and expenditures. The bank had a rocky start (overextension of loans helped trigger the Panic of 1819), but it became a dependable institution, and Biddle was generally considered a highly successful and respected leader. By the end of the 1820s, the bank had twenty-nine branches and conducted $70 million in business annually. Nevertheless, President Jackson's first annual message to Congress in 1829 alleged corruption and condemned the bank as an unconstitutional entity. He favored hard money over bank notes, but also blamed the bank for the Panic of 1819, particularly for his personal losses.

While Jackson, a Democrat, opposed the bank, National Republicans in Congress sought to renew the institution's charter in 1832 (four years early), believing a veto would cost Jackson reelection. The House approved by 107-85 and the Senate by 28-20. Pennsylvania's two senators and all but one of its twenty-five congressmen were among the bill's advocates. The New Jersey and Delaware delegations were also strongly pro-bank. During congressional debates, pro-bank petitions came in from citizens of Philadelphia and Delaware County as well as from state banks, including fifteen from Pennsylvania. Despite nationwide support across various social groups, Jackson vetoed the bill.

Jackson handily won reelection in 1832, though his veto likely cost him votes. A majority of Philadelphians voted against Jackson (he did carry Pennsylvania); New Jersey voted in an anti-Jackson state legislature, but the state's electoral votes ended up in Old Hickory's column. He was still personally very popular. When Jackson visited Philadelphia on the first anniversary of his charter veto in June 1833, a reception in Independence Hall–just one block from the Second Bank–became so crowded with enthusiastic supporters that some had to escape the throng through open first-floor windows.

Jackson insisted that the bank was "trying to kill me," and he vowed to destroy it at any cost. He believed his reelection a mandate and continued to portray the bank as a corrupt tool of foreign interests that worked against Americans. In 1833, President Jackson instructed his treasury secretary to withhold federal deposits, later transferring federal money to "pet banks" (state banks with Democratic ties). Jackson dismissed two secretaries before finding a willing accomplice in Roger B. Taney (1777-1864). In response, Biddle contracted the bank's operations by calling in loans and exchanging state notes for specie to protect the institution and its investors. The bank's board of governors unanimously concurred.

As the Second Bank limited its operations, however, an economic depression began, businesses closed, unemployment rose, and inflation reached one of its highest rates in U.S. history. Biddle did not have the capital to make payments on the national debt. The War Department forbade the bank from carrying out its responsibility of paying Revolutionary War pensions in an attempt to turn public opinion against it. Still, the bank initially lost little support and a new political party, the Whigs, emerged to challenge Jackson's supposed tyranny. At the height of the Bank War, 1833-34, the Senate received 243 memorials calling for

the return of federal deposits and only 55 petitions supporting the president's actions. In January 1834, the Philadelphia Board of Trade issued a statement blaming the financial panic on the Jackson administration. Other Philadelphia banks also protested the president's actions. Tensions grew to the point that wealthy, pro-administration Philadelphians found themselves excluded or expelled from social organizations. In Congress, the Whig-controlled Senate censured Jackson for his actions against the bank. Each side blamed the other for the turmoil.

Biddle ultimately relaxed the bank's credit policies and the economic malaise lifted. The bank thus received the brunt of the blame for the previous years' problems. The public turned against the bank, viewing its actions as vindictive. In 1834, Election Day riots occurred in Philadelphia, and the Whigs lost seats in Congress and the state legislature. Finally, in 1836, two weeks before the U.S. charter expired, the Pennsylvania legislature granted the bank a state charter. By the time Biddle retired in 1839, the bank was in poor shape. Over the following two years, when it could not pay its debts, the bank suspended and resumed specie payments twice, closing its doors permanently in 1841.

The Bank War cost Philadelphia and the nation a central bank, shifting the nation's financial center to New York City. Thereafter, local banks lacked any regulating authority and the resulting speculation triggered panics through the rest of the century.

Original Article

https://philadelphiaencyclopedia.org/essays/bank-war/

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.15

Martin Van Buren: Domestic Affairs

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PUBLICATION	n.d.
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.4.1 Support; 10.4.3 Support

Excerpt · 875 words

When Democrats nominated Martin Van Buren in May 1835, he assured them that he would "endeavor to tread generally in the footsteps of President Jackson—happy if I shall be able to perfect the work which he has so gloriously begun." To that end, Van Buren retained all but one of his predecessor's cabinet members. Most of Van Buren's cabinet officers were longtime colleagues and friends, such as Secretary of State John Forsyth, Treasury secretary Levi Woodbury, and Attorney General Benjamin Butler. They provided not only continuity with Jackson's administration but also familiarity as the New Yorker entered the White House. The only new cabinet member was Joel R. Poinsett, who headed the Department of War.

Economic Depression

Shortly after Van Buren took office, the United States plunged into an economic depression often referred to as the Panic of 1837, although it was actually a series of economic crises that began in 1837 and lasted into the early 1840s. At the time, critics largely attributed its origins to the Bank War of Jackson's presidency, although other domestic and foreign circumstances played significant roles as well, including British banks limiting money going into the U.S. economy and U.S. banks calling in loans. Nevertheless, Van Buren found himself facing an unprecedented economic downturn that called for an innovative response, one which challenged his belief in a restrained national government.

The Second Bank of the United States' charter had ended in 1836 thanks to Andrew Jackson's veto of the Bank recharter bill in 1832, and Van Buren had no interest in reviving it. He also did not consider Jackson's use of "pet banks," moving government funds into pro-Jackson state banks, a viable solution. Instead, the president called a special session of Congress, which convened in September 1837, and he introduced the idea of an independent treasury system, in which federal dollars would be housed in an independent Treasury rather than a national bank or state banks. The independent treasury system would "divorce" the U.S. Treasury from the nation's banking system and restore economic stability. President Van Buren's proposal met with opposition from both Whigs and Democrats, and Congress did not pass the Independent Treasury Act based on Van Buren's model until 1840.

By then, Van Buren's chances of crafting a positive economic turnaround were virtually nil. Banks had closed, costing Americans their deposits. Farmers were ruined when they lost the farms that they had bought on credit. In the southern states, planters, many of whom relied on credit to buy land and the enslaved people who worked on it, lost everything.

All of this economic suffering cost the Democrats their control of Congress. Van Buren began his presidency with Democrats possessing cushions of almost twenty seats in the U.S. Senate and nearly thirty in the U.S. House. By the time he left office in 1841, Whigs had over forty more seats than the Democrats in the House and seven more in the Senate. Even Van Buren's months-long tour of the mid-Atlantic states in the summer of 1839, during which he made speeches defending his economic policies, failed to turn the tide in the Democrats' favor.

Support for Slavery

As if the economy was not enough of a problem, Van Buren had other issues that demanded his attention. One was slavery. During his 1836 presidential campaign, he had promised to oppose any congressional attempt to end slavery in the nation's capital and to leave it alone where it existed. Van Buren's inaugural address reinforced this message to his proslavery supporters. Faced with "scenes of dangerous excitement [and] terrifying instances of local violence" perpetrated, in his belief, by abolitionists, he predicted that during his administration, Americans would continue to "resist and control every effort, foreign or domestic, which aims or would lead to overthrow our institutions."

Van Buren did his best to keep his promise to protect slavery. He supported John C. Calhoun's attempt to stop the introduction of antislavery petitions on the Senate floor. In 1839, a group of Africans seized control of the Spanish slave ship *Amistad* that had taken them to Cuba. They ordered the ship to return to Africa, but the captains turned the ship north, and it landed in New York. Van Buren and his cabinet considered the self-emancipated Africans property, and, in January 1840, the president issued an executive order that the African men be turned over to their previous enslavers. Abolitionists took up the cause of the Africans, and the Amistad survivors eventually won their case for freedom before the U.S. Supreme Court, but by that time, Van Buren was out of office.

Van Buren inherited another slavery-related dilemma from Andrew Jackson. The Mexican territory of Texas won its independence in 1836 (largely with the help of Americans living there) and requested annexation to the United States. Jackson only recognized Texas' independence before leaving office, however, forcing Van Buren to come up with a conclusive answer to Texas' request to become part of the United States. Consumed with addressing the economic depression and concerned that annexing Texas would focus debate not just on slavery's existence but its expansion westward, Van Buren declined to act. This decision seemed to align with expressed public opinion at the time, but it would come back to haunt him during the 1844 presidential campaign.

Original Article

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 10 · WEB ARTICLE W10.16

Beyond Biddle

Jessica M. Lepler

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WEBSITE	Commonplace: The Journal of Early American Life
PUBLICATION	Fall 2014 (issue 15.1)
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 10 | 10.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	10.4.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,142 words

Common-place asks Jessica Lepler, author of the 2013 book The Many Panics of 1837: People, Politics, and the Creation of a Transatlantic Financial Crisis, about the historical literature on panics, the experience of the panic for ordinary Americans, and the experience of writing about one financial crisis in the midst of another.

The argument of The Many Panics of 1837 starts with the premise that historians have gotten the chronology wrong. What had they missed, and how does The Many Panics correct the problem?

Historians are especially attuned to the fact that time only moves in one direction. If time machines worked, our discipline would not. Faith in chronology allows us to interpret evidence and make arguments about change over time. We have to know when something happened in order to make arguments about why something happened.

With a year in its name, the timing of the Panic of 1837 sounds like it ought to be obvious. When I began my research, I discovered that both the chronology of the Panic of 1837 and what was meant by this name were inconsistent in the existing literature. In some books, the Panic of 1837 was an economic depression provoked by American politics that began in New York City on May 10, 1837, and lasted approximately seven years. In other books, the Panic of 1837 was a financial crisis that began in the banks of London, reached New York City after New Orleans, and lasted from late 1836 through mid-1837. Moreover, few of these accounts of a panic featured anyone who seemed remotely panicked. So in different accounts, the same event had different causes, started in different places at different times, varied in length by six years, and despite being called a panic lacked any account of actual people panicking. The secondary sources ignored these striking inconsistencies.

The Many Panics of 1837 identifies and corrects these "problem[s]" by documenting the actual experience of panic in New York, New Orleans, and London in 1837. It argues that panic was plural. Individuals panicked differently. Communities dealt with their own independent yet interrelated local crises. And, although the United States of America and Great Britain shared transnational trade, they did not share the same national political economies. Moreover, the singular Panic of 1837, the event that had been so inconsistently defined by the secondary sources, was invented during the many panics of 1837 as panicked people transferred blame from their own behavior to systems larger than any individual. Some blamed the American political system; others blamed the transnational financial system. Both of these stories were specifically crafted to erase the individual experience of panic from the history of the Panic of 1837. Thus, the people of 1837 told multiple competing accounts of a panic-less Panic of 1837. These stories, in turn, shaped the way later scholars understood the history of this event and the concept of the business cycle.

So, it turns out that historians' inconsistent chronology had not actually been "wrong"; it was incomplete. The chronological inconsistencies are only a "problem" if we expect the Panic of 1837 to be a singular event. If we accept, as The Many Panics argues, that the panic was plural from the very beginning, we gain a window not only into many previously undocumented experiences of financial crisis but also into the writing of history.

In many ways, the story of the Panic of 1837 seems to have been as much about information imbalances — both because of time lags and secrecy — as it was about economics or policy. Yet the financiers in New York, New Orleans, and London all worked in an environment where the same was true in flush times. What went wrong in 1837 with respect to communication?

Previous histories of the Panic of 1837 have focused on the political or macroeconomic causes of this event. By recognizing the plurality of not only the experience of panic but also of the event itself, The Many Panics was liberated from the quest for a single cause. Instead of why, the book answers the question how. How did the financial system work? How did panic spread? How did people panic? How did many panics become one Panic of 1837? It turns out that the answers to all four of these interrelated questions are based on information and interpretation.

Sometimes historians use negative evidence to demonstrate the existence of something otherwise invisible in the sources. Social historians, especially scholars of sexuality, look to the passing of laws to prevent certain socially taboo behaviors to prove that those otherwise undocumented behaviors existed. Similarly, financial crises offer the historian a special opportunity to render visible the ordinarily hidden world of financial communication. Merchants and bankers did not spend their time documenting and describing the system that enabled enormous transatlantic trade to occur in the 1820s and 1830s; they were too busy running it. But when confidence faltered and credit markets crashed in the spring of 1837, these same people wrote texts in private letters and public newspapers hoping to figure out what went wrong. In doing so, they cast a visibility charm on the structures of financial communication. Suddenly, the historian could see how the system operated when everything went right. By studying communication during a financial crisis, The Many Panics enables us to understand how, in more ordinary times, the financial system relied upon information and interpretation.

The Panic of 1837 is a particularly good subject for studying the flow of financial information because it happened after the United States became the globe's leading supplier of the key raw material of the industrial revolution (cotton) but before the invention of electricity-based communication technology. It was a far-reaching paper-based panic, and as such it produced voluminous evidence that would be nearly impossible to find for later panics. This evidence demonstrates that one reason why the experience of panic in 1837 was long and plural was because of extraordinary winds that kept vital transatlantic news at sea. Londoners were desperate for news from the United States, and Americans acted in ignorance of British policy changes. Within the United States, New Yorkers were closer than New Orleanians to both England and Washington, D.C.; they used this geographic advantage to save their city's reputation. Another reason for the panic's plurality was the imprecision of the language used to describe local events. Different interpreters came to different conclusions about similar phenomena. Intense partisanship and nationalism colored the news; correspondents manipulated news for their own profits. Even a merchant's own well-maintained ledger could not evaluate all the circulating goods and paper it documented because prices were in a state of flux. Like the old joke, the news in the spring of 1837 was bad and there was not enough of it. The uncertainty proved overwhelming. Incomplete and inaccurate information precipitated and, to some extent, constituted panic.

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.1

Slavery in Antebellum Georgia

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Excerpt · 869 words

[Excerpt begins at the section "Slaveholders."]

Slaveholders

Although slavery played a dominant economic and political role in Georgia, most white Georgians did not claim people as property. In 1860 less than one-third of Georgia's adult white male population of 132,317 were slaveholders. The percentage of free families holding people in slavery was somewhat higher (37 percent) but still well short of a majority. Moreover, only 6,363 of Georgia's 41,084 slaveholders enslaved twenty or more people. The planter elite, who made up just 15 percent of the state's slaveholder population, were far outnumbered by the 20,077 slaveholders who enslaved fewer than six people. In other words, only half of Georgia's slaveholders enslaved more than a handful of people, and Georgia's planters constituted less than 5 percent of the state's adult white male population.

These statistics, however, do not reveal the economic, cultural, and political force wielded by the slaveholding minority of the population. Slaveholders controlled not only the best land and the vast majority of personal property in the state but also the state political system. In 1850 and 1860 more than two-thirds of all state legislators were slaveholders. More striking, almost a third of the state legislators were planters. Hence, even without the cooperation of nonslaveholding white male voters, Georgia slaveholders could dictate the state's political path.

As it turned out, slaveholders expected and largely realized harmonious relations with the rest of the white population. During election season wealthy planters courted nonslaveholding voters by inviting them to celebrations that mixed speechmaking with abundant supplies of food and drink. On such occasions slaveholders shook hands with yeomen and tenant farmers as if they were equals. Nonslaveholding whites, for their part, frequently relied upon nearby slaveholders to gin their cotton and to assist them in bringing their crop to market. These political and economic interactions were further reinforced by the common racial bond among white Georgia men. Sharing the prejudice that slaveholders harbored against African Americans, nonslaveholding whites believed that the abolition of slavery would destroy their own economic prospects and bring catastrophe to the state as a whole.

Propping up the institution of slavery was a judicial system that denied African Americans the legal rights enjoyed by white Americans. Since the colonial era, children born of enslaved mothers were deemed chattel, doomed to "follow the condition of the mother" irrespective of the father's status. Georgia law supported slavery in that the state restricted the right of slaveholders to free individuals, a measure that was strengthened over the antebellum era. Other statutes made the circulation of abolitionist material a capital offense and outlawed literacy and unsupervised assembly among enslaved people. Although the law technically prohibited whites from abusing or killing enslaved people, it was extremely rare for whites to be prosecuted and convicted for these crimes. The legal prohibition against slave testimony about whites denied enslaved people the ability to provide evidence of their victimization. On the other hand, Georgia courts recognized confessions from enslaved individuals and, depending on the circumstances of the case, testimony against other enslaved people.

The relative scarcity of legal cases concerning enslaved defendants suggests that most slaveholders meted out discipline without involving the courts. Slaveholders resorted to an array of physical and psychological punishments in response to misconduct, including the use of whips, wooden rods, boots, fists, and dogs. The threat of selling an enslaved person away from loved ones

and family members was perhaps the most powerful weapon available to slaveholders. In general, punishment was designed to maximize the slaveholders' ability to gain profit from slave labor. Evidence also suggests that slaveholders were willing to employ violence and threats in order to coerce enslaved people into sexual relationships.

Over the antebellum era whites continued to employ violence against the enslaved population, but increasingly they justified their oppression in moral terms. As early as 1790, Georgia congressman James Jackson claimed that slavery benefited both whites and Blacks. The expanding presence of evangelical Christian churches in the early nineteenth century provided Georgia slaveholders with religious justifications for human bondage. White efforts to Christianize the slave quarters enabled slaveholders to frame their power in moral terms. They viewed the Christian slave mission as evidence of their own good intentions. The religious instruction offered by whites, moreover, reinforced slaveholders' authority by reminding enslaved African Americans of scriptural admonishments that they should "give single-minded obedience" to their "earthly masters with fear and trembling, as if to Christ."

This melding of religion and slavery did not protect enslaved people from exploitation and cruelty at the hands of their owners, but it magnified the role played by slavery in the identity of the planter elite. In 1785, just before the genesis of the cotton plantation system, a Georgia merchant had claimed that slavery was "to the Trade of the Country, as the Soul [is] to the Body." Seventy-five years later Georgia politician Alexander Stephens noted that slavery had become a moral as well as an economic foundation for white plantation culture. The "corner-stone" of the South, Stephens claimed in 1861, just after the Lower South had seceded, consisted of the "great physical, philosophical, and moral truth," which is "that the negro is not equal to the white man; that slavery—subordination to the superior race—is his natural and normal condition."

Original Article

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.2

Slavery in the United States

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PUBLICATION	n.d.
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ARGUMENT ROLES	11.1.1 Support; 11.1.3 Support; 11.3.1 Support; 11.3.2 Support

Excerpt · 800 words

Slavery is fundamentally an economic phenomenon. Throughout history, slavery has existed where it has been economically worthwhile to those in power. The principal example in modern times is the U.S. South. Nearly 4 million slaves with a market value estimated to be between $3.1 and $3.6 billion lived in the U.S. just before the Civil War. Masters enjoyed rates of return on slaves comparable to those on other assets; cotton consumers, insurance companies, and industrial enterprises benefited from slavery as well. Such valuable property required rules to protect it, and the institutional practices surrounding slavery display a sophistication that rivals modern-day law and business.

THE SPREAD OF SLAVERY IN THE U.S.

Not long after Columbus set sail for the New World, the French and Spanish brought slaves with them on various expeditions. Slaves accompanied Ponce de Leon to Florida in 1513, for instance. But a far greater proportion of slaves arrived in chains in crowded, sweltering cargo holds. The first dark-skinned slaves in what was to become British North America arrived in Virginia — perhaps stopping first in Spanish lands — in 1619 aboard a Dutch vessel. From 1500 to 1900, approximately 12 million Africans were forced from their homes to go westward, with about 10 million of them completing the journey. Yet very few ended up in the British colonies and young American republic. By 1808, when the trans-Atlantic slave trade to the U.S. officially ended, only about 6 percent of African slaves landing in the New World had come to North America.

Slavery in the North

Colonial slavery had a slow start, particularly in the North. The proportion there never got much above 5 percent of the total population. Scholars have speculated as to why, without coming to a definite conclusion. Some surmise that indentured servants were fundamentally better suited to the Northern climate, crops, and tasks at hand; some claim that anti-slavery sentiment provided the explanation. At the time of the American Revolution, fewer than 10 percent of the half million slaves in the thirteen colonies resided in the North, working primarily in agriculture. New York had the greatest number, with just over 20,000. New Jersey had close to 12,000 slaves. Vermont was the first Northern region to abolish slavery when it became an independent republic in 1777. Most of the original Northern colonies implemented a process of gradual emancipation in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, requiring the children of slave mothers to remain in servitude for a set period, typically 28 years. Other regions above the Mason-Dixon line ended slavery upon statehood early in the nineteenth century — Ohio in 1803 and Indiana in 1816, for instance.

Slavery in the South

Throughout colonial and antebellum history, U.S. slaves lived primarily in the South. Slaves comprised less than a tenth of the total Southern population in 1680 but grew to a third by 1790. At that date, 293,000 slaves lived in Virginia alone, making up 42 percent of all slaves in the U.S. at the time. South Carolina, North Carolina, and Maryland each had over 100,000 slaves. After the American Revolution, the Southern slave population exploded, reaching about 1.1 million in 1810 and over 3.9 million in 1860.

Slave Ownership Patterns

Despite their numbers, slaves typically comprised a minority of the local population. Only in antebellum South Carolina and Mississippi did slaves outnumber free persons. Most Southerners owned no slaves and most slaves lived in small groups rather than on large plantations. Less than one-quarter of white Southerners held slaves, with half of these holding fewer than five and fewer than 1 percent owning more than one hundred. In 1860, the average number of slaves residing together was about ten.

Rapid Natural Increase in U.S. Slave Population

How did the U.S. slave population increase nearly fourfold between 1810 and 1860, given the demise of the trans-Atlantic trade? They enjoyed an exceptional rate of natural increase. Unlike elsewhere in the New World, the South did not require constant infusions of immigrant slaves to keep its slave population intact. In fact, by 1825, 36 percent of the slaves in the Western hemisphere lived in the U.S. This was partly due to higher birth rates, which were in turn due to a more equal ratio of female to male slaves in the U.S. relative to other parts of the Americas. Lower mortality rates also figured prominently. Climate was one cause; crops were another. U.S. slaves planted and harvested first tobacco and then, after Eli Whitney's invention of the cotton gin in 1793, cotton. This work was relatively less grueling than the tasks on the sugar plantations of the West Indies and in the mines and fields of South America. Southern slaves worked in industry, did domestic work, and grew a variety of other food crops as well, mostly under less abusive conditions than their counterparts elsewhere. For example, the South grew half to three-quarters of the corn crop harvested between 1840 and 1860.

Original Article

https://eh.net/encyclopedia/slavery-in-the-united-states/

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.3

Continuing the Debate on Slavery and Capitalism

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ARGUMENT ROLES	11.1.1 Support; 11.1.3 Support; 11.3.2 Support

Excerpt · 681 words (complete article)

It's been two and a half years since the new history of capitalism marked its arrival with the full red carpet treatment in the *New York Times*. So it's about time we saw some serious and constructive critiques of the project. Robin Blackburn's lengthy review of *Empire of Cotton* goes some way to bringing that Bancroft-winner back down to earth, particularly by scrutinising the concept of "war capitalism." But what I particularly want to share with *Junto* readers today is an article by the NYU sociologist John Clegg recently published in the Chicago-based journal, *Critical Historical Studies*.

Anyone who has read Beckert, Baptist, and Johnson, or is eagerly awaiting the forthcoming volume on *Slavery's Capitalism*, ought to read what Clegg has to say. In earlier posts at *The Junto*, I've pointed out the way new historians of capitalism have made a feature out of their resistance to defining the primary term. Clegg puts that resistance at the centre of his critique. "None of them," he writes, "seem interested in asking what capitalism is" (281). As a result, he argues, "these authors fail to explain how the various features of the antebellum economy that they identify form part of a coherent capitalist system" (284). That makes it very difficult for them to "engage scholars in other fields and contribute to contemporary political and economic debates" (282).

Edward Baptist's *The Half Has Never Been Told* comes in for a particularly compelling corrective.[1] One of the book's core arguments was that the violent techniques of the slave-drivers' "pushing system," not improvements in fertility or seed stock, accounts for the nineteenth-century's consistent increases in cotton productivity. Clegg demolishes that claim (however, see Baptist's response in the comments below). For one thing, it doesn't account for differences in Sea Island plantation productivity. Nor does it account for the high productivity of postbellum sharecroppers, who were not subject to the violence of slavery. But more important than either of those considerations is simply the question of capitalist logic—why would it take slavers half a century to reach maximum levels of violence?

> Slave owners subject to a competitive constraint can always be expected to use violence to whatever extent it is profitable. They will use violence to extract the maximum output when cotton yields and pickability are low, and they will continue to use violence to extract the even larger output when yields and pickability rise due to changing soils and seeds. Thus it is implausible that increased violence alone could account for a fourfold increase in productivity from 1805 to 1860. For it would suggest that market-dependent slave owners in 1805 were either too ignorant or too kind to take advantage of a relatively simple way to make a lot of money. (294-5)

Clegg also takes on the question of what these historians mean when they say slavery was central or essential to capitalism. Without slavery, could there have been no capitalism? Beckert and Baptist both seem to claim as much. In that sense, they are successors to Eric Williams. As Clegg makes clear, however, such a claim is hard to substantiate. What can more easily be said is, in fact, the opposite. "While it is questionable that British and Northern industry were dependent on Southern slavery," Clegg writes, "the reverse does not hold." As Robin Blackburn has suggested, "there would have been no African slaves in the New World had European markets not existed for the products of their labor, but capitalism in Europe gave a new lease of life to slavery in the Americas" (298-9).

Slavery was indeed integral to the history of capitalism, and violence was indeed fundamental to slavery. But if we want to understand just how those things related to each other, we still need to get to grips with just what capitalism means to us. To do that, we might need to engage more closely with the work of theorists and others in the social sciences. It may be that in the process, historians of capitalism can no longer avoid the question of political commitment, or the spectre of Marx.

Original Article

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.4

George Fitzhugh (1806–1881)

Calvin Schermerhorn

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PUBLICATION	2020; updated 2021
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.1
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.1.2 Support

Excerpt · 1,047 words

Fitzhugh was born on November 9, 1806, in Prince William County and was the son of George Fitzhugh, a physician, and Lucy Stuart Fitzhugh. The family moved to a plantation in King George County about 1812. As a child he attended a small school that met irregularly, but he read extensively, mastered Latin, and educated himself. Fitzhugh then studied law and qualified as an attorney on October 4, 1827. He married Mary Metcalf Brockenbrough on December 21, 1829, and they settled in her native Port Royal, in Caroline County, where by 1842 he was in a law partnership with John T. Thornton. The Fitzhughs had six daughters and three sons. One daughter and one son died in November 1844, ages ten and two.

Defender of Slavery

Fitzhugh published the most spirited defense of slavery of any antebellum Virginian. In doing so he exacerbated sectional tensions over the issue. Fitzhugh aimed his proslavery writings to provoke reactions from opponents, but he articulated a resilient social mythology of slaveholder paternalism. His writings about slaveholders' culture figured largely in twentieth-century historians' examinations of American slavery.

Fitzhugh's Tidewater Virginia society was changing rapidly. Enslavers sold surplus slaves at a high rate, more than 20 percent per decade, and a significant percentage of white Virginians left the region during the first half of the nineteenth century. At mid-century, Fitzhugh's Caroline County had an African American majority, and a majority of the whole population was enslaved. The free black population was small but rising. According to census records, Fitzhugh owned five bondspeople in 1830, eight in 1840, and twenty-seven in 1850.

Rather than investigate the changes that were unsettling his neighbors in eastern Virginia, Fitzhugh idealized the society of slaveholders. In 1850 he published Slavery Justified; by a Southerner, the first of several essays in which he defended slavery by attacking what he called free society. Fitzhugh denied that the slave South was a modern commercial society dependent on foreign trade. Southern slavery, he argued, was a benign domestic institution and less inequitable than the free society of industrial Britain and Europe or the commercial American North. Continuing the argument in an addendum published four years later Fitzhugh wrote, "Experience has universally shown, that the slavery of the working classes to the rich, which grows out of liberty and equality, or free competition, is ten times more onerous and exacting than domestic slavery." He also addressed his white Port Royal neighbors' concerns that a growing free black population threatened white impoverishment. In a series of essays he wrote for the Fredericksburg Recorder and published as a pamphlet What Shall Be Done With the Free Negroes (1851), Fitzhugh advocated enslavement of free African Americans.

Fitzhugh reveled in the controversy he created. He was an amateur in the sense that he assiduously but informally studied the issues on which he wrote. John Taylor of Caroline influenced Fitzhugh, particularly in taking economic approaches to social problems. Fitzhugh subscribed to about a half-dozen British reviews of political economy and from them absorbed conservative thought including that of Scottish essayist and historian Thomas Carlyle. Fitzhugh imitated Carlyle's florid and energetic style. He corresponded with ideological foes, including the abolitionists Gerrit Smith, to whom he was distantly related, and William Lloyd Garrison, to whom he declared, "If history, human experience and statistics prove the evils of free society to be less than the evils of slave society, slavery should be abolished." Fitzhugh also subscribed to Garrison's abolitionist newspaper, The Liberator.

Sociology for the South and Cannibals All!

The two books for which Fitzhugh is best known are Sociology for the South, or the Failure of Free Society (1854) and Cannibals All! or, Slaves Without Masters (1857). In Sociology for the South, the first American imprint to include the relatively new word sociology in the title, he argued that free society was a failure because free trade and free labor created social antagonisms that endangered civilization. Fitzhugh wrote that Adam Smith had failed to grasp the damage free markets did to unprotected workers and rejected John Locke's social contract theory, arguing that slavery afforded protections to enslaved workers by creating reciprocal social interests between them and their owners. In Cannibals All! Fitzhugh went further, asserting that slavery was biblically based and argued that capitalism made workers into slaves of capitalists. Capitalists were cannibals.

Fitzhugh advocated slavery in the abstract, not merely for people of African descent. He wrote, "To defend and justify mere negro slavery, and condemn other forms of slavery, is to give up expressly the whole cause of the South—for mulattoes, quadroons, and men with as white skins as any of us, may legally be, and in fact are, held in slavery in every State of the South." That statement reflected the social realities of the antebellum Chesapeake, in which the oldest-reproducing slave society in North America was a multiethnic mix of people of European, Native American, and African descent. Fitzhugh disagreed with the theological justifications for slavery espoused by clergyman James Henley Thornwell and rejected the proslavery ethnology of physician Josiah Nott. Fitzhugh was not colorblind, however. He argued that a black man possesses "neither energy nor enterprise" and that "his liberty is a curse to himself, and a greater curse to the society around him."

Sociology for the South brought Fitzhugh notoriety, and in March 1855 he received an invitation to debate the abolitionist Wendell Phillips in New Haven, Connecticut. That was the first time Fitzhugh traveled north of the Potomac River and into the free society he disparaged. Phillips and Fitzhugh spoke on alternating evenings, and after touring parts of New York and New England, the Virginian returned home more firm in his convictions than ever. He embarked on a more-ambitious writing career, taking a wide variety of issues as subjects for a broad southern audience. Fitzhugh published more than ninety articles and essays in De Bow's Review and the Southern Literary Messenger between 1855 and 1867 on a range of topics including culture, genealogy, history, foreign affairs, political economy, travel, and social and political issues of the day such as slavery, the Civil War, and Reconstruction. After the war he also published articles in Lippincott's Magazine and the Southern Magazine. The essays in De Bow's Review constitute the main body of his work, but Sociology for the South and Cannibals All! have overshadowed them.

Original Article

https://encyclopediavirginia.org/entries/fitzhugh-george-1806-1881/

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.5

Slavery

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PUBLICATION	n.d.
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.2.1 Support; 11.2.2 Support

Excerpt · 1,165 words

American chattel slavery was a unique institution that emerged in the English colonies in America in the seventeenth century. Enslaved peoples were held involuntarily as property by slave owners who controlled their labor and freedom. By the eighteenth century, slavery had assumed racial tones as white colonists had come to consider only Africans who had been brought to the Americas as peoples who could be enslaved. Invariably, the earliest white settlers who moved into Arkansas brought slave property with them to work the area's rich lands, and slavery became an integral part of local life. The enslaved played a major role in the economic growth of the territory and state. Their presence contributed to the peculiar formation of local culture and society. The existence of slavery ultimately helped to determine the political course of the territory and state until the end of the Civil War and slavery's abolition in 1865 with the ratification of the Thirteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

Slavery's Origins in Arkansas

The first people enslaved by Europeans entered what was to become Arkansas in about 1720, when settlers moved into the John Law colony on land given to them on the lower Arkansas River by the king of France. The Law colony failed within two years, but a small number of inhabitants, including some who probably were enslaved, remained in the area for the rest of the French and Spanish territorial periods. In the first official U.S. census of Arkansas as the "District of Louisiana" in 1810, the census takers found 188 slaves in a total population of 1,062 people. The development of this area and its creation as Arkansas Territory in 1819 spurred a rapid growth in the enslaved population. By 1820, it had risen to 1,617. These trends continued through the territorial period and up to the Civil War. By 1830, the enslaved population reached 4,576; then 19,935 in 1840; 47,100 in 1850; and 111,115 in 1860. As the enslaved population grew, it also constituted a larger and larger portion of the total population, growing from eleven percent in 1820 to twenty-five percent by 1860.

Enslaved people lived in every county and in both rural and urban settings in antebellum Arkansas. Historian Orville Taylor estimated that roughly one in four white Arkansans either owned slaves or lived in families that did. Many more probably benefited from slavery, however, as leasing the enslaved was not an uncommon practice. Although slavery clearly touched the lives of many white Arkansans, most slave-owners possessed only a few. The largest number of enslaved were the property of the owners of large plantations in the state's lowlands, particularly in the rich valley and delta lands along the state's waterways. A relatively large slave holding would have been ten people, a work force valued at about $9,000 on the average in 1859, an amount equal to approximately $200,000 in 2002. By 1860, seventy-three percent of of the enslaved population were on plantations and farms of that size. They were owned, however, by only about twenty-six percent of the state's slave owners. Elisha Worthington of Chicot County was the state's largest slave owner, holding more than 500 people on the eve of the Civil War.

Legal Protection for Slavery

The Code Noir, or Black Code, of French Louisiana and additional legislation during Arkansas's territorial and statehood periods established the basic legal definition of slavery and helped determine the world in which the individual slave lived. By law, an enslaved person was subject to all laws involving personal property. Like cattle, horses, or other types of possessions, slaves formed part of the owner's estate. This meant that they had no legal identity of their own, making it impossible for them to engage in contractual relations for labor, business, or even marriage. The enslaver, on the other hand, could dispose of slave property just like any other asset, including hiring them out, selling them, or even sending children away from their parents. Heirs inherited slaves upon an owner's death.

Even though it defined people held in slavery as less than human, the law recognized the enslaved as a unique form of property. Numerous statutes made it clear that the white community knew their slaves were human beings and could not be dealt with in the same way as livestock. Slaves had to be controlled, and laws attempted to achieve that goal and provided for punishment of those who broke these laws. Statutes restricted their movement, required passes to leave their home plantation, limited their rights of assembly, and prohibited their possession of firearms, clearly indicating that whites saw their property as restless and potentially dangerous. An 1825 law created the slave patrol, an institution that enforced such limits across the countryside, the existence of which further indicated the contradictory character of white perceptions of their slave property. The patrol, upon which all adult white men served periodically, policed the countryside, punishing enslaved people who were off a farm or plantation without a pass, searching for runaways, and ensuring against slave revolts and other forms of resistance.

Contemporary whites often looked at their peculiar institution as a benevolent one and saw the lack of any notable slave revolts in Arkansas as reflecting its benign character. The majority of those enslaved probably did not see it that way. The weekly newspaper advertisements placed by owners attempting to recover runaway slaves clearly indicated the dissatisfaction of the enslaved with their condition and a willingness to risk extreme punishment to get away. The frequent need of enslavers to resort to physical punishment to secure obedience also indicates the refusal of individuals held in slavery to be satisfied with their condition. Impudence, disobedience, and a refusal to work—all behaviors that led to whippings by Arkansas planters—demonstrated the efforts by those enslaved to establish some degree of personal independence within the system of slavery. In the end, only the use of force made possible this critical labor system through the antebellum years.

Economics of Slavery

Slavery served primarily to provide labor for the state's economy, and the enslaved added greatly to its development. Slavery made possible the rapid expansion of the cotton frontier within Arkansas, and slave labor contributed greatly to the state's material wealth, adding at least $16 million to the economy each year and making Arkansas the sixth largest cotton producer in the United States by 1860. Historians have debated whether or not slavery was profitable for the South, but in Arkansas there is no question that slave labor produced profits for some individual enslavers. Nothing shows more clearly that contemporaries considered the system profitable as much as the inflation in the price of slaves through the antebellum period. Orville W. Taylor has shown that average prices in Arkansas rose from $105 in the 1820s to nearly $900 by 1860, taking into account children as well as adults. Enslaved adults with skills such as carpentry or blacksmithing could bring enormous prices, with some such slaves costing as high as $2,800. These prices were comparable to approximately $2,200, $20,000, and $61,000 in 2002 dollars.

Original Article

https://encyclopediaofarkansas.net/entries/slavery-1275/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.6

Home, Sweet Home: Gender in the Antebellum Household—Men's Role as Head of Household

Elizabeth Vanek

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PUBLICATION	n.d.
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.2.1 Support; 11.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,146 words

When examining gender roles, it is important to study how they affected men as well as women. During the antebellum era, white men kept the social hierarchy in place. White men during the antebellum era had the responsibility to protect their dependents. For the social order to work, white men needed their dependents to be subordinate. White men achieved this subordination though violence and disenfranchisement. Southern white men gained power through paternalism. Fox-Genovese defines paternalism as a "peculiar combination of hierarchically sanction male dominance in the household and bourgeois egalitarianism among men in the public sphere."[1] Both wealthy and poor white men had the right to be the head of a household. In the South, the household's political and economic significance left the domestic sphere a white male controlled space. During the antebellum era, white women may have occupied the domestic sphere but white men controlled it.

Slave masters epitomized the paternalistic duties of wealthy white men in the South. A plantation was mainly populated by dependents comprised of women, children and slaves. It was the responsibility of the master to know everything about the plantation and the slaves who labored on it. Masters had the duty to run the plantation to be financially successful. All problems large and small were the master's concern: from slave training to selling raw goods. Slave masters enforced their power though violence. Paternalism dictated that a master control his dependents both women and slaves. Mistresses could be overruled in their own sphere because the master had the final authority. Southern masculinity assumed slavery and household control. Elite men could afford to have many dependents making them even more powerful.[2]

White yeoman farmers still had the power of masters, even without slave labor. Stephanie McCurry argues that white yeoman farmers were masters of small worlds. She outlines how culturally and legally white male farmers had total control over their households. White farmers owned few or no slaves, so majorities of the dependents in the household were women and children. The courts during the antebellum period reinforced the white man's power over matters within the household. For example, a South Carolina Judge ruled that men had "a power of control over all members of his household." This meant that white women had no legal identity and no legal power. A white woman's whole identity came through her male kin. As Chief Justice Pearson of North Carolina stated "The wife must be subject to the husband... Every man must govern his household." Do to their lack of wealth, white yeoman farmer's legal and customary rights over the household gave them power. Even with very little money or land to a yeoman farmer's name, he had inherent power due to his race and number of dependents.[3] The laws and customs upheld the antebellum social order of white men at the top of the social hierarchy.

Paternalism allowed white men's domination of his dependants to be described like a family, with white men as the head of the family. In the 1830's the analogy for family shifted from abstract to specific, equating women, children and slaves. If marriage dictated a women's subordination to a man, then a man's dominance over a slave was also natural. As Stephanie McCurry argues, "females thus provided the only constant point of reference for naturalizing subordination."[4] The proslavery movement used gender to legitimize slavery by emphasizing women's "natural" subordinate state. Proslavery advocates argued that slavery was also natural. To the proslavery South, abolitionism meant not just racial equality but gender equality. The South's social order relied on the subordination of females and slaves. The analogy of the family was used to further naturalize slavery.[5] Casting abolitionism as an attack on the household and a man's right as master of it strengthened proslavery arguments. This

created a larger following because the argument extended to white yeomen without slaves.[6] Equating slavery to family legitimized the South's social order, with white men as the heads of households.

White men had the responsibility to protect white women's chastity and purity. McCurry argues that as early as 1835 scientific thinking established a ridged binary of sexual differences: "man was the warrior and assailant on the fortress of chastity, women the guardian of chastity and seductress of man. Women, then, was simultaneously chaste and seductive, man simultaneously protector and predator." While the scientific community put these roles in universal terms, in the South these roles took on a racial component. A white man's exclusive claim over his wife's body, as protector cast the black man as predator. White women's exclusive rights as the protected also cast black women as the seductress. Female protection was excusive to white women and the only proper protectors were white men.[7] In the slave holding class, a young white woman's purity reflected on the family as a whole. A white woman's sexual reputation indicated her father's ability to protect her. Young slaveholding women had supervised and restricted interactions with men. Only in marriage would a woman's protector switch to her husband.[8] Race, class and gender dictated who was protected and who received protection.

Especially in the yeoman class, a white man's main responsibility was to protect his family from starvation. Yeomen farmers were expected to have a successful farm that supported his family. A white yeomen farmer valued hard work to support the household. White yeomen farmers looked down upon the slaveholding class for their leisurely pursuits. A white yeoman farmer needed to work hard for the survival of his family. One unsuccessful harvest could send a yeomen family into poverty. Running a successful farm was a white yeomen farmer's best protection for his family. While all members of a family worked on the farm, it was a white man's duty to ensure his family could survive.[9] As the war demanded white men's military service, protection from starvation would become a point of contention for the yeoman class.

Privileged white men clearly held the most power in the South, through land ownership, political influence and wealth. Slave owning men had the most invested in the hierarchy of the South. Nevertheless, white yeomen also had a stake in the social order. The more dependents a man had, the more power he possessed in the public sphere. A poor man's power came from his status as household head and control over his dependents and not though wealth. However, white men in the South shared common cause in maintaining the social order because as heads of households both benefited from the subordination of dependents.[10] A man depending on a woman was unmanly; being a man meant being independent. The reverse did not apply to women. Minister Benjamin Morgan Palmer explained, "Dependence…is not her degradation but her glory." White men insisted that women choose subordination, denying women any personal power and legitimizing a man's authority.[11]

Original Article

https://cwnc.omeka.chass.ncsu.edu/exhibits/show/protect/1/men

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.7

Poor Whites and Slavery in the Antebellum South: An Interview with Historian Keri Leigh Merritt

Keri Leigh Merritt (interview by Robin Lindley)

AUTHOR	Keri Leigh Merritt (interview by Robin Lindley) (Historian; author of Masterless Men (Cambridge University Press, 2017))
WEBSITE	History News Network
PUBLICATION	November 5, 2017
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.2.1 Support; 11.2.4 Support

Excerpt · 1,013 words

> The lords of the lash are not only absolute masters of the blacks, but they are also the oracle and arbiters of non-slaveholding whites, whose freedom is merely nominal, and whose unparalleled illiteracy and degradation is purposely and fiendishly perpetuated.
>
> Hinton Helper, The Impending Crisis of the South (1857)

While the Southern abolitionist Hinton Helper abhorred the cruel institution of slavery, he was also appalled by the condition of poor whites in the South of the 1850s who he saw as suffering a "second degree of slavery" under the dominance of the slaveholding ruling class. Wealthy slaveholders brutally enforced the enslavement of blacks while repressing and degrading poor whites who they saw as disaffected pariahs that could upend the rigid hierarchy of the rich white slave-owning class.

Historian Keri Leigh Merritt presents a comprehensive study of this malignant and overlooked aspect of slavery in her new book Masterless Men: Poor Whites and Slavery in the Antebellum South (Cambridge University Press). She offers a groundbreaking interdisciplinary perspective that explores economics, law, class, labor, race, social relations, the court system, and vigilante violence, among other issues, to reveal the world of poor whites in the South during the decades preceding the Civil War.

Dr. Merritt details how an underclass of white people grew in the Deep South. By the 1840s and 1850s, the global demand for cotton had skyrocketed, and slaveholders from the Upper South had sold over 800,000 African Americans to Lower South states. This influx of slaves reduced the need for white laborers, whose ranks also grew due to white immigration, particularly from Ireland. As she vividly describes, these whites were landless, jobless or underemployed, and illiterate, and faced involuntary servitude, a hostile legal system, illness, starvation, harassment, and the constant threat of violence—the result of the policies designed to expand the wealth and power of the white slaveholding master class while preserving slavery at all costs in a de facto police state.

Dr. Merritt also dispels myths about this time, including the idea that virtually all whites in the South supported slavery and secession. She concludes by chronicling how poor whites benefited from the end of slavery by gaining the ability to compete in a free economy while, ironically, free black people were excluded from the economic system and became subject to "slavery by another name" with the persistence of white supremacy and a racist justice system.

Because of the illiteracy of most poor white people in the prewar South, they left few written documents. To address this problem, Dr. Merritt conducted extensive original research to uncover their story by studying sources from county court records, jail and penitentiary records, newspapers, and coroners' reports to slave narratives, accounts from slaveholders and abolitionists and veterans, petitions from laborers, and much more.

Dr. Merritt works as an independent scholar in Atlanta, Georgia. She earned a doctorate in history from The University of Georgia. In addition to Masterless Men, Dr. Merritt is also co-editor with Matthew Hild of Reconsidering Southern Labor History: Race, Class, and Power (University Press of Florida, 2018). She is currently researching books on radical black resistance during Reconstruction, and on the role of sheriffs and police in the nineteenth century South. She has earned

numerous honors for her writing and research on inequality and poverty, and she frequently contributes articles to the non-academic press that place current events in historical perspective.

Dr. Merritt generously talked about her book and her work as a historian during a visit to Seattle.

Robin Lindley: Before getting to your new book Dr. Merritt, I wanted to ask how you decided to study history and then specialize in the issues of slavery, labor, race, and economics in the American South of the nineteenth century.

Dr. Keri Leigh Merritt: I've always been attracted to history. I've read history books since I was a young teenager. Growing up in the South and seeing the racism there drew me in even more.

I started studying poor whites and the nineteenth century South as an undergraduate and realized their story was largely untold. They were nearly always left out of history simply due to the fact that they were illiterate. I knew I wanted to go onto graduate school and study this topic, because I believe it adds a lot of nuance to how race and class interact – and how racism is perpetuated in America.

Robin Lindley: And you've brought in legal, social and economic history and other aspects of the story beyond the focus of many histories of the period.

Dr. Keri Leigh Merritt: Yes. I think we miss a lot as historians by just staying within our discipline. For example, what economists have come up on the price of slaves in the last few years that changes the whole dynamics of how we think about the South and slavery. By using interdisciplinary methods and relying on other subjects, we inch closer to the reality of the situation.

Robin Lindley: You've done pioneering research on an overlooked aspect of race and slavery in the antebellum South. How would you briefly describe your new book Masterless Men to readers?

Dr. Keri Leigh Merritt: Masterless Men examines how black slavery - and subsequently, black freedom – affected poor whites in the Deep South. Basically, with the influx of slaves from the Upper to the Lower South in the mid-1800s, poor whites increasingly found themselves unemployed and underemployed, and became cyclically impoverished. While poor whites certainly never experienced anything close to the horrific brutality of slavery, they did suffer socio-economically because of the peculiar institution.

I document the ways in which poorer whites traded and socially interacted with the enslaved, and how the slaveholders were constantly trying to figure out how to achieve segregation between the groups.

I show how poor whites were exploited by slave owners, who used myriad ways, from keeping them ignorant and illiterate to policing and terrorizing them, to maintain an effective system of slavery. Conversely, I also argue that black emancipation "freed" poor whites in certain, very important ways, often at the expense of African Americans.

Original Article

https://www.historynewsnetwork.org/article/poor-whites-and-slavery-in-the-antebellum-south-an

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Merritt, "Poor Whites and Slavery."

CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.8

Helper, Hinton Rowan

James W. Wall

AUTHOR	James W. Wall (Contributor, Dictionary of North Carolina Biography (UNC Press))
WEBSITE	NCpedia, State Library of North Carolina
PUBLICATION	1988
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.2.4 Support

Excerpt · 851 words (complete article)

Hinton Rowan Helper, abolitionist author and lecturer and consul to Argentina, was born on the Squire Boone homesite two miles west of Mocksville, the son of Daniel J. and Sarah Brown Helper. He was educated at the Mocksville Academy taught by Peter Stuart Ney and the Reverend Baxter Clegg. Graduating in 1848, he was apprenticed to a printer, Michael Brown, of Salisbury.

In 1850 Helper went to the California gold fields but failed as a prospector; according to his own account, he worked one mine claim for three months and made 93 3/4 cents. The California experience, however, provided material for his first book, California Land of Gold: Reality vs. Fiction. Published in 1855, it presented a most unfavorable view of California and its potential, consisting largely of fabricated and garbled statistics intended to serve the purpose of the writer. In this volume Helper praised and advocated the extension of slavery, and scolded "meddling abolitionists."

Helper returned to Salisbury and then moved to New York. In June 1857 he published The Impending Crisis of the South: How to Meet It, a work destined to help elect Abraham Lincoln president in 1860 and to rank perhaps next to Uncle Tom's Cabin in its impact as an abolitionist document fueling the fires of secession and war. Helper, scorned by proslavery elements in the North, unable to find employment, and harassed and threatened with physical harm, applied to Lincoln for a consular appointment. The request was granted and in November 1861 he was sent to Buenos Aires. While there he married Maria Louisa Rodriquez.

In 1867 Helper settled in Asheville. He was described at this time as a "tall, strongly built man . . . and always alone." Despite the former Southern hatred and threats against his life, he was not molested in any way. He later lived in New York, St. Louis, and Washington, D.C.

Helper wrote five other books, three of which were extremely racist and unleashed intense hatred towards Black people. His writings contained rational, progressive, and farsighted viewpoints and ideas as well as irrationalities and illogical ideas which sometimes sounded like the ravings of a maniac. Historians John Spencer Bassett and J. G. de R. Hamilton have portrayed him as a man of keen intellect with a touch of genius which at times bordered on insanity. The Louisville Courier Journal once described him as having "an expression of unmistakable resolution written all over his countenance and an air of manifest sincerity in his every utterance."

After about 1890 Helper spent most of his time in Washington, D.C. His wife became blind and returned to South America with their son. Helper's mental instability worsened and he eventually committed suicide. His burial plot was donated, and the burial expenses were paid by the Authors Society of New York. His grave is unmarked.

When he died, the Courier Journal wrote: "The world had wrestled with him and thrown him. His mind was shattered and his heart broken. Friendless, penniless, and alone, he took his own life, and died at the age of eighty—this man who had shaken the Republic from center to circumference and who at a critical period had held and filled the center of the stage."

Helper and The Impending Crisis indeed "had shaken the Republic from center to circumference." Though he said that the book was intended to help the nonslave-holding whites (three-fourths of the South's population disadvantaged by slavery), it was, in reality, a powerful and dangerous abolitionist work. The 150 pages of statistics from the census of 1850, indiscriminately used to show that the slave states were at a disadvantage in every area of comparison with the free states, had little influence. The real

impact of the book came from its scathing denunciation of Southern enslavers, whom the author branded as "robbers, thieves, ruffians, and murderers," and the admonishment to enslaved people to gain freedom by violence if necessary.

Republican party leaders endorsed the printing of a compendium of the book for distribution in the presidential campaign of 1860. This endorsement led to the "Speakership Flight" in the House of Representatives between 5 Dec. 1859 and 1 Feb. 1860. The debate there about The Impending Crisis and the Republican party's endorsement of it gave the book nationwide recognition far out of proportion to its merit. Southern states passed stringent laws against the circulation of abolitionist literature, and persons were punished for possessing the Helper volume.

Hinton Rowan Helper and The Impending Crisis shaped history. Historian James Ford Rhodes wrote that the book "proved a potent Republican document especially in the doubtful states of New Jersey, Pennsylvania, Indiana, and Illinois, where it was easier to arouse sympathy for the degraded white than for the oppressed Negro." James Gordon Bennett, editor of the New York Herald, reportedly handed a copy to President James Buchanan in the summer of 1857 with the statement: "There is gunpowder enough in that book to blow the Union to the devil." In January 1861 the Herald declared that Lincoln's election had been due to "this very work of Mr. Helper, and kindred speeches and documents."

Original Article

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.9

An Introduction to the WPA Slave Narratives

Norman R. Yetman

AUTHOR	Norman R. Yetman (Professor of American Studies and Sociology, University of Kansas)
WEBSITE	Born in Slavery: Slave Narratives from the Federal Writers' Project, 1936–1938, Library of Congress
PUBLICATION	2001
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.3
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.3.1 Support; 11.3.2 Support; 11.3.3 Support

Excerpt · 775 words (complete article)

The Slave Narrative Collection, a group of autobiographical accounts of former slaves, today stands as one of the most enduring and noteworthy achievements of the WPA, Compiled in seventeen states during the years 1936-38, the collection consists of more than two thousand interviews with former slaves, most of them first-person accounts of slave life and the respondents' own reactions to bondage. This introductory essay, which accompanied the Library's initial 2001 release of the collection, was written by Norman R. Yetman, then Chancellors Club Teaching Professor of American Studies and Sociology and Chair of the American Studies Program at the University of Kansas, where he was also Courtesy Professor of African and African-American Studies and co-editor (with David Katzman) of the transdisciplinary journal American Studies. Among other publications, Yetman is the author of Life Under the 'Peculiar Institution': Selections from the Slave Narrative Collection (1970), also published under the title Voices from Slavery: 100 Authentic Slave Narratives (revised edition, 2000).

In 1855, John Little, a fugitive slave who had escaped to Canada, uttered this perceptive commentary upon attempts to convey the realities of the existence that he had fled: "Tisn't he who has stood and looked on, that can tell you what slavery is--'tis he who has endured." The view that slavery could best be described by those who had themselves experienced it personally has found expression in several thousand commentaries, autobiographies, narratives, and interviews with those who "endured." Although most of these accounts appeared before the Civil War, more than one-third are the result of the ambitious efforts of the Federal Writers' Project of the Works Progress Administration (WPA) to interview surviving ex-slaves during the 1930s. The result of these efforts was the Slave Narrative Collection, a group of autobiographical accounts of former slaves that today stands as one of the most enduring and noteworthy achievements of the WPA. Compiled in seventeen states during the years 1936-38, the collection consists of more than two thousand interviews with former slaves, most of them first-person accounts of slave life and the respondents' own reactions to bondage. The interviews afforded aged ex-slaves an unparalleled opportunity to give their personal accounts of life under the "peculiar institution," to describe in their own words what it felt like to be a slave in the United States.1

The Slave Narrative Collection provides a unique and virtually unsurpassed collective portrait of a historical population. Indeed, historian David Brion Davis has argued that the voluminous number of documented slave testimonies available in the United States "is indisputably unique among former slaveholding nations."2 In addition to the substantial number of life histories it contains, the most compelling feature of the collection is the composition of the sample of people who made up its informants. Although not a representative sample of the slave population, they were a remarkably diverse and inclusive cross-section of former slaves. Those whose voices are included in the collection ranged in age from one to fifty at the time of emancipation in 1865, which meant that more than two-thirds were over eighty when they were interviewed. Almost all had experienced slavery within the states of the Confederacy and still lived there. They represented all the major slave occupations. Moreover, the size of the slave units on which respondents reported living varied considerably, from plantations with over a thousand slaves to situations in which the informant was his or her owner's only slave. The treatment these individuals reported ran the gamut from the most harsh, impersonal, and exploitative to work and living conditions and environments that were intimate and benevolent. In fact, except that most of the informants were relatively young when they experienced slavery (older slaves had died long before these interviews were undertaken), all the major categories of the slave population appear to be well represented in the collection.

Because the actual occupational distribution of the slave population is unknown, assurance of total randomness in this sample is impossible. But there appears little reason to believe that the processes involved in the selection of interviewees produced a sample that systematically diverged from the larger population. At least the sample biases that characterized the universe of antebellum slave autobiographies--the disproportionate number of runaways, individuals who had purchased their freedom or had been freed, males, craftsmen, and individuals from border states--are absent. While not totally eliminated, the methodological problem of sample bias that inevitably confronts the historian is substantially reduced in this sample of the ex-slave universe. The WPA narratives thus constitute an illuminating and invaluable source of data about antebellum and post-Emancipation Southern life, the institution of slavery, and, most important, the reactions and perspectives of those who had been enslaved.

Original Article

https://www.loc.gov/collections/slave-narratives-from-the-federal-writers-project-1936-to-1938/articles-and-essays/introduction-to-the-wpa-slave-narratives/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.10

Vesey, Denmark

Douglas R. Egerton

AUTHOR	Douglas R. Egerton (Professor of History, Le Moyne College; author of He Shall Go Out Free)
WEBSITE	South Carolina Encyclopedia, University of South Carolina, Institute for Southern Studies
PUBLICATION	2016; updated 2022
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.4.1 Support

Excerpt · 1,088 words (complete article)

Slave, artisan, abolitionist. Vesey was probably born on the Danish Caribbean sugar island of St. Thomas around 1767; the names and nationality of his parents are unknown. In 1781 he was purchased by Captain Joseph Vesey, a slave trader, who trained him as a cabin boy during the short voyage to the French colony of Saint Domingue. Captain Vesey sold the boy as one of 390 slaves in the city of Cap François but was forced to purchase him back on April 23, 1782, because the child had displayed "epileptic fits." These were perhaps feigned, for they ceased once the boy reboarded Captain Vesey's vessel. This time Joseph Vesey kept him and renamed him Telemaque, after the mythical son of Odysseus. Over time fellow slaves corrupted or punned the name into Telmack and then into Denmark, after the Danish-owned island of his birth.

In the late spring of 1783 Joseph Vesey established himself in Charleston as a ship chandler. Denmark evidently lived with the Vesey family on 281 King Street. For the next seventeen years the literate and multilingual Denmark was responsible for helping to receive imported goods from incoming ships, cataloging items in Captain Vesey's East Bay Street office, and even conducting minor transactions in his master's absence. At some point during this time Denmark married an enslaved woman named Beck, who gave birth to at least three of his children: Sandy, Polydore, and Robert. But Denmark and Beck never lived in the same home, and their relationship was further strained in 1796 when Joseph Vesey, now a widower, moved his household to the Grove, an Ashley River plantation.

Denmark's luck changed on November 9, 1799, when he won $1,500 in the "East-Bay Lottery." The captain and his wealthy mistress–who by then was Denmark's legal owner–agreed to let him purchase his freedom for $600. On December 31, 1799, Denmark handed over a portion of his winnings in exchange for his freedom papers. Because he intended to stay in Charleston and learn carpentry, he adopted the surname of Vesey, which was well known among the white businessmen who would be his main clients as the city expanded north up the peninsula.

Vesey rented a modest home at 20 Bull Street. Thomas Bennett, a merchant and politician, constructed his lumber mill at the west end of the avenue on the Ashley River, which made the street a natural home for men who earned their livelihoods in construction. There, following the collapse of his relationship with Beck, Vesey married the much younger Susan, who was born a slave around 1795 but gained her freedom early in the nineteenth century. Despite modern allegations that Vesey practiced polygamy, no evidence exists to support the theory. As the only woman to bear Denmark's adopted surname, Susan Vesey may have married her husband in one of the city's churches. To help supplement the family's meager income, Susan took in laundry and ironing from her white neighbors. Despite later assertions that Vesey died a wealthy man worth more than $7,000, there is no evidence that he ever owned property.

Vesey may have had his marriage to Susan solemnized in the Second Presbyterian Church, which he attended as late as April 1817. But perhaps infuriated by the proslavery brand of Christianity heard within that church's walls, Vesey became an early member (and lay preacher) in the city's African Methodist Episcopal Church on Anson Street, commonly dubbed the "African Church." Although the Reverend Morris Brown's Sunday sermons included a creative melding of African and Christian elements, Vesey's nightly Bible lessons turned to "the stern and Nemesis-like God of the Old Testament." Embittered by the continuing bondage of Beck and his children, Vesey turned his back on the New Testament and what he regarded as its false promise of universal brotherhood.

Recognizing the dangers that the African Church posed to white control, city authorities briefly closed its doors in 1818 and then again in late 1820 and in January 1821. In response, Vesey began to consider a plan by which he might lead his children and disciples into freedom in Haiti. What made his conspiracy unique was not merely the advanced age of its leader (fifty-four years), but that Vesey planned a mass exodus of families out of Charleston. The plot called for urban slaves and bondmen across the Ashley and Cooper Rivers to slay their masters on the morning of Sunday, July 14, 1822, and fight their way toward the city docks. Although Vesey employed several enslaved blacksmiths to forge weapons, the leading conspirators wisely decided not to stockpile weapons nor to recruit thousands of soldiers before mid-July. “Let us assemble a sufficient number to commence the work with spirit,” Vesey remarked, “and we’ll not want men, [as] they’ll fall in behind fast enough.”

On May 22 William Paul, one of Vesey’s chief recruiters, made a fatal mistake. While at the Market Wharf, he spoke of the plan to Peter, a mulatto cook, who passed the alarm to his master Colonel John C. Prioleau. At about the same time another mulatto slave, George Wilson, gave information about the plan to his master, who hurried with the news to Intendant (Mayor) James Hamilton and Governor Thomas Bennett. Exactly one month later, on June 22, Vesey was arrested at the “house of one of his wives,” probably Beck. Four days after his capture, the aged carpenter was brought before two magistrates and five freeholders in the city workhouse. The tribunal found Vesey guilty and sentenced him to hang “on Tuesday next, the 2d July, between six and eight in the morning.” On that morning Warden John Gordon loaded Vesey and five other abolitionists into a “cart” for the two-mile ride north to Blake’s Lands. Before “immense crowds of whites and blacks,” the six men hobbled up the gallows stairs. According to Intendant Hamilton, they collectively “met their fate with the fortitude of Martyrs.”

In all, related to Vesey’s plan, the Charleston courts arrested 131 slaves and free blacks. Thirty were released without trial. Of the 101 men who appeared before the tribunals, the magistrates ordered 35 hanged and 37, including Vesey’s daughter Sandy, transported to Spanish Cuba. Twenty-three were acquitted, 2 more died while in custody, 3 were found not guilty but were whipped, and 1 free black was released on condition that he leave the state. City authorities exiled the Reverend Morris Brown of the AME Church to Philadelphia and razed the building. Vesey’s son Robert rebuilt it in October 1865 at the end of the Civil War.

Original Article

https://www.scencyclopedia.org/sce/entries/vesey-denmark/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Egerton, "Vesey, Denmark."

CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.11

African American Christianity, Pt. I: To the Civil War

Laurie Maffly-Kipp

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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.4.1 Support; 11.4.3 Support

Excerpt · 683 words

The story of African-American religion is a tale of variety and creative fusion. Enslaved Africans transported to the New World beginning in the fifteenth century brought with them a wide range of local religious beliefs and practices. This diversity reflected the many cultures and linguistic groups from which they had come. The majority came from the West Coast of Africa, but even within this area religious traditions varied greatly. Islam had also exerted a powerful presence in Africa for several centuries before the start of the slave trade: an estimated twenty percent of enslaved people were practicing Muslims, and some retained elements of their practices and beliefs well into the nineteenth century. Catholicism had even established a presence in areas of Africa by the sixteenth century.

Preserving African religions in North America proved to be very difficult. The harsh circumstances under which most slaves lived—high death rates, the separation of families and tribal groups, and the concerted effort of white owners to eradicate "heathen" (or non-Christian) customs—rendered the preservation of religious traditions difficult and often unsuccessful. Isolated songs, rhythms, movements, and beliefs in the curative powers of roots and the efficacy of a world of spirits and ancestors did survive well into the nineteenth century. But these increasingly were combined in creative ways with the various forms of Christianity to which Europeans and Americans introduced African slaves. In Latin America, where Catholicism was most prevalent, slaves mixed African beliefs and practices with Catholic rituals and theology, resulting in the formation of entirely new religions such as vaudou in Haiti (later referred to as "voodoo"), Santeria in Cuba, and Candomblé in Brazil. But in North America, slaves came into contact with the growing number of Protestant evangelical preachers, many of whom actively sought the conversion of African Americans.

Religion and Slavery

In the decades after the American Revolution, northern states gradually began to abolish slavery, and thus sharper differences emerged in the following years between the experiences of enslaved peoples and those who were now relatively free. By 1810 the slave trade to the United States also came to an end and the slave population began to increase naturally, making way for the preservation and transmission of religious practices that were, by this time, truly "African-American."

This transition coincided with the period of intense religious revivalism known as "awakenings." In the southern states increasing numbers of slaves converted to evangelical religions such as the Methodist and Baptist faiths. Many clergy within these denominations actively promoted the idea that all Christians were equal in the sight of god, a message that provided hope and sustenance to the slaves. They also encouraged worship in ways that many Africans found to be similar, or at least adaptable, to African worship patterns, with enthusiastic singing, clapping, dancing, and even spirit-possession. Still, many white owners insisted on slave attendance at white-controlled churches, since they were fearful that if slaves were allowed to worship independently they would ultimately plot rebellion against their owners. It is clear that many blacks saw these white churches, in which ministers promoted obedience to one's master as the highest religious ideal, as a mockery of the "true" Christian message of equality and liberation as they knew it.

In the slave quarters, however, African Americans organized their own "invisible institution." Through signals, passwords, and messages not discernible to whites, they called believers to "hush harbors" where they freely mixed African rhythms, singing, and beliefs with evangelical Christianity. It was here that the spirituals, with their double meanings of religious salvation and freedom from slavery, developed and flourished; and here, too, that black preachers, those who believed that God had called them to speak his Word, polished their "chanted sermons," or rhythmic, intoned style of extemporaneous preaching. Part church, part psychological refuge, and part organizing point for occasional acts of outright rebellion (Nat Turner, whose armed insurrection in Virginia in 1831 resulted in the deaths of scores of white men, women, and children, was a self-styled Baptist preacher), these meetings provided one of the few ways for enslaved African Americans to express and enact their hopes for a better future.

Original Article

https://nationalhumanitiescenter.org/tserve/nineteen/nkeyinfo/aareligion.htm

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Maffly-Kipp, "African American Christianity."

CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.12

Gabriel's Rebellion (1800)

Michael L. Nicholls

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PUBLICATION	2020; updated 2026
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.4
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.4.1 Support

Excerpt · 922 words

Gabriel's Rebellion was a plan by enslaved African American men to attack Richmond and destroy slavery in Virginia. Although thwarted, it remains one of the half-dozen most important insurrection plots in the history of North American slavery. Named after an enslaved blacksmith who emerged as the most significant leader of the plot, Gabriel's Conspiracy originated during the spring and summer of 1800 in a Henrico County neighborhood north of Richmond and extended primarily across Hanover County into Caroline County and south toward Petersburg. Two enslaved men betrayed the plot just hours before a torrential rainstorm prevented the conspirators from gathering on the night of August 30, 1800. In response, Virginia authorities arrested and prosecuted more than seventy enslaved men for insurrection and conspiracy. Twenty-six of those found guilty were hanged and eight more were transported, or sold outside of the state, while another suspected conspirator committed suicide before his arraignment. A small number of free Blacks were also implicated and one was prosecuted. The alleged involvement of two Frenchmen in the plot provided fodder for Federalist attacks on Thomas Jefferson's candidacy for the presidency that year. The aborted uprising also provoked refinements in the state's slave laws at the next meeting of the General Assembly, including the adoption of transportation as an alternative to capital punishment for some enslaved offenders and calls for an end to private manumissions and for the deportation of free Blacks.

[Omitted: the entry's chronology and opening sections. The excerpt resumes in the section on the 1790s.]

During the 1790s many white Virginians believed that living conditions for enslaved people had improved since the American Revolution (1775–1783). Governor James Monroe said as much in his report on the slave plot to the General Assembly. Indeed, the state had banned the importation of enslaved laborers from Africa and the West Indies in 1778, private manumissions had become possible in 1782, and religious groups such as Quakers, Methodists, and to some extent Baptists had questioned the institution or condemned its worst practices. Two Virginians, Ferdinando Fairfax and St. George Tucker, had presented plans for the gradual elimination of the institution, but both tied their schemes to expectations that freed people of color would be forced out of the state. Neither proposal garnered much support, nor did private manumissions or moral criticisms of slavery ever really threaten the existence of the institution. But if enslavers believed their enslaved people were better off and that the institution was generally secure, the uprisings and rebellion that began in 1791 in the French colony of Saint-Domingue increased anxieties over its potential influence on Virginia's enslaved population, especially after hundreds of white refugees, some with their enslaved property, began arriving in Virginia in July 1793.

Later that month a conversation was overheard in Richmond among several Black men who, it was alleged, were discussing what property would soon be theirs; their purported reference to Saint-Domingue stirred up authorities in the capital. Concern spread after a letter was found a few weeks later on a street in Yorktown from the "Secret keeper" in Richmond to his counterpart in Norfolk; it contained references to men ready to rise in rebellion as far away as Charleston, South Carolina, and mentioned stockpiles of arms. According to the letter, the plot was to begin "in every town in one nite." Officials in Richmond, York, Norfolk, and Petersburg informed the governor of local fears or solicited arms for local militias, and Virginia authorities sent a warning to South Carolina. But the scare passed without further incident.

Several years later, on December 3, 1797, Richmond authorities charged Jacob Valentine, a white man who had been an officer during the Revolutionary War, with "committing and encouraging an Insurrection among the Slaves of the City of Richmond." When he couldn't produce a bond on December 11 to guarantee his good behavior, the court incarcerated him for several

months, but nothing else seems to have come of this incident. To many southerners, slave unrest seemed to arise from sources other than enslaved people themselves.

When Gabriel and his co-conspirators came together in the spring and summer of 1800, other issues were creating tensions in Virginia's social and political order. The outbreak of war in Europe following the French Revolution had divided Americans and contributed to the emergence of party factions. During the administration of President John Adams, a Federalist, the failure of a diplomatic effort to secure peace with France had led to congressional restrictions on speech—the Sedition Act (1798)—and an increase in the United States armed forces in anticipation of war with France. Opponents of these and other measures believed the federal government had exceeded its powers and that a future under the Federalists would lead to monarchical government. Federalists, on the other hand, viewed opposition to the federal government as both illegitimate and inspired by the worst ideals of the French Revolution.

As the campaign leading up to the election of 1800 intensified, some Virginia supporters of the Republican candidate, Thomas Jefferson, saw the stationing near Richmond of some of the recently raised federal troops as an attempt to intimidate Virginians at the polls. They also worried that the troops' presence was designed to influence the outcome of the sedition trial held in Richmond of James Thomson Callender, a harsh critic of the Adams administration. To enslaved men in the area, the undeclared, so-called Quasi-War with France (1798–1800) and the divisive nature of politics as reflected in the political campaigns of 1800 may well have made it seem an opportune time to rebel. This was especially true when, in June, the federal regiment demobilized, an event the conspirators noted.

Original Article

https://encyclopediavirginia.org/entries/gabriels-conspiracy-1800/

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.13

Home, Sweet Home: Gender in the Antebellum Household—Domestic Sphere

Elizabeth Vanek

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PUBLICATION	n.d.
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.5.1 Support; 11.5.2 Support; 11.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 838 words

[Excerpt begins with the exhibit section "Domestic Sphere."]

Wealthy white women epitomized the ideals of the domestic sphere by embodying the grace and leisure their class afforded them. The term lady was racially charged in the South. The English journalist, J. S Buckingham, wrote, "a female negro is call a 'wench,' or a 'woman'; ...which makes the term 'women' so offensive to American ears, when applied to white females, who must all be called ladies." Lady was a term for white women exclusively and usually for wealthy white women.[1]

Many elite white women in the South lived and worked on plantations. Plantations were like small factories producing raw goods. The hierarchy of the South prescribed certain roles for everyone on the plantation. White women were the mothers and the mistresses of the family.[2] Slave holding women oversaw labor within the house like the kitchen, garden and dairy. While not participating in all of the physical labor, a mistress's work was complex. The mistress had to procure all food not produced on the plantation. White women also had many children and were in charge of their children's education and they alone had exclusive right to motherhood. While slave women had children, the master could tear apart their family at anytime by selling members of the family. White men protected white women's right to motherhood. White women's life in the domestic sphere revolved around family. First she belonged to her biological family and after marriage to her husband and children.[3] While elite white women used slave labor in the household production, elite women did not spend all their days in leisure. Their privileged status allowed elite women to oversee instead of physically participating in the domestic sphere.

While the master controlled the plantation, the slave mistress was the administrator of domestic labor. While holding significantly less power than the master, slave mistresses had the responsibility to manage the household slaves. Even though black and white women lived in the domestic sphere, their womanhood did not unite them. The close physical proximity created tension between the mistress and slaves. Household slave women knew their mistress well and often used this knowledge to rebel against them. A successful slave mistress had to control the slaves, often implementing violence. A mistress' main goal was a smooth running household, meaning the mistress often supervised training and assignments of slaves. Paternalism allowed slave mistresses the authority as mother over the slaves in the domestic sphere. However, this paternalism never gave total control of the plantation to the mistress.[4]

The lithograph "The Life & Age of Woman" portrays a woman's life in the domestic sphere. It begins with a baby girl in a cradle. As the girl grows, she plays with a doll to prepare for her future as a mother. The adolescent girl holds a rose form a suitor as she prepares to become a wife. The next stage shows the young woman in her wedding, representing her leaving her biological family for her husband. The next step shows motherhood, with a woman holding an infant. At the top of the arch depicts a woman in the prime of her life as a mother and wife. The stage down shows the toll that the life in the domestic sphere takes on a woman. In the next the woman is dressed morning cloth as she becomes a widow. After that the women is shown becoming increasingly crippled and elderly. The final stage has an elderly woman knitting and waiting for death. This arch shows the ideal life for a woman in the life in the domestic sphere. It also demonstrates that as women become less useful as a unit of production and reproduction she becomes less valuable, shown here as hunched and small. The small arch at the bottom shows her family morning her after her death, her legacy from the domestic sphere mourns her. The arch in this lithograph shows the stages of

usefulness that women achieve throughout their life and the duties associated with age in the domestic sphere. Rich or poor white women's lives in the domestic sphere had strict roles that enforced their duties as units of production and reproduction.

Life in the private sphere for elite white women meant white men protecting women from the public sphere. Elite white female delicacy and purity required male protection. Historian Fox-Genovese writes "In a dangerous world ladies required protection against unruly men, white as well as black." This protection created the barrier of public and private. Protection isolated white women in the private sphere. Fox-Genovese also writes, "women have only one right - the right to protection. The right of protection involves the obligation to obey"[5] Protection was a luxury for white women with strings attached. To be protected, women needed to obey a white man. Marriage shifted the responsibility of protection from a woman's father to her husband. Sarah Gayle, a slave-owning woman from Alabama, wrote to her husband "from this moment henceforth, I acknowledge none but you as my protector in the wide, wide world."[6]

Original Article

https://cwnc.omeka.chass.ncsu.edu/exhibits/show/protect/1/domestic

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Vanek, "Domestic Sphere."

CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.14

Chesnut, Mary Boykin Miller

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WEBSITE	South Carolina Encyclopedia, University of South Carolina, Institute for Southern Studies
PUBLICATION	2016; updated 2022
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.5.1 Support; 11.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 718 words (complete article)

Diarist. Chesnut was born on her father's plantation near Stateburg in Sumter District on March 31, 1823. She is recognized as "the preeminent writer of the Confederacy" because of the diary she kept during the Civil War and revised for publication in the early 1880s. No other southern writer of her era possessed the combination of literary cultivation, psychological perception, opportunity to observe closely the upper echelons of the Confederacy, and a willingness to write candidly about people, events, and issues–including slavery. The resulting publication, much revised and more appropriately labeled a memoir, secured her place in southern literary history. Chesnut was the eldest child of Stephen Decatur Miller and Mary Boykin. Her father, a leader in the states' rights campaign, was elected governor in 1828 and U.S. senator in 1830. Thus, she grew up in a political environment. She received as good an education as could be provided a southern girl of her day, first at home and then at Madame Talvande's French School for Young Ladies in Charleston, where she acquired all of the intellectual and social equipment needed to flourish in her milieu. Her father's death in 1838 ended her carefree childhood, and she soon accepted a marriage proposal from James Chesnut, Jr., whom she had met in Charleston. They were married on April 23, 1840; she was barely seventeen.

Her new home, Mulberry, the baronial Chesnut plantation just south of Camden, was dominated by her parents-in-law, who would live twenty-five more years. Childless, Mary found little satisfaction and suffered bouts of depression and illness in this unfulfilling setting. She regarded her father-in-law, James Chesnut, Sr., as a tyrant and was appalled at the liberties he took with his female slaves. Although the couple moved to their own house in Camden in 1848, it was not until her husband's election to the U.S. Senate in 1858 that she found a society that suited her gifts and her zest for life. In Washington she flourished as a charming literary lady and valuable asset to her husband, attracting the admiration of several prominent men and arousing her husband's jealousy. Among her intimate friends was Varina Davis, wife of the senator and future Confederate president Jefferson Davis. When the secession of South Carolina ended this idyllic life after only two years, Chesnut quickly became an ardent southern patriot.

Chesnut began keeping a diary in February 1861, confessing regret that she had not done so earlier. James's prominent role in the new Confederacy carried her to the centers of action and allowed her to witness and record her impressions of those dramatic times. She was in Montgomery, Alabama, while the provisional Confederate government was being formed, in Charleston for the bombardment of Fort Sumter, and in Richmond when the new government moved to its permanent capitol. All the while she recorded her perceptive observations of people and events, and the frustrations of a spirited woman in a world of men, many of whom she considered too "discrete, cautious, lazy for the roles they were playing." The couple returned to South Carolina in 1862 as James became chairman of the state's Executive Council. James, urged on by Mary, accepted a post as aide to President Davis in December, and again in Richmond she experienced and wrote about the highs and lows of war. The death of her mother-in-law in 1864 brought them home again to care for his father, now ninety-three and blind.

In early 1865 Union forces ravaged Mulberry and the Chesnuts took refuge in North Carolina and then in Chester, South Carolina. After the war James inherited his father's property but also large debts. A butter-and-egg business provided the little cash they had for some time, but they grew closer as a couple. Since her father-in- law's will left his property to his son and, on James's death (he died in 1885), to his grandsons, Chesnut found security only in the new Camden home built for her in the early 1870s. There she completed the revisions and extensions of her war diary by the mid-1880s. However, before it was published, Mary Chesnut died of a heart attack on November 22, 1886. She was buried next to her husband in Knight's Hill Cemetery in Camden. Mary Chesnut was posthumously inducted into the South Carolina Academy of Authors in 1987.

Original Article

https://www.scencyclopedia.org/sce/entries/chesnut-mary-boykin-miller/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.15

Women in North Carolina, Part 4: Life in Antebellum North Carolina

Terrell A. Crow and Ansley Herring Wegner

AUTHOR	Terrell A. Crow and Ansley Herring Wegner (Contributors, Encyclopedia of North Carolina (UNC Press, 2006))
WEBSITE	NCpedia, State Library of North Carolina
PUBLICATION	2006
CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 11 | 11.5
ARGUMENT ROLES	11.5.1 Support; 11.5.2 Support; 11.5.3 Support

Excerpt · 527 words (complete article)

The seasonal routines of agrarian life defined North Carolina culture throughout most of the antebellum era. Women of the state's planter elite generally met the expectations of southern society rather than seeking independent careers. Southern patriarchy gave planter women stronger ties with their male relations than with women of other classes and races. Planter women supervised complex households of slaves and children. The work was never-ending, even for women who escaped much of the drudgery by using servants and slaves. Planter women also faced repeated pregnancies. Many found the unceasing demands and lack of privacy exhausting.

Elite women who lived in towns escaped the agrarian responsibilities of plantation women, and some used their time to work in volunteer groups. They began attending political gatherings after about 1840, and a few wrote and published under pseudonyms in newspapers and literary journals. Educated, intelligent women used their talents to create opportunities for themselves while remaining southern "ladies."

Meanwhile, slave women worked from dawn until dusk and then had to care for their own families at night. House slaves might develop skills as midwives, weavers, and cooks and obtain special status within the white and slave communities. Enslaved women left few records of their experiences, but interviews conducted in the 1930s with former North Carolina slaves indicate the importance of religion and family in the slave community and the anguish caused by the separation of families. These accounts also reveal how slave mistresses enforced their authority through whippings, poor food, and threats to put slaves "in their pocket," meaning to sell them if they caused trouble. The difficulty slave women faced in caring for their own children and babies when forced always to put the needs of the white family first are well documented. Additionally, they faced the threat of sexual assault by their owners, as strikingly described by Harriet Jacobs in her book Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl, Written by Herself (1861).

Religious revivals swept the state in repeated waves during the nineteenth century. Yeoman women participated in emotionally charged services to seek salvation and to express themselves in meetings. They fed and housed traveling ministers. Women from all classes joined churches to obtain a degree of independence. More women than men became church members during the nineteenth century. Baptist women as early as 1810 raised money for church missionary work, and women of other denominations followed. Groups of women started charitable organizations in New Bern, Fayetteville, Wilmington, Raleigh, and Elizabeth City for the worthy poor. Antebellum society accepted this work outside the home as an extension of women's roles as wives and mothers.

Marriage was a civil contract in North Carolina, but women remained unequal partners. Women hoped for affectionate marriages, but the gap between these expectations and reality troubled many wives. The sexual double standard applied to white men displeased many women. Some husbands were poor businessmen, as well. If women chose unwisely in their partners, the legal system offered little help. Divorce proved difficult to obtain in a state controlled by men determined to maintain white male authority over wives and slaves. The courts often protected a husband's right to chastise his wife.

Original Article

https://www.ncpedia.org/women-part-4-life-antebellum-north-

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 11 · WEB ARTICLE W11.16

Stephanie Jones-Rogers Gives Interview on How White Women's "Investment" in Slavery Has Shaped America Today

Stephanie E. Jones-Rogers (interview by Anna North)

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WEBSITE	History News Network
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Excerpt · 364 words (complete article)

In her recent book, They Were Her Property: White Women as Slave Owners in the American South, Jones-Rogers makes the case that white women were far from passive bystanders in the business of slavery, as previous historians argued. Rather, they were active participants, shoring up their own economic power through ownership of the enslaved.

In the past, historians had often based their conclusions about white women's role in slavery on the writings of a small subset of white Southern women. But Jones-Rogers, an associate professor of history at the University of California Berkeley, drew on a different source: interviews with formerly enslaved people conducted during the Great Depression as part of the Federal Writers' Project, an arm of the Works Progress Administration. These interviews, Jones-Rogers writes, show that white girls were trained in slave ownership, discipline, and mastery sometimes from birth, even being given enslaved people as gifts when they were as young as nine months old.

The result was a deep investment by white women in slavery, and its echoes continue to be felt today. As the New York Times and others commemorate the date, 400 years ago, when enslaved Africans arrived in Virginia, Vox reached out to Jones-Rogers to talk about the history of white, slaveholding women in the South and what that history says about race, gender, wealth, and power in America in 2019. Our conversation has been condensed and edited.

Anna North

Can you talk a little about how this book came about?

Stephanie Jones-Rogers

When I was in graduate school, I was taking all these different courses and reading all these books on African American history but also on women's and gender history. I was particularly interested in what these two subfields of history had to say about white women's economic investments in the institution of slavery. What struck me is that they seemed to be in direct contradiction to each other, in many respects.

Those historians who explored the experiences of white Southern women would often argue that while women had access to enslaved people that male kin or their spouses may have owned, they were not directly involved in the buying and selling of enslaved people — particularly married women weren't.

Original Article

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FULL FOOTNOTE

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Jones-Rogers, "Stephanie Jones-Rogers Gives Interview."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.1

Evangelicalism, Revivalism, and the Second Great Awakening

Donald Scott

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ARGUMENT ROLES	12.1.1 Support

Excerpt · 695 words

Nineteenth century America contained a bewildering array of Protestant sects and denominations, with different doctrines, practices, and organizational forms. But by the 1830s almost all of these bodies had a deep evangelical emphasis in common. Protestantism has always contained an important evangelical strain, but it was in the nineteenth century that a particular style of evangelicalism became the dominant form of spiritual expression. What above all else characterized this evangelicalism was its dynamism, the pervasive sense of activist energy it released. As Charles Grandison Finney, the leading evangelical of mid-nineteenth century America, put it: "religion is the work of man, it is something for man to do." This evangelical activism involved an important doctrinal shift away from the predominately Calvinist orientation that had characterized much of eighteenth-century American Christianity. Eighteenth-century Calvinists like Jonathan Edwards or George Whitefield had stressed the sinful nature of humans and their utter incapacity to overcome this nature without the direct action of the grace of God working through the Holy Spirit. Salvation was purely in God's hands, something he dispensed as he saw fit for his own reasons. Nineteenth-century evangelicals like Finney, or Lyman Beecher, or Francis Asbury, were no less unrelenting in their emphasis on the terrible sinfulness of humans. But they focused on sin as human action. For all they preached hellfire and damnation, they nonetheless harbored an unshakable practical belief in the capacity of humans for moral action, in the ability of humans to turn away from sinful behavior and embrace moral action. Whatever their particular doctrinal stance, most nineteenth-century evangelicals preached a kind of practical Arminianism which emphasized the duty and ability of sinners to repent and desist from sin.

Conversion

The core of nineteenth-century evangelicalism was the experience of conversion. Conversion was compelled by a set of clear ideas about the innate sinfulness of humans after Adam's fall, the omnipotence of God--his awful power and his mercy--and, finally, the promise of salvation for fallen humankind through Christ's death on the cross as the atonement for human sin. But what students need to understand is that conversion was an experience. It was not simply something that people believed--though belief or faith was essential to it--but something that happened to them, a real, intensely emotional event they went through and experienced as a profound psychological transformation left them with a fundamentally altered sense of self, an identity as a new kind of Christian. As they interpreted it, they had undergone spiritual rebirth, the death of an old self and the birth of a new one that fundamentally transformed their sense of their relationship to the world.

Conversion consisted of a sequence of clearly mapped-out steps, each of which was accompanied by a powerful emotion that led the penitent from the terror of eternal damnation through redemption to the promise of heavenly salvation. The process of conversion characteristically began in a state of "concern" about the state of one's soul and "inquiry" into what were called the doctrines of salvation propelled by the question "what can I do to be saved?" This led to a state of acute spiritual "anxiety," marked by deep fear over the prospect of eternal damnation, which in turn grew into an unmistakable sense of "conviction," the heartfelt realization that one stood justly condemned for one's sins and deserved eternal damnation. Conviction was the terrifying point of recognition that no matter how much one might desire it, there was absolutely nothing one could do to earn salvation. But there was something the penitent could do, indeed, was bound to do. That was to fully repent and surrender unconditionally to God's will to do with as he saw fit and to serve him fully. It was this act of repentance, surrender, and dedication to serving his will that Finney meant when in his most famous sermon he insisted that "sinners [are] bound to change their own hearts." This moment of renunciation of sin and the abject surrender to the will to God was the moment of conversion, if it was to come, the moment at which, through the promise of Christ's atonement for human sin, a merciful God would bestow his grace upon the repentant sinner.

Original Article

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Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Scott, "Evangelicalism, Revivalism."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.2

Evangelicalism as a Social Movement

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ARGUMENT ROLES	12.1.1 Support; 12.1.2 Support; 12.2.1 Support; 12.2.2 Support

Excerpt · 1,104 words

Evangelicalism needs to be understood not only as a religious movement, but also as a social movement. As such, it was an integral part of a broader organizational revolution that transformed nineteenth-century American society. For the most part, eighteenth-century Americans lived their lives within hierarchically ordered institutions. They were oriented primarily to place, and they valued order and stability in their families, work lives, and communities. Communities were composed of a recognizable set of "ranks and orders" in which the higher orders governed and the lower orders were expected to defer to the greater wisdom and virtue of their betters. Families were mini-hierarchies governed by male heads of household who sought suitable marriages for their daughters and tried to place their sons in appropriate occupations. By the early nineteenth century, however, Americans increasingly had become a people in motion, constantly moving across social and geographical space. Under the force of this fluidity, families, towns, and occupational structures lost much of their traditional capacity to regulate individual and social life. Instead, Americans devised a different kind of institutional order as they turned to an increasingly dense fabric of new organizations—religious sects and denominations, voluntary societies of various sorts, and political parties—to give needed structure and direction to their lives.

Historians have usually looked to political parties, reform societies like temperance organizations, or fraternal associations like the Masons for the origins of this new associational order. In fact, evangelicals were its earliest and most energetic inventors. Indeed, as historian Donald Mathews has pointed out, the Second Great Awakening was an innovative and highly effective organizing process. Religious recruitment was intensely local, a species of grass-roots organizing designed to draw people into local congregations. But recruitment into a local Baptist, Methodist, or Universalist church also inducted people into a national organization and affiliational network that they could participate in wherever they moved. Moreover, adherence to a particular evangelical denomination also inducted them into the broader evangelical campaign. Conversion thus not only brought communicants into a new relationship to God, it also brought them into a new and powerful institutional fabric that provided them with personal discipline, a sense of fellowship, and channeled their benevolent obligations in appropriate directions. Aggressively exploiting a wide variety of new print media, evangelicals launched their own newspapers and periodicals and distributed millions of devotional and reform tracts. (By 1835, the cross-denominational American Tract Society and the American Sunday School Union alone distributed more than 75 million pages of religious material and were capable of delivering a new tract each month to every household in New York City.) They deployed home missionaries, circuit-riding preachers, and agents from town to town preaching revivals, organizing new churches and religious reform societies, and distributing Bibles and other religious materials. By the l830s, these devices, in conjunction with the aggressive revivalism that was the hallmark of the new evangelicalism, had assembled a huge new evangelical public. Not for nothing did evangelicals and nonevangelicals alike dub this new religious phalanx the "Evangelical Empire."

Guiding Student Discussion

One way to help students understand the character and scope of this religious mobilization is to see it as analogous in form and comparable in scale to the new democratic politics associated with the Jacksonian era. Just as a new form of politics emerged in which the pursuit of power came to center on intense, organized competition for the allegiance of an expanding democratic electorate, so too did religion come to revolve around the intense competition of religious bodies old and new to win adherents of their particular belief. Sects and denominations thus can be seen as directly analogous to political parties. Similarly, just as the new-style politicians like Martin van Buren made their mark as much by their skill as organizers as by their oratory, so too did new-style evangelical clergymen like Methodist John Asbury, Congregational-Presbyterian Lyman Beecher, or Universalist Alexander Campbell. When viewed from this perspective, the religious practices associated most fully with evangelicalism represent what historian Nathan Hatch has referred to as "the democratization of American religion."

Just as the intense competition for their votes seemed to enshrine "the people" as the ultimate arbiter of politics, so too did the competition for religious adherents give communicants power. To succeed—to win elections—politicians had to fashion their message to the needs and interests of their constituents; similarly, if a clergyman wanted to win and hold adherents, he had to fit his preaching to the spiritual needs of his communicants. Individual communicants were great preacher shoppers, ever ready to abandon a "cold" and "formal" preacher for someone from a different denomination whose "edifying" preaching was more to their liking. Congregations readily dismissed clergymen whose preaching failed to move them or whose other ministrations fell short. But the tie between democracy and evangelicalism was even stronger. Not only had religion become more democratic, it was in itself a democratizing force. Evangelicalism reinforced the growing sense of the sovereign power of the individual: it made the individual's own religious experience—not the clergy's learning and authority, not formal creeds and doctrines—the ultimate spiritual arbiter. Moreover, for evangelical converts, self-esteem came not from secular social status but from spiritual standing, measured by intensity of feeling and dedication to evangelical disciplines. The respect of their brothers and sisters in the faith was more important to them than external social standing. They counted themselves in no way inferior to any person who possessed mere wealth and secular prominence.

Ideas about conversion, revival strategies, new modes of organizing—all these things were essential to the extraordinary growth of early nineteenth-century evangelicalism. But in the end they are not sufficient to account for its prosperity. It is the appeal of evangelicalism for so many Americans that needs to be explained. To get at this question we need to place evangelicalism in the context of what historian Gordon Wood has called a "social and cultural revolution as great as any in American history." No longer a relatively stable order in which people occupied a recognizable secure place, American society seemed to have become a chaotic jumble in which few things remained unchanged and few people remained in the same place, a scramble of aspiring individuals moving from place to place and situation to situation in what Abraham Lincoln called "the race of life." Americans embraced this new society as unprecedentedly democratic, a land of vast opportunity in which the individual (so long as he was male and white) was free to rise to whatever position his talent and effort took him. But if American society held out unprecedented opportunity for "rise," "betterment," and "improvement," it was also a site of uncertainty, isolation, frustration, and anxiety.

Original Article

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Chicago Citations

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Scott, "Evangelicalism as a Social Movement."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.3

Jarena Lee and the Early A.M.E. Church

National Museum of African American History and Culture

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Excerpt · 646 words (complete article)

The Second Great Awakening marked an era of transformation for America, and a new path forward for Jarena Lee.

Born into a free Black family in Cape May, NJ in 1783 and later moving to Philadelphia, Lee navigated the intense religiosity and social reformation of her time to emerge as the nation's first African American woman preacher, and the first woman to be recognized as an evangelist in the male-dominated African Methodist Episcopal (AME) Church.

Lee's journey to Christianity began when she moved to Philadelphia as a young adult in 1807. Like many Americans in her time, Lee struggled with changing national beliefs on human nature, morality, and the path to salvation. To find her own answers, she sought out a personal connection to the gospel. During her search, she heard the teachings of famed preacher Bishop Richard Allen and was so inspired by his powerful sermon that she decided to get baptized and fully convert to Christianity.

But Lee's path to faith would be difficult. The years that followed saw her in a continuous battle between her spirituality and her desire for "the vanities of this life." Lee also struggled to make a place for herself and her passion for the gospel within the male-dominated church—a struggle that brought on depression and even thoughts of suicide.

Despite the challenges, this time also served to fuel Lee's conviction to go beyond the church and share her faith in Christ with the world.

She carried this conviction with her when she moved back to New Jersey in 1811 after marrying Methodist Pastor Joseph Lee. While in New Jersey, Jarena Lee was able to serve in an African Methodist congregation and grow her faith, but she still couldn't practice what she believed was her true calling: preaching.

Seven years into her marriage, Lee became a widow. The grief that followed her husband's death only strengthened Lee's conviction to "preach the word of God." She returned to Philadelphia shortly after, determined to advocate for women in the ministry.

Initially, Bishop Allen, who by then had founded the African Methodist Episcopal (AME) Church refused to grant Lee permission to preach because the church banned female ministers. But Lee was driven by the intensity of her faith, so she began delivering sermons wherever she could—in open fields, town squares, and even in her own home.

Then one day, while at a Sunday worship service at Bishop Allen's church, Lee noticed that a guest speaker was struggling with his message—so she sprung to action, picking up where he left off to deliver her own testimony. Bishop Allen was so impressed by Lee's preaching and boldness that he publicly endorsed her, and shortly after she was ordained, becoming the first woman preacher in the AME Church.

Lee's evangelical career spanned three decades and greatly intersected with her equal rights advocacy and her powerful leadership within the abolitionist movement. Before her ultimate death in 1849, Jarena Lee became the first Black woman to publish an autobiographical memoir, The Life and Religious Experience of Jarena Lee.

"For as unseemly as it may appear now-a-days for a woman to preach," Lee says, "it should be remembered that nothing is impossible with God. And why should it be thought impossible…or improper for a woman to preach?"

At a time when Black women's contributions were often overlooked or forgotten, it is Lee's relentless persistence that helped her break down barriers and pave the way for Black women to enter the ministry.

Like so many Black pioneers of her time, Jarena Lee's story is one of resiliency, optimism, and spirituality—values that are deeply rooted throughout African American history and culture. Her story is not widely known, but Lee's legacy as the first African American woman preacher represents an important example of Black women defying social barriers, transcending traditional gender roles, and touching the hearts, minds, and souls of many.

Original Article

https://nmaahc.si.edu/explore/stories/jarena-lee-and-early-ame-church

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

"Jarena Lee."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.4

Horace Mann and the Creation of the Common School

Graham Warder

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WEBSITE	Social Welfare History Project, VCU Libraries
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CHAPTER / PROMPTS	Chapter 12 | 12.2
ARGUMENT ROLES	12.2.1 Support; 12.2.2 Support; 12.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 577 words (complete article)

Horace Mann (1796-1859), "The Father of the Common School Movement," was the foremost proponent of education reform in antebellum America. An ardent member of the Whig Party, Mann argued that the common school, a free, universal, non-sectarian, and public institution, was the best means of achieving the moral and socioeconomic uplift of all Americans. The reform movement he led sought to create the virtuous republican citizenry needed to sustain American political institutions, the educated workforce required to expand the American economy, and the disciplined generation necessary to forestall the social disorders so common in American cities in the decades before the Civil War.

Brother-in-law of Nathaniel Hawthorne and close friend of Samuel Gridley Howe, Mann was well connected to the cultural and political elite of New England. Mann held numerous political offices in Massachusetts state government in 1820s and 1830s, and he represented Massachusetts as an anti-slavery Whig in the House of Representatives from 1848 to 1853, taking the seat vacated by the death of John Quincy Adams.

The most influential post he occupied, however, was that of Secretary of the Massachusetts Board of Education. From that pulpit, to which he was appointed in 1837, Mann would spread the gospel of education as social redemption. The common school would mitigate class conflict, circumvent anarchy, enhance civic engagement, and perhaps most importantly inculcate moral habits, all by molding society's most malleable members. Like his friend Howe, Mann was a Unitarian, and his inclusion of the Bible in school curriculum was based on Unitarian doctrine. Children were to be exposed to the words and moral teachings of the Bible but would not be indoctrinated to any specific denomination. Such openness merely reflected the liberal theology of his Unitarianism. The orthodox Congregationalists of New England opposed many of Mann's reforms.

Mann's ideas reached far beyond the borders of the Bay State. A national spokesman for education reform, he wrote numerous books and founded and edited "The Common School Journal," a periodical that successful spread the message that public schools should be more open and nurturing, with a wider curriculum delivered by professional teachers. He visited Massachusetts schools to determine their needs and went to Europe in 1843 to research educational institutions there. He was especially impressed with the school system existing in Prussia, including the Prussian approach to educating deaf children.

Like those of many reformers, Horace Mann's historical legacy is mixed. Some historians consider his movement as an important step toward a more open and fluid society in which merit would trump birth. Other historians view the common school as a rather blunt tool for social control, one that tended both to stifle intellectual curiosity and to suppress diversity. He certainly sought to universalize the values and beliefs of the mainstream Protestant middle class of the North. The Irish immigrants to Massachusetts were especially vociferous in their condemnation of his Protestant-centered morality and reacted by constructing their own system of parochial schools.

For people with disabilities, Mann legacy is especially troubling. The controversies about Mann's reforms influenced Howe's handling of Laura Bridgman. For Deaf Americans, Mann's role as an early proponent of oral education had long-term negative consequences. According to Mann, intellect required spoken language. While lauding Howe's work at Perkins Institution, he was far less sanguine about the approach to deaf education initiated by Thomas Gallaudet at the American Asylum for the Deaf in Hartford, Connecticut. Mann's attacks on sign language may represent the opening salvos of oralism.

Original Article

https://socialwelfare.library.vcu.edu/programs/education/horace-mann-creation-common-school/

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Warder, "Horace Mann."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.5

Dix, Dorthea Lynde

Graham Warder

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ARGUMENT ROLES	12.2.1 Support

Excerpt · 1,024 words (complete article)

Dorothea Dix was born on April 4, 1802 in the frontier town of Hampden, Maine. Her father was poor, a drifter, and probably an alcoholic. He was also a Methodist minister and thus preached to the common folk. Dorothea had a troubled childhood and later portrayed herself as an orphan. She may have been concealing her upbringing out of embarrassment. At twelve, she moved to Boston to live with her wealthy grandmother. She became a teacher for girls, wrote and published moral tales for children, and came under the influence of Unitarianism, the religion of Boston's wealthy elite who had rejected Congregationalism in the early 1800s. Unitarianism was a softer faith than the one in which she had been raised. Unitarians, for example, were less likely to emphasize sinfulness, hell, and damnation than either Methodists or Congregationalists. It was more likely to stress reason and the role of wealthy people in setting examples for those they saw as social inferiors.

In Boston, Dix developed a powerful network of allies, including the Rev. William Ellery Channing, for whose children Dix served as a nanny. Channing was the American leader of a revitalized Unitarianism that promoted all sorts of social reforms. He favored an active humanitarian outlook. Because of her connections with Channing, Dix become acquainted with and deeply respected by Boston's Brahmin leaders — Ralph Waldo Emerson, Horace Mann, Charles Sumner, and Samuel Gridley Howe, important allies in her later career as a professional reformer.

Dix came of age during a period of tremendous change. Like many Americans of the 1820s and 1830s, she was influenced by the religious upheavals of the Second Great Awakening, the revivalism sweeping the nation. She also witnessed the social and economic upheavals of the Market Revolution, the spread of a growing commercial economy into what had been isolated rural backwaters. Like so many contemporaries, Dix experimented with religion. Her spiritual wanderings led her away from the emotional backcountry religiosity of her father to the more rational ideology and assumptions of moral stewardship embraced by Boston's Unitarians. She shifted from the fire-and-brimstone sensibilities of Methodism to something much cooler and more elitist and genteel. In other words, her soul and psyche journeyed from "fire" to "ice." Her journey also took her from the nomadic poverty and marginality of her father's life to the opulent success and intellectual wealth of Boston's high society — the people who came to be known as the Brahmins.

Both theology and class led people like Dix to express concern for the unfortunate. But upon what group of unfortunates would she focus her energies? Dix did not truly discover her life's work until she was almost forty years old. She did not become a leader in the asylum movement until she herself experienced a debilitating bout of depression and physical illness in 1836. Then Dix traveled to England and stayed for five years. While there she learned of reforms in the treatment of insanity. She met Samuel Tuke, the superintendent of the York Retreat and a leader in British asylum reform. He was the grandson of William Tuke, an early proponent of "moral treatment" for mental disorders. Moral treatment asserted that people with mentally illnesses could be nurtured back to rationality in "home-like" settings.

Dix returned to Massachusetts and in 1841 began teaching Sunday school to women at the East Cambridge jail. There she observed firsthand that many inmates had a psychiatric disability and suffered from abuse and neglect. Appalled by the conditions she witnessed at the jail, she embarked on a career as a sort of early investigative reporter, at a time when no such career existed. Thereafter, reforming the care of the insane became her passion and purpose in life.

Dix had found her calling, a mission to which she could devote her talents. She traveled throughout Massachusetts examining jails and almshouses to collect the evidence needed to create an argument for better care.

In January, 1843, Dix presented her petition before the state legislature. The immediate goal was to secure funding to increase the size of the State Hospital for the Insane in Worcester. In Gothic vividness, Dix declared, "I proceed, gentlemen, briefly to call your attention to the present state of insane persons confined within this Commonwealth, in *cages, closets, cellars, stalls, pens! Chained, naked, beaten with rods, and lashed into obedience*..." In her petition, hers is the only voice. In her calls for sympathy, we see things through her eyes alone. She holds a monopoly on perspective. Her petition was also a powerful indictment against the cruel and irresponsible practices of jail wardens and almshouse keepers.

Dix's efforts took her outside the accepted cultural norms of behavior for women. In 1843, women could not vote, and respectable women were expected to remain within the private "sphere," the world of children, morality, piety, and home. Women had moral authority but no political power. Dix became an effective and active political lobbyist at the state and federal levels of government, and she assumed a public role very rare for a woman of her generation. But her activities were also carefully limited. Dix wrote, but men spoke. In presenting evidence in support of asylum reform, Dorothea Dix directly addressed neither the Massachusetts Legislature, the United States Senate, nor the House of Representatives. She instead relied on powerful male allies to speak for her.

Despite voices raised in local newspapers questioning Dix's account, her emotionally powerful memorials were successful. In her first appeal (many others would follow), the Massachusetts legislature granted a large increase in funding for the Worcester institution. In the long career ahead, Dix would travel throughout the country to lobby for the construction of asylums by the states and even the federal government. She played a direct role in the establishment of 32 state institutions for the care of the mentally ill.

During the Civil War, Dix was placed in charge of all female nurses in Union military hospitals and aspired to be the American Florence Nightingale. She believed that women, not men, were superior caretakers, but she also demanded that all nurses be plain-looking and at least thirty years of age.

Original Article

https://socialwelfare.library.vcu.edu/people/dix-dorthea-lynde/

Chicago Citations

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.6

Eastern State Penitentiary

Jennifer Lawrence Janofsky

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Excerpt · 825 words

Eastern State Penitentiary, considered by many to be the world's first full-scale penitentiary, opened in Philadelphia in 1829 and closed in 1971. Known for its system of total isolation of prisoners and remarkable architecture, Eastern State proved to be one of the most controversial institutions of the antebellum period. Abandoned as a prison in the 1970s, Eastern State became a popular museum of penal history and continued to serve as a stark reminder of the failure of isolation as a humane model of punishment.

Eastern State emerged from the concerns of prison reformers in Philadelphia in the late eighteenth century, when prisons held accused criminals only until their trials. If convicted, prisoners faced public and corporal punishment. Following the American Revolution, reformers including Dr. Benjamin Rush (1746-1813) argued for a more humane and systematic approach to treating criminality and began advocating for a system of incarceration as the primary form of punishment. Isolation, he argued, would provide the criminal with an appropriate environment to repent, reflect, and ultimately reform. In this spirit, in 1787 advocates for reforming Philadelphia's prisons formed the Pennsylvania Society for Alleviating the Miseries of Public Prisons under the direction of Bishop William White (1748-1836), though Rush provided the driving force. Many modern accounts attribute Eastern State's early approach to Quaker inspiration, but considerable evidence suggests that the penitentiary's strategies were grounded in Enlightenment thought in England that made its way across the Atlantic and took hold in the prison society.

Experiments with prisoner isolation began in the 1790s at the Walnut Street Jail, located between Fifth and Sixth Streets behind the Pennsylvania State House (later Independence Hall). Opened in 1775, the Walnut Street Jail housed accused men, women, and children together in common rooms until they went to trial. In the aftermath of the Revolution, critics of this "den of debauchery" and "school of crime" successfully petitioned the state to eliminate harsh public punishments such as whippings, brandings, and beatings in favor of a new experiment in isolation and labor. All prisoners were sentenced to labor within the walls of the prison, thereby moving punishment from the public to the private—an important shift in penological theory.

In 1789 and 1790 Pennsylvania passed legislation to convert a portion of the Walnut Street Jail into a penitentiary house, where more serious offenders would serve their sentences in complete isolation. Advocates of isolation, who argued for the humanity of silent reflection over the barbaric punishments of the past, initially viewed the experiment positively. However, by the late 1790s the system began to break down due to severe overcrowding and mismanagement.

Total Isolation on a Large Scale

In response to prison society reformers' agitation for a new penitentiary based on the concept of total isolation, in 1821 the Pennsylvania Legislature appropriated $250,000 for Eastern State. Reformers chose a site northwest of the city (later Philadelphia's Fairmount neighborhood), where they believed the high elevation would promote good air flow and contribute to healthy prisoners. In the competition to determine who would design the new penitentiary, prominent Philadelphia architect William Strickland (1788-1854) and British-trained architect John Haviland (1792-1852) both submitted plans. The state awarded Haviland the project and a $100 prize.

Haviland faced the formidable task of designing an institution based entirely on prisoner separation. To meet each prisoner's needs in isolation, each cell needed to be equipped with a rudimentary toilet and central heat. Haviland chose a "hub and spoke" design or a radial plan, which would facilitate the observation of prisoners as well as properly ventilate the building. Prisoner

health and the avoidance of miasmas (bad air) were among the concerns of reformers, who remembered all too well the deadly epidemics of the Walnut Street Jail. The penitentiary's interior earned Haviland high praise, and Eastern's imposing gothic facade made it one of the most recognizable buildings in nineteenth-century America.

Opened in 1829, Eastern State's unique system of solitary confinement and labor became known as the "Pennsylvania System" or "separate system." This new system effectively merged the best qualities of the Walnut Street Prison: solitary confinement and labor. To preserve isolation and anonymity at all times, prison policy required inmates to wear hoods whenever overseers moved them around the penitentiary. To help offset the cost of incarceration, the state required prisoners to do work in their cells, including shoemaking, weaving, and chair caning. They ate three meals a day in their cells and exercised one to two times daily in small exterior exercise yards. On Sundays local ministers offered sermons in the corridors. The only other visitors allowed were members of the prison society or a local minister employed by the penitentiary known as the "moral instructor." The Philadelphia Bible Society provided prisoners with Bibles, and when the number of German prisoners began to rise in the 1840s, the German Society provided German Bibles. Reformers no doubt believed a Bible could be a source of consolation for lonely prisoners, but many prisoners struggled with illiteracy and the Bible remained inaccessible to them.

Original Article

https://philadelphiaencyclopedia.org/essays/eastern-state-penitentiary/

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.7

Poor Relief and the Almshouse

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ARGUMENT ROLES	12.2.2 Support; 12.2.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,066 words

For an amazingly long three hundred years prior to the passage of the Social Security Act of 1935, the only aid available to people who were poor, elderly, disabled, widowed, orphaned or otherwise in need came from local authorities who administered the "Poor Laws," laws which came to the United States with English settlers in the 1620s. Whether you were a once-prosperous man who was hurt in an accident or a poor woman who had an illegitimate child, you needed to go to your town or city's Overseers of the Poor, who would judge whether you were "deserving" or "worthy" enough to secure some minimal aid. They also examined whether you were a person deemed "settled" in the particular town or city. Overseers of the Poor were local officials, like selectman or freeholders, who usually knew little or nothing of poverty but came from the middle or even upper classes. Some no doubt were compassionate, some not so much.

Meeting the eligibility requirements of the Poor Laws was not easy. Widows or elderly who were well known in a town were often granted small amounts of aid at home, usually food or fuel, but many people, particularly unemployed men who looked able to work (including many we today would see as mentally disabled) and women who were judged as immoral (particularly if they were sexual outside of marriage), were frequently found unworthy of aid. Gradually American reformers hoped to move those they considered the "undeserving poor" into almshouses or poorhouses, if they gave them any help at all. Aid for those who received help at home was called "outdoor relief," as you did not have to give up your home and independence to move into an institution, which was called "indoor relief." Settlement was extremely hard for poor people to achieve. Particularly after the great immigration of the mid-nineteenth century, many states raised the number of years a person had to live and pay taxes in one town to as high as seven years to qualify for residence. Women, who were not seen as citizens, could gain settlement only if their husbands or fathers had this record of settlement. Of course, no recent immigrant could achieve such settlement, so they were often denied aid by the Overseers of the Poor, and if they got aid at all, it would be in a poorhouse.

The "poorhouse" still struck fear into people's minds into the late twentieth century. My mother would say, "you are driving us to the poorhouse!" if I asked for something slightly expensive. It was not a joke. The Monopoly game included until recently a card that said, "Go to the Poorhouse! Lose a Turn!" This was not a good thing. Poorhouses (almshouses were simply the same thing with the old English word "alms" for charity used) started out rather small, sometimes in private homes, and at first were scattered in America. But in the 1820s, when America ceased being a completely agricultural society and began to receive more immigration, reformers such as Josiah Quincy in Massachusetts and John Yates in New York led a drive to build almshouses or poorhouses in every town and city. Their purposes were deeply steeped in a desire to not only save money but also to deter the "undeserving poor." As stated in the Yates Report:

"The present poor laws tend to encourage the sturdy beggar and profligate vagrant to become pensioners upon the public funds. These provisions operate as so many invitations to become beggars.... Outdoor relief [had] blunted his proper instincts, or in the words of various overseers of the poor, served to relax individual exertion by "unnerving the arm of industry," and weakened the "desire of honest independence."(quoted in Rothman, 1971)

As David Rothman (1971) has well documented, the reformers of the Jacksonian period dreamed of a "utopian world" in which almshouses — as well as the mental asylum, prison or penitentiary and orphanage — were positive institutions which would "reform" the characters of people who were poor or deviant and which would serve as a model for citizens who were not incarcerated. Today experts generally do not believe institutions provide rehabilitation, but for many decades Americans, at least

of higher classes, seemed to believe they did.

Between the 1820s and the late nineteenth century there was a huge growth in the number of poorhouses in America. Some were small, even homey, and held ten or twelve people with a superintendent and a matron, usually his unpaid wife. Large cities and some states had more notorious concrete block institutions which held thousands. Among the most notorious was the Tewksbury Almshouse in Massachusetts, near the large industrial center of Lowell. Bellevue Almshouse in New York City, now Bellevue Hospital, and Cook County Almshouse in Chicago, later Cook County Hospital, were other examples of large poorhouses. Over time, who entered the almshouse changed. For most of the nineteenth century, unemployed men came in and out of the poorhouses, and a large permanent population of people, including the aged, mentally and physically disabled, constituted the bulk of the "inmates." Reformers made efforts to remove from the poorhouses the mentally ill (an objective of the famous Dorothea Dix), children, the "feeble minded" (developmentally disabled) and "fallen women" (woman perceived as immoral or prostitutes). As these reforms gained momentum, most people who had no choice but to stay in poorhouses were elderly. By the 1880s, the fear of the poorhouse as being the place to die had so permeated the American culture that a ballad "Over the Hill to the Poorhouse" by Will Carleton became a major musical hit. It went in part,

Over the hill to the poor-house I'm trudgin' my weary way— I a woman of 70 and only a trifle gray— I, who am smart an' chipper, for all the years I've told, As many another woman that's only half as old. . . What is the use of heapin' on me a pauper's shame? Am I lazy or crazy? Am I blind or lame? True, I am not so supple, nor yet so awful stout: But charity ain't no favor, If one can live without Over the hill to the poorhouse—my child'rn dear, goodbye! Many a night I've watched you when only God was nigh: And God'll judge between us; but I will always pray That you shall never suffer the half I do today. (Carleton, 1882)

Original Article

https://socialwelfare.library.vcu.edu/issues/poor-relief-almshouse/

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FULL FOOTNOTE

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Wagner, "Poor Relief."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.8

American Abolitionism and Religion

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Excerpt · 1,087 words

Students reading about the coming of the Civil War will find the topic of religion and abolition more interesting than they imagined. The religious affiliation of politicians and the religious makeup of voting constituencies are much in the news these days. So it was, too, in the years before the Civil War broke out. In both cases, evangelical Christians were most especially influential when pressing their moral issues forward into the public arena. Growing out of the Great Awakening, these Protestants, largely in New England, were inspired less by earlier Calvinistic doom and gloom theology than by concepts of human betterment under God's grace and His gift of free will. Out of this fresh religious doctrine, called Arminianism, grew a movement that included the plea for the freedom of all of God's human creatures, especially the Southern slaves. Eventually the antislavery cause with its strong religious support helped to create the Republican party in the 1850s. This development led directly into the sectional crisis of 1860 and the war that followed.

A General Misconception

Most students probably assume that the antislavery crusade that culminated in the Civil War was largely an outgrowth of Thomas Jefferson's Declaration of Independence, which proclaimed, "All men are created equal." Yet a nation of states of which one-half held African Americans in bondage did not fulfill that noble sentiment. Of course, some Southern slaveholders, including George Washington, recognized the discrepancy between the ideal of equality and its violation. Most Americans failed to see such a discrepancy. Northerners did not want to interfere with slavery in the South. Seldom questioning its morality, Southerners were used to a system of labor that had been a way of life since early colonial days. Yet even those slaveholders who felt a twinge of conscience feared insurrection might emerge from any massive effort at manumission. You can ask students why the free and slave states did not go their separate ways even before the writing of the Constitution. After all, slavery was practiced in the Northern states, though only in relatively small numbers. Northern legislatures freed most of the slaves in their states by the late 1820s.

The Two-Nation Emergence of Antislavery Evangelicalism

The cause of immediate emancipation, as the abolitionists came to define it, had a different germ of inspiration from those Enlightenment ideals that Jefferson had articulated: the rise of a fervent religious reawakening just as the new Republic was being created. That impulse sprang from two main sources: the theology and practice of Quakerism and the emergence of an aggressive, interdenominational evangelicalism. Both movements arose in England and America during the Age of Enlightenment—the eighteenth century. The pietism of the Quakers, a radically egalitarian Protestant sect, asserted the love of God for every human being, regardless of color, sex, or station in life. Even before the American Revolution, the most famous of the mid- and late eighteenth-century Quaker reformers, John Woolman, Anthony Benezet, Benjamin Lay, and later Benjamin Lundy began to publish their opinions and raise the issue of human bondage at Quaker meetings, largely in Pennsylvania. Even in Southern states where a greater number in the faith held slaves, their activities led to increased manumissions. Benjamin Lay, however, proved the most dramatic of the early Quaker advocates. A hunchback, he sympathized with the lowly and despised and denounced slavery as the greatest sin against God's will. As early as 1738, he had addressed the Yearly Meeting in Philadelphia, wearing a long cloak that he threw off to reveal a military outfit. He then cried out to the startled worshipers, "Oh all you negro masters who are contentedly holding your fellow creatures in a state of slavery during life…you might as well throw off the plain coat as I do." He drew out a sword and plunged it into a book in which he had hidden a bladder of red berry juice. It spilled over those seated nearby.1 Yet, Quaker exertions were successful only within their own ranks, although they persevered with citizens' petitions to the newly formed Congress to free the slaves. To be sure, the Methodists under the leadership of John Wesley and some Baptist churches proclaimed slaveholding an evil. But the expansion of these faiths in the Southern states during the cotton boom of the early nineteenth century gradually stifled their antislavery convictions.

Much more dynamic than the Quaker movement was another undertaking, not at first in America but in the leading cultural and naval power in the Western World, Great Britain. Throughout the 1780s and 1790s, the Rev. John Newton, a London vicar, preached fiery sermons against the horrors of the slave trade and his own participation in it. As a former sailor on slave ships, he called himself, the "African Blasphemer." When, in his hymn, "Amazing Grace," he claimed that God's mercy had "saved a wretch like me," he meant it. Newton converted to his cause William Wilberforce, a member of Parliament from Hull. The latter soon joined forces with Cambridge-educated Thomas Clarkson and Anthony Benezet's friend Granville Sharp, long an advocate for black—and American freedom. All three were devout Anglican evangelicals with considerable social standing. Their writings, meetings, and speeches spread the word against the highly lucrative African slave trade and merged their efforts with those of wealthy and pious English Quakers. They included the factory-owner, Josiah Wedgwood, maker of Wedgwood china. Under Wilberforce's shrewd leadership, the anti-slave trade reformers convinced Parliament to close the African traffic in 1806. The Society for the Abolition of the Slave Trade, founded in 1787, set a standard of religious work in politics that would be imitated across the Atlantic many years later. Students should be encouraged to see the film Amazing Grace (2007) which dramatizes the humane work of John Newton, the House of Commons reformer Wilberforce, and others in ending the brutal, forced transportation of Africans to the West.

Indeed, the antislavery crusade in America owed much to the development of the British civic philanthropies that Wilberforce, Hannah More, and many others developed. “Ours is the age of societies,” boasted the evangelical Sir James Stephen.2 Apart from the society to suppress slave trafficking, the most prominent benevolent agencies, The British and Foreign Bible Society (1803), and the Religious Tract Society (1799) spread a vigorous Christian message. Other more narrowly focused agencies included “Guy’s Hospital, For Sick and Impotent Persons, and Lunaticks,” (1721), “The Marine Society, for Educating Poor Destitute Boys to the Sea” (1756), “The Humane Society for the Recovery of Drowned and Suffocated Persons” (1774), and “The Society for Superseding the Necessity of Climbing Boys” (chimney sweeps) (1803).3

Original Article

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Wyatt-Brown, "American Abolitionism and Religion."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.9

How the Alliance between Slaves and Abolitionists Ended Slavery

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ARGUMENT ROLES	12.3.1 Support; 12.3.2 Support; 12.3.3 Support

Excerpt · 1,011 words

One hundred fifty years ago this December, the U.S. completed its long process of abolishing slavery. Why did the nation endure nine long decades as a "house divided against itself"? The answer lies in the actions of John Brown, who six Decembers earlier was hung for his failed attempt to spark slave insurrection.

On December 6, 1865, the ratification of the Thirteenth Amendment to the Constitution formally ended slavery in the U.S. While the nation was not alone in abolishing property in man, its story of abolition stands out in the annals of Atlantic history. For one, it took a long time. The country began ending the institution in 1777, when Vermont wrote slavery out of its state constitution, and remained a "house divided" (in Abraham Lincoln's famous words) for almost nine decades. Slavery also ended late in the U.S. The Spanish colonies of mainland South America destroyed bondage as they became independent (1808-1833), and major European powers ended it between 1834 and 1848. Only Cuba (1880) and Brazil (1888) followed the U.S. Finally, ending slavery in the U.S. required an unprecedented level of violence. In no other society did abolition require a national bloodletting rivaling the 750,000 who perished in the American Civil War.

Clearly, the threshold for achieving complete abolition in the U.S. was higher than it was throughout most of the Atlantic world. Ending slavery here took so long, and required such sacrifice, because the slaveholding power lay not in a subordinate colonial periphery but within the confines of the nation — a nation built on the principle of federalism, in which every state was its own sovereign entity.

What was more, the devil's bargain struck at the convention that framed the U.S. Constitution in 1787 ensured that the slaveholding interest exercised influence in national tribunals disproportionate to its population. The three-fifths clause of the Constitution converted slaveholders' labor power into political power by counting sixty percent of their bound population toward their representation in the House of Representatives and Electoral College. These factors made the threshold for abolishing slavery much higher than in Great Britain, where popular pressure led Parliament to end chattel bondage in its colonies in 1834, or France, where executive action accomplished the feat in 1848.

In the U.S., overcoming the formidable obstacles to abolition required something more — a remarkable alliance between slaves and their abolitionist allies. The process began in earnest in the early 1830s, when a new breed of northern reformers began championing the cause of the slave, calling for the immediate and uncompensated end of chattel bondage. Figures such as William Lloyd Garrison began as pacifists, but as slavery's champions mounted ever more strident defenses of the institution, their approaches diversified. Some sought inroads into the political system, compelling the two major parties to attend to an issue they studiously ignored as being suicidally divisive.

Others acted more directly for and with the enslaved, helping them secure their freedom in the North through the Underground Railroad. When the slaveholders extracted from Congress an assertive new fugitive slave law in 1850, northerners responded with outrage. Resistance led abolitionists and free black activists to engage in forceful rescues of suspected fugitives. This growing willingness to embrace physical means demonstrated that the gulf between the resistance of the enslaved and the antislavery rhetoric of the abolitionists was drawing ever closer together.

The two merged spectacularly in Fall 1859, when John Brown, a militant white abolitionist, led a mixed-race band of men in an assault on the federal armory at Harpers Ferry, Virginia. Brown had gained military experience in Kansas, where pro- and anti-slavery guerrillas had battled to determine whether the territory would enter the union slave or free. Inspired by the Haitian Revolution that had overthrown slavery on France's prize sugar colony, Brown hoped to spark "insurrectionary warfare" in western Virginia. Once begun, he believed, "all the free negroes in the Northern States would immediately flock to his standard," along with "all the slaves in the Southern States," and "many of the free negroes in Canada." The conditions of revolutionary chaos that had so effectively undermined slavery during the American, Haitian, and Latin American wars for independence would become the basis for a full-fledged war on slavery.

The insurrection failed. But Brown was only acting on impulses that were growing in northern politics. Out of sectional crisis the Republican Party had emerged, dedicated to confining slavery to its existing borders. John Brown's raid stoked southern fears that this new party sought nothing less than the institution's immediate destruction. "The republican party of the North is stained with the blood of insurrection," wrote one Democratic editor. Southern demagogues charged that if the Republican Abraham Lincoln were elected President in the upcoming 1860 race, he would send "armed bands" into the South to liberate slaves. Many in the South thus viewed his November victory as tantamount to inciting slave rebellion. Eleven slaveholding states chose to secede from the union rather than face an uncertain future under Republican rule.

In the early stages of the war that followed, Lincoln prioritized preservation of the union over the destruction of slavery, declaring: "if I could save the Union without freeing any slave I would do it." Eventually, though, the need for manpower in a lengthening battle of attrition convinced him that "we must free the slaves or be ourselves subdued." This was the fateful moment, when the federal government finally mobilized the Union war machine in the service of abolitionists' longstanding goal. The Emancipation Proclamation, by transferring nearly one hundred thousand African Americans from the plantation into the Union army, transformed enslaved laborers into conquering armies of liberation, spreading freedom as they marched across the Confederacy. John Brown had envisioned a long-running insurrection, in which those who fled the plantations "would be formed into regiments and brigades and be drilled in the whole art of war, as were the black soldiers of Toussaint L'Ourverture and Dessalines, in Hayti." To a remarkable degree, the Union's ultimate policy of emancipation and recruitment fulfilled at last the militant vision of 1859.

Original Article

https://www.aaihs.org/how-the-alliance/

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Rael, "Alliance between Slaves and Abolitionists."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.10

Northern Black People's Freedom Struggle in the Nineteenth Century

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ARGUMENT ROLES	12.3.2 Support

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During the mid-nineteenth-century, Black people collectively fought for racial equality and social justice within the U.S. The scholarship of historians, including Herbert G. Gutman and Jennifer L. Morgan, collectively illustrate that enslaved people consistently and diversely challenged the complex institution of slavery. Their work, for instance, highlights that enslaved people demonstrated agency (over an extended period and locations) in their unified demands for the recognition of their humanity.

To be clear, there is no question that the important histories of enslaved people (later freedpeople) should continue receiving both public and academic attention. At the same time, turning attention to northern freeborn Black people, who lived in free states, gives avenues to understanding how racial discrimination evolved, in numerous ways, outside of slavery. Additionally, focusing on northern freeborn Black people provides ways to explore how they repeatedly demonstrated agency against their white oppressors.

Living in free states, during the antebellum and Civil War-era, did not guarantee that freeborn Black people could avoid becoming enslaved themselves. While the threat of becoming a victim of Blackbirding—the kidnapping of a Black person for the explicit purpose of selling them into slavery—was a sad reality in the early-nineteenth-century, the threat dramatically intensified after the Compromise of 1850. More specifically, the passage of the Fugitive Slave Law of 1850 (FSA of 1850), a revised version of the 1793 federal policy, legalized slaveowners' attempts to reclaim enslaved people who refugeed, regardless of the length of freedom, to a free state. In addition to forcing any deputized white person (regardless of their stance on slavery) to participate in the detainment of a suspected refugee, the federal law provided latitude for a slaveowner to claim any Black person was their "property." Black people throughout the nation understood that the passage of the FSA of 1850, which free state Congressmen supported to keep the U.S. unified, sanctioned war on all Black people as their citizenship and humanity, regardless of their status, was unimportant to the U.S. government.

Northern Black communities swiftly mobilized to condemn the policy, while seeking to protect Black people from possibly becoming bondspeople. In various northern localities, Vigilance Committees (some of which originated in the 1830s) refocused their efforts to offer aid and possible safety to "fugitives." For instance, the New York City Vigilant Committee successfully helped 1,000 people avoid enslavement. Northern Black women were critical members of the Vigilance Committee, including working to keep freeborn Black children from becoming victims of the FSA of 1850 (sometimes as they traveled and from school). Black women also helped adults avoid becoming enslaved as well.

In September of 1850, when James Hamlet became the first FSA of 1850 victim in New York City, the local Black community quickly raised funds to pay for his freedom from a local jail. Shortly afterward, Black New Yorkers held an event (with 1,500 attendees) that celebrated Hamlet's release. Most of the attendees were Black women, illustrating how they publicly condemned the inhumane federal policies that simultaneously protected slaveowners' "property rights" and denigrated Black lives.

Meanwhile, throughout the North, the public education system was rife with racially discriminatory practices and policies that attempted to hinder the educational development of Black youths, which reinforced white supremacy across multiple generations. In 1854, for example, Pennsylvania lawmakers passed legislation that ordered the creation and maintenance of racially segregated public schools if twenty (or more) Black children attended public school with white pupils. Unfortunately,

many northern Black public schools dealt with several issues, including overcrowded classrooms, dilapidated buildings, and unqualified (and sometimes) openly racist white teachers.

In order to challenge the racialized inequalities that northern Black children experienced, northern Black community members, especially women, regularly criticized the inequalities in northern public schools.s Their collective actions, such as performing impromptu inspections of the schools, reveal that Black people remained committed to ensuring that Black children could receive a quality education. Furthermore, when a school did not meet the standards of the local Black community, they openly expressed their displeasure. Some Black families chose one option to remove their school-age children from the racially segregated institutions. For instance, Black Philadelphians threatened to stop sending youths to the Colored Public School on Sixth Street if Miss Donnelly, a white teacher who was racially hostile towards her pupils, did not lose her job. Black Philadelphians informed the school, "…We [c]an break up the school up by preventing our children for going; and we will do it rather than have our children taught by such teachers."1

Unfortunately, freeborn northern Black people (regardless of their age, gender, or socio-economic standing) discovered that racial discrimination could evolve in free states. Many white northerners, including U.S. Congressmen, focused on appeasing the "rights" of southern slaveowners to maintain the "unity" of the U.S. Other white northerners imposed state and local laws that illustrated that their race defined their lived experience to freeborn Black people. Moreover, even with the constant pressures of racial discrimination, northern Black people continued fighting for racial equality and social justice. Their collective efforts were, and remain, an inspiration for people seeking to establish a more inclusive society.

Original Article

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SHORTENED FOOTNOTE

Pinheiro, "Northern Black People's Freedom Struggle."

CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.11

Seneca Falls and Building a Movement, 1776–1890

Library of Congress

AUTHOR	Library of Congress (Unsigned exhibition text, Library of Congress)
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ARGUMENT ROLES	12.4.1 Support

Excerpt · 950 words (complete article)

Notions of equality that inspired America's war for independence from Great Britain brought only modest and fleeting change to the status of women, most of whom remained "civilly dead." Women had no legal identity separate from their husbands and were unable to sign contracts, own property, obtain access to education, obtain divorces easily, and gain custody of their children after divorce well into the nineteenth century. The desire to address this inequality and challenge the country to live up to its revolutionary promise led to a two-day convention in Seneca Falls, New York, in 1848, where 300 women and men gathered to debate Elizabeth Cady Stanton's Declaration of Sentiments. Modeled after the Declaration of Independence, it outlined women's inferior status and included a radical demand for suffrage.

After Seneca Falls, women's rights conventions became annual events, where women met to discuss educational opportunities, divorce reform, property rights, and sometimes labor issues. Women lent their support to abolishing slavery believing universal suffrage would follow, but both the Fourteenth and Fifteenth Amendments ignored their demand for suffrage. National leaders responded differently, leading to a split in the movement and contrasting campaigns for voting rights at the local, state, and national levels. In 1878 the first federal women's suffrage amendment was introduced but was soundly defeated later in the first full Senate vote in 1887. As the nineteenth century neared an end, competing national suffrage groups reunited as the National American Woman Suffrage Association (NAWSA), and groundwork was laid for a national movement.

Early Feminist Inspirations

> But I ask no favors for my sex. I surrender not our claim to equality. All I ask of our brethren is, that they will take their feet from off our necks, and permit us to stand upright on that ground which God has designed us to occupy.
>
> —Sarah Grimké, Letters on Equality of the Sexes, 1838

The beginning of the American women's suffrage movement is often marked by either the 1848 women's rights convention in Seneca Falls, New York, or the earlier 1840 World Antislavery Convention in London, where Lucretia Mott and five other American women delegates were barred from participating after making the long journey. The women's treatment convinced Mott and Elizabeth Cady Stanton of the need to convene a meeting focusing exclusively on women's rights. Although the 1840 and 1848 conventions were undeniably pivotal events, women had for decades been writing and speaking about their inequality in private letters, public lectures, and published books, as shown here. A half-century of feminist writing and political activism preceded Seneca Falls, providing both an intellectual framework and fearless role models for the first generation of suffragists.

Seneca Falls and the Start of Annual Conventions

> I am a woman's rights. I have as much muscle as any man, and can do as much work as any man. I have plowed and reaped and husked and chopped and mowed, and can any man do more than that?
>
> —Sojourner Truth, Woman's Rights Convention in Akron, Ohio, 1851

Many early suffragists served their political apprenticeships in the temperance and abolition movements, learning to organize, speak in public, and operate in volatile political environments. Veterans of both movements converged on Seneca Falls, New York, on July 19–20, 1848, to discuss "the social, civil, and religious condition and rights of women." The organizers—Lucretia

Mott, Elizabeth Cady Stanton, Martha C. Wright, Jane Hunt, and Mary McClintock—were all married mothers. Influenced by the writings of Mary Wollstonecraft, Lydia Maria Child, Sarah Grimké, and others, they overcame their initial nervousness and sought to address the discrimination found in their homes and communities. The meeting's success led to subsequent, more diverse conventions and visible progress in the areas of property rights, dress reform, and educational opportunities.

Family, Friends, and the Personal Side of the Movement

> I expect to plead not for the slave only, but for suffering humanity everywhere. Especially do I mean to labor for the elevation of my sex.
>
> —Lucy Stone, 1847

In asserting women's equality, the suffrage movement challenged men's control not only in the public world of politics and paid work, but also in the private sphere, where men typically "ruled the roost." Antisuffragist songs and cartoons suggested that domestic tranquility and the virility of American men were under siege. Achieving happy marriages and finding ways to balance family responsibilities with a commitment to the cause proved as challenging for suffragists as it is for today's working women. The campaign inevitably raised one's consciousness to the inequities within marriage and to the social conventions that blocked women's advancement. Sadly, many of the friendships that nurtured the movement before the Civil War suffered a setback when suffragists divided in 1869 over support for the Fifteenth Amendment, which failed to include women.

A Movement at Odds with Itself

> The history of our country the past hundred years, has been a series of assumptions and usurpations of power over woman, in direct opposition to the principles of just government. . . .
>
> —National Woman Suffrage Association, Declaration of Rights of the Women of the United States, July 4, 1876

In the late 1860s and 1870s, white and black suffrage leaders swept across the country giving lectures and inspiring the creation of new suffrage organizations. Key leaders emerged in every region, and in 1878, a federal women's suffrage amendment was first introduced in Congress. Suffragists gained publicity by attempting to vote and disrupting the nation's centennial celebration, but such tactics lost appeal by the late 1880s as the movement grew more conservative. Previously women had advocated for universal suffrage based on the individual rights of all people, regardless of sex and race. In the 1870s and 1880s, suffragists began to claim that women were different from men, and their distinctly higher morals would uplift the nation if given the vote. This emphasis on character and qualifications widened racial and class divides between suffragists.

Original Article

https://www.loc.gov/exhibitions/women-fight-for-the-vote/about-this-exhibition/seneca-falls-and-building-a-movement-1776-1890/

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FULL FOOTNOTE

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CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.12

Seneca Falls in 1848

National Park Service, Women's Rights National Historical Park

AUTHOR	National Park Service, Women's Rights National Historical Park (Unsigned page of Women's Rights National Historical Park)
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Excerpt · 960 words (complete article)

In the 1790s, the first white settlers founded Seneca Falls alongside the falls of the Seneca River, a mile-long series of rapids with a combined drop of 49 feet. Participants in the Sullivan-Clinton Campaign (1779) had recognized the potential of the area and returned. The Continental Army's Campaign is considered by some an astounding military feat, by others a tragic devastation of the homelands of the Iroquois Confederacy or Six Nations. By 1794 the state of New York had charted a route for the Great Western Road, a section of which crossed the Seneca River using the main street (Fall Street) through the settlement of Seneca Falls. By 1800 the Seneca Road Company was established to maintain and improve the condition of the roadway. Locally the thoroughfare became known as the Seneca Turnpike.

The Bayard Company held a monopoly on the area's abundant waterpower and controlled access to the falls of Seneca Falls. Their inflated prices prevented development of new industry until 1825. That year the company went bankrupt, and its interests were sold. The now-accessible waterpower allowed for rapid growth of mills and factories along the river banks and on islands in the riverbed. Within six years, there were five sawmills, two textile factories, five flour mills, and three tin and sheet-iron plants. In 1821, when the Seneca Lock Navigation Company opened a canal to bypass the falls, more islands were created between the two waterways. New factories were built on these islands and the village grew and prospered. By 1828, the Cayuga-Seneca Canal was linked to the Erie Canal, making transport of raw materials and finished goods easier and opening up a much larger market for items manufactured locally. Seneca Falls had become the place the Bayard Company had once advertised: a place for "men of enterprise and capitol" that "offered profitable employment of both." The area originally known as Mynderse Mills officially became the Village of Seneca Falls in 1831. Ansel Bascom was selected as the first President (Mayor) of the Village.

Beginning in 1841 the Rochester-Auburn railroad system opened the door to world markets for goods manufactured in Seneca Falls. Trains provided a tangible link to the outside world that was faster and more efficient than shipping goods and transporting people by barge or overland. The railroad brought a swift influx of ideas, people, and mail, and connected local markets to national ones. The local industry began to specialize in manufactured products rather than offer a variety of goods intended for the local market. By the 1840s and 50s, pumps, fire engines, and other metal goods became important products of Seneca Falls industry shipped to a world market via the railroad. The advent of manufacturing opened new possibilities for women as well; for the first time, women could work outside the home. As women started to earn money, they began to realize the extent of discrimination they faced. Married women had to give up their wages to their husbands and were unable to execute contracts or buy property. Women were paid less than their male coworkers. As they could not vote, they were taxed without representation. These economic realities led people to think about the issues that would be raised at the Seneca Falls Convention. Social and religious upheavals during this period were considerable. Reform movements, such as temperance and abolition, had broad support in the region by 1848, but there was also considerable opposition. The area later became known as "The Burned-Over District," because of the popularity of religious revivals and new religious sects that "spread like wildfire." Many utopian communities shared a faith in perfectibility of people and society and were open to and experimented with new forms of social and religious organization. Seneca Falls was a thriving and prosperous community, rich in waterpower resources and surrounded by fertile farmland. Its inhabitants could be optimists about the future and were undoubtedly affected by demands for social reform and religious and utopian ideas about people and society. Many local citizens formed and participated in antislavery societies and temperance leagues, ran stations on the Underground Railroad; they were willing to listen to and participate in a discussion about changing the public roles of women in society. These factors led nearly 300 people to respond to the call for a women's rights convention. Religious and political reformers, especially the Free Soil Party members, were important participants in the Seneca Falls Convention. In 1848, a presidential election year, both major party candidates favored extending slavery from the South into the western territories. The Free Soil Party was formed in response to this. The Free Soilers would only support a candidate who opposed the extension of slavery. Local abolitionists created a Free Soil chapter in a meeting in the Wesleyan Chapel on June 13, 1848. Many of these abolitionists returned to the Chapel for the Women's Rights Convention in July. These reformers recognized the similarities between the status of black men and that of women in society. Quakers were another important group at the Convention. In June 1848, the local Genesee Yearly Meeting of Friends had split over issues of church governance. Those who broke away – the Progressive or Congregational Friends – believed that all persons were equal and should not be subject to the control of a hierarchy of ministers and elders. They based their religious organization on a commitment to social reform work. They came to the Convention to demonstrate their commitment to radical equality. The 1848 Seneca Falls Women's Rights Convention occurred in an atmosphere of idealistic reform. This was the first meeting to be held for the purpose of discussing the "social, civil, and religious conditions and the rights of woman." It was the beginning of the women's rights movement in the United States.

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CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.13

Henry David Thoreau

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Excerpt · 1,075 words

Henry David Thoreau (1817–1862) was an American philosopher, poet, environmental scientist, and political activist whose major work, Walden, draws upon each of these various identities in meditating upon the concrete problems of living in the world as a human being. He sought to revive a conception of philosophy as a way of life, not only a mode of reflective thought and discourse. Thoreau's work was informed by an eclectic variety of sources. He was well-versed in classical Greek and Roman philosophy (and poetry), ranging from the pre-Socratics through the Hellenistic schools, and was also an avid student of the ancient scriptures and wisdom literature of various Asian traditions. He was familiar with modern philosophy ranging from Descartes, Locke, and the Cambridge Platonists through Emerson, Coleridge, and the German Idealists, all of whom are influential on Thoreau's philosophy. He discussed his own empirical findings with leading naturalists of the day, and read the latest work of Humboldt and Darwin with interest and admiration. His philosophical explorations of self and world led him to develop an epistemology of embodied perception and a non-dualistic account of mental and material life. In addition to his focus on ethics in an existential spirit, Thoreau also makes unique contributions to ontology, the philosophy of science, and radical political thought. Although his political essays have become justly famous, his works on natural science were not even published until the late twentieth century, and they help to give us a more complete picture of him as a thinker. Among the texts he left unfinished was a set of manuscript volumes filled with information on Native American religion and culture. Thoreau's work anticipates certain later developments in pragmatism, phenomenology, and environmental philosophy, and poses a perennially valuable challenge to our conception of the methods and intentions of philosophy itself.

1. Life and Writings

Thoreau was born in Concord, Massachusetts in 1817 and died there in 1862, at the age of forty-four. Like that of his contemporary Søren Kierkegaard, Thoreau's intellectual career unfolded in a close and polemical relation to the town in which he spent almost his entire life. After graduating from Harvard in 1837, he struck up a friendship with fellow Concord resident Ralph Waldo Emerson, whose essay "Nature" he had first encountered earlier that year. Although the two American thinkers had a turbulent relationship due to serious philosophical and personal differences, they had a profound and lasting effect upon one another. It was in the fall of 1837 that Thoreau made his first entries in the multivolume journal he would keep for the rest of his life. Most of his published writings were developed from notes that first appeared on these pages, and Thoreau subsequently revised many entries, suggesting that his journal can be considered a finished work in itself. During his lifetime he published only two books, along with numerous shorter essays that were first delivered as lectures. He lived a simple and relatively quiet life, making his living briefly as a teacher and pencil maker but mostly as a land surveyor. Thoreau had intimate bonds with his family and friends (the loss of his brother John in 1842 was a major trauma) and remained unmarried, although he was deeply in love at least twice. His first book, A Week on the Concord and Merrimack Rivers, was still a work in progress in 1845, when he went to live in the woods by Walden Pond for two years and two months. This "experiment" in living on the outskirts of town was an intensive time of examination for Thoreau, as he drew close to nature and contemplated the final ends of his own life, which was otherwise at risk of ending in quiet desperation. Thoreau viewed his existential quest as a venture in philosophy, in the ancient Greek sense of the word, because it was motivated by an urgent need to find a reflective understanding of reality that could inform a life of wisdom. This is because, according to the belief that philosophy is a way of life, that very way of life "will necessarily be deliberative and reflective"; accordingly, for Thoreau, "thinking about his life in the woods is central to his life in the woods" (Bates 2012, 29). Moreover, it is only after having cultivated "a meticulous and discerning awareness of the particularities of nature" in one specific place (Robinson 2004, 100) that he became able to articulate a vision of the human being's capacity to be grounded and at home in the world.

His experience bore fruit in the 1854 publication of his literary masterpiece Walden, a work that almost defies categorization: it is a work of narrative prose which often soars to poetic heights, combining philosophical speculation with close observation of a concrete place. It is a rousing summons to the examined life and to the realization of one's potential, while at the same time it develops what might be described as a religious vision of the human being and the universe. Walden has been admired by a larger world audience than any other book written by an American author, and—whether or not it ought to be called a work of philosophy—it contains a substantial amount of philosophical content, which deserves to be better appreciated than it has been. Stanley Cavell has argued that Thoreau is an embarrassment to "what we have learned to call philosophy," since his work embodies "a mode of conceptual accuracy" that is "based on an idea of rigor" somewhat foreign to the academic establishment (Cavell 1988, 14). Yet, as Cavell also notes, philosophical authors have more than one way to go about their business, and Thoreau—like Descartes in the Meditations—begins his argument by accounting for how he has come to believe that certain questions need to be addressed. In other words, his method is predicated on the belief that it is philosophically worthwhile to clarify the basis of your own perplexity and unrest (see Reid 2012, 46). And this is only one way of explaining how a significant part of the challenge in coming to terms with Thoreau is that his philosophy, like Nietzsche's, has a literary and poetic quality. The reader is charged with finding the coherence of Thoreau's whole philosophical outlook. Accordingly, this entry attempts to delineate the main themes of Thoreau's project, in the hope of serving as an aid and stimulus to further study. It draws upon Thoreau's entire corpus, including the works he left in manuscript that were published after his death.

Original Article

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CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.14

Transcendentalism

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Excerpt · 1,085 words

Transcendentalism is an American literary, philosophical, religious, and political movement of the early nineteenth century, centered around Ralph Waldo Emerson. Other important transcendentalists were Henry David Thoreau, Margaret Fuller, Lydia Maria Child, Amos Bronson Alcott, Frederic Henry Hedge, Elizabeth Palmer Peabody, and Theodore Parker. Stimulated by English and German Romanticism, the Biblical criticism of Herder and Schleiermacher, and the skepticism of Hume, the transcendentalists operated with the sense that a new era was at hand. They were critics of their contemporary society for its unthinking conformity, and urged that each person find, in Emerson's words, "an original relation to the universe" (O, 3). Emerson and Thoreau sought this relation in solitude amidst nature, and in their writing. By the 1840s they, along with other transcendentalists, were engaged in the social experiments of Brook Farm, Fruitlands, and Walden; and, by the 1850s in an increasingly urgent critique of American slavery.

1. Origins and Character

What we now know as transcendentalism first arose among the liberal New England Congregationalists, who departed from orthodox Calvinism in two respects: they believed in the importance and efficacy of human striving, as opposed to the bleaker Puritan picture of complete and inescapable human depravity; and they emphasized the unity rather than the "Trinity" of God (hence the term "Unitarian," originally a term of abuse that they came to adopt.) Most of the Unitarians held that Jesus was in some way inferior to God the Father but still greater than human beings; a few followed the English Unitarian Joseph Priestley (1733–1804) in holding that Jesus was thoroughly human, although endowed with special authority. The Unitarians' leading preacher, William Ellery Channing (1780–1842), portrayed orthodox Congregationalism as a religion of fear, and maintained that Jesus saved human beings from sin, not just from punishment. His sermon "Unitarian Christianity" (1819) denounced "the conspiracy of ages against the liberty of Christians" (P, 336) and helped give the Unitarian movement its name. In "Likeness to God" (1828) he proposed that human beings "partake" of Divinity and that they may achieve "a growing likeness to the Supreme Being" (T, 4).

The Unitarians were "modern." They attempted to reconcile Locke's empiricism with Christianity by maintaining that the accounts of miracles in the Bible provide overwhelming evidence for the truth of religion. It was precisely on this ground, however, that the transcendentalists found fault with Unitarianism. For although they admired Channing's idea that human beings can become more like God, they were persuaded by Hume that no empirical proof of religion could be satisfactory. In letters written in his freshman year at Harvard (1817), Emerson tried out Hume's skeptical arguments on his devout and respected Aunt Mary Moody Emerson, and in his journals of the early 1820s he discusses with approval Hume's Dialogues on Natural Religion and his underlying critique of necessary connection. "We have no experience of a Creator," Emerson writes, and therefore we "know of none" (JMN 2, 161).

Skepticism about religion was also engendered by the publication of an English translation of F. D. E. Schleiermacher's Critical Essay Upon the Gospel of St. Luke (1825), which introduced the idea that the Bible was a product of human history and culture. Equally important was the publication in 1833—some fifty years after its initial appearance in Germany—of James Marsh's translation of Johann Gottfried von Herder's Spirit of Hebrew Poetry (1782). Herder blurred the lines between religious texts and humanly-produced poetry, casting doubt on the authority of the Bible, but also suggesting that texts with equal authority could still be written. It was against this background that Emerson asked in 1836, in the first paragraph of Nature: "Why should we not have a poetry and philosophy of insight and not of tradition, and a religion by revelation to us, and not the history of

theirs" (O, 5). The individual's "revelation"—or "intuition," as Emerson was later to speak of it—was to be the counter both to Unitarian empiricism and Humean skepticism.

An important source for the transcendentalists' knowledge of German philosophy was Frederic Henry Hedge (1805–90). Hedge's father Levi Hedge, a Harvard professor of logic, sent him to preparatory school in Germany at the age of thirteen, after which he attended the Harvard Divinity School. Ordained as a Unitarian minister, Hedge wrote a long review of the work of Samuel Taylor Coleridge for the Christian Examiner in 1833. Noting Coleridge's fondness for "German metaphysics" and his immense gifts of erudition and expression, he laments that Coleridge had not made Kant and the post-Kantians more accessible to an English-speaking audience. This is the task—to introduce the "transcendental philosophy" of Kant, (T, 87)—that Hedge takes up. In particular, he explains Kant's idea of a Copernican Revolution in philosophy: "[S]ince the supposition that our intuitions depend on the nature of the world without, will not answer, assume that the world without depends on the nature of our intuitions." This "key to the whole critical philosophy," Hedge continues, explains the possibility of "a priori knowledge" (T, 92). Hedge organized what eventually became known as the Transcendental Club, by suggesting to Emerson in 1836 that they form a discussion group for disaffected young Unitarian clergy. The group included George Ripley and Bronson Alcott, had some 30 meetings in four years, and was a sponsor of The Dial and Brook Farm. Hedge was a vocal opponent of slavery in the 1830s and a champion of women's rights in the 1850s, but he remained a Unitarian minister, and became a professor at the Harvard Divinity School.

Another source for the transcendentalists' knowledge of German philosophy was Germaine de Staël (Anne-Louise-Germaine Necker) (1766–1817), whose De l'Allemagne (On Germany) was a favorite of the young Emerson. In a sweeping survey of European metaphysics and political philosophy, de Staël praises Locke's devotion to liberty, but sees him as the originator of a sensationalist school of epistemology that leads to the skepticism of Hume. She finds an attractive contrast in the German tradition that begins with Leibniz and culminates in Kant, which asserts the power and authority of the mind.

James Marsh (1794–1842), a graduate of Andover and the president of the University of Vermont, was equally important for the emerging philosophy of transcendentalism. Marsh was convinced that German philosophy held the key to a reformed theology. His American edition of Coleridge's Aids to Reflection (1829) introduced Coleridge's version—much indebted to Schelling—of Kantian terminology, terminology that runs throughout Emerson's early work. In Nature, for example, Emerson writes: "The Imagination may be defined to be, the use which the Reason makes of the material world" (O, 25).

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CHAPTER 12 · WEB ARTICLE W12.15

Ralph Waldo Emerson

Russell Goodman

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An American essayist, poet, and popular philosopher, Ralph Waldo Emerson (1803–82) began his career as a Unitarian minister in Boston, but achieved worldwide fame as a lecturer and the author of such essays as “Self-Reliance,” “History,” “The Over-Soul,” and “Fate.” Drawing on English and German Romanticism, Neoplatonism, Kantianism, and Hinduism, Emerson developed a metaphysics of process, an epistemology of moods, and an “existentialist” ethics of self-improvement. He influenced generations of Americans, from his friend Henry David Thoreau to John Dewey, and in Europe, Friedrich Nietzsche, who takes up such Emersonian themes as power, fate, the uses of poetry and history, and the critique of Christianity.

1. Chronology of Emerson’s Life

1803: Born in Boston to William and Ruth Haskins Emerson.

1811: Father dies, probably of tuberculosis.

1812: Enters Boston Public Latin School

1817: Begins study at Harvard College: Greek, Latin, History, Rhetoric.

1820: Starts first journal, entitled “The Wide World.”

1821: Graduates from Harvard and begins teaching at his brother William’s school for young ladies in Boston.

1825: Enters Harvard Divinity School.

1829: Marries Ellen Tucker and is ordained minister at Boston’s Second Church.

1831: Ellen Tucker Emerson dies, at age 19.

1832: Resigns position as minister and sails for Europe.

1833: Meets Wordsworth, Coleridge, J. S. Mill, and Thomas Carlyle. Returns to Boston in November, where he begins a career as a lecturer.

1834: Receives first half of a substantial inheritance from Ellen’s estate (second half comes in 1837).

1835: Marries Lidian Jackson.

1836: Publishes first book, Nature.

1838: Delivers the “Divinity School Address.” Protests relocation of the Cherokees in letter to President Van Buren.

1841: Essays published (contains “Self-Reliance,” “The Over-Soul,” “Circles,” “History”).

1842: Son Waldo dies of scarlet fever at the age of 5.

1844: Essays, Second Series published (contains “The Poet,” “Experience,” “Nominalist and Realist”).

1847–8: Lectures in England.

1850: Publishes Representative Men (essays on Plato, Swedenborg, Montaigne, Goethe, Napoleon).

1851–60: Speaks against Fugitive Slave Law and in support of anti-slavery candidates in Concord, Boston, New York, Philadelphia.

1856: Publishes English Traits.

1860: Publishes The Conduct of Life (contains “Culture” and “Fate”).

1867: Lectures in nine western states.

1870: Publishes Society and Solitude. Presents sixteen lectures in Harvard’s Philosophy Department.

1872–3: After a period of failing health, travels to Europe, Egypt.

1875: Journal entries cease.

1882: Dies in Concord.

2. Major Themes in Emerson’s Philosophy

2.1 Education

In “The American Scholar,” delivered as the Phi Beta Kappa Address in 1837, Emerson maintains that the scholar is educated by nature, books, and action. Nature is the first in time (since it is always there) and the first in importance of the three. Nature’s variety conceals underlying laws that are at the same time laws of the human mind: “the ancient precept, ‘Know thyself,’ and the modern precept, ‘Study nature,’ become at last one maxim” (CW1: 55). Books, the second component of the scholar’s education, offer us the influence of the past. Yet much of what passes for education is mere idolization of books — transferring the “sacredness which applies to the act of creation…to the record.” The proper relation to books is not that of the “bookworm” or “bibliomaniac,” but that of the “creative” reader (CW1: 58) who uses books as a stimulus to attain “his own sight of principles.” Used well, books “inspire…the active soul” (CW1: 56). Great books are mere records of such inspiration, and their value derives only, Emerson holds, from their role in inspiring or recording such states of the soul. The “end” Emerson finds in nature is not a vast collection of books, but, as he puts it in “The Poet,” “the production of new individuals,…or the passage of the soul into higher forms” (CW3:14).

The third component of the scholar’s education is action. Without it, thought “can never ripen into truth” (CW1: 59). Action is the process whereby what is not fully formed passes into expressive consciousness. Life is the scholar’s “dictionary” (CW1: 60), the source for what she has to say: “Only so much do I know as I have lived” (CW1:59). The true scholar speaks from experience, not in imitation of others; her words, as Emerson puts it, are “are loaded with life…” (CW1: 59). The scholar’s education in original experience and self-expression is appropriate, according to Emerson, not only for a small class of people, but for everyone. Its goal is the creation of a democratic nation. Only when we learn to “walk on our own feet” and to “speak our own minds,” he holds, will a nation “for the first time exist” (CW1: 70).

Emerson returned to the topic of education late in his career in “Education,” an address he gave in various versions at graduation exercises in the 1860s. Self-reliance appears in the essay in his discussion of respect. The “secret of Education,” he states, “lies in respecting the pupil.” It is not for the teacher to choose what the pupil will know and do, but for the pupil to discover “his own secret.” The teacher must therefore “wait and see the new product of Nature” (E: 143), guiding and disciplining when appropriate-not with the aim of encouraging repetition or imitation, but with that of finding the new power that is each child’s gift to the world. The aim of education is to “keep” the child’s “nature and arm it with knowledge in the very direction in which it points” (E: 144). This aim is sacrificed in mass education, Emerson warns. Instead of educating “masses,” we must educate “reverently, one by one,” with the attitude that “the whole world is needed for the tuition of each pupil” (E: 154).

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